

# Fate's Edge: Player's Guide

Nicholas A. Gasper

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## **Fate's Edge: Player's Guide**

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# Chapter 1

## Welcome to Fate's Edge

*A world where every choice carries weight, every spell risks backlash, and every legend is written in the shadow of consequence.*

Welcome to **Fate's Edge**, a tabletop roleplaying game where narrative drives mechanics, and every decision shapes not only your character's path—but the world around them. This is not a game of perfect successes or clean victories. It is a game of risk, drama, and legacy.

### What Is This Game?

Fate's Edge is a narrative-first RPG where:

- Every roll introduces potential for triumph *and* complication.
- Magic is powerful—but dangerous.
- Choices ripple outward, shaping character arcs and the setting.
- Growth is meaningful, earned through experience spent on skills, talents, and assets.

This guide helps you build a character, understand the setting, and step into a world where your actions matter. For the complete core rules (dice resolution, Position, Difficulty Values, Story Beats, Boons, and more), refer to the *Fate's Edge System Reference Document (SRD)*.

### Core Principles

The game is built on four key ideas:

**Narrative First** Mechanics serve the story. Rules reward descriptive play and creative problem-solving.

**Risk Creates Drama** Every roll carries tension. Even success may come at a cost.

**Meaningful Growth** Experience is a currency of choice. Invest in yourself or in your influence on the world.

**Consequences Matter** No action is free. Every choice changes the fiction.

### Style of Play

Expect cinematic, collaborative storytelling:

- Stories driven by character choices.
- A world that reacts to your decisions.

- Themes of legacy, sacrifice, and moral complexity.

Whether you are a lone duelist, a scheming mastermind, or a spirit-touched outlander, your path is yours to forge.

## Safety Tools: Lines, Veils & X-Card

### Safety Tools: Lines, Veils & X-Card

Fate's Edge explores mature themes—conflict, loss, horror, betrayal, and difficult choices. The table should always feel safe. Use these simple tools to keep the game enjoyable for everyone.

**X-Card (by John Stavropoulos).** Any player (including the GM) can draw an “X” on a card or simply say “X” when a moment makes them uncomfortable. When the X-Card is shown, the described content is **removed from the fiction**—no questions, no explanations, no judgments. You do not need to justify using the X-Card. The scene is retconned or redirected immediately.

**Lines.** A **Line** is a hard boundary: content that will not appear in the game at all. Examples: “No sexual violence,” “No harm to children,” “No body horror.” Before the campaign or a session, players name their Lines. The GM and group honor them completely.

**Veils.** A **Veil** is a soft boundary: content that can happen “off screen” or fade to black. The event is acknowledged but not described in detail. Example: “A romantic scene can happen, but fade to black before it becomes explicit.” Veils allow the story to acknowledge mature themes without forcing players to roleplay through them.

#### How to Use These Tools at Your Table.

- Establish Lines and Veils during **Session Zero** (or before your first game). Write them down where everyone can see them.
- Keep an X-Card visible on the table (a printed card, a drawn X, or a digital symbol). Remind players they can use it at any time, even mid-sentence.
- When the X-Card is used, pause, rewind if needed, and move on. Do not interrogate the player who used it.
- The GM is also a player. The GM may use the X-Card for their own comfort.
- Respect the tools. If someone calls an X-Card, trust that they had a good reason and support them.

These tools are not about censorship—they are about **consent**. They allow the group to tell darker, more intense stories together *because* everyone knows they can tap out at any time. A game that feels safe is a game that can go to the edge.

For more detail, search online for “TTRPG X-Card” or “Lines and Veils RPG”. Many free resources are available.

## Session Zero: The Foundation of Your Story

Before you roll your first die, gather with your GM and fellow players for a **Session Zero**. This is where you build the shared understanding that makes Fate's Edge sing – and where you make sure everyone is excited for the same kind of story.

## Core Philosophy to Embrace as Players

- **Optimal play = most fun.** Spending Boons, embracing failure, and courting Patron attention leads to better stories. There is no “winning” except an unforgettable session.
- **You and the GM are co-creators, not adversaries.** The GM frames pressure; you drive the fiction. No one is trying to “beat” anyone else.
- **Boons are not XP tokens.** Spend them. Hoarding Boons for conversion starves the table of drama and leads to less engagement.
- **Patrons are allies who demand payment – embrace it.** Obligation is plot, not punishment. When a Patron calls, a story hook arrives.

## Session Zero Checklist (Player's Edition)

### Session Zero Checklist

Answer these together and write down the answers where everyone can see them.

1. **Lines & Veils** – What content is off-limits (Lines) or only implied (Veils)?
2. **Tone** – Cinematic action? Grim survival? Political intrigue? Dark horror? Mix of several?
3. **Campaign length** – One-shot, short arc (3–6 sessions), or long campaign (12+ sessions)?
4. **Character hooks** – Each player shares one goal and one fear for their character.
5. **Patron interest** – Which Patrons (if any) are already watching the party?
6. **Starting situation** – Where does the story begin?
7. **House rules** – Any optional subsystems (Threat Pool, Deck of Consequences, etc.) the GM plans to use?
8. **Scheduling & attendance** – How often do you meet? What happens if a player misses a session?

Taking thirty minutes for Session Zero will save hours of mid-campaign friction and give you a richer, more invested table.

## Guide Structure

This Player's Guide contains:

- **Chapters 2–3: Core Mechanics** — Action resolution, Position, Difficulty Values, Story Beats, Boons, and character advancement. (For the complete SRD, see the separate document.)
- **Chapters 4–5: Attributes, Skills & Advancement** — Building your dice pools and growing your character.
- **Chapters 6–7: Talents & Character Concepts** — Special abilities and example builds.
- **Chapters 8–11: World & Cultures** — The peoples, lands, and factions of Fate's Edge.
- **Appendices** — Quick references, magic tags, and player tools.

### Quick Reference: Where to Find It

Use this one-page guide to jump straight to the rules you need at the table.

| What you need                             | Where to look                     |
|-------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Core resolution (roll dice, DV, outcomes) | Chapter 2 (2)                     |
| Position & Effect                         | Chapter 2 (2.8)                   |
| Combat (initiative, actions, harm)        | Chapter 2 (??)                    |
| Magic (paths, rites, backlash)            | Chapter 3 (3)                     |
| Travel (legs, clocks, roles)              | Chapter 8 (9.4)                   |
| Clocks & Fronts                           | GM Guide, Chapter 2 – ask your GM |
| Story Beats (SB)                          | Chapter 2 (2.9)                   |
| Boons (earning, spending, limits)         | Chapter 2 (2.7)                   |
| Assets & Followers                        | Chapter 7 (8)                     |
| High-tier play (Tiers IV–V)               | GM Guide, Chapter 8               |

## How to Use This Book

Read cover to cover or jump to relevant sections. Each chapter stands alone while connecting to broader themes. The SRD provides full mechanical detail; this guide focuses on character creation, setting, and player-facing options.

## Getting Started

This is a game of bold choices and lasting consequences. Your story is written in decisions—not dice rolls.

Welcome to the Edge. The world is watching.

*What will you risk to reshape the world?*

## 1.1 The Philosophy of Narrative First

In Fate's Edge, the story is not a byproduct of the rules—it is the reason the rules exist. When you sit down to play, you are not rolling dice to see what happens; you are telling a story together, with dice as your co-authors. This is the *narrative first* philosophy.

### 1.1.1 Why Narrative First?

Imagine this scene:

*Your character, a wounded duelist, faces the baron's champion in the royal arena. Your legs ache from the earlier fight, and the crowd's roar has become a physical pressure. You know one strike will end it—but you also know you are one misstep from death.*

Now consider two ways this might play out:

- **Mechanics-First Approach:** “I roll Body 3 + Melee 2 to attack. I get 3 successes. The baron's champion has 2 Harm. I win.”
- **Narrative-First Approach:** “I lunge forward, my blade a silver arc against the red of the arena sand. But my injured leg buckles—I spend 1 Boon to re-roll the die that came up 1—and



I twist to drive my shoulder into his chest instead. The crowd roars as we both fall to the sand, my blade at his throat.” *GM: “You have the advantage, but your wound has reopened. What do you do?”*

The first version tells you who won. The second tells you *how* you won and what it cost you. This is the heart of narrative first: your choices matter not because of numbers on a sheet, but because of the story they create.

### 1.1.2 Your Role in the Story

In Fate’s Edge, you are:

- **A storyteller** — Your descriptions shape the world.
- **An active participant** — Your choices drive the narrative.
- **A co-creator** — You and the GM build the story together.

This means:

- **Flavor is free:** Describe how you fight, what your character looks like, or what the world feels like—no mechanical cost, only story enrichment. *Example:* “I parry with the grace of a dancer, my movements a memory of my mother’s training, even as blood drips from my brow.”
- **Describe your action before rolling:** Do not just say “I attack”—show us how. This informs the GM’s response and often determines Position (Dominant, Controlled, Desperate). *Example:* “I use the crowd’s noise as cover to slip behind him and strike his exposed back.” (Likely *Dominant Position*.)
- **Embrace failure as opportunity:** A miss is not “you fail to hit.” It is “the blade glances off his armor, and you see the baron’s hand reach for the hilt of his dagger.” Failures should always move the story forward.

### 1.1.3 The Golden Rule

**When in doubt, make the choice that serves the story.** If you find yourself asking “What’s the optimal move?” try reframing it as “What would be most interesting for the story?”

#### Remember

In Fate’s Edge, the dice do not determine your success or failure. *You* determine the story. The dice just help decide which path you take to get there.

### 1.1.4 Flavor is Free (Even for Mundane Actions)

#### Flavor is Free

**Players:** Add descriptive details, cultural elements, and atmospheric touches without spending resources or requiring rolls. **This applies to all descriptive actions, not just magic.** Want your Vhasian duelist to parry with a flourish from royal fencing schools? Go ahead. Want to describe the eerie silence of a Valewood ruin when searching for clues? Perfect. Want to narrate how you reload your crossbow with a practiced flick of the wrist? Even better. Flavor enriches the narrative without changing mechanical outcomes. Describe your character’s background, customs, or scene details. The GM should encourage this and reciprocate. Mechanics determine success or failure, but flavor determines the story we tell about it.

## Narrative-Heavy Gameplay Options (Optional)

For groups that prefer strong narrative focus, consider these approaches:

- **Collaborative Scene Framing:** Players may suggest scene elements (weather, NPC reactions, environmental details) that fit the fiction, with GM approval.
- **Intent-Driven Resolution:** When success is reasonably assured, the GM may ask players to describe *how* they accomplish their goal rather than rolling.
- **Flashback Declarations:** Spend 1 Boon to declare a flashback establishing past preparation, and describe the scene.
- **Descriptive Assistance:** Players can assist each other by providing vivid descriptions, granting a +1 die to the primary actor's roll.
- **Narrative Control Points:** Each player starts each session with 1 Narrative Control Point. Spend it to:
  - Introduce a minor NPC who provides useful information or assistance.
  - Establish that they have a useful item on hand (within reason).
  - Create a favorable environmental detail.

These points refresh each session and encourage proactive storytelling.

## What's Next?

The next chapter covers the core mechanics that drive play. If you are eager to build a character, jump ahead to Chapter 4 (Attributes Skills). For an overview of the world, see Chapter 11 (World Regions and Cultures).

Now close the book—or keep reading. The road is waiting.

# Chapter 2

## Core Mechanics

### A Word from the Raven Road

*“The road is a ledger. Every broken wheel is a debt, every lit lamp a witness. The only question is: what are you willing to owe?”* — Dusana of the Raven Road, *The Hearth Ledger*

### 2.1 The 90-Second Play Loop

At the heart of every scene is a simple, fast loop that keeps the story moving:

1. **GM sets the stage** – Describe the situation and ask “What do you do?”
2. **Player declares intent and approach** – State what you want to achieve and how (Attribute + Skill).
3. **GM sets Position and Difficulty Value (DV)** – Choose Dominant/Controlled/Desperate and a DV (2–5+).
4. **Player rolls dice** – Count Successes (6+) and Story Beats (1s).
5. **Apply outcome** – Compare Successes to DV (Clean Success / Success with Cost / Partial / Miss).
6. **GM spends Story Beats (SB)** – Introduce complications, advance clocks, or escalate the scene.
7. **Player marks resources** – Gain Boons (1 on Partial, 2 on Miss), track Fatigue/Harm, update Obligation, etc.
8. **Pass the spotlight** – Next player acts, or GM frames a new beat.

This loop should take about 90 seconds per player action. If it drags, simplify: focus on intent, one roll, and a clear consequence.

### 2.2 The Core Resolution Cycle

Every meaningful action in Fate’s Edge follows this cycle:

1. **Declare Action & Approach:** State what you want to achieve and how (Attribute + Skill).
2. **GM sets Difficulty Value (DV):** Based on narrative stakes (see 2.5).
3. **GM sets Position:** Dominant, Controlled, or Desperate (see 2.8).
4. **Roll dice pool:** Attribute + Skill d10s.

5. **Count Successes (6+) and Story Beats (1s).**
6. **Check against DV using the Outcome Matrix** (see 2.6).
7. **Apply outcome:** Clean Success, Success with Cost, Partial, or Miss.
8. **GM spends Story Beats (SB)** for complications and twists.

### Golden Rule

**When in doubt, make the choice that serves the story.** If you find yourself asking “What’s the optimal move?” try reframing it as “What would be most interesting for the story?”

## 2.3 Player-Managed Modules

In Fate’s Edge, you are the primary manager of your character’s mechanical state. This isn’t just about convenience—it is a core design principle that reduces GM overhead and keeps you engaged.

### You Track Your Own Story

#### What You Manage:

- Obligation tracks (one per Patron or Symbol)
- Corruption clocks (Cantors, Pact-Whisperers)
- Leash clocks (summoned spirits)
- Asset states (Maintained, Neglected, Compromised)
- Follower conditions (Exposure, Harm)
- Progression clocks (Repertoire, Spirit Bond)
- Boons, Favour, Leverage

#### Your Responsibilities:

1. **Mark immediately** when a rule says “mark +X”.
2. **Declare thresholds** (“My Obligation is full!”).
3. **Keep it visible** (use trackers everyone can see).
4. **Maintain ownership** – you know your state best.

**GM Support:** The GM spot-checks and provides consequences, but you drive your character’s mechanical narrative.

### Example: Tracking Your Obligation

A character with Spirit2 and Presence2 has an Obligation Capacity of 4. She invokes a Rite from PatronA (+1), then later Pushes a Rite from PatronB (+1), then Cracks the Seal on a Symbol (+2). She now has:

- PatronA: 1 segment
- PatronB: 1 segment
- Symbol (Invoker): 2 segments

Total Obligation=4 → exactly at Capacity. No Fatigue yet. If she invokes one more Rite from any Patron, she exceeds Capacity and marks **\*\*1 Fatigue\*\*** immediately.

## 2.4 Basic Dice Mechanics

When you attempt a significant action, roll a pool of ten-sided dice (d10s). The size of your pool is:

$$\text{DicePool} = \text{Attribute} + \text{Skill}$$

**Attribute** (1–5) Broad traits like Strength, Wit, or Charm.

**Skill** (0–5) Training in a specific area (e.g., Melee, Stealth, Arcana).

### Lore of the Fall: The Weight of Numbers

*“The Aeler count their breaths; the Aelaerem pour eight cups and stop. The ninth is not a number – it is a wound that hasn’t closed.”* In Fate’s Edge, dice are not mere randomisers. They are the echo of every oath sworn, every debt unpaid. When you roll a 1, you feed the Hollow – and the Hollow feeds the story.

## Reading the Dice

Each die that rolls **6 or higher** counts as a **Success**. Each die that rolls a **1** generates a **Story Beat (SB)**.

| Die Result | Effect             |
|------------|--------------------|
| 6–10       | +1 Success         |
| 1          | +1 Story Beat (SB) |
| 2–5        | Nothing            |

**2.4.0.0.1 Example:** Lyra (Agility 3 + Stealth 2 = 5 dice) rolls: 6, 4, 3, 1, 6 → 2 Successes, 1 SB. The DV is 2 – she succeeds, but the GM has 1 SB to spend (perhaps a guard stirs).

### When to Roll

You roll only when:

- The outcome is uncertain, **and**
- Failure would matter to the story, **and**
- The action is significant enough to deserve a spotlight.

For routine actions with no real risk, the group can simply agree that you succeed. *Example:* Climbing a knotted rope in calm weather → no roll. Climbing the same rope while goblins shoot arrows → roll.

## 2.5 Difficulty Value (DV)

The Game Master sets a **Difficulty Value** – the target number of Successes needed.

### Difficulty Value (DV) Ladder

| DV       | Situation                                   |
|----------|---------------------------------------------|
| 2        | Routine, no pressure                        |
| <b>3</b> | <b>Pressured, mild opposition (default)</b> |
| 4        | Difficult, active resistance                |
| 5+       | Extreme, high stakes                        |

**DV 3 is the default.** If the GM calls for a roll, something is at stake. Do not inflate DVs – they already do their job.

# 2.6 The Outcome Matrix

Compare your Successes to the DV to determine the outcome.

| Outcome Matrix                          |                                                                           |
|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Outcome                                 | What It Means                                                             |
| <b>Clean Success</b> (S ≥ DV)           | You achieve your goal without complication.                               |
| <b>Success with Cost</b> (S ≥ DV, SB>0) | You succeed, but the GM spends SB to add a twist.                         |
| <b>Partial</b> (0 < S < DV)             | You make progress, but the situation remains unresolved. You gain 1 Boon. |
| <b>Miss</b> (S = 0)                     | You fail, and the situation escalates. You gain 2 Boons.                  |

**2.6.0.0.1 What a Partial Means.** A Partial is not failure – it moves the story forward. Examples:

- Improve your Position for the next attempt (see 2.8).
- Reduce the effective DV of the next roll.
- Succeed at reduced scale or duration.
- Reveal information or open a new path.

**Fail Forward**

A **Miss** is never “nothing happens.” The GM must introduce a complication, advance a clock, or reveal a hidden danger. You gain 2 Boons – the story moves, and you get resources to try again.

*Example:* You fail to pick a lock (Miss). The GM says: “Your pick snaps, but you hear the guard’s footsteps – he’s about to turn the corner. You have one beat to hide.” The story advances.

## 2.6.1 Critical Successes

A roll of **10** counts as **two Successes**. If the roll succeeds, each 10 adds narrative weight.

| 10s | Effect                                                                                                        |
|-----|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | Strong success – improve your Position by one step on your next action this scene, or gain a minor advantage. |
| 2   | Exceptional success – choose two benefits from the list above.                                                |
| 3   | Legendary success – decisive victory; clear 1 segment from a relevant clock.                                  |
| 4+  | Mythic success – reshape the scene; clear 1–2 segments from a relevant clock.                                 |

**Example: Rolling a 10**

Lyra rolls 3 dice: **10**, 8, 1. She gets: 2 successes (from the 10) + 1 success (from the 8) = 3 successes. The roll also generates 1 SB (from the 1). Because she rolled a 10, the GM grants an extra benefit: “Your arrow pierces the bandit’s shoulder – he drops his sword.” (*Narrative benefit chosen by GM.*)

**Important:** 10s are never re-rolled by Position effects. Critical effects apply only if the roll succeeds.

## 2.7 Boons

Boons represent momentum and narrative leverage. You may hold up to **5 Boons**.

**Lore of the Velvet Touch**

*“The coin that never spends is the one you don’t remember taking.”* Boons are the thief’s best friend – a second chance when the lock clicks wrong, a sudden shadow when the guard turns. In Silkstrand, they say a Boon is a debt to luck, and luck always collects.

**Why You Should Spend Boons – The Math of Fun**

**Hoarding Boons for XP conversion leads to less engagement and lower fun scores.**

Every Boon you hold is a dramatic moment waiting to happen:

- Re-rolling a critical failure turns despair into triumph.
- Improving Position before a risky roll turns a Desperate gamble into a Controlled chance.
- Activating an Asset brings your character’s network into the story.

**XP from Boons is a trickle (max 2 per session).** The real reward is *agency*. Spend Boons freely – they are not XP tokens.

*Example:* You have 3 Boons. Instead of converting them later, use 1 to re-roll a missed lockpick, another to improve your Position before a fight, and save the last for an emergency. That is how legends are made.

### 2.7.1 Earning Boons

- **Partial Success:** Gain 1 Boon (see 2.6).
- **Miss:** Gain 2 Boons.
- **Bond-Driven Action:** Once per bond per session, gain 1 Boon when an action meaningfully engages that bond (see ??).
- **GM Award:** For creativity, sacrifice, or strong narrative play.

**When not awarded:** Safe rehearsal, null-risk probes, or repeated identical attempts in the same scene do not generate Boons.

### 2.7.2 Spending Boons

- Re-roll a single die (after seeing the result)
- Activate an on-screen Asset (1 Boon)
- Improve Position by 1 step before a roll (see 2.8)
- Power certain Rites or abilities (see 3)

- Convert to XP (2 Boons = 1 XP, once per session during downtime, max 2 XP per session)

### 2.7.3 Carryover Limit

At the end of each scene, reduce held Boons to a maximum of **2**. Excess are lost – spend them or lose them.

## 2.8 Position

Every action takes place from a **Position** that reflects the character's advantage.

#### Position Effects

| Position   | Narrative Frame          | Mechanical Effect            |
|------------|--------------------------|------------------------------|
| Dominant   | You press your advantage | Re-roll one <i>failure</i> . |
| Controlled | Balanced norm            | No re-rolls.                 |
| Desperate  | You act under duress     | Re-roll one <i>success</i> . |

You can spend **1 Boon** to improve Position by one step before rolling. The GM can spend **2 SB** to worsen your Position by one step (after the roll).

#### A Vhasian Duelist's Lesson

*“On the Pont-du-Tithe, Position is everything. Stand with the sun at your back – you are Dominant. Feet on a slippery plank – Desperate. The bridge does not care for your pride.”*  
Your Position is the story's judgement of your risk. Change the fiction, and Position follows.

**2.8.0.0.1 Boon Interaction with Fatigue:** When Fatigue forces a success re-roll (see 2.10.1), spending 1 Boon negates *one* such re-roll. You may spend Boons after seeing the result of a Fatigue re-roll.

#### Boon Economy at a Glance

| Action                         | Boon Change                             | Maximum |
|--------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|---------|
| Partial Success                | Gain 1 Boon                             |         |
| Miss                           | Gain 2 Boons                            |         |
| Bond-Driven Action             | Gain 1 Boon (once/bond/session)         |         |
| GM Award                       | +1 Boon (rare)                          |         |
| Re-roll a die                  | Spend 1 Boon                            |         |
| Activate Asset                 | Spend 1 Boon                            |         |
| Improve Position (before roll) | Spend 1 Boon                            |         |
| Convert to XP (downtime)       | Spend 2 Boons → 1 XP (max 2 XP/session) |         |

**held:** 5 Boons. At end of scene, reduce to **2** (excess lost).



## 2.9 Story Beats (SB)

Story Beats are narrative tools the GM spends to introduce twists. They keep the story alive with complications.

### 2.9.1 SB Spend Examples

- **1 SB:** Minor complication – noise, trace, +1 Supply segment.
- **2 SB:** Moderate setback – alarm raised, lose cover, lesser foe appears.
- **3 SB:** Serious trouble – reinforcements, key gear breaks.
- **4+ SB:** Major turn – trap springs, authority arrives, scene shifts.

**2.9.1.0.1 Player Advice:** Don't fear Story Beats – they are fuel for drama, not punishment. Every time you roll a 1, you give the GM a spark. That spark can light a fire that makes the story burn brighter.

## 2.10 Harm and Fatigue

### 2.10.1 Fatigue Track

Each character has a Fatigue track equal to **Body**. Mark Fatigue for exertion, magical strain, or stress.

- Each Fatigue step worsens your Position: Dominant → Controlled → Desperate (see 2.8).
- If already Desperate, apply –1 die per Fatigue instead.
- Penalties from Fatigue and Harm **stack**. For example, a character with Harm1 (–1 die) who is also Desperate from Fatigue suffers both penalties.
- **Overflow:** When the track fills, increase Harm by 1 step (see 2.10.3) and clear all Fatigue.
- **Recovery:** Short rest clears 1–2 Fatigue; full night's rest clears all.

#### Aeler Breath-Counting

*“The Deep Accountants say: eight breaths is a corridor, sixteen is a chamber, thirty-two is a fool who forgot to turn back. Fatigue is your breath running out – mark it, or the mountain will mark you.”* Fatigue is not just tiredness; it is the weight of every hard choice you've already made.

### 2.10.2 The Roller-Coaster Effect (Taking Harm Clears Fatigue)

When you take Harm, the shock of the wound temporarily clears your Fatigue. This creates natural dramatic swings – a character near collapse who takes a wound and suddenly finds a second wind.

**2.10.2.0.1 Example:** Kael is at Fatigue 3 (Desperate, –2 dice). A goblin stabs him for Harm 1. Following the procedure in 2.10.4, the Harm clears his Fatigue (step2), then he adds the converted Fatigue (step3). He ends with Harm1, Fatigue0 – wounded but clear-headed.

### 2.10.3 Harm Levels

| Harm Level | Effect                               |
|------------|--------------------------------------|
| Harm 1     | −1 die on related actions            |
| Harm 2     | −1 die on most actions until treated |
| Harm 3     | Incapacitated or dying               |

### 2.10.4 Taking Harm and Fatigue – The Procedure

When you are hit, follow these steps **in order**:

1. **Convert** incoming Harm to Fatigue using your Armor Conversion (see 2.10.4.0.1). **Minimum 1 Fatigue** per hit, even if the conversion would give 0.
2. **Apply remaining Harm** – if any Harm remains after conversion, increase your Harm level by that amount, and **clear all existing Fatigue** (the shock of a wound resets your exhaustion).
3. **Add the Fatigue** from step1 to your Fatigue track. If this fills or exceeds your track, resolve **Overflow** (see 2.10.1).

#### 2.10.4.0.1 Armor Conversion Table

| Armor Type | Conversion (Harm → Fatigue)                  |
|------------|----------------------------------------------|
| Light      | 1 Harm → 1 Fatigue (minimum 1 Fatigue total) |
| Medium     | 2 Harm → 1 Fatigue (minimum 1 Fatigue total) |
| Heavy      | 3 Harm → 2 Fatigue (minimum 1 Fatigue total) |

#### 2.10.4.0.2 Examples

- **Light Armor, Harm 2:** Convert 1→1 Fatigue, remaining Harm 1. Apply Harm (clears Fatigue, Harm0→1), then add 1 Fatigue. Result: Harm1, Fatigue1.
- **Heavy Armor, Harm 3:** Convert 3→2 Fatigue, remaining Harm 0. No Harm taken, add 2 Fatigue. Result: Fatigue +2.
- **Heavy Armor, Harm 1:** Convert 1→0 Fatigue, but minimum 1 Fatigue. No Harm, add 1 Fatigue. Result: Fatigue +1.
- **Overflow:** Body2, currently 1 Fatigue, Heavy Armor hit with Harm3. Convert 3→2 Fatigue. Add Fatigue: 1+2=3 → track full. Overflow triggers: Harm0→1, clear Fatigue. Result: Harm1, Fatigue0.

### 2.10.5 Recovery

- **Fatigue:** Short rest (food/water) removes 2 Fatigue; full night removes all.
- **Harm:** Requires medical care and time – minor treatment downgrades Harm, proper care removes it.

## 2.11 Initiative and Turn Order

**2.11.0.0.1 Default: Narrative Initiative.** Fate’s Edge does not use fixed initiative. Turn order follows the fiction:

- **Narrative Fiat:** The GM frames spotlight order based on circumstances.

- **Player Input:** Players may suggest acting when it makes sense.
- **Surprise:** Ambushers act first; targets respond after.
- **Flexibility:** Spotlight may shift mid-scene if fictionally appropriate.

(Optional structured initiative systems – popcorn, side-based, speed slots – are available in the GM Guide if your table prefers them.)

### 2.11.1 Turn Economy (Quick Rules)

Each character takes **1 Action and 1 Move** on their turn. Actions and Moves may be taken in any order; repeating the same Action is not allowed unless noted.

**2.11.1.0.1 Move:** Traverse up to **one range band** (Close → Near → Far, or the reverse).

- **Stand:** Use your Move to stand from prone.

## 2.11.1.0.2 Action Options:

| Action                    | Effect                                                      | Notes                                                                                                                                             |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Attack                    | Make melee or ranged attack against a target.               | Ranged in Close is <b>Desperate</b> .                                                                                                             |
| Disengage                 | Enable safe movement.                                       | Your Move does not provoke opportunity attacks; you cannot Attack this turn.                                                                      |
| Charge (Full turn)        | Move two bands toward an enemy + make one melee attack.     | Costs 1 Fatigue, next defense Desperate, requires open ground. <b>Leaving Close range during a Charge provokes opportunity attacks as normal.</b> |
| Skirmish (Full turn)      | Move two bands away from an enemy + make one ranged attack. | Costs 1 Fatigue, next defense Desperate, requires open ground.                                                                                    |
| Observe / Change Position | Gain +1 Position once.                                      | Once per turn.                                                                                                                                    |
| Setup (Teamwork)          | Grant an ally +1 Position or step up Effect.                | Requires a roll (typically Wits + relevant skill).                                                                                                |
| Assist (Teamwork)         | Spend 1 Boon to give +1 die to an ally's roll.              | Max +3 dice from all assists.                                                                                                                     |
| Defend / Protect          | Adopt a guarding stance.                                    | Your defense rolls improve Position by one step.                                                                                                  |
| Channel / Weave           | Runekeeper/ritual preparation.                              | Interruption may worsen Position.                                                                                                                 |
| Cast Rite / Song          | Perform a magical action.                                   | May Push (cost Fatigue/Corruption).                                                                                                               |
| Interact                  | Manipulate an object or environment.                        | GM sets DV.                                                                                                                                       |
| Free Items                | Short shouts, dropping an item.                             | Longer actions require proper action types.                                                                                                       |

### Helping Others – Assistance

You can help an ally on their roll:

- **Assist (Spend 1 Boon):** Give the ally +1 die on their roll. You must describe how you help (distract, flank, steady, etc.).
- **Setup (Take an Action):** Roll an appropriate skill (DV set by GM). On success, the ally gains +1 Position or +1 Effect on their next action.

**Limits:** Only one assistant per PC per exchange (by default). Max total assist dice from all sources: **+3**.

**2.11.1.0.3 Opportunity Attacks** Leaving an enemy's **Close** range without using *Disengage* provokes one free melee attack (Controlled Position, no action cost). Additionally, the following actions provoke an opportunity attack if performed while **engaged in Close** with an enemy:

- Making a ranged attack (bow, crossbow, thrown weapon).
- Casting a spell that does not have the [TOUCH] or [WARD] attribute.

A **Charge** that takes you out of an enemy's Close range provokes an opportunity attack as usual (unless you used *Disengage* beforehand).

### 2.11.1.0.4 Position and Dice Modifiers

- **Position ladder:** Desperate → Controlled → Dominant.
- **Improving Position:** Each step above Dominant grants **+1 die** instead.
- **Worsening Position:** Each step below Desperate imposes **-1 die** instead.
- **Example:** If bonuses would raise Position two steps above Dominant, you gain **+2 dice**. If penalties would drop you two steps below Desperate, you suffer **-2 dice**.

### 2.11.1.0.5 Caveats and Talents:

- **Charge** and **Skirmish** require open ground (no difficult terrain) unless a talent says otherwise (see ??).
- Talents such as *Effortless Charge* (4 XP) or *Effortless Skirmish* (4 XP) allow ignoring the Fatigue cost once per scene.
- The *Relentless* talent (6 XP) allows Charge or Skirmish over difficult terrain (Fatigue cost still applies).

## Combat in Brief

- **Turn:** 1 Action + 1 Move.
- **Move:** Close Near Far.
- **Attack:** Roll Attribute + Skill vs. DV (enemy's defense). Ranged attack while in Close range → Desperate.
- **Harm:** When you hit, the target marks Harm (see 2.10.4). Enemies use the same Harm levels as players.
- **Fatigue:** Each point worsens your Position (or -1 die if already Desperate). Taking Harm clears Fatigue – the “roller-coaster”.
- **Clocks:** GMs often use clocks for reinforcements, environmental collapse, or enemy morale.

*Full combat rules are in Chapter ?? (GM Guide).*

## 2.12 Weapons & Armor

### Silkstrand Steel

*“A Light blade is a courtier’s promise – fast, elegant, easy to hide. A Heavy blade is a condotta captain’s ultimatum – slow, brutal, and final.”* Choose your weight as you choose your words. Both can cut.

### 2.12.1 Weapons by Weight Class

- **Light (4 XP)** – fast, concealable.
- **Medium (8 XP)** – balanced, battlefield standard.
- **Heavy (12 XP)** – punishing, slow.

### 2.12.2 Melee Modifiers

| Weight | Close | Near | Notes                              |
|--------|-------|------|------------------------------------|
| Light  | +2d   | +1d  | Quick in tight quarters            |
| Medium | +1d   | +2d  | Set once/scene or -1d first attack |
| Heavy  | -1d   | +3d  | Set once/scene or -2d first attack |

### 2.12.3 Ranged & Tempo

| Weight        | Tempo    | Close      | Near | Far |
|---------------|----------|------------|------|-----|
| Light (4 XP)  | Fast     | Controlled | +1d  | —   |
| Medium (8 XP) | Standard | Desperate  | +2d  | +1d |
| Heavy (12 XP) | Slow     | Desperate  | +1d  | +3d |

**2.12.3.0.1 Tempo:** **Fast** = Move+Shoot. **Standard** = Move or Shoot, Aim for +1d/+1 Effect. **Slow** = Set/Brace, full reload, cannot Move+Shoot.

### 2.12.4 Weapon Tags (Optional, +4 XP each, max 2)

Reach, Close, Accurate, Brutal, Hook, Concealable, Quickdraw, Two-Handed, Off-Hand.

### 2.12.5 Shields (Optional)

| Shield  | XP | Benefit                              | Tradeoff            |
|---------|----|--------------------------------------|---------------------|
| Buckler | 4  | +1d Defend vs melee or +1 DV once    | Off-hand occupied   |
| Heater  | 8  | +1d Defend; convert 1 Harm→1 Fatigue | −1d Ranged          |
| Pavise  | 12 | Plant: heavy cover cone              | Slow to move; bulky |

### 2.12.6 Armor

| Armor  | XP | Conversion (Harm → Fatigue)     | Penalty                          |
|--------|----|---------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| Light  | 4  | 1→1 (minimum 1 Fatigue per hit) | —                                |
| Medium | 8  | 2→1 (minimum 1 Fatigue per hit) | −1d physical skills              |
| Heavy  | 12 | 3→2 (minimum 1 Fatigue per hit) | −2d physical, no sprint in rough |

**2.12.6.0.1 Notes:** Conversion is applied per Harm instance before marking Fatigue. See [2.10.4](#) for the full step-by-step procedure.

### 2.12.7 Condition & Upkeep

**Neglected Weapons:** −1d; **Armor:** conversion worsened by one step (e.g., Light behaves as no armor, Heavy as Medium).

**Compromised Weapons:** −1d first attack each round; **Armor:** no conversion.

*Fix:* Short rest with tools removes Neglected (no roll required). A scene of work or a smith removes Compromised; a successful Craft roll (DV3) can reduce the time to a short rest.

## 2.13 Ranged Options

- **Aim:** +1 die or +1 Effect next shot (lost if you Move or are disrupted).
- **Volley:** Spend extra ammo for +1 die (max +2).
- **Suppress:** Zone under fire; foes there act at −1 die or Limited Effect until they shift cover.
- **Overwatch:** Ready a Controlled shot on a clear trigger crossing your line.

## 2.14 Followers and Assets

### 2.14.1 Followers

Followers are named NPCs with a personal relationship to your character. They:

- Assist during scenes via Bonds and Assists (see ??).
- Act offscreen to gather information or manage tasks.
- Have motives and vulnerabilities – the GM may place them at risk.

Followers are not disposable tools. They can grow, change, or be lost.

### 2.14.2 Assets

Assets are durable resources or positions under your control – safehouses, networks, political offices, relics. They:

- Create advantages that persist beyond a single scene.

- Resolve problems that dice alone cannot.
- Cost Boons to activate (the GM determines the impact).

Assets can be threatened, degraded, or lost. Overuse attracts attention.

### 2.14.3 Followers vs. Assets

|              | Followers                                     | Assets                 |
|--------------|-----------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| Nature       | People                                        | Resources/Structures   |
| Primary Role | Personal support                              | Strategic leverage     |
| Activation   | Assists (spend Boon) or narrative interaction | Boon expenditure       |
| Risk         | Emotional, narrative                          | Structural, political  |
| Growth       | Can become PCs                                | Can expand or collapse |

**2.14.3.0.1 Design Principle:** Followers create *depth*. Assets create *reach*. High-tier play depends on managing both.

## 2.15 Game Structure

### 2.15.1 Time Scales

**Moment** A heartbeat, a single action.

**Some Time** A few minutes, a short activity.

**Significant Time** Hours, extended effort.

**Days** Large-scale endeavors.

### 2.15.2 Game Units

**Scene** Basic narrative unit, covers a specific conflict.

**Session** One game session (3–6 hours).

**Campaign** Entire story arc.

## 2.16 Action Resolution Steps

1. Describe your intent and method.
2. Build dice pool: Attribute + Skill (+ gear, assists).
3. Roll d10s; count Successes (6+) and Story Beats (1s).
4. Compare Successes to DV.
5. Apply outcome from the Outcome Matrix (see 2.6).
6. GM spends SB if applicable (see 2.9).
7. Earn Boons for Partial or Miss (see 2.7).



### Quick Reference

**Dice Pool:** Attribute + Skill d10s  
**Success:** 6+ on each die  
**Story Beat:** 1 on any die gives SB to GM  
**DV:** 2 (easy) to 5+ (extreme) – default 3  
**Harm:** 3-level system; see 2.10.4 for the procedure  
**Boons:** 2 on miss, 1 on partial

## 2.17 Narrative Suggestions

- **Collaborative Scene Framing:** Players may suggest scene elements (weather, NPC reactions) with GM approval.
- **Intent-Driven Resolution:** If success is reasonably assured, the GM may ask players to describe *how* rather than roll.
- **Flashback Declarations:** Spend 1 Boon to declare a flashback establishing past preparation, and describe the scene.
- **Descriptive Assistance:** Players can assist by providing vivid descriptions, granting a +1 die to the primary actor.
- **Proactive Storytelling:** Players may suggest minor favorable details (a helpful NPC, a useful item on hand) subject to GM approval.

### Core Mechanics Quick Reference

| What            | How                                                                                                                                                     |
|-----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Dice Pool       | Attribute + Skill d10s                                                                                                                                  |
| Success         | Die 6                                                                                                                                                   |
| Story Beat (SB) | Die = 1                                                                                                                                                 |
| Difficulty (DV) | Default 3 (2=easy, 4=hard, 5+=extreme)                                                                                                                  |
| Outcomes        | Clean Success (SDV, SB=0)<br>Success with Cost (SDV, SB>0)<br>Partial ( $0 < S < DV \rightarrow$ gain 1 Boon)<br>Miss ( $S=0 \rightarrow$ gain 2 Boons) |
| Boons           | Max 5; trim to 2 at scene end. Spend: re-roll, improve Position, activate Asset, convert 2→1                                                            |
| Position        | Dominant (re-roll failure), Controlled (normal), Desperate (re-roll success)                                                                            |
| Fatigue         | Worsens Position (or –1 die if Desperate). Full track → Harm+1, clear Fatigue.                                                                          |
| Harm            | 1 (–1 die), 2 (–2 dice), 3 (incapacitated). Taking Harm clears Fatigue first.                                                                           |
| Armor           | Converts Harm to Fatigue; minimum 1 Fatigue per hit.                                                                                                    |

# Chapter 3

## Magic and Special Abilities

Magic in this game is powerful but dangerous—a negotiation with reality itself that always carries risks. This chapter covers the core magical systems and the distinct paths a character may follow.

### Sidebar: [TAGS] & Magic

**What are [TAGS]?** Effects in *Fate's Edge* are communicated via [TAGS]. Each [TAG] is a discrete effect gated behind a Talent, Rite, spell, or asset—it *cannot be invoked spontaneously* unless a rule grants access.

**How they're used.** [TAGS] provide a common language for describing effects, especially when players invent spells via *Free Casting*. Many prewritten spells and abilities also list their [TAGS] for clarity.

### 3.1 The Nature of Magic

Magic is not a safe tool but a dangerous force:

- **Powerful:** Can reshape battles, stories, or even the world.
- **Controlled:** Every use generates **Story Beats (SB)** that manifest as backlash (see 2).
- **Thematic:** Effects and consequences align with the type of magic used.
- **Volatile:** Never fully predictable or controllable.
- **Narrative:** Casting is always a significant story moment.

**3.1.0.0.1 Table Vignette:** “*I can hold the avalanche,*” says Mira, *fingers trembling.* “*But something will answer.*” The party nods—risk accepted, stakes clear.

#### 3.1.1 Patron as Co-Star

Your Patron is not just a source of power—they are a **co-star** in your story. How often they appear depends on your campaign's length. Ask your GM which style they will use:

**Passive Patrons (long campaigns)** – The Patron stays in the background, appearing only when Obligation thresholds are breached. Their demands feel like slow, inevitable consequences.

**Active Patrons (short campaigns / one-shots)** – The Patron appears often: in dreams, omens, or through intermediaries. They offer bargains, push the Obligation spiral, and make the price

of power immediate.

**Player advice:** Embrace Patron demands as *story hooks*, not punishments. When the GM says “Your Patron requires a task,” lean into it. That task will lead to adventure, not just a tax. A Patron who intervenes is a Patron who cares – and a caring Patron is a source of power and drama.

#### For Full Patron Details

The complete descriptions of all Patrons—including their Rites, Obligation mechanics, and corruption tables—are found in **Chapter 12 (World Powers and Obligation)**. That chapter also covers terrestrial patrons, faction obligations, and the mechanics of clearing debt. This chapter focuses on the *paths* of magic; for the *sources* of power, see the World Powers chapter.

## 3.2 Paths of Magic

Magic in *Fate’s Edge* is not a single system. Characters may follow one of several distinct paths, each with its own mechanics, costs, and narrative flavor. The five primary paths are:

**Free Caster** Improvisational magic using [TAGS]. Flexible but risky (3.2.1).

**Runekeeper** Structured rites granted by a Patron. Reliable but accrues Obligation (3.2.2).

**Invoker** Ritual magic using Patron symbols. Safe but slow (3.2.3).

**Cantor** Songs that mimic Low Rites. Accessible but corrupting (3.2.4).

**Summoner** Binding and commanding spirits. Powerful but requires control (3.2.5).

A character may dabble in multiple paths, but specialization is more effective.

### 3.2.1 Free Caster (Spellcraft)

Free casters shape raw magic through will and knowledge. They do not rely on Patrons or rote rites.

#### Requirements

- Talent: **Spellcraft** (6 XP) – see 6.
- Appropriate magical skill (Arcana, Elemental Magic, etc.).

#### Casting Procedure

1. **Declare Intent:** Describe the desired effect using [TAGS].
2. **Choose Approach:** Attribute + magical skill.
3. **Set Position & DV:** DV = 1 + number of [TAGS]. Dangerous tags add +2 each.
4. **Roll:** Resolve normally (see 2). Each 1 generates a Story Beat.

For powerful or complex effects, use the **Casting Loop** (two actions: Weave then Cast). Simple effects (one tag) may be cast as a **cantrip** (one action, no separate Weave).

#### Backlash

On a failure or mixed result, the GM may impose:

- Harm 2 (Arcane)
- +2 Fatigue
- Corruption +1
- A catastrophic side effect

Backlash is always flavored by the elements used.

### Free Caster Talents

**Ritual Mastery (6 XP)** Reduce casting time for major spells by half.

**Elemental Focus (4 XP)** Gain +1 die when using a chosen element.

**Stabilize Weave (8 XP)** Once per session, cancel 1 SB from a failed cast.

## 3.2.2 Runekeeper (Rites)

Runekeepers bind themselves to a single Patron, learning structured Rites that produce reliable effects.

### Requirements

- **Thiasos (Familiar) (2 XP)** – a token or bond with the Patron (see 6).
- **Codex (4 XP)** – a personal record of Rites.
- **Patron Choice:** Select one Patron (e.g., Traveler, Oath of Flame, Morag).

### Invoking a Rite

- **Action:** 1 action.
- **Cost:** Mark +1 Obligation to your Patron.
- **Effect:** The Rite works as written.
- **Push It:** Once per scene, mark +1 Obligation to amplify the effect (+1 die or +1 Effect).

### Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene, as 1 action, imbue a held item with +1 Melee and +1 Thematic skill (e.g., Navigation for Traveler). Lasts one scene. Mark +1 Obligation.

### Runekeeper Talents

**Efficient Invocation (4 XP)** Reduce Obligation cost of one specific Low Rite by 1 (min 0).

**Patron's Favor (8 XP)** Once per session, ignore Obligation cost for a Rite.

**Runebound Resilience (18 XP)** Convert up to 2 Harm into Obligation instead of damage.

## 3.2.3 Invoker (Symbols)

Invokers do not bond permanently. They use consecrated Symbols to borrow a Patron's power through ritual.

### Requirements

- **Patron's Symbol (4 XP per Patron).** One Symbol per Patron.
- No Thiasos or Codex required.

### Ritual Invocation

- **Time:** Significant Time (DV in rounds). +1 round per DV.
- **Cost:** Always mark +1 Obligation to that Patron.
- **Symbol Benefit:** If the Symbol is openly displayed, reduce DV by 1 (min 1) and Obligation by 1 (min 0).
- **No Symbol:** +1 DV, +1 Obligation, and on a partial/failure, GM gains +1 extra SB.

### Crack the Seal

Resolve a known Rite instantly as 1 action. Set the Symbol to **Compromised** and mark +2 Obligation (+3 for High Rites). Restore the Symbol during downtime (Arcana test DV 3) or spend

1 XP.

### Invoker Talents

**Borrowed Grace (Free)** Spend 1 Boon or 1 Fatigue to gain +1 Melee or +1 Thematic for one action. Mark +1 Obligation.

**Crack Specialist (6 XP)** Reduce Obligation cost of Crack the Seal by 1.

**Symbol Resonance (4 XP)** When using a Symbol, gain +1 die to the ritual roll.

### 3.2.4 Cantor (Songs)

Cantors perform Low Rites as songs, using voice and performance instead of Patron bonds.

#### Requirements

- Talent: **Cantor's Path** (8 XP) – see 6.
- Prerequisites: Lore 1+, Performance 2+, Presence 2+.

#### Performing a Song

- **Action:** 1 action to begin; resolves at start of next turn.
- **Test:** Lore + Performance (DV 2–3).
- **Cost:** Materials as listed. No Obligation on success.
- **Corruption:** Track a Corruption Clock (size = Spirit). Mark segments when you Push, perform a Resonant Rite, or when the GM spends SB on your occult activities.

#### Push It

Resolve immediately. Mark Fatigue 1, mark toward Corruption accumulation, and the GM gains 1 SB (social/Patron fallout).

#### Corruption Clock

When the clock fills, gain a thematic benefit and drawback from the last Patron whose Rite you performed. Reset the clock to a minimum of your Tier (see 4.8).

#### Chorus Cults (Optional)

If you perform a Resonant Rite before 10+ witnesses, you may found a **Chorus**. This grants a minor follower benefit (see 8), but you must mark Obligation each session you use it. **If neglected, the cult may fracture** – your followers could splinter into a rival sect, spread false rumours, or ally with a Patron's enemy. Keep an eye on your followers; a neglected Chorus can become a serious problem.

### Cantor Talents

**Resonant Performance (3 XP)** Gain +1 die when performing for an audience of 5+.

**Song Weaver (4 XP)** Combine two compatible Songs for +1 Effect.

**High Cantor (18 XP)** Learn Standard Rites as songs; resolve instantly.

### 3.2.5 Summoner (Pact-Whisperer)

Summoners call and bind Outsiders for temporary aid.

#### Requirements

- Talent: **Pact-Whisperer** (2 XP) – see 6.
- Lesser Pactwright (2 XP) for Cap 1 spirits; Greater Pactwright (4 XP) for Cap 3.

## Core Mechanics

- **Call (1 action):** Manifest a spirit at Near range.
- **Bind:** Spend 1 Boon or mark 1 Fatigue.
- **Leash Capacity:** Cap + Spirit segments.
- **Tick Leash:** Spirit takes harm, commanded against nature, crosses a [WARD], or you split focus.
- **Departure:** When Leash fills, spirit acts once according to its nature, then departs (or turns hostile at GM discretion).

## Spirit Whims Table (When the Spirit Acts on Its Own)

When the Leash fills or the spirit acts independently, the GM may choose (or roll) from this table to make the action interesting – not just damage.

| d6 Spirit's Independent Action |                                                                                                                   |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1                              | <b>Reveal a Secret:</b> The spirit blurts out a hidden fact about a PC or NPC – true, embarrassing, or damaging.  |
| 2                              | <b>Break Something:</b> The spirit shatters a mundane object (a lantern, a rope bridge, a crucial tool).          |
| 3                              | <b>Lead Astray:</b> The spirit moves a short distance and creates a false trail, forcing the party to waste time. |
| 4                              | <b>Call for Help:</b> The spirit summons a minor ally (a rat swarm, a will-o'-wisp, a lesser elemental).          |
| 5                              | <b>Curse a PC:</b> The spirit leaves a lingering mark (–1 die on one skill until the next sunrise).               |
| 6                              | <b>Bargain:</b> The spirit offers a deal: “Release me now, and I’ll tell you where the treasure is hidden.”       |

## Boon Finesse

Once per round, spend 1 Boon to clear 1 Leash tick.

## Summoner Talents

**Spirit Synergy (4 XP)** When commanding two spirits, reduce each Leash by 1.

**Spirit Link (10 XP)** Spirits act on your turn; commands are free actions.

**True Name Keeper (15 XP)** Call any previously encountered spirit by true name; reduce Leash Capacity by 2.

# 3.3 Universal Mechanics

## 3.3.1 Obligation Capacity

A character’s **Obligation Capacity** equals Spirit + Presence. Track total Obligation segments across all Patrons.

- **Exceeding Capacity:** For each segment above Capacity, mark 1 Fatigue. Cannot invoke Rites until Obligation is reduced.
- **Resolution:** Reduce Obligation through downtime service, Patron tasks, or ritual cleansing.

**Player guidance:** You track your own Obligation (see Player-Managed Modules, 2.3). When a Patron intrudes (e.g., a demand or omen), treat it as a **plot hook, not a penalty**. The Patron is offering you a story.

### Components as Devotion

Even if you already have a Patron's Symbol, Codex, or Thiasos, voluntarily acquiring rare components for a ritual shows dedication. Use this rule of thumb:

- **Ritual with no components (just Symbol/Codex):** Normal DV, normal Obligation cost.
- **Ritual with common components (herbs, salt, a candle):** Reduce Obligation by 1 (minimum 0).
- **Ritual with rare or dangerous components (a phoenix feather, a drop of troll blood, a whispered secret):** Reduce DV by 1 and clear 1 segment of existing Obligation to that Patron (once per session max).
- **Ritual with a truly legendary component (the crown of a dead king, a tear from a goddess):** The Patron may waive all Obligation for that ritual – and even grant a free Boon.

This turns component hunting into adventure hooks and gives you a meaningful choice: use the easy, costly path or invest legwork to earn the Patron's favour.

### 3.3.2 Backlash

Any magical roll can generate backlash. The GM spends Story Beats (SB) to introduce complications tied to the element or Patron involved.

| Result                     | Backlash Severity                                         |
|----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Partial                    | Minor (e.g., Position -1, Fatigue 1, minor complication)  |
| Miss                       | Major (e.g., Harm 1, condition, significant complication) |
| Critical failure (many 1s) | Catastrophic (e.g., Patron intervention, scene shift)     |

#### Backlash Severity by Position

| Position   | Backlash Severity on Partial/Miss                           |
|------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| Dominant   | Minor – one SB complication, manageable cost.               |
| Controlled | Moderate – 1–2 SB complication, temporary setback.          |
| Desperate  | Severe – 2–3 SB complication, lasting consequences or Harm. |

### Elemental Backlash Examples

- **Fire:** Burns, flares, smoke.
- **Water:** Slick footing, gear corrosion, flooding.
- **Earth:** Tremors, encumbrance, binding roots.
- **Air:** Dispersal, deafening gusts, thrown debris.
- **Fate:** Opportunities close, predictions become set.
- **Life:** Uncontrolled growth, fever, exhaustion.
- **Luck:** Fortunes reverse at the worst moment.
- **Death/Dreams:** Whispers, numbness, portents.

### 3.3.3 DV by Spell Scope

Use this table as a quick reference when the GM asks for a DV for a new spell:

| Scope          | Example                                     | DV              |
|----------------|---------------------------------------------|-----------------|
| Cantrip        | Light a candle, sense magic                 | 2               |
| Combat         | Fire bolt, force shield                     | 3               |
| Ritual (small) | Find a lost object, speak with a spirit     | 4               |
| Ritual (large) | Summon a storm, teleport across a region    | 5+              |
| Epic           | Raise a dead army, rewrite a law of reality | 6+ (with quest) |

#### When in Doubt

A spell's power is not measured by how many dice it rolls, but by **how much it changes the story**. Use this rule of thumb:

- **Minor change (1 TAG):** The effect affects only yourself or a single object. Examples: **Light**, **Mend**, **Veil** (self only). DV 2–3.
- **Moderate change (2 TAGS):** The spell affects a whole zone, creates a significant advantage, or bypasses a notable obstacle. Examples: **Area + Force**, **Barrier** across a doorway. DV 3–4.
- **Major change (3+ TAGS):** The spell rewrites the situation, solves a major problem outright, or introduces a new faction/ally/threat. Examples: **Teleport** across a city, **Summon** a Cap3 spirit, **Transform** a person into a beast. DV 5+ and often a ritual.

If your description would *skip over a scene* (“I teleport us past the entire fortress”), that’s a major change – require components, a clock, or a steep cost. If it would only *add flavour* (“I make my eyes glow red”), that’s free. Let the fiction guide the DV, not a pre-computed formula.

### 3.3.4 Example: Accepting a Cost – The Hard Choice

When a magical roll generates SB, the GM may offer you a choice instead of a flat consequence.

**3.3.4.0.1 Example:** You cast a ritual to divine an enemy’s location. The roll generates 2 SB. The GM says:

“The vision comes clearly – but your Patron’s symbol glows hot on your hand. **You can have the vision for free, or you can let the spell fizzle and keep your Obligation unchanged.** If you accept the vision, mark +2 Obligation and your Patron will demand a task next session. What do you choose?”

This turns a success into a *narrative fork*. Embrace it – the Patron’s task will be an adventure hook.

### 3.3.5 Magic in Social Situations

Using magic socially carries additional risks:

- **Discretion:** Hidden casting may require a Stealth or Subterfuge test.
- **Consent:** Affecting minds without permission is often considered a crime or taboo.
- **Reputation:** Known magic users may face distrust or fear.
- **Legal Consequences:** Many cities restrict magic use without a license.



### 3.4 Magical Item Creation

Creating permanent magical items is a complex, campaign-level endeavor. See the full rules in the *Game Master's Guide*. In brief:

- Requires high magical and craft skills (Arcana 3+, Craft 2+).
- Costs XP (minimum 5 XP for Tier I) and rare materials.
- Takes weeks or months of downtime.
- Risk of backlash or permanent curse on failure.

For temporary enchantments, use the **Patron's Gift** (3.2.2) or **Borrowed Grace** (3.2.3).

### 3.5 Optional Magic Expansions

The following systems are optional and may be introduced by the GM.

#### Psionics (Optional)

Psionics represents mental power drawn from within. It uses **Mental Fatigue** and the same resolution rules as other actions.

**Example Arts:** Telekinesis, Telepathy, Clairvoyance, Biofeedback, Astral Projection, Psychic Assault, Mind Shield, Empathic Manipulation, Precognition.

**Warning:** Psionics generates Story Beats (SB) quickly – be prepared for the GM to spend them on interesting complications. Mental backlash is common.

Each use costs Mental Fatigue. Overflow converts to normal Fatigue or Harm. Psionics carries social consequences; many societies distrust mind-readers.

#### Witchcraft (Optional)

Witchcraft is magic practiced through patron-bound Orders. Witches suffer **–1 die** in consecrated spaces and must navigate the Curse of the Unanointed.

**Ritual Magic (Weave & Cast):** Two-step process, each roll generates SB.

**Example Orders:**

- **Mab, Queen of Courts:** Glamour, bargains, fae oaths. Risk — Glamour-Bloom (lose a memory for +1 Effect).
- **Aveh, The Rider:** Identity shedding. Risk — Unface (your features blur).
- **Morag, The Hag:** Hidden costs and prophecy. Risk — Mirecloth (sacrifice identity for truth).

**Identity Cost:** Every use marks who you are. The cost is memory, identity, or reputation.

## 3.6 Quick Reference

### Magic Quick Reference

#### Free Caster

- Talent: Spellcraft (6 XP)
- DV = 1 + number of [TAGS]
- Backlash on miss or mixed

#### Runekeeper

- Thiasos + Codex (6 XP)
- 1 action, mark +1 Obligation
- Push It: +1 Obligation

#### Invoker

- Patron's Symbol (4 XP each)
- Ritual: Significant time, +1 Obligation
- Crack the Seal: instant, +2 Obligation

#### Cantor

- Cantor's Path (8 XP)
- Song: 1 action (resolves next round)
- Corruption Clock (size = Body)

#### Summoner

- Pact-Whisperer (2 XP)
- Call + Bind (1 Boon or Fatigue)
- Leash = Cap + Spirit

# Chapter 4

## Character Advancement and Capabilities

### Philosophy of Growth

**Every XP spent is a choice about who your character becomes – invest in yourself, your network, or your legacy.**

Your character is not just a collection of numbers; they are a living story. When you spend XP on an Attribute, you are saying “I become stronger, smarter, more resilient.” When you invest in a Follower or an Asset, you are saying “I build relationships and influence that outlast me.” When you buy a Talent, you are saying “This is my signature, my unique edge.”

There is no single “correct” way to grow. A lone duelist (see 5.4) might pour everything into personal skill; a merchant prince might build a trading empire. Both are valid. The question is: *what kind of story do you want to tell?*

### Why This Chapter Matters

In this game, growth is not just about numbers — it is about deciding who your character becomes. Advancement through **Experience Points (XP)** lets you shape your capabilities, influence, and legacy in the world. Every XP choice is a statement about your character’s priorities and the mark they leave behind.

Your capabilities are built on four core **Attributes** and a set of specialized **Skills**. This chapter explains how they work together, what advancement looks like in play, and offers player-facing tips for making satisfying choices.

### 4.1 Core Attributes

Attributes represent your character’s fundamental capabilities. Each is rated from 1 to 5; higher numbers mean greater potential in that area.

#### 4.1.1 Body

Physical strength, endurance, coordination, and health.

- **Used for:** melee combat, athletics, endurance tests, physical labor.
- **Typical applications:** lifting, running, climbing, fighting, resisting physical harm.

- **Associated skills:** Athletics, Brawl, Melee, Endurance (see 4.2).

**Rating guide:**

- 1: Average person; some physical activity.
- 2: Fit; trains or works physically on a regular basis.
- 3: Athlete or soldier; excellent condition.
- 4: Exceptional athlete; near peak human.
- 5: Peak human capability; legendary strength and stamina.

### 4.1.2 Wits

Mental acuity, perception, quick thinking, and problem-solving.

- **Used for:** investigation, perception, tactics, snap decisions.
- **Typical applications:** spotting details, solving puzzles, planning, reacting quickly.
- **Associated skills:** Perception, Investigation, Tactics, Lore (see 4.2).

**Rating guide:**

- 1: Average awareness; sometimes misses important cues.
- 2: Observant; notices most relevant details.
- 3: Sharp-minded; quick to spot patterns.
- 4: Exceptionally perceptive; rarely surprised.
- 5: Almost uncanny awareness; sees connections others miss.

### 4.1.3 Spirit

Willpower, intuition, mental resilience, and connection to intangible forces.

- **Used for:** resisting mental effects, intuition, magical aptitude, persistence.
- **Typical applications:** resisting fear, sensing danger, channeling magic, enduring hardship.
- **Associated skills:** Resolve, Intuition, Magic, Faith (see 4.2).

**Rating guide:**

- 1: Average willpower; somewhat suggestible.
- 2: Strong-minded; resists ordinary pressure.
- 3: Very determined; hard to intimidate.
- 4: Exceptional will; can inspire others.
- 5: Iron will; nearly unshakeable resolve.

### 4.1.4 Presence

Charisma, social influence, appearance, and force of personality.

- **Used for:** social interactions, leadership, persuasion, intimidation.
- **Typical applications:** negotiating, leading, charming, commanding attention.
- **Associated skills:** Sway, Command, Performance, Deception (see 4.2).

**Rating guide:**

- 1: Average presence; does not particularly stand out.
- 2: Noticeable; leaves a mild impression.

- 3: Charismatic; naturally influential.
- 4: Commanding; people listen when you speak.
- 5: Magnetic; can sway crowds and redefine the mood of a room.

## 4.2 Skill System

Skills represent specialized training and expertise. In play, you combine an Attribute with a relevant Skill to form your dice pool (see 2).

### 4.2.1 Skill Ratings

| Rating | Description                        |
|--------|------------------------------------|
| 0      | Untrained — no formal experience   |
| 1      | Novice — basic understanding       |
| 2      | Competent — reliable and capable   |
| 3      | Professional — expert in the field |
| 4      | Master — renowned specialist       |
| 5      | Grand Master — legendary skill     |

### 4.2.2 Skill Categories

Below are common skills grouped by theme. Your table may rename or reskin these, but the roles remain similar.

#### 4.2.2.0.1 Combat Skills

- **Melee:** swords, axes, close-quarters weapons.
- **Ranged:** bows, crossbows, thrown weapons, firearms (if present).
- **Brawl:** unarmed combat, grappling, improvised fighting.
- **Tactics:** battlefield strategy, unit coordination, ambush planning.

#### 4.2.2.0.2 Physical Skills

- **Athletics:** running, climbing, jumping, swimming.
- **Stealth:** moving unseen, hiding, blending into shadows.
- **Endurance:** resisting fatigue, harsh weather, poison, disease.
- **Craft:** building, repairing, creating tools, art, or structures.

#### 4.2.2.0.3 Social Skills

- **Sway:** persuasion, negotiation, charm.
- **Command:** leadership, intimidation, issuing orders.
- **Deception:** lying, bluffing, misdirection.
- **Performance:** entertainment, oration, acting, musical display.

#### 4.2.2.0.4 Knowledge Skills

- **Lore:** history, culture, religions, general knowledge.
- **Investigation:** research, deduction, analysis of clues.
- **Medicine:** healing, anatomy, first aid, treatment.
- **Nature:** wilderness, animals, plants, weather patterns.

#### 4.2.2.0.5 Specialized Skills

- **Arcana:** magic theory, rituals, mystical phenomena.
- **Mechanics:** devices, engineering, construction, traps.
- **Diplomacy:** formal negotiation, etiquette, protocol.
- **Streetwise:** urban survival, criminal underworld, gossip networks.

## 4.3 Building Dice Pools

Your dice pool for any action is:

$$DicePool = Attribute + Skill.$$

You roll that many d10s and interpret the results according to the core rules (see 2).

### 4.3.1 Choosing the Right Combination

The same fictional action can often be approached with different Attribute + Skill pairs, depending on how your character does it.

- **Climbing a wall:**
  - *Body + Athletics*: sheer strength and stamina.
  - *Wits + Athletics*: clever route-finding and leverage.
  - *Spirit + Athletics*: grim determination against fear or pain.
- **Persuading a guard:**
  - *Presence + Sway*: charm and personality.
  - *Wits + Sway*: logical, well-constructed arguments.
  - *Spirit + Sway*: conviction that burns through doubt.
- **Investigating a crime scene:**
  - *Wits + Investigation*: methodical observation and deduction.
  - *Spirit + Investigation*: intuitive leaps and gut feelings.
  - *Presence + Investigation*: getting witnesses to open up.

### 4.3.2 Creative Combinations

With your GM's agreement, you can justify unusual combinations that fit the fiction:

- **Body + Lore**: recalling combat drills or physical techniques.
- **Presence + Medicine**: soothing and reassuring a patient.
- **Spirit + Craft**: inspired, visionary craftsmanship.

*Example:* A ranger scales an ice wall using **Wits + Athletics** to find the safest holds, then switches to **Body + Athletics** to muscle over the lip. The fiction guides which combination fits each moment.



## 4.4 Earning Experience Points

XP represents learning through action. You gain it by engaging meaningfully with the world: overcoming challenges, taking risks, making hard choices, and leaning into your character's story.

### 4.4.1 Session Breakdown

At the end of each session, XP is awarded based on what happened at the table. A typical breakdown might look like:

- **Base Participation:** +2 XP for attending and contributing.
- **Major Objectives:** +2–4 XP for completing significant story goals.
- **Discoveries:** +1–2 XP for uncovering important lore, locations, or secrets.
- **Hard Choices:** +1–2 XP for making difficult moral or strategic decisions.
- **Story Engagement:** +1–3 XP for embracing complications and twists.
- **Personal Goals:** +1–2 XP for pursuing your character's individual storylines.

*Example:* At the end of a session, the party rogue gains:

- +2 XP for participation,
- +2 XP for helping retrieve a cursed artifact,
- +1 XP for pushing a personal rivalry subplot.

Total: 5 XP.

### 4.4.2 Game Pace Options

You and your GM can decide how quickly characters advance, matching the tone you want:

| Mode     | XP / Session | Tone                      |
|----------|--------------|---------------------------|
| Gritty   | 4–6          | Hard choices, slow growth |
| Standard | 6–10         | Balanced progression      |
| Epic     | 10–14        | Heroic, rapid development |

**Player Tip:** If you want a sweeping, mythic tale, ask for an *Epic* pace. If you want advancement to feel hard-won, lean toward *Gritty*.

### 4.4.3 Arc Completion Bonus

When a major story arc finishes (typically 3–6 sessions), everyone gains an additional +8–12 XP. One player may receive +2 XP more for a particularly memorable contribution. This rewards the story as a whole, not just individual rolls.

#### Boons vs. XP

You may convert 2 Boons → 1 XP (once per session, max 2 XP per session via conversion).

**But:** Spending Boons during play is almost always more fun. A re-rolled failure, an improved Position, or an activated Asset creates a memorable moment. Hoarding Boons for XP conversion starves the table of drama. Spend freely; the XP will come from your adventures.

## 4.5 Spending Experience Points

XP is your currency for growth. You can invest it in three broad areas:

1. **Personal Improvement** (Attributes and Skills)
2. **Special Abilities** (Talents, magic, unique tricks)
3. **Resources and Influence** (Assets, followers, organizations)

Think of these as three pillars: *what you can do*, *what makes you unique*, and *what you own or command*.

### 4.5.1 Personal Improvement

#### Attributes

Attributes are expensive but powerful. The cost to raise an Attribute is:

$$XPCost = 3 \times newrating.$$

Examples:

- Raising Body from 2 to 3 costs  $3 \times 3 = 9$  XP.
- Raising Spirit from 4 to 5 costs  $3 \times 5 = 15$  XP.

Attribute increases usually require downtime equal to the new rating in days, spent training, reflecting, or transforming yourself (see 4.7).

#### Skills

Skills are cheaper and represent focused practice. The cost is:

$$XPCost = 2 \times newlevel.$$

Examples:

- Lore  $1 \rightarrow 2$  costs  $2 \times 2 = 4$  XP.
- Melee  $3 \rightarrow 4$  costs  $2 \times 4 = 8$  XP.

Skill increases typically require downtime equal to the new level in days.

*Example:* Kara wants to improve her swordsmanship (Melee) from 2 to 3. She saves 6 XP and spends three in-game days training with her mentor. This training becomes part of the story, not just a line on a sheet.

### 4.5.2 Special Abilities

Special abilities are unique moves, talents, or tricks that define your style.

**General Abilities (4–8 XP)** Universal benefits, like improved recovery, bonus dice in a common situation, or a signature combat technique. *Example:* “Quick Recovery” — heal 1 extra Harm when you rest.

**Cultural Abilities (variable)** Abilities tied to heritage or background. They may require specific fictional positioning (see 11.3.1). *Example:* “Stone Sense” — an instinctive feel for stonework and tunnels.

**Advanced Abilities (12+ XP)** High-impact features available at higher tiers, often with strong narrative hooks or prerequisites (see 4.8). *Example:* “Master Diplomat” — once per session, you can reroll or soften the outcome of a failed major negotiation.

*Example:* A veteran bard purchases *Silver Tongue* for 6 XP, gaining the ability to sway a hostile crowd once per session. This quickly becomes their trademark in tense public scenes.

4.5.3 Resources and Influence

See §8 for full rules. As a quick reference:

**Minor Resource (4 XP, 1 week)** A small shop, basic workshop, discreet safe house, or minor contact network. Offers modest but reliable benefits.

**Standard Resource (8 XP, 2 weeks)** A decent-sized business, crew, or operation with real impact. Comes with some upkeep and obligations.

**Major Resource (12 XP, 1 month)** A large enterprise, elite team, or rare capability. Very potent but also demanding; often becomes a major part of your character’s story.

**Player Tip:** Resources pull the camera out from your character to your *sphere of influence*. A spy network means intrigue. A workshop means invention. A guild hall means politics.

When to Invest in Assets and Followers

| Player Archetype | Typical Investment | Best For                                                    |
|------------------|--------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| Solo             | 0–10% XP           | Reliable personal power, minimal upkeep.                    |
| Mixed (Balanced) | 15–25% XP          | One solid Follower or Asset (e.g., a scout or a safehouse). |
| Mastermind       | 35–55% XP          | Networks, informants, multiple Assets; build a faction.     |

**Planning for succession?** A loyal Follower (Cap 3+) can become your successor – see the **Legacy Engine** (§??). Investing in a potential heir early pays off when your character retires or falls.

## 4.6 Character Development Paths

How you spend XP shapes your character's growth. These are broad patterns, not rigid classes.

| Path       | Typical XP Split                                    | Strengths / Weaknesses                                                    |
|------------|-----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Specialist | 70–90% personal, 0–20% resources, 0–20% abilities   | Extremely effective in a narrow niche. Vulnerable outside it.             |
| Leader     | 50–65% personal, 15–25% resources, 15–25% abilities | Well-rounded, boosts the group. Rarely the best at one thing.             |
| Mastermind | 25–40% personal, 35–55% resources, 20–40% abilities | Solves problems through assets. Personally vulnerable, many moving parts. |

*Example (Leader):* A merchant-prince spends 60% of XP on personal skills and social abilities, 20% on a network of trade contacts, and 20% on talents that improve negotiation and command.

These patterns are *guides*, not rules. You can shift between them as your story evolves.

## 4.7 Training and Development Time

Most improvements take time in the fiction. Training montages, study scenes, and building projects are all opportunities for character moments.

### 4.7.1 Standard Time Requirements

- **Attribute increase:** new rating in days.
- **Skill improvement:** new level in days.
- **Resource acquisition:** about 1 week to 1 month depending on scope.
- **Ability learning:** typically 3–10 days.

### 4.7.2 Accelerated Development (Rush Rule)

You *can* attempt to learn faster, but rushing has a price.

- The group tracks a short **Risk Clock** (4 segments) for your crash training.
- If it fills, the new capability has flaws:
  - Attribute/Skill: temporary –1 die penalty until you retrain properly.
  - Resource: loyalty issues, partial effectiveness, or hidden problems.
  - Ability: unreliable effects or quirky side consequences.

*Example:* A wizard crams advanced spellwork into three frantic days. She gains the ability, but the Risk Clock fills: her spells spark and flicker until she takes time to train safely.

## 4.8 Character Progression Tiers

As you accumulate XP and capabilities, you advance through tiers that represent your growing reputation and influence.

### 4.8.1 Tier I: Novice (0–40 XP)

- Learning the ropes, establishing yourself.
- Local reputation, modest capabilities.
- Typical assets: basic equipment, a few contacts.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between life and death; a shift from Desperate to Controlled means “I live to fight another day.”

### 4.8.2 Tier II: Seasoned (41–90 XP)

- Proven capability, reliable in your specialty.
- Regional reputation, respected in your field.
- Typical assets: skilled followers, specialized equipment.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between victory and defeat; a shift from Controlled to Dominant means “I’ve earned the right to choose how this ends.”

### 4.8.3 Tier III: Veteran (91–150 XP)

- Master of your craft, significant influence.
- National reputation, can handle major challenges.
- Typical assets: multiple operations, elite teams.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between influence and control; a shift from Controlled to Dominant means “The city hangs on my decision.”

### 4.8.4 Tier IV: Paragon (151–220 XP)

- Exceptional capability, strategic influence.
- Continental influence, shapes regional outcomes.
- Typical assets: organizations, unique capabilities.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between shaping events and defining eras; a shift from Controlled to Dominant means “I am the axis upon which history turns.”

### 4.8.5 Tier V: Mythic (221+ XP)

- Legendary status, world-changing influence.
- Historical reputation, defines eras.
- Typical assets: nations, legendary artifacts.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between ending and remaking the world; a shift from Desperate to Controlled means “The universe waits on my choice.”

### 4.8.6 Position Scales with Narrative Weight

The mechanical effect of Position (re-rolling one die, see [2](#)) never changes — but what it *means* evolves with your tier:

- **Tier I:** Position defines personal survival.
- **Tier III:** Position shapes regional outcomes.
- **Tier V:** Position reshapes reality.

The system does not need to scale — your story does.

**GM Tip:** Never add mechanical bonuses to Position. Instead, deepen the narrative weight:

- **Tier I:** “Your Position shows whether you live or die.”
- **Tier V:** “Your Position shows how the world bends to your will.”

The mechanics stay consistent so the narrative can grow as large as your imagination allows.

## 4.9 Managing Allies and Followers

Allies can extend your reach but also create obligations and risks. For full rules, see §8.

### 4.9.1 Acquisition Costs

A skilled helper's cost in XP is roughly their *capability rating squared*. *Example:* A capability 3 scout costs  $3^2 = 9$  XP.

### 4.9.2 Upkeep Requirements

Each downtime period, you either:

- spend XP equal to their capability rating, **or**
- dedicate a meaningful scene to maintaining the relationship (time, favors, protection).

### 4.9.3 Risk Management

- When big complications arise, your allies can be targeted instead of you.
- Allies can handle one significant task off-screen per downtime, but this often creates extra story fallout (the GM gains a Story Beat).

## 4.10 Skill Advancement and Synergies

### 4.10.1 XP Costs

| Improvement | XP Cost |
|-------------|---------|
| 0 → 1       | 2 XP    |
| 1 → 2       | 4 XP    |
| 2 → 3       | 6 XP    |
| 3 → 4       | 8 XP    |
| 4 → 5       | 10 XP   |

### 4.10.2 Training Time

- 0 → 1: 1 day of practice.
- 1 → 2: 3 days of training.
- 2 → 3: 1 week of intensive study.
- 3 → 4: 2 weeks with a master or rigorous practice.
- 4 → 5: 1 month of dedicated focus.

### 4.10.3 Attribute Limits

You cannot have a Skill rating higher than the relevant Attribute. To advance a Skill further, you must first raise its primary Attribute (see 4.1).

### 4.10.4 Skill Synergies

When the fiction supports it, well-justified combinations of skills can grant +1 die or better Position/Effect. Examples:

- **Combat:** Tactics + Command (battlefield coordination), Melee + Athletics (acrobatic strikes).
- **Social:** Sway + Lore (persuasion backed by knowledge), Deception + Performance (long

cons).

- **Exploration:** Investigation + Perception (thorough search), Nature + Survival (tracking).

## 4.11 Using Skills in Play

### 4.11.1 When to Roll

You roll when:

- the outcome is uncertain,
- failure would matter to the story, and
- the action is significant enough to deserve the spotlight.

For routine actions with no real risk, the group can often simply agree that you succeed.

### 4.11.2 Difficulty and Skill Level

As your skill rises, routine tasks become trivial. A rough guideline:

| Skill Level | Routine Task            | Challenging Task                 |
|-------------|-------------------------|----------------------------------|
| 0           | Needs a roll; modest DV | Needs a roll; higher DV          |
| 1           | Often needs a roll      | Challenging but fair             |
| 2           | Usually automatic       | Needs a roll; moderate DV        |
| 3           | Automatic               | Needs a roll; interesting stakes |
| 4+          | Automatic               | Automatic for simple cases       |

**Reading this as a player:** by Skill 3, basic tasks in your area of expertise should rarely require rolls. You are there to be impressive, not to trip over routine jobs.

### 4.11.3 Group Skill Use

When multiple characters contribute:

- **Assistance:** One character is primary; up to three others add +1 die each by describing how they help (see 2).
- **Cooperation:** Several characters each roll; the group succeeds or fails based on combined results.
- **Complementary:** Different skills cover different parts of a larger task (e.g. one distracts, one picks a lock).

## 4.12 Skill Challenges

Some goals are too big for a single roll.

### 4.12.1 Extended Tests

For long, involved tasks:

- The group sets a progress clock (4–8 segments).
- Each significant success fills one or more segments.
- Complications can add segments or create new problems.



### 4.12.2 Complex Challenges

For multi-step or multi-skill situations:

- Different skills tackle different phases of the challenge.
- Success in one area creates opportunities; failure creates obstacles.

*Example (Heist):* **Stealth** to infiltrate, **Mechanics** to bypass locks, **Investigation** to find the vault, **Deception** to mislead guards. Each roll advances a *Heist Clock*; complications add heat, suspicion, or security changes.

## 4.13 Strategic Advancement Considerations

### 4.13.1 Early Game (Tiers I–II)

- Focus on survival and a clear niche.
- Raise a key Attribute to 3 early.
- Bring core Skills to 2–3.
- Establish one or two modest resources or safe havens.

### 4.13.2 Mid Game (Tier III)

- Develop signature moves or combinations.
- Expand your resource base.
- Consider your role in the group and lean into it.

### 4.13.3 Late Game (Tiers IV–V)

- Choose advanced abilities that reshape the story around you.
- Build organizations, movements, or legacies.
- Decide how your character will leave their mark on the world.

#### Common Advancement Mistakes

**Avoid these pitfalls:**

- **Over-specializing too early:** A Melee 5 character with Body 3 is fragile and incapable outside combat.
- **Forgetting training time:** You cannot learn a new skill in the middle of a dungeon without justification.
- **Neglecting resources:** A few well-chosen assets can solve problems no amount of personal skill can.
- **Hoarding XP:** Spend your XP! Characters who never improve become irrelevant to the escalating threats.

## 4.14 Practical Examples

### 4.14.1 Combat Example

A warrior with Body 4 and Melee 3 attacks:

- Dice pool:  $4 + 3 = 7d10$ .
- Opponent's defenses and the fiction help set the difficulty (see 2).

- Strong successes translate into higher Effect or better Position.

#### 4.14.2 Social Example

A diplomat with Presence 3 and Sway 2 negotiates:

- Dice pool:  $3 + 2 = 5d10$ .
- Position might be *Controlled* if circumstances favor them, or worse if under suspicion.
- Consequences for failure could be mistrust, delays, or new complications.

#### 4.14.3 Exploration Example

A scout with Wits 3 and Perception 2 searches for tracks:

- Dice pool:  $3 + 2 = 5d10$ .
- Easier tasks (fresh tracks) are more forgiving; older or obscured tracks are harder.
- Partial successes might reveal some information but not all, or come with side effects.

Your Attributes and Skills determine not just *if* you succeed, but *how* you tackle problems. Lean into combinations that express your character's style.

### XP Planning Guide

#### Early Tier Priorities:

- Raise a core Attribute to 3 (9 XP).
- Bring key Skills to 2–3 (4–6 XP each).
- Claim 1–2 minor resources (4 XP each).

#### Mid Tier Expansion:

- Push core Attributes toward 4 (12 XP).
- Specialize key Skills to 4 (8 XP).
- Add standard resources (8 XP each).
- Explore cultural or thematic abilities (6–10 XP).

#### Late Tier Mastery:

- Purchase capstone abilities (12+ XP).
- Establish major resources (12 XP).
- Launch legacy projects, organizations, or movements.

**Attributes and Skills Quick Reference****Attributes (1–5):**

- **Body:** physical capability
- **Wits:** mental acuity
- **Spirit:** willpower and inner strength
- **Presence:** social influence

**Skill Levels:**

- 0: Untrained    1: Novice    2: Competent
- 3: Professional    4: Master    5: Grand Master

**Dice Pool:** Attribute + Skill d10s.

**Skill Improvement:** New level  $\times$  2 XP (plus training time).

**Specialization:** At Skill 3+, you are a known expert in that field.

**Synergy:** Well-justified combinations of skills can grant +1 die or better Position/Effect when the fiction supports it.

# Chapter 5

## Experience Paths and Character Building

How you spend your **Experience Points (XP)** shapes more than your numbers on a sheet—it defines your character’s *career*, their growth over time, and the kind of stories they invite into play.

This chapter focuses on:

- turning a loose idea into a clear **character concept**,
- mapping that concept into **starting choices** that fit the campaign rules,
- choosing a **career path** (how you plan to grow),
- and understanding how your character can evolve across **early, mid, and late** game.

All examples in this chapter are *legal starting builds* under the standard creation rules, and are written to be directly usable by players.

### 5.1 From Concept to Career

Before you spend a single XP, start with the story you want to tell.

#### Step 1: Concept Seed

Begin with a simple statement of who your character is:

- “Stoic bodyguard who will take the hit for anyone else.”
- “Nervy courier who knows every back alley in the city.”
- “Soft-spoken merchant who pulls strings behind the scenes.”

This is your **concept seed**. Everything else grows from here.

#### Step 2: Role in the Party

Decide what you want to *do at the table*:

- Take hits and lock down threats?
- Spot danger and solve practical problems?
- Talk through conflicts and manage social fallout?
- Create tools, magic, or plans that enable everyone else?

Your role helps you choose a **Primary Attribute** and 2–3 **Key Skills** (see [4](#)).

### Step 3: Career Theme

Ask yourself:

- Is this a story of *self-mastery*? (training, discipline, pushing limits)
- A story of *connections*? (alliances, obligations, webs of influence)
- A story of *balance*? (learning to juggle many demands at once)

Your answer naturally points you toward one of the three **XP paths** in this chapter.

### Step 4: Long Arc in One Sentence

Write a single sentence for where you imagine your character at high XP:

- “I want to become the greatest duelist in the realm.”
- “I want to map the unknown and bring others safely home.”
- “I want to run the network everyone relies on but no one sees.”

You do not have to stick to this forever, but it gives you a *direction* for your early choices.

#### Character Career Checklist

Before spending XP, decide:

1. Your **concept seed** (one sentence).
2. Your **role in the party** (what you do most).
3. Your preferred **career theme**: self, balance, or influence.
4. A rough **long arc** (where you want to end up).

Start simple. You can always refine these as the campaign unfolds.

## 5.2 Mapping Concept to Mechanics

Once you have a concept, you turn it into numbers. Use this as a guideline:

1. Pick a **Primary Attribute** that supports your role (Body, Wits, Spirit, or Presence) – see 4.1.
2. Choose 2–3 **Key Skills** that you want to be noticeably good at (see 4.2).
3. Choose a **Career Path** (Personal, Balanced, Influencer) that matches your theme.
4. Use the starting XP budget in 5.9 to buy:
  - Attribute steps for your primary and possibly secondary stats.
  - Skill steps for your key and supporting skills.
  - Optional resources or special abilities, if your path calls for them.

Throughout this chapter, each example shows how a concept becomes a legal build.

## 5.3 Three Career Paths

There are three broad approaches to character development, each representing a different **career philosophy**:

**Personal Path** Focus on personal mastery and self-improvement (5.5).

**Balanced Path** Mix personal growth with resources and influence (5.6).

**Influencer Path** Build networks, assets, and strategic power (5.7).

These paths are not rigid classes. They are *patterns* that help you decide where most of your XP will go, especially in the early game.

## 5.4 Player Archetypes

Not every player spends XP the same way. These three **player archetypes** describe common patterns. Identify yours – it will help you choose a career path and avoid frustration.

### The Solo

**Definition:** Invests XP primarily in Attributes and Skills. Minimal followers, minimal holdings. All power is on the character sheet.

**Typical XP Spread:** 70–90% Self; 0–10% On-screen help; 0–20% Off-screen assets.

**Strengths:** Consistent scene impact; few moving parts; resilient to follower loss.

**Risks:** Limited fiction reach between sessions; can stall when problems demand logistics or networks.

**Starting Focus:** Attributes 2–3, Skills 1–2, minimal assets.

### The Mixed Player

**Definition:** Splits XP between self-growth and one or two meaningful assets (a small follower or a reliable holding).

**Typical XP Spread:** 50–65% Self; 15–25% On-screen help; 15–25% Off-screen assets.

**Strengths:** Versatile: credible in scenes and has a lever for special problems.

**Risks:** Upkeep pressure; helper can be targeted when the GM spends 2+ Story Beats.

**Starting Focus:** Balanced approach with one minor asset or low-cap follower.

### The Mastermind

**Definition:** Prioritises followers / cadres / familiars and off-screen networks. The character sheet is the hub of a larger apparatus.

**Typical XP Spread:** 25–40% Self; 35–55% On-screen help; 20–40% Off-screen assets.

**Strengths:** Scene control via assistance; strategic reach between sessions; strong heist / social-planning play.

**Risks:** Dependency on assist lanes; followers can be endangered on 2+ SB spends; upkeep pressure.

**Starting Focus:** Significant investment in followers or major assets from the beginning.

### Which Archetype Are You?

Ask yourself:

- Do I want my character to be self-sufficient and always ready? → **Solo**
- Do I enjoy having a helpful sidekick or a home base, but not too much bookkeeping? → **Mixed**
- Do I love managing networks, commanding troops, and solving problems through influence? → **Mastermind**

There is no wrong answer – but knowing your style helps you build a character you will enjoy for many sessions.

## 5.5 Path 1: Personal Development

The **Personal Path** centers your character’s career on what *they* can do: their body, mind, and honed skills. This is the path of the duelist, the ascetic, the elite scout, the master healer.

### Typical Investment

- 70–90% Personal improvement (Attributes and Skills)
- 0–10% Resources and assets
- 0–20% Special abilities

### Strengths

- Reliable in direct challenges and combat
- Minimal upkeep or management required
- Resilient to loss of external resources
- Consistent performance in spotlight moments

### Weaknesses

- Limited influence in social or strategic scenes
- May struggle with problems requiring networks
- Less capable in logistics or large-scale operations
- Dependent on personal presence for all solutions

### Career View

On this path, your “career ladder” is mostly about pushing numbers related to **you**: raising Attributes, deepening Skills, and picking a few defining abilities. Your late-game questions are:

- “What does a legendary version of this look like?”
- “What scenes prove that I have truly mastered my craft?”

### Build Example: The Duelist (Legal Start)

**Concept Seed:** “A proud blade whose entire life is training and challenge.”

**Total XP: 30** (34 with +4 from Bonds/Complications; see 5.9)

- **Attributes:** Body 3, Wits 2, Spirit 1, Presence 1
  - Costs (Attributes cost *new rating* × 3): Body 1→2 (6), 2→3 (9) = **15**; Wits 1→2 (6) =

6; Spirit/Presence remain 1 = 0. *Subtotal: 21 XP*

- **Skills:** Melee 2, Athletics 1
  - Costs (Skills cost *new level* × 2): Melee 0→1 (2), 1→2 (4) = 6; Athletics 0→1 = 2. *Subtotal: 8 XP*
- **Totals:** 21 + 8 = 29 XP. Bank 1 XP.
- **With +4 XP (Bonds/Complications):** Add *Perception* 0→1 (2) and spend banked 1 XP on *Stealth* 0→1 (2), or instead take *Perception* 0→1 (2) and *Sway* 0→1 (2) for broader utility. *Cap: 34 XP.*

**Career Hook:** Early scenes show duels and drills. Mid game focuses on notorious opponents. Late game tells the story of a blade whose name carries across borders.

## 5.6 Path 2: Balanced Approach

The **Balanced Path** mixes personal capability with supportive resources. This is the path of the scout-captain, the field medic with a small clinic, the problem-solver who always seems to have *something* ready.

### Typical Investment

- 50–65% Personal improvement
- 15–25% Resources and assets
- 15–25% Special abilities

### Strengths

- Adaptable to diverse situations
- Handles both direct and indirect challenges
- Excellent supporting role for the group
- Moderate risk profile

### Weaknesses

- Not exceptional in any single area
- Requires management of resources
- Moderate upkeep demands
- Can be outshone by focused specialists

### Career View

Balanced characters often have careers that feel like juggling:

- they add contacts, gear, or small bases *and*
- keep raising the core skills that let them use those tools well.

Their late-game questions are:

- “What does my little network or operation look like at full size?”
- “How do my personal skills and resources fit together as a whole?”

### Build Example: The Scout (Legal Start)

**Concept Seed:** “A pathfinder who knows how to get in, get out, and get others home.”



**Total XP: 30** (34 with +4 from Bonds/Complications)

- **Attributes:** Wits 2, Body 2, Spirit 1, Presence 1
  - Costs: Wits 1→2 (6), Body 1→2 (6) = **12 XP**
- **Skills:** Survival 2, Perception 1, Stealth 1
  - Costs: Survival 0→1 (2), 1→2 (4) = **6**; Perception 0→1 **2**; Stealth 0→1 **2**. *Subtotal: 10 XP*
- **Resources:** *Minor equipment cache* (camp gear, maps, signal kit) = **4 XP**
- **Special Abilities:** *Wilderness Lore* (broad travel benefits) = **4 XP**
- **Totals:** 12 + 10 + 4 + 4 = **30 XP**.
- **With +4 XP:** add *Perception 1→2* (+4) or take a *trained hawk companion* (Minor Resource, 4 XP).

**Career Hook:** Early stories show small journeys. Mid game explores dangerous routes and rescue missions. Late game might see the scout running expeditions, caravans, or an entire mapping guild.

## 5.7 Path 3: Influencer Focus

The **Influencer Path** emphasizes networks, assets, and strategic power. This is the path of the merchant-prince, the fixer, the spymaster, the noble with more favors owed than coins in their purse.

### Typical Investment

- 25–40% Personal improvement
- 35–55% Resources and assets
- 20–40% Special abilities

### Strengths

- Strong strategic and social influence
- Can solve problems indirectly
- Excellent at planning and preparation
- Creates opportunities for the whole group

### Weaknesses

- Personally vulnerable in direct confrontations
- High maintenance requirements
- Complications can cascade through networks
- Dependent on external factors

### Career View

Influencer careers are about building and surviving **webs**:

- webs of contacts, debts, trade routes, cells, or clients.

Late game questions become:

- “How big can this web reasonably grow within the fiction?”
- “What happens when a strand of my web is cut, or pulled tight?”

## Build Example: The Merchant (Legal Start)

**Concept Seed:** “A friendly shopkeeper whose real power lies in who owes them favors.”

**Total XP: 30** (34 with +4 from Bonds/Complications)

- **Attributes:** Presence 2, Wits 2, Spirit 1, Body 1
  - Costs: Presence 1→2 (6), Wits 1→2 (6) = **12 XP**
- **Skills:** Sway 2, Deception 1, Lore 1
  - Costs: Sway 0→1 (2), 1→2 (4) = **6**; Deception 0→1 **2**; Lore 0→1 **2**. *Subtotal: 10 XP*
- **Resources:** *Standard trading office* (staffed storefront, ledgers, storage) = **8 XP**
- **Totals:** 12 + 10 + 8 = **30 XP**.
- **With +4 XP:** add *Negotiation Mastery* (4 XP general ability) *or* expand to a second *Minor merchant route* (4 XP).

**Career Hook:** Early scenes are about one shop and a few key clients. Mid game introduces caravans, deals, and rivals. Late game might place the merchant at the center of regional politics and supply chains.

## 5.8 Building for Group Synergy

Your character’s career path matters most in context with the rest of the party. A well-constructed party covers key roles without excessive overlap.

### Key Roles to Consider

**Combat** Frontline defence, skirmishing, or ranged fire support.

**Social** Negotiation, intimidation, information gathering.

**Exploration** Scouting, navigating, surviving hostile environments.

**Magic** Free casting, rites, rituals, or summoning.

**Assets** Logistics, networks, safehouses, followers.

### Complementary Paths

- **Personal path** characters provide reliable combat and specialist solutions.
- **Balanced path** characters handle diverse, connective challenges.
- **Influencer path** characters create opportunities and resources for everyone.

Together, a mixed party can cover nearly every type of problem.

### Redundant Paths

- Multiple personal path characters may overlap in combat or role.
- Multiple influencer path characters may compete for spotlight and assets.
- Consider diversifying within similar paths: different weapon styles, different Patrons, different social approaches.
- Example: Two combatants – one a duelist (single-target damage), one a shield-focused guardian (area protection).

## Balancing Your Table

If you notice a gap (e.g., no one has investment in social skills or no one has a safehouse asset), consider adjusting your XP spending or discussing with the group. A party that talks about roles early will have a smoother campaign.

## 5.9 Starting Character Guidelines

### Base XP Allocation

- **Standard Starting XP: 30** points
- **Bonds and Complications:** You may take up to **two total** from any mix of meaningful *Bonds* (up to 2, +2 XP each) and significant *Complications* (up to 2, +2 XP each), granting maximum **+4 XP**. (See Bonds, ??.)
- **Maximum Starting XP: 34** points
- **Complication Effect:** Each unresolved starting Complication adds +1 banked SB to early scenes until cleared.

### Recommended Starting Ranges

| Category             | Recommended XP           |
|----------------------|--------------------------|
| Primary Attribute    | 9–12 XP (rating 3–4)     |
| Secondary Attributes | 0–9 XP each (rating 1–3) |
| Key Skills           | 4–6 XP each (rating 2–3) |
| Supporting Skills    | 2–4 XP each (rating 1–2) |
| Resources            | 0–8 XP total             |
| Special Abilities    | 0–8 XP total             |

#### 5.9.0.0.1 Cost Reminders:

- **Attributes:** Each step costs *new rating* × 3 XP (e.g., 1→2 costs 6; 2→3 costs 9). See 4.1.
- **Skills:** Each step costs *new level* × 2 XP (e.g., 0→1 costs 2; 1→2 costs 4). See 4.2.
- **Resources:** Minor 4 XP; Standard 8 XP; Major 12 XP.
- **Special Abilities:** Minor Edge 2 XP; Major Edge 4 XP; Prestige 6+ XP.

## 5.10 Progression Planning

Think of your character’s career in phases. These XP bands are approximate and assume you began at 30–34 XP.

### Early Game (0–40 XP)

Focus on establishing core capabilities:

- Reach attribute rating 3 in your primary area.
- Develop 2–3 key skills to rating 2–3.
- Acquire basic resources or one special ability (if your path uses them).
- Clarify your character’s niche in the group.

**When to take a Follower vs. Asset vs. Talent (Early):**

- **Follower:** If you want on-screen help (a scout, a bodyguard, an apprentice). Start with Cap 1–2.
- **Asset:** If you want an off-screen advantage (a safehouse, a workshop, a contact network). Start with Minor Asset (4 XP).
- **Talent:** If you want a signature move (combat technique, social edge, magic access). Minor talents (2–3 XP) are great early.

**Mid Game (41–90 XP)**

Expand and specialize:

- Increase your primary attribute to 4.
- Specialize key skills to rating 3–4.
- Develop supporting capabilities that fit your concept.
- Build strategic resources or networks if on the Balanced or Influencer path.
- Acquire signature special abilities that define your style.

**When to take a Follower vs. Asset vs. Talent (Mid):**

- **Follower:** Upgrade a loyal contact to Cap 3 (9 XP) – they become a reliable asset who can act independently.
- **Asset:** Expand your network – a Standard Asset (8 XP) turns a safehouse into a spy ring or a workshop into a guild connection.
- **Talent:** Major talents (4–6 XP) define your mid-game identity – Backstab, Ritual Mastery, Command Presence.

**Late Game (91–150 XP)**

Master your chosen path:

- Achieve peak attributes (rating 4–5).
- Master key skills (rating 4–5).
- Build substantial influence or unique capabilities.
- Develop advanced special abilities.
- Consider legacy projects, organizations, or long-term changes to the setting.

**When to take a Follower vs. Asset vs. Talent (Late):**

- **Follower:** A Cap 4–5 follower (16–25 XP) can become a successor (see ??) – invest in someone who could carry on your cause.
- **Asset:** Major Assets (12 XP) give you regional influence – a fortress, a charter, a fleet.
- **Talent:** Prestige (7–10 XP) and Epic (11+ XP) talents reshape the story. Plan your build around one or two capstones.

### XP Path Quick Reference

**Personal Path (70–90% self):**

- Reliable individual performance.
- Low upkeep, high consistency.
- Best for combatants and focused specialists.

**Balanced Path (50–65% self):**

- Good all-around capability.
- Moderate risk and upkeep.
- Flexible support and problem-solving role.

**Influencer Path (25–40% self):**

- Strategic power and influence.
- High upkeep, high reward.
- Creates opportunities for the entire group.

**Starting XP:** 30 base + up to +4 from Bonds/Complications (max start 34).

## 5.11 Path Combination Strategies

Many players mix elements from different paths as their character's life unfolds.

### Combat Specialist with Resources

- Strong personal combat capabilities.
- Moderate resource investment for support.
- Good for frontline fighters who need logistical backup.
- Example: Warrior with a fortified base and loyal troops.

### Social Character with Personal Skills

- Excellent social capabilities.
- Solid personal skills for self-defense or utility.
- Good for diplomats who operate independently.
- Example: Ambassador with combat training and persuasion skills.

### Technical Expert with Networks

- Deep technical or magical expertise.
- Network of contacts and resources to enable projects.
- Good for specialists who need supply chains and helpers.
- Example: Master crafter with supplier network and apprentices.

## 5.12 Resource Management

Each path asks for different management styles across your character's career.

### Personal Path Management

- Minimal upkeep requirements.
- Focus on equipment, training scenes, and personal growth.
- Low complexity, high reliability.

## Balanced Path Management

- Moderate upkeep for resources.
- Relationship maintenance with contacts.
- Skill development alongside resource management.
- Balanced time investment between self and assets.

## Influencer Path Management

- Significant upkeep demands.
- Network maintenance and expansion.
- Resource allocation and development.
- Strategic planning and opportunity management.

## 5.13 Risk Assessment

Each path carries different career risks.

### Personal Path Risks

- Over-specialization in one area.
- Vulnerability to problems outside your specialty.
- Limited diversification later in the game.
- May become predictable in approach.

### Balanced Path Risks

- Jack-of-all-trades, master of none.
- Spread too thin across capabilities.
- Moderate risks in multiple areas.
- May lack standout, defining capabilities if unfocused.

### Influencer Path Risks

- Networks are vulnerable to attack and betrayal.
- High maintenance requirements.
- Cascade failure potential if a key asset falls.
- Personal safety concerns when the web is targeted.

## 5.14 Adapting Your Path

Your chosen path is a starting point, not a contract. You can shift focus as your character's story changes.

### Early Shift (0–40 XP)

- Easy to change direction.
- Minimal sunk cost in any single approach.
- Good time to experiment with different styles.
- You can respond quickly to group needs or unexpected story turns.

### Mid Game Shift (41–90 XP)

- Requires more deliberate planning.

- Some capabilities need to be maintained while others change.
- You can fill emerging gaps in group capability.
- Temporary performance dips may occur during the transition.

### Late Game Shift (91+ XP)

- Significant investment in your current path.
- Major shifts require substantial XP and story justification.
- Often better to add complementary capabilities than completely pivot.
- Consider how changes reflect pivotal events in your character's life.

## 5.15 Practical Building Examples (Narrative Roles, Legal Starts)

Each of the following examples combines:

- a short **concept**,
- a **path choice**,
- a legal **starting build**,
- and a sketch of their **career arc**.

### Example 1: The Guardian

**Path:** Personal    **Total:** 30 XP

**Concept Seed:** “Quiet wall of muscle who would rather bleed than lose anyone.”

- **Attributes:** Body 3 (1→2: 6, 2→3: 9), Wits 2 (1→2: 6) = **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Melee 2 (0→1: 2, 1→2: 4 = 6), Athletics 1 (0→1: 2) = **8 XP**
- **Bank:** 1 XP
- **Role at table:** Frontline protection and reliable pressure in fights.
- **With +4 XP:** add *Combat Reflexes* (2 XP talent) and *Shield Mastery* (4 XP talent) using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP (GM may allow rounding or an extra minor Complication), or instead buy more supporting skills.

**Career Arc:** Early on, the Guardian is “the one who stands in front.” Mid game adds tactical awareness and maybe leadership. Late game might see them training others or becoming the symbol of a cause.

### Example 2: The Explorer

**Path:** Balanced    **Total:** 30 XP

**Concept Seed:** “Curious wanderer whose maps are more valuable than gold.”

- **Attributes:** Wits 2 (6), Body 2 (6) = **12 XP**
- **Skills:** Survival 2 (0→1: 2, 1→2: 4 = 6), Perception 1 (2), Stealth 1 (2) = **10 XP**
- **Resources:** Minor mapping kit & route notes = **4 XP**
- **Ability:** Trail Sense = **4 XP**
- **Totals:** 30 XP. With +4 XP, raise *Perception* 1→2 (+4) or add a trained beast (Minor Resource, 4 XP).

**Career Arc:** Early stories focus on survival and discovery. Mid game might see them guiding trade, armies, or refugees. Late game, they may literally redraw the map of the setting.

### Example 3: The Schemer

**Path:** Influencer    **Total:** 30 XP

**Concept Seed:** “The person who always knows someone who knows someone.”

- **Attributes:** Presence 2 (6), Wits 2 (6) = **12 XP**
- **Skills:** Sway 2 (0→1: 2, 1→2: 4 = 6), Deception 1 (2), Lore 1 (2) = **10 XP**
- **Resources:** Standard safehouse & message drops = **8 XP**
- **Totals:** 30 XP. With +4 XP, take *Network Builder* (4 XP talent) or add *Minor informant ring* (4 XP).

**Career Arc:** Early on, the Schemer is just “the one with connections.” Mid game grows their network and enemies. Late game, they might operate entire webs of spies, informants, merchants, or political factions.

**5.15.0.0.1 Reminder:** All builds above assume baseline *Attributes at 1* and *Skills at 0* before spending. Attribute and Skill advances are cumulative by step (see costs in 5.9).

Remember: Your chosen path should reflect both your character concept and your preferred play style. There is no single “correct” path—only what works for you, your group, and the story you want to tell.

## Planning for Succession (The Legacy Engine)

If you are playing a long campaign or enjoy the idea of your character’s influence outlasting them, consider investing in a **Follower** (Cap 3+) early. That follower can become your **successor** when your character retires or falls – inheriting your faction standing, one unresolved burden, and a Legacy Bond (see **Chapter 13: The Legacy Engine**). A loyal apprentice, a trusted lieutenant, or a family member can carry your story forward.

## 5.16 Narrative-Heavy Character Building Options

For groups that prefer a strong narrative focus in character building, you can treat XP as a tool for telling the story of a career, not just a currency.

**5.16.0.0.1 Story-Driven Milestones** Instead of tracking XP numerically, the GM can award advancement when characters reach significant story milestones. “You have trained with the master for months—you’ve improved your skill.”

**5.16.0.0.2 Experience Through Reflection** Players can spend downtime scenes reflecting on past experiences to earn XP. A meaningful flashback, confession, or revelation can justify growth without counting every point.

**5.16.0.0.3 Collaborative Advancement** The group can discuss and agree on advancement choices, ensuring everyone’s growth supports the overall story direction and shared arcs.



**5.16.0.0.4 Narrative Justification Focus** When spending XP, players should explain how their character gained this capability through in-game experiences, creating richer backstory and continuity. “I raise Presence because I’ve been forced to handle the group’s negotiations for weeks.”

**5.16.0.0.5 Path as Theme** Use your chosen path as a **theme** rather than a strict budget:

- A Personal Path character emphasizes physical, mental, or spiritual self-mastery.
- A Balanced Path character emphasizes learning how to juggle tools and relationships.
- An Influencer Path character emphasizes their growing web of relationships and obligations.

In all cases, let your character’s **career** on the page match the career they are living in the fiction.

# Chapter 6

## Talents and Special Abilities

Talents are the building blocks of character specialization. They represent learned techniques, supernatural gifts, or cultural inheritances. Each Talent costs XP, and its cost reflects its impact.

### 6.1 Understanding Talents

Talents are purchased with **Experience Points (XP)** (see 4) and provide special capabilities:

- They go beyond simple skill bonuses.
- They often have specific **activation conditions**.
- They may provide **narrative permissions** (you can try things others cannot).
- They can define your character's **unique identity**.

#### Talent Costs by Tier

| Tier     | Cost    | Scope                                         |
|----------|---------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Minor    | 2–3 XP  | Small situational bonus, once per scene.      |
| Major    | 4–6 XP  | Strong upgrade, permanent effect in a niche.  |
| Prestige | 7–10 XP | Campaign-defining, breaks fundamental limits. |
| Epic     | 11+ XP  | Legendary ability, shapes the story.          |

##### 6.1.0.0.1 Activation Types.

- **Passive:** Always on; no action required.
- **Active:** Requires an action or scene focus to use.
- **Reactive:** Triggers automatically on a condition.

##### 6.1.0.0.2 Limits and Economy. Unless a talent says otherwise:

- **Per scene** uses refresh at scene end.
- **Per session** uses refresh after downtime.
- Some talents allow you to spend **Boons** (see 2) to push effects further.

### Only One Active Talent?

The rule “only one talent can be active at a time” applies only to **activated abilities** that require a decision or action. **Passive** talents (e.g., +1 die to perception) are always active and stack. **Active** talents that require an action or reaction cannot be used simultaneously – you choose which one to activate when the trigger occurs. Talents that are “once per scene” reset at the end of the scene.

## 6.2 Minor Talents (2–3 XP)

### General

#### Keen Senses [PERCEPTION]

**Cost: 2 XP Passive.** +1 die on perception checks to spot danger or hidden details.

#### Silver Tongue [PERSUASION]

**Cost: 2 XP Passive.** +1 die on persuasion attempts.

#### Second Wind [RECOVERY]

**Cost: 2 XP Active, once per scene.** Clear 1 Fatigue when you take a moment to catch your breath.

#### Combat Reflexes [REACTIVE]

**Cost: 2 XP Reactive.** +1 die on defense rolls when surprised or flanked.

#### Precise Strike [STRIKE]

**Cost: 2 XP Active, once per scene.** Ignore armor on one attack if you had Dominant or Controlled position.

#### Trackless Step [EVADE]

**Cost: 2 XP Active, once per scene.** Leave no trail for the rest of the scene.

#### Urban Navigation [DIRECTION]

**Cost: 2 XP Passive.** Never get lost in cities.

#### Wilderness Lore [NATURE]

**Cost: 2 XP Passive.** Automatically find food and water in hospitable biomes.

#### Read Emotions [INSIGHT]

**Cost: 2 XP Active, once per scene.** Automatically detect surface emotions in a social exchange.

#### Iron Patience [RESISTANCE]

**Cost: 2 XP Passive.** When you Defend, gain +1 die to resist Conditions (fear, charm, fatigue) for the rest of the exchange, even outside the triggering roll.

*Requires: Resolve 1+.*

#### Stand Firm [PROTECT]

**Cost: 2 XP Reactive.** When you Defend and roll a Miss, downgrade incoming Harm by 1 level (minimum 0).

*Requires: Body 2+.*

**Counterpoise** [EVADE]

**Cost: 2 XP Reactive.** When you take a Defend action and score a Partial, you may immediately move 1 range band or reposition within Near without provoking retaliation.

*Requires: Athletics 1+ or Melee 1+.*

**Magic Access****Familiar** [SPIRIT] [BOND]

**Cost: 2 XP Passive.** Required to access Patron features such as Patron's Gift. Binds a Thiasos.

**Spellcraft** [FIRE] [WATER]

**Cost: 6 XP** (This is a Major-tier talent; see 6.3.)

**Monk****Disciplined Body** [STRENGTH] [RECOVERY]

**Cost: 3 XP Passive + Active.** +1 die to unarmed combat attacks. Once per scene, convert 1 Harm to Fatigue, and once per scene improve Position by one step.

*Requires: Melee 1+, Body 2+.*

**Combat****Defensive Survival** [DEFENSE] [RECOVERY]

**Cost: 3 XP Passive + Active.** +1 die to defense rolls while engaged in melee. Once per scene, convert first Harm 1 from melee to Fatigue.

*Requires: Melee 2+.*

**Weapon Master (Light)** [MASTERY]

**Cost: 3 XP Passive.** +1 die with a chosen weapon category (instead of +2 from the Major version).

*Note: The full +2 dice version is a Major talent (Weapon Mastery; see 6.3).*

**6.3 Major Talents (4–6 XP)****Magic Access****Spellcraft** [FIRE] [WATER]

**Cost: 6 XP Passive.** Grants access to Weave & Cast freeform spellcasting using the Eight Elements. Without this, characters cannot freeform cast.

**Codex** [FATE] [RITUAL]

**Cost: 4 XP Passive.** Required to fully join a Patron's service as a Runekeeper. Grants access to that Patron's Rites and Obligation system (see 3).

**Patron's Symbol** [WARD] [SIGIL]

**Cost: 4 XP Minor Asset.** Allows an Invoker to access a Patron's Rites via ritual precision. Each Patron requires its own Symbol.

**Patron's Gift** [IMBUEMENT]

**Cost: Free (requires Familiar) Active, once per scene.** Imbue one item with +1 Melee and +1 thematic Skill for the scene. Push It (mark +1 Obligation) to extend one more scene.

## General

### Weapon Mastery [WEAPON]

**Cost: 5 XP Passive.** Choose a weapon type; +2 dice when using it. Once per scene, +1 Effect with signature weapon.

*Requires: Melee 2+.*

### Command Presence [LEADERSHIP]

**Cost: 4 XP Passive.** +1 die on leadership and intimidation rolls.

### Network Builder [BOND]

**Cost: 4 XP Passive.** Gain a minor contact in each new settlement visited.

### Tactical Movement [MOVEMENT] [POSITION]

**Cost: 4 XP Passive + Active.** Move within engagement zone as Move action (instead of full action). Once per scene, disengage from Close as Move action.

*Requires: Athletics 2+.*

### Conditioning [RESISTANCE] [ENDURANCE]

**Cost: 4 XP Passive.** Body attribute counts as +1 for Fatigue track calculations. +1 die to resist Fatigue overflow effects.

*Requires: Body 3+.*

### Spell Shaping [CONTROL]

**Cost: 4 XP Active.** When you Weave a spell, modify range, scale, or targeting by one step.

*Requires: Spellcraft.*

### Elemental Focus [ELEMENT]

**Cost: 4 XP Passive.** Choose one element (Fire, Water, Earth, Air). +1 die when casting spells of that element.

*Requires: Spellcraft.*

### Ritual Mastery [RITUAL]

**Cost: 4 XP Passive.** The GM spends 1 fewer SB on ritual backlash.

*Requires: Familiar or Patron's Symbol.*

### Efficient Invocation [RITUAL]

**Cost: 4 XP Passive.** Reduce ritual casting time by one step (minimum 1 action).

*Requires: Patron's Symbol.*

## Combat

### Flurry Strike [STRIKE] [SPEED]

**Cost: 6 XP Active, once per scene.** When engaged with multiple opponents, make 2 attacks as one action. Each attack at -1 die.

*Requires: Melee 3+, Body 3+.*

### Duelist's Edge [DOMINANCE] [TECHNIQUE]

**Cost: 6 XP Passive + Active.** When engaged with a single opponent: +1 die to all melee rolls. Once per scene, ignore first Harm 1 or 2 from that opponent.

*Requires: Melee 3+, Wits 3+.*

**Battlefield Mastery** [STRATEGY] [LEADERSHIP]

**Cost: 6 XP Active, once per scene.** When engaged with 3+ opponents, for the next 3 exchanges: all melee attacks gain +1 Effect, enemies act at -1 die, your Position improves by one step, and you may convert one Harm 1 per exchange to Fatigue.

*Requires: Melee 4+, Wits 4+, Command 2+.*

**Backstab** [STEALTH] [STRIKE]

**Cost: 6 XP Active, once per scene.** When you attack an Unaware or Engaged foe from Stealth, deal +1 Harm and ignore 1 point of their Armor. On a miss, you are Exposed (Desperate Position or mark 1 Harm).

*Requires: Stealth 2+, Melee 2+, light weapon.*

**Elusive Dodge** [DEFENSE] [EVADE]

**Cost: 6 XP Reactive, once per exchange.** When targeted by a physical attack, you may immediately enter a Defend stance as a free reaction. Mark 1 Fatigue after use.

*Requires: Stealth 2+, Wits 3+, Tier II.*

**Berserker Rage** [FURY] [POWER]

**Cost: 6 XP Active, once per scene.** For 3 rounds: +2 dice to melee attacks, ignore first Harm 1 each round, ignore Harm/Fatigue penalties, Position becomes Desperate (re-roll successes). When rage ends, mark Fatigue equal to Spirit. Cannot be ended early.

*Requires: Melee 3+, Spirit 3+, Body 3+.*

**Cavalier** [MOBILITY] [MARTIAL]

**Cost: 4 XP Passive while mounted.** Gain +2 dice to melee attacks when moving Far→Near, or +2 dice to ranged attacks when moving Near→Far.

*Requires: War Mount Asset, Melee 2+ or Ranged 2+.*

**Subtle Casting** [HIDDEN] [CONTROL]

**Cost: 6 XP Active.** Make a Performance + Lore roll to quietly cast a spell, invoke a Rite, or sing a Cantos against DV (Tier). If successful, the casting does not generate Story Beats on the Channel or initial roll. Any SB generated are banked by the GM and applied later. Cannot be used for Great or Extreme Tier effects.

*Requires: Lore 3+, Performance 2+ or Runekeeper with Codex.*

**Effortless Charge** [MOVEMENT] [MARTIAL]

**Cost: 4 XP Active, once per scene.** When you take the **Charge** action (see 2), you may ignore the Fatigue cost. All other costs and restrictions (Desperate defense, open ground requirement) still apply.

*Requires: Body 3+, Melee 2+.*

**Effortless Skirmish** [MOVEMENT] [MARTIAL]

**Cost: 4 XP Active, once per scene.** When you take the **Skirmish** (or **Harring Shot**) action (see 2), you may ignore the Fatigue cost. All other costs and restrictions (Desperate defense, open ground requirement) still apply.

*Requires: Wits 3+, Ranged 2+.*

**Relentless** [MOVEMENT] [TERRAIN]

**Cost: 6 XP Passive.** You may take the **Charge** or **Skirmish** action over **difficult terrain** (rubble, dense forest, shallow water, steep slopes). The Fatigue cost (1) is *not* waived unless you

also have the relevant Effortless talent.

*Requires: Body 3+, Athletics 2+.*

### Stubborn Pursuer [MOVEMENT] [REACTION]

**Cost: 6 XP Reactive.** When an opponent within Close range uses the **Disengage** action (or any movement intended to leave your engagement without provoking an opportunity attack), you may use your reaction to move with them, staying in Close range. This movement does not cost an action and does not provoke opportunity attacks. You move the same number of range bands as they do (e.g., Close → Near, or Near → Far), up to your normal movement limit for the round. You cannot use this talent if you have already taken a Move action or Dash this round. Once per round.

*Requires: Body 3+, Athletics 2+.*

## Defense

### Riposte Instinct [COUNTER] [STRIKE]

**Cost: 4 XP Reactive, once per scene.** When you Defend and score a Success, you may make a free Melee attack against the attacker at Position -1.

*Requires: Melee 2+.*

### Guarded Step [STANCE] [MOVEMENT]

**Cost: 4 XP Active.** When Defending, you may declare your defense pool after the GM calls Position. Once per scene, you may instead choose the Attribute + Skill pair after the roll.

*Requires: Athletics 2+ or Shield Proficiency.*

### Measured Guard [TACTICS] [FLEXIBILITY]

**Cost: 4 XP Active.** When Defending, you may declare your defense pool after the GM calls Position. Once per scene, you may instead choose the Attribute + Skill pair after the roll.

*Requires: Perception 2+.*

### Wardbreaker Reflex [WARD] [DEFENSE]

**Cost: 4 XP Reactive.** When Defending against spells or supernatural effects, you may reroll 1 failed die. If your reroll succeeds, mark +1 Fatigue (arcane recoil).

*Requires: Spirit 2+ or any magical Path.*

## Monk

### Iron Fist Way [STRIKE] [BURNING]

**Cost: 6 XP Passive.** +1 die to unarmed attacks; strikes count as enchanted.

### Flowing Spirit Way [WIND] [STRENGTH]

**Cost: 6 XP Passive + Active.** Convert up to 1 Harm into Fatigue per attack; +1 die against fear or charm.

### Perfect Timing Way [FATE] [MOVEMENT]

**Cost: 6 XP Active.** Twice per scene, improve Position by +1 step; +1 die to reactions.

## 6.4 Prestige Talents (7–10 XP)

### Arcane Dominance [POWER] [OVERRIDE]

**Cost: 8 XP Passive.** When you contest another magical effect, you automatically overpower weaker effects (Tier II or lower).

*Requires: Spirit 4, Arcana 4.*

### Forbidden Knowledge [SECRETS] [DANGEROUS]

**Cost: 8 XP Active, once per session.** Access one forbidden summon or dangerous rite without its normal prerequisites. The GM gains 2 SB.

*Requires: Tier II.*

### Crack Specialist [RITUAL] [INSTANT]

**Cost: 8 XP Passive.** Reduce the Obligation cost of Crack the Seal by 1 (minimum +1).

*Requires: 3 Patron Symbols.*

### Dual Covenant [BOND] [SYNCHRONIZATION]

**Cost: 8 XP Passive.** You may maintain two active summoned spirits simultaneously.

*Requires: Pact-Whisperer, Lesser Pactwright.*

### Triad Bond [BOND] [SYNCHRONIZATION]

**Cost: 10 XP Passive.** You may maintain three active summoned spirits simultaneously.

*Requires: Dual Covenant, Tier III.*

### Shrike Parry [COUNTER] [PARRY]

**Cost: 8 XP Reactive.** When Defending against a melee attack: on Success, negate the hit and make a free attack at equal Position; on Partial, reduce Harm by two levels; on Miss, improve Position one step next turn without Defending again.

*Requires: Melee 3+, Athletics 2+, notable duel history.*

### Mystic Bulwark [PROTECT] [BOND]

**Cost: 8 XP Active.** When you Defend, you may Shield an adjacent ally (they gain your Position bonus). If you succeed, both avoid the effect. Once per scene, spend 2 Fatigue to extend to all allies in Near.

*Requires: Resolve 3+, Spirit 2+, access to Rites or Cantos.*

### High Stance Duelist [DOMINANCE] [TECHNIQUE]

**Cost: 8 XP Passive.** While Defending: enemies suffer –1 die to attacks against you; on a Success, your riposte becomes Dominant instead of Controlled.

*Requires: Melee 3+, Presence 1+.*

### Hollow-Touched [RESILIENCE]

**Cost: 8 XP Reactive.** When you would take Harm, you may mark that amount as Fatigue instead. If you do, either the GM gains 1 SB or you mark 1 Obligation to the Pale Shepherd. Overflow triggers normal Fatigue→Harm conversion plus the chosen cost.

*Requires: Aelaerem affinity, Spirit 3+, Stealth 2+.*

### Stone-Bound Interdictor [RESILIENCE]

**Cost: 8 XP Reactive.** When you would take Harm, you may mark that amount as Fatigue instead. If you do, either spend 1 Boon immediately or speak a geas (until fulfilled, –1 die on social



rolls with fae and stone-kin). Overflow triggers normal conversion plus the cost.

*Requires: Aelinnel affinity, Body 3+, Wits 3+.*

### **Large Soul** [ADAPTATION]

**Cost: 8 XP Passive.** You may wear Heavy Armor and wield Heavy Weapons without restriction. You lose your Small Folk racial bonuses (+1 Position Dodging, +1 die Hide/Evasion).

*Requires: Aelaerem or Aelinnel affinity, Body 4+, Spirit 3+.*

### **Untouchable Way** [EVADE] [STRENGTH]

**Cost: 10 XP Passive + Active.** +1 die to unarmed attacks; convert 2 Harm into Fatigue; cannot be grappled.

*Requires: Iron Fist + Flowing Spirit.*

### **Inevitable Way** [FATE] [FORCE]

**Cost: 10 XP Passive + Reactive.** +2 dice to unarmed attacks; ignore 1 Armor; may counterattack when an enemy misses.

*Requires: Iron Fist + Perfect Timing.*

### **Battlefield Terror** [FEAR] [DOMINANCE]

**Cost: 10 XP Passive + Active.** Enemies in Close range act at -1 die due to intimidation. Once per scene, convert an enemy's success to a partial with cost.

*Requires: Melee 4+, Body 4+, Harm 2+ experience.*

### **Shadow Dance** [EVADE] [STEALTH]

**Cost: 10 XP Active.** After a successful Backstab, test Stealth vs. DV (Tier). On success, re-enter Stealth and clear 1 Fatigue or improve Position +1. On failure, remain Exposed and mark 1 Fatigue. May only chain once per scene.

*Requires: Backstab, Stealth 3+, Mobility 2+.*

### **Embrace the Void** [CORRUPTION] [POWER]

**Cost: 8 XP Active, once per session.** Embrace your Patron's corrupting influence. Mark 2 Obligation and 1 Corruption segment, then gain one for the scene: +1 die and +1 Effect on Patron-domain rolls, immunity to one consequence type, use one Rite without Obligation, or +1 Effect on social manipulations. Permanent mark on sheet; GM gains +1 SB against you when Patron is relevant.

*Requires: Any character with 2+ skill levels tied to Patron, at least 1 Obligation segment to that Patron.*

## **6.5 Epic Talents (11+ XP)**

### **Elemental Mastery** [ELEMENT] [HARMONY]

**Cost: 18 XP Passive + Active.** Reduce Backlash severity by one step when casting with your focus elements. When casting with two focus elements, gain +2 dice and +1 Effect. Once per scene, cast a spell without generating SB on the Weave roll. Allies gain +1 die when you cast an aligned element spell.

*Requires: Tier III, Spellcraft, Arcana 5, 2+ Focus Elements.*

### **Crack the Seal Mastery** [RITUAL] [PRECISION]

**Cost: 18 XP Passive + Active.** When Cracking the Seal, choose one: reduce Obligation cost by 1, prevent Symbol from becoming Compromised, or gain +1 Effect. With 4+ Symbols, reduce all

ritual casting times by 1 round. Once per scene, Crack the Seal on up to 3 Symbols as one action. Ignore No Symbol penalties.

*Requires: Tier III, Invoker's Grimoire, 3+ Patron Symbols.*

### **Blade Dance** [STRIKE] [MASTERY]

**Cost: 18 XP Active, once per scene.** Engage and attack up to 3 targets in one action. Each attack at -1 die, but your Position improves by one step.

*Requires: Melee 5+, Duelist's Edge, Flurry Strike.*

### **Miststep Reflex** [DEFENSE] [MOVEMENT]

**Cost: 12 XP Passive.** You are always treated as Defending against physical attacks unless Exposed, Grappled, or Surprised. If you take the Defend action, improve Position by +2 steps instead. Once per scene when you roll 1s while defending, you must mark 2 Fatigue or lose the benefit for the scene.

*Requires: Elusive Dodge, Tier III, Stealth 4+, Athletics 3+.*

### **Transcendent Harmony** [LIFE] [WIND]

**Cost: 18 XP Passive + Active.** Convert 2 Harm into Fatigue; once per session become immune to Harm; allies gain +1 defense.

*Requires: Flowing Spirit + Perfect Timing, Spirit 4+.*

### **Deathblow** [DEATH] [STRIKE]

**Cost: 12 XP Active, once per scene.** When you strike from Dominant Position or after re-entering Stealth via Shadow Dance, declare a Deathblow. On a hit, deal triple Harm. If the attack incapacitates the target, attempt a free Stealth test to vanish. On a miss, you are Exposed (Desperate Position and mark 1 Harm). May mark 1 Fatigue to attempt a second time.

*Requires: Shadow Dance, Stealth 4+, Melee/Ranged 3+.*

## 6.6 Talent Synergies and Building Strategies

### Synergy Examples

- **Spellcraft + Elemental Focus + Elemental Mastery:** Reliable freeform casting with reduced backlash and epic control (see 3).
- **Backstab + Shadow Dance + Deathblow:** Stealth assassination chain.
- **Ritual Mastery + Efficient Invocation + Crack Specialist:** Fast, safe, low-cost rituals.
- **Defensive Survival + Elusive Dodge + Miststep Reflex:** High survivability in melee.
- **Iron Fist + Flowing Spirit + Untouchable Way:** Unstoppable monk durability.
- **Iron Fist + Perfect Timing + Inevitable Way:** Monk counterattack master.
- **Effortless Charge + Relentless:** Charge over difficult terrain once per scene without Fatigue cost.
- **Stubborn Pursuer + Tactical Movement:** Stay glued to a disengaging foe while preserving your own movement options.

### When to Take Talents (By Tier)

- **Early Game (0–40 XP):** Take 1–2 access talents (Spellcraft, Familiar, Pact-Whisperer) and 2–3 minor talents that support your core concept.
- **Mid Game (41–90 XP):** Add major talents (Codex, Patron's Symbol, Backstab, etc.) and 2–3 synergistic power talents. Plan for prestige prerequisites.

- **Late Game (91+ XP):** Acquire 1–2 prestige or epic talents that define your legacy. Focus on party-supporting or campaign-shaping abilities.

### Example: The Shadow Assassin

A rogue who takes **Backstab** (6.3) at Tier I, **Shadow Dance** (6.4) at Tier II, and **Deathblow** (6.5) at Tier III can execute a devastating assassination chain:

1. Attack from stealth with Backstab (+1 Harm, ignore armor).
2. After a kill, use Shadow Dance to re-enter stealth.
3. Later, strike from Dominant Position with Deathblow (triple Harm).

This combination requires careful positioning and Boon management, but is highly effective.

## 6.7 Custom Talents

Work with your GM to create custom talents:

- Base on story events.
- Use the cost tiers above (2–3 / 4–6 / 7–10 / 11+ XP).
- Define clear prerequisites, activation, and limits.

## 6.8 Talent Respecification

With GM approval, you may retrain talents during downtime (one downtime period). Provide a narrative justification. Typically limited to once per major story arc.

### Talent Selection Quick Reference

**Minor (2–3 XP):** Small bonuses, once/scene tricks.

**Major (4–6 XP):** Strong permanent upgrades, core path abilities.

**Prestige (7–10 XP):** Campaign-shaping, breaks limits.

**Epic (11+ XP):** Legendary, story-defining power.

*Remember: Passive talents stack; active talents require an action or reaction.*

# Chapter 7

## Example Character Concepts

This chapter presents example character concepts to illustrate how the game’s systems can create diverse and interesting heroes. These are **examples only**—not prescriptive templates or exhaustive lists. Use them for inspiration, as pre-generated characters, or as starting points for your own unique creations.

### 7.1 Important Disclaimer

**These examples are provided for illustrative purposes only.** They demonstrate how the game’s mechanics can support different character archetypes and play styles. You are encouraged to:

- Modify these concepts to fit your preferences
- Create completely original characters
- Mix and match elements from different examples
- Work with your Game Master to develop unique concepts

The game system is designed to support a wide variety of character types beyond these examples.

### 7.2 How to Use These Examples

Each concept includes:

- **Concept Overview:** Narrative identity and role
- **Traditional Analogues:** Common RPG classes that share similar themes — *not* mechanical restrictions, just touchstones
- **Mechanical Foundation:** Suggested starting capabilities
- **Play Style:** How the character typically engages with challenges
- **Development Path (by Tier):** What to buy at Tier I, II, and III (see [4.8](#))
- **Tactical Advice:** Tips for playing the role effectively
- **Story Hooks:** Plot opportunities for the Game Master
- **Legacy Note:** How this character might pass the torch (see [14](#))
- **Build Blocks:** A *30 XP* starting build, plus an optional *34 XP* variant using Bonds/Complications (+4 XP) (see [4](#) for XP rules)

## 7.3 1. The Guardian (Fighter / Paladin / Knight)

**Concept:** A protector who stands between danger and those they've sworn to defend. *Steel in hand, vow in heart.* Whether a chivalrous knight, a grizzled mercenary, or a holy warrior of the Everflame, the Guardian makes others safe through sacrifice.

**Traditional Analogues:** Fighter, Paladin, Barbarian (defensive), Knight, Samurai, Legionary

**Mechanical Foundation:**

- **Primary:** Body (strength, endurance), Spirit (willpower, resolve)
- **Skills:** Melee, Athletics, Command, Endurance
- **Talents:** Defensive Survival, Combat Reflexes, Conditioning (see 6)

**Play Style:**

- Frontline combat and protection
- Drawing attention away from allies (taunts, positioning)
- Using presence and authority to control situations
- Taking risks to protect others — absorbing Harm meant for teammates

### 7.3.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I (0–40 XP):** Raise Body to 3, Melee to 2, take *Defensive Survival* and *Combat Reflexes*. Use a shield.
- **Tier II (41–90 XP):** Raise Body to 4, take *Conditioning* and *Tactical Movement*. Consider a War Mount Asset (8 XP) for mobility.
- **Tier III (91–150 XP):** Take *Battlefield Mastery* or *Mystic Bulwark*. Upgrade armor to Heavy if you have Strength. Start training a successor (Cap 3+ follower).

### 7.3.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Use the Defend action** when outnumbered; it improves your Position by one step and can protect allies.
- **Spend Boons on re-rolling failed defense rolls**, not on offense. Your job is to survive.
- **Position matters more than damage.** A Dominant position lets you re-roll failures – use shoves, terrain, and cover to stay in control.
- **When you take Harm, remember it clears Fatigue.** Sometimes a small wound is worth the reset.

**Story Hooks:**

- Who or what are they protecting? A person, a place, an ideal?
- What oath or duty drives them — sworn, inherited, or self-imposed?
- What happens if they fail in their protection?
- What personal costs do they bear for their role (scars, lost loved ones, broken oaths)?

**Legacy Note:** A loyal follower (squire, apprentice) can become your successor, inheriting your sworn duty and reputation. See 14.

### 7.3.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes** (Cost = rating  $\times$  3 XP): Body 3 (9), Spirit 2 (6), Wits 1 (3), Presence 1 (3)  $\rightarrow$  **21 XP**
- **Skills** (Cost = level  $\times$  2 XP): Melee 2 (4), Athletics 1 (2), Command 1 (2)  $\rightarrow$  **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

**With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).**

- Add **Talent:** Combat Reflexes (2 XP)
- Add **Talent:** Defensive Survival (3 XP)
- **Total:** 29 + 5 = 34 XP

## 7.4 2. The Mage (Wizard / Sorcerer / Arcanist)

**Concept:** A wielder of arcane power who reshapes reality through study, intuition, or pact. *Candlesmoke, marginalia, and dangerous truths.* From the rational Wizard of Thepyrgos to the instinctive Sorcerer of the Bloodlands, magic flows through them — and sometimes through them.

**Traditional Analogues:** Wizard, Sorcerer, Warlock (pact magic), Arcanist, Runekeeper

**Mechanical Foundation:**

- **Primary:** Wits (theory, precision), Spirit (willpower, channeling)
- **Skills:** Lore, Arcana, Investigation, (optionally) Sway (for social casting)
- **Talents:** Spellcraft (freeform), Codex (runekeeper), Patron's Symbol (invoker)

**Play Style:**

- Information gathering and magical analysis
- Solving puzzles and mysteries with arcane insight
- Using magic to gain advantages in combat and social scenes
- Researching new spells and rituals between adventures
- Managing Obligation (for Runekeepers) or Backlash (for free casters)

### 7.4.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Take *Spellcraft* (6 XP) or *Codex* + *Thiasos* (6 XP). Raise Wits to 3, Arcana/Lore to 2.
- **Tier II:** Add *Elemental Focus* (4 XP) or *Ritual Mastery* (4 XP). Raise Spirit to 3 for more Obligation capacity.
- **Tier III:** Take *Arcane Dominance* or *Crack Specialist* (if Invoker). Build a library (Standard Asset, 8 XP) to research faster.

### 7.4.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Push It** only when necessary – extra Obligation or Fatigue can snowball. Use Boons to improve Position before rolling.
- **Free casters:** Use cantrips (single tag) for safe, repeatable effects. Reserve multi-tag spells for critical moments.
- **Runekeepers:** Your Patron's Gift gives +1 Melee and +1 Thematic. Use it even if you aren't a fighter – the Thematic skill can be Sway, Lore, or Stealth.
- **Invokers:** *Crack the Seal* is for emergencies. Restore your Symbol during downtime before you need it again.

**Story Hooks:**

- What forbidden knowledge are they seeking?
- How did they acquire their magical talent — bloodline, study, pact, accident?
- What dangerous secrets might they uncover?
- Who opposes their research (rival mages, witch-hunters, the Church)?

**Legacy Note:** A trusted apprentice (follower) can inherit your Codex or Symbol collection, continuing your magical legacy. See 14.

**7.4.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).**

- **Attributes:** Wits 3 (9), Spirit 2 (6), Body 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Lore 2 (4), Arcana 1 (2) → **6 XP**
- **Total:** 27 XP (bank 3 XP)

**With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).**

- Add **Talent:** Spellcraft (6 XP) using banked  $3 + 4 = 7$  XP; bank 1 XP
- **Total:**  $27 + 6 = 33$  XP (bank 1 XP)

**7.5 3. The Rogue (Thief / Assassin / Scout)**

**Concept:** A shadow who moves where others cannot, taking what others cannot keep. *Quiet footfalls, hawk eyes, and no loyalties but coin.* From the street-wise cutpurse of Silkstrand to the deadly assassin of Zakov, the Rogue survives by wits, speed, and one hidden knife.

**Traditional Analogues:** Rogue, Thief, Assassin, Scout, Ranger (stealth focus), Spy

**Mechanical Foundation:**

- **Primary:** Wits (perception, quick thinking), Body (agility, stealth)
- **Skills:** Stealth, Subterfuge, Investigation (or Streetwise), (optionally) Melee (light weapons)
- **Talents:** Backstab, Elusive Dodge, Shadow Dance (later – see 6)

**Play Style:**

- Scouting ahead and gathering intelligence
- Infiltrating secured areas and disabling traps
- Ambush and skirmish tactics — striking from stealth
- Finding paths, contacts, and secrets in cities and wilderness

**7.5.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :**

- **Tier I:** Raise Wits to 3, Stealth/Subterfuge to 2. Take *Backstab* (6 XP) – you can afford it at 34 XP start.
- **Tier II:** Take *Elusive Dodge* (6 XP). Raise Body to 3 for better tracking. Consider a Minor Asset (Hidden Cache, 4 XP).
- **Tier III:** Take *Shadow Dance* (10 XP) and *Deathblow* (12 XP) – the classic assassination chain. Build a spy network (Standard Asset, 8 XP).

**7.5.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :**

- **Always aim for Dominant Position before attacking from stealth.** Spend a Boon to improve Position if needed.
- **Use the environment.** Ask the GM: “Is there a chandelier? A shadowed alcove? Loose gravel?” Use it to gain advantage.
- **Backstab + Shadow Dance + Deathblow** is lethal, but requires Boons. Engage only when you have 2–3 Boons saved.
- **When outmatched, retreat.** Spend a Boon to make a Controlled withdrawal instead of Desperate.

**Story Hooks:**

- What crime or secret forced them into the shadows?
- What treasure or truth are they hunting?
- How do they balance loyalty to allies with self-preservation?
- Who wants them dead — and why?

**Legacy Note:** A young pickpocket or informant (follower) could inherit your network of fences and contacts. See [14](#).

**7.5.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).**

- **Attributes:** Wits 3 (9), Body 2 (6), Presence 1 (3), Spirit 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Stealth 2 (4), Subterfuge 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

**With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).**

- Add **Talent:** Backstab (6 XP) – needs 6 XP; bank 1 + 4 = 5 XP → not enough. Alternative: Add **Skill:** Perception 1 (2 XP) and **Talent:** Combat Reflexes (2 XP) and bank 2 XP. Or take a Minor Asset: Hidden Cache (4 XP) and bank 2 XP.
- **Suggested:** Hidden Cache + bank 2 XP → total 33 XP.

**7.6 4. The Cleric (Priest / Healer / Exorcist)**

**Concept:** A vessel of divine or spiritual power, channeling healing, truth, and judgment. *Sacred flame, holy water, and a prayer on the lips.* From the Lampers of Ecktoria to the fog-named exorcists of the Mistlands, the Cleric binds wounds and banishes darkness.

**Traditional Analogues:** Cleric, Priest, Paladin (healing focus), Exorcist, Shaman, Healer

**Mechanical Foundation:**

- **Primary:** Spirit (faith, willpower), Presence (authority, channeling)
- **Skills:** Lore (theology, rites), Medicine, Sway (prayer, exhortation), (optionally) Melee (symbolic weapon)
- **Talents:** Invoker (Patron’s Symbol) or Runekeeper (Thiasos + Codex of a divine Patron like Everflame, Oath of Flame & Light, Pale Shepherd – see [3](#))

**Play Style:**



- Healing and protecting allies
- Purifying curses, diseases, and undead
- Ley line and ritual magic (wards, consecrations)
- Using authority of faith to command or persuade

#### 7.6.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Spirit to 3, Lore/Medicine to 2. Take a divine Patron's *Symbol* (4 XP) or *Codex* (4 XP).
- **Tier II:** Take *Symbol Resonance* (4 XP) or *Efficient Invocation* (4 XP). Raise Presence to 3 for better social influence.
- **Tier III:** Take *Crack Specialist* or *Patron's Favor*. Build a hospice or shrine (Standard Asset, 8 XP) to support your community.

#### 7.6.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Healing is powerful but slow.** In combat, stabilise Harm 2+ allies first; use Mend (Fatigue recovery) on everyone else.
- **Your Patron's Symbol grants a free +1 to ritual rolls.** Keep it displayed.
- **Consecrate ground before a big fight** – *Rite of Consecrated Ground* can turn the tide against undead or demons.
- **Obligation is story fuel.** When your Patron calls, answer – it will lead to adventure.

#### Story Hooks:

- What crisis of faith have they survived?
- What heresy or supernatural threat haunts them?
- How do they serve both the living and the dead?
- What price do they pay for divine power?

**Legacy Note:** An acolyte or lay healer (follower) can take up your Patron's Symbol and continue your mission. See [14](#).

#### 7.6.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Spirit 3 (9), Presence 2 (6), Wits 1 (3), Body 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Medicine 2 (4), Lore 1 (2), Sway 1 (2) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

#### With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Patron's Symbol (4 XP) for a divine Patron (e.g., Oath of Flame & Light), using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP; bank 1 XP
- **Total:** 33 XP (bank 1 XP)

## 7.7 5. The Bard (Diplomat / Skald / Courtier)

**Concept:** A master of words, music, and social influence who changes minds and opens doors. *A smile for the foyer, steel for the parlor.* From the Skald of Linn to the Courtier of Vhasia, the Bard wields charm, rumor, and reputation as weapons.

**Traditional Analogues:** Bard, Diplomat, Courtier, Skald, Spy (social), Negotiator

**Mechanical Foundation:**

- **Primary:** Presence (charm, performance), Wits (reading people, timing)
- **Skills:** Sway, Performance, Insight, (optionally) Lore (customs, history)
- **Talents:** Silver Tongue, Inspire, Network Builder (or Read Emotions)

**Play Style:**

- Social interaction and negotiation
- Gathering information through rumors and contacts
- Resolving conflicts without violence (or making violence fashionable)
- Building alliances, manipulating factions

#### 7.7.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Presence to 3, Sway to 2. Take *Silver Tongue* (2 XP) and *Inspire* (3 XP).
- **Tier II:** Take *Command Presence* (4 XP) and *Network Builder* (4 XP). Raise Wits to 3 for social reading.
- **Tier III:** Take *High Stance Duelist* (if you use a blade) or *Battlefield Terror*. Build a spy network (Standard Asset, 8 XP) or a courtly title (Major Asset, 12 XP).

#### 7.7.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Social scenes are your domain.** Use *Inspire* to give allies +1 die or +1 Boon – it can turn a negotiation.
- **Flashback declarations** (spend 1 Boon) are perfect for bards. “I already bribed the guard last night.”
- **Don’t neglect combat skills entirely.** A rapier and *High Stance Duelist* can make you a credible threat.
- **Use *Intricate* descriptions** to gain free re-rolls on 1s. Describe your performance, your charming smile, your family crest.

**Story Hooks:**

- What major conflict are they trying to resolve?
- What secret do they know that could topple a dynasty?
- How do they handle betrayal or failed negotiations?
- What personal relationships affect their diplomacy?

**Legacy Note:** A protégé or herald (follower) can inherit your reputation and contacts, keeping your network alive. See [14](#).

#### 7.7.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Presence 3 (9), Wits 2 (6), Spirit 1 (3), Body 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Sway 2 (4), Performance 1 (2), Insight 1 (2) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

**With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).**

- Add **Talent**: Inspire (3 XP) — once/scene, gain +1 die and potentially +1 Boon for bonded ally, using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP; bank 2 XP
- **Total**: 32 XP (bank 2 XP)

## 7.8 6. The Ranger (Hunter / Tracker / Beastmaster)

**Concept:** A wilderness expert who navigates dangerous territories and hunts down quarry. *Quiet footfalls, hawk eyes, and the long road.* From the Ykrul scout to the Valewood warden, the Ranger lives where roads end.

**Traditional Analogues:** Ranger, Hunter, Tracker, Beastmaster, Pathfinder, Wilderness Scout

**Mechanical Foundation:**

- **Primary:** Wits (perception, navigation), Body (agility, endurance)
- **Skills:** Survival, Stealth, Nature (or Animal Handling), Archery or Melee
- **Talents:** Wilderness Lore, Keen Senses, (optionally) Animal Companion

**Play Style:**

- Scouting ahead and gathering intelligence
- Wilderness survival and navigation
- Tracking creatures or people across terrain
- Ambushing from concealment, using terrain
- (Optional) Bonding with an animal companion

### 7.8.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Wits to 3, Survival/Stealth to 2. Take *Wilderness Lore* (2 XP) and *Keen Senses* (2 XP).
- **Tier II:** Take *Trackless Step* (2 XP) and *Elusive Dodge* (6 XP) or a War Hound (Minor Asset, 4 XP). Raise Body to 3.
- **Tier III:** Take *Shadow Dance* (10 XP) (if melee) or *Relentless* (6 XP) for traversal. Upgrade your animal companion to a War Mount (Standard Asset, 8 XP) if allowed.

### 7.8.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Use terrain to your advantage.** High ground, cover, and difficult terrain are your best friends. Ask the GM to set Position based on these.
- **Scout ahead** even when not required. Knowledge of what's coming negates ambushes and reduces travel clocks.
- **If you have an animal companion**, use it to harass enemies (Distract & Draw independent action) rather than direct combat.
- **Survival 3+ means you rarely need to roll for basic tasks.** Leverage that for guaranteed successes in wilderness travel.

**Story Hooks:**

- What uncharted territory are they exploring?
- What secrets have they discovered in the wild?
- How do they balance civilization and wilderness?

- What prey (beast or man) still eludes them?

**Legacy Note:** Your animal companion or a young tracker (follower) could carry on your legacy. See [14](#).

#### 7.8.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Wits 3 (9), Body 2 (6), Spirit 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Survival 2 (4), Stealth 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

#### With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Keen Senses (2 XP)
- Add **Talent:** Wilderness Lore (2 XP)
- **Total:** 29 + 4 = 33 XP (bank 1 XP)

## 7.9 7. The Survivor (Veteran / Outcast / Hardened)

**Concept:** Someone who has endured hardship and developed resilience. *Scars are maps; read them well.* From the war-torn mercenary to the plague survivor, the Survivor won't break — they've already been broken and rebuilt.

**Traditional Analogues:** Barbarian (resilience focus), Veteran, Ranger (endurance), Drifter, Refugee

#### Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Spirit (willpower, resolve), Body (toughness)
- **Skills:** Endurance, Survival, (optionally) Perception (danger sense), Medicine (field)
- **Talents:** Iron Stomach, Conditioning, Second Wind (see [6](#))

#### Play Style:

- Enduring difficult conditions (lack of food, exposure, poison)
- Overcoming physical and mental challenges through grit
- Using experience to avoid dangers
- Helping others survive hardships
- Taking hits that would fell others and still standing

#### 7.9.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Spirit to 3, Endurance/Survival to 2. Take *Iron Stomach* (3 XP) and *Second Wind* (2 XP).
- **Tier II:** Take *Conditioning* (4 XP) – your Body counts as +1 for Fatigue track. Raise Body to 3.
- **Tier III:** Take *Hollow-Touched* (8 XP) or *Stone-Bound Interdictor* (8 XP) to convert Harm to Fatigue. Build a safehouse (Minor Asset, 4 XP) for respite.

#### 7.9.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Embrace the roller-coaster effect.** Taking Harm clears Fatigue – sometimes a small wound

is a tactical reset.

- **Iron Stomach** makes you immune to mundane poisons and spoiled food. Volunteer to test unknown rations.
- Use *Second Wind* to clear Fatigue before it overflows into Harm.
- **When outmatched, use the environment.** Collapse a wall, start a fire, or trigger a rockfall. Your survival skills tell you how.

#### Story Hooks:

- What trauma or hardship have they survived?
- How has their past shaped their present?
- What survival skills have saved them repeatedly?
- How do they help others facing similar challenges?

**Legacy Note:** A fellow survivor (follower) can inherit your network of caches and safehouses. See 14.

#### 7.9.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Spirit 3 (9), Body 2 (6), Wits 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Endurance 2 (4), Survival 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

#### With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Iron Stomach (3 XP)
- **Total:** 29 + 3 = 32 XP (bank 2 XP)

## 7.10 8. The Innovator (Artificer / Engineer / Tinker)

**Concept:** A creative problem-solver who finds new solutions through craft and invention. *Blueprints on napkins, tomorrow in your pocket.* From the Aeler engineer to the Gnome clockmaker, the Innovator builds what others only dream.

**Traditional Analogues:** Artificer, Engineer, Tinker, Alchemist, Inventor, Savant

#### Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Wits (design, analysis), Body (fine manipulation)
- **Skills:** Craft, Tinker, Mechanics, (optionally) Alchemy, Investigation
- **Talents:** Quick Study, Technical Expert, (optionally) Magical Laboratory asset (see 8)

#### Play Style:

- Solving problems with unique inventions
- Creating or repairing specialized items
- Providing services others cannot (lockpicking, trap disarm, device creation)
- Using knowledge to gain advantages in planning

#### 7.10.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Wits to 3, Craft/Tinker to 2. Take *Quick Study* (3 XP) and *Workshop* (Minor

Asset, 4 XP).

- **Tier II:** Take *Efficient Invocation* (if magical) or *Weapon Mastery* (if martial). Raise Body to 3 for fine manipulation.
- **Tier III:** Take *Technical Expert* (custom) or *Crack Specialist* (for magical items). Build a Guild Workshop (Standard Asset, 8 XP) to attract apprentices.

#### 7.10.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Preparation is your superpower.** Spend downtime building tools, traps, and contingencies. Your GM will reward that.
- Use *Quick Study* to learn enemy weaknesses on the fly. “I notice the golem’s joints are unarmoured – aim there.”
- **Your workshop asset can jury-rig solutions.** Spend 1 Boon to “have the right tool” for a lock, a trap, or a repair.
- **When combat starts, use gadgets.** Caltrops, smoke bombs, and flash pellets can shift Position without a spell slot.

#### Story Hooks:

- What makes their specialty unique or valuable?
- How did they acquire their special skills (guild, apprenticeship, self-taught)?
- What problems require their specific expertise?
- Who seeks to control or exploit their abilities?

**Legacy Note:** An apprentice (follower) can inherit your workshop and blueprints, continuing your inventive tradition. See [14](#).

#### 7.10.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Wits 3 (9), Body 2 (6), Presence 1 (3), Spirit 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Craft 2 (4), Tinker 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

#### With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Quick Study (3 XP) — +1 die to learn or adapt from observation, using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP; bank 2 XP
- **Total:** 32 XP (bank 2 XP)

## 7.11 9. The Summoner (Pact-Whisperer / Necromancer / Shaman)

**Concept:** A binder of spirits, elementals, and otherworldly entities. *Circles of salt, whispered names, and bargains struck in shadows.* From the necromancer of the Mistlands to the shaman of the Steppe, the Summoner commands powers that others fear.

**Traditional Analogues:** Necromancer, Conjurer, Summoner, Shaman, Spirit Caller, Demonologist

#### Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Spirit (willpower, binding), Wits (rituals, names)

- **Skills:** Arcana, Lore (spirits), (optionally) Command, Survival
- **Talents:** Pact-Whisperer (Lesser/Greater), Spirit Link, (optionally) Codex of Names (see 3)

### Play Style:

- Summoning creatures to fight, scout, or work
- Binding entities to solve problems (guard, research, transport)
- Negotiating with spirits and outsiders (social challenges)
- Managing Leash clocks and Boon Finesse

#### 7.11.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Take *Pact-Whisperer* (2 XP) and *Lesser Pactwright* (2 XP). Raise Spirit to 3, Arcana/Lore to 2.
- **Tier II:** Take *Greater Pactwright* (4 XP) to summon Cap 3 spirits. Take *Spirit Synergy* (4 XP) if you want two spirits.
- **Tier III:** Take *Spirit Link* (10 XP) or *True Name Keeper* (15 XP). Build a Spirit Circle (Minor Asset, 4 XP) to reduce Leash ticks.

#### 7.11.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Boon Finesse** is your most important tool. Spend 1 Boon to clear 1 Leash tick – keep a reserve of 2–3 Boons for emergencies.
- **Spirits are disposable but not free.** Use them for dangerous tasks (scouting a trapped room, triggering a trap) before risking your own skin.
- **When the Leash fills, the spirit acts once to its nature.** Plan for it – position it near enemies before it breaks free.
- **Negotiate with spirits.** They have desires – a promise of freedom, a drop of blood, a secret. A willing spirit ticks Leash slower.

### Story Hooks:

- What entity are they bound to or seeking?
- What price did they pay for their first summoning?
- How do others react to their “dark” magic?
- Who hunts them for their forbidden practices?

**Legacy Note:** A bonded spirit or an apprentice medium (follower) could inherit your spirit contracts, continuing your work. See 14.

#### 7.11.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Spirit 3 (9), Wits 2 (6), Body 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Arcana 2 (4), Lore 1 (2) → **6 XP**
- **Total:** 27 XP (bank 3 XP)

#### With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Pact-Whisperer (2 XP)
- Add **Talent:** Lesser Pactwright (2 XP)

- **Total:**  $27 + 4 = 31$  XP (bank 3 XP; can add Familiar (2 XP) later or upgrade to Greater Pactwright)

## 7.12 10. The Commander (Warlord / Tactician / Leader)

**Concept:** A leader who directs allies, controls battlefields, and shapes conflicts through strategy. *Orders in a whisper, victory in formation.* From the Condotta captain to the Ekstorian legate, the Commander wins before blades are drawn.

**Traditional Analogues:** Warlord, Marshal, Tactician, Commander, Strategist, Banneret

**Mechanical Foundation:**

- **Primary:** Presence (authority, command), Wits (tactics, observation)
- **Skills:** Command, Tactics, (optionally) Sway (morale), Investigation (battlefield analysis)
- **Talents:** Inspire, Command Presence, Tactical Movement (for allies – see 6)

**Play Style:**

- Directing allies in combat (bonus dice, improved Position)
- Planning and executing tactical maneuvers
- Leading followers and assets in mass action (see 8)
- Using authority to intimidate or persuade

### 7.12.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Presence to 3, Command/Tactics to 2. Take *Command Presence* (4 XP) and *Inspire* (3 XP).
- **Tier II:** Take *Tactical Movement* (4 XP) and *Network Builder* (4 XP). Acquire a Cap 2–3 follower (soldier, herald).
- **Tier III:** Take *Battlefield Mastery* (6 XP) or *Mystic Bulwark* (8 XP). Build a War Chest (Standard Asset, 8 XP) to fund operations.

### 7.12.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- Use *Inspire* to give allies +1 die and +1 Boon. A well-timed inspiration can turn a miss into a success.
- **Your followers are your strength.** Keep them alive – spend Boons to protect them. A Cap 3 scout is worth more than a single attack.
- Use *Tactical Movement* to reposition without disengaging. Order allies to flank while you hold the line.
- **In mass combat, treat your unit as a high-Cap follower.** Your Command roll can advance the War Clock faster than any sword.

**Story Hooks:**

- What army or company did they lead before?
- What strategic defeat haunts them?
- Who are their rivals in the art of war?
- What cause do they fight for — coin, country, or creed?



**Legacy Note:** A loyal lieutenant or sergeant (follower) can inherit your command, leading the company after you. See [14](#).

#### 7.12.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Presence 3 (9), Wits 2 (6), Body 1 (3), Spirit 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Command 2 (4), Tactics 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

#### With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Command Presence (4 XP) — +1 die on leadership/intimidation rolls, using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP; bank 1 XP
- **Total:** 33 XP (bank 1 XP)

## Reskinning the Paths: Runekeeper and Invoker as Familiar Concepts

The magic systems in *Fate's Edge* are designed to be reimagined. Neither **Runekeeper** (Thiasos + Codex) nor **Invoker** (Patron's Symbol) is locked into a single narrative identity. Below are common reskins — use the same mechanics, change the fiction.

### Runekeeper – The Devoted Agent

A Runekeeper has sworn themselves to a single Patron, learning its Rites and bearing its Obligation. This framework can represent:

- **Paladin / Crusader:** Sworn to the *Oath of Flame & Light* or the *Inquisitor Prime*. Rites become prayers, smites, and consecrations. The Codex is a prayer book or a vow-etched gauntlet.
- **Warlock / Pact-Bearer:** Bound to a distant, alien, or dangerous Patron (e.g., Khemesh, Malachai, the Ninth). Rites are granted, not learned. Obligation is the steady pull of a bargain.
- **Cleric / Priest:** Devoted to the Everflame, the Pale Shepherd, or other divine powers. Rites are liturgies. The Patron's Gift is a blessing or a relic.
- **Dark Knight / Death Knight:** A fallen or morally ambiguous warrior who draws power from a grim Patron (Carrion-King, Mor'iraath). Melee and Rites mix; Obligation is a slow doom.

*Mechanical core unchanged:* 1 action Rites, Obligation track, Patron's Gift imbuelement, Push It option.

### Invoker – The Professional Occultist

An Invoker does not fully commit to a single Patron. Instead, they carry **Symbols** (often tools, badges, or relics) of several Powers and perform rituals to invoke their Rites. This framework can represent:

- **Exorcist / Witch Hunter:** Carries symbols of several protective Patrons (The Sealed Gate, Oath of Flame, Gallow's Bell). Rites are wards, banishments, and purification rituals. *Crack the Seal* is an emergency exorcism.
- **Alienist / Scholar of the Unseen:** Studies forbidden Patrons (The Ninth, Khemesh, Mor'iraath) from a safe distance — “safe” being relative. Uses Symbol libraries to invoke their power without full devotion. Rituals are experimental and dangerous.
- **Consulting Occultist / Paranormal Investigator:** Carries a briefcase or satchel of Symbols — a bell from the Mistlands, a sun-seal from Ecktoria, a hag's stone from Aelinnel. Hired to solve magical problems. Rituals are filed like work orders; *Crack the Seal* is “burning a favor.”
- **Ritualist / Ceremonial Mage:** Believes that power lies in procedure, not faith. Each Symbol is a “key” — a geometric diagram, a calendar, a consecrated blade. Rites are slow, deliberate, and precise. The Invoker is a technician, not a worshipper.

*Mechanical core unchanged:* Ritual time, Obligation per invocation, Symbol display reduces cost, *Crack the Seal* for instant effect.

### Mixing and Blurring Lines

Characters may also blend these frameworks — a Runekeeper who occasionally carries a second Symbol for emergency rites, or an Invoker who one day pledges fully to a Patron and becomes a Runekeeper. The system does not penalize narrative growth; simply retrain Talents during downtime (§6) when the fiction justifies it.

*Remember:* The fiction leads. If you want to play a Paladin, describe your Runekeeper's Rites as prayers. If you want a Vodouisant or Hoodoo practitioner, re flavor Patron's Symbols as sacred bundles, veyes, or spirit vessels. If you want a monster hunter, carry a satchel of

## 7.13 Creating Your Own Concept

### Start with Narrative

- What is your character's background and motivation?
- What role do they play in their community or society?
- What relationships are important to them?
- What goals are they pursuing?

### Add Mechanical Support

- Choose attributes that support your concept (see [4.1](#))
- Select skills that reflect their training and experience (see [4.2](#))
- Consider talents that provide unique capabilities (see [6](#))
- Think about assets that represent their resources (see [8](#))

### Consider Group Role

- How does your concept complement other party members?
- What gaps in group capability can you fill?
- What unique contributions can you make?
- How will you work with other characters?

### Plan for Growth

- What short-term improvements make sense?
- What long-term development aligns with your concept?
- How might your character change over time?
- What legacy do you want to build? (See [14](#))

### Character Concept Worksheet

#### Narrative Elements:

- Concept: \_\_\_\_\_
- Traditional Analogues: \_\_\_\_\_
- Motivation: \_\_\_\_\_
- Background: \_\_\_\_\_
- Relationships: \_\_\_\_\_

#### Mechanical Foundation:

- Primary Attributes: \_\_\_\_\_
- Key Skills: \_\_\_\_\_
- Starting Talents: \_\_\_\_\_
- Initial Assets: \_\_\_\_\_

#### Development Plan:

- Short-term goals: \_\_\_\_\_
- Long-term vision: \_\_\_\_\_

## 7.14 Final Notes

Remember that these examples are starting points, not limitations. The most interesting characters often combine elements from multiple concepts or create entirely new approaches. Work with your Game Master to ensure your character concept fits the campaign and provides engaging story opportunities.

The best characters are those that you find interesting to play and that contribute to an enjoyable experience for everyone at the table.

# Chapter 8

## Assets and Followers

Power in Fate’s Edge is not measured only by what your character can do with their own hands. As characters grow, their influence extends outward—into places, people, and institutions that act in their name.

**Assets** and **Followers** represent this outward reach. They are how a character’s past choices continue to matter when the dice stop rolling.

*Assets reshape the world around you. Followers stand beside you when the world pushes back.*

### A Word from the Raven Road

*“A safehouse is not a home; it is a promise you may not keep. A follower is not a servant; they are a weight you choose to carry. Invest wisely, or the road will collect.” — Dusana of the Raven Road, *The Hearth Ledger**

## 8.1 Understanding Assets and Followers

Assets and Followers serve different roles in play, but both are expressions of legacy, leverage, and risk.

### Key Differences

- **Assets** are off-screen resources: places, networks, titles, or enterprises.
- **Followers** are on-screen allies who act during scenes.
- **Assets** change the situation *before or around* a scene.
- **Followers** participate *directly* in the moment.

Both are powerful—but neither is free.

### Management and Risk

Assets and Followers require care and invite consequences:

- They demand upkeep through XP, downtime, or narrative obligation.
- They can be targeted, compromised, or destroyed.
- Overuse draws attention from enemies, factions, and rivals.

*Power creates gravity. What you rely on can be taken from you.*

## 8.2 Assets System

Assets are persistent resources under your control: holdings, institutions, reputations, or infrastructures.

***Assets do not replace rolls. They change what rolls are possible.***

Assets allow characters to:

- Arrive prepared instead of improvising.
- Reframe danger into opportunity.
- Shift Position without negating risk.

### Asset Types and Costs

| Type     | XP Cost | Establishment Time |
|----------|---------|--------------------|
| Minor    | 4 XP    | 1 day              |
| Standard | 8 XP    | 1 week             |
| Major    | 12 XP   | 1 month            |

### Asset Examples

**Minor Assets** Safehouse, small shop, minor title, basic workshop.

**Standard Assets** Guild membership, noble office, trading post, spy network.

**Major Assets** Fortress, chartered city license, major enterprise, regional authority.

### Using Assets

Assets provide leverage in two primary ways: quiet preparation and dramatic activation.

**8.2.0.0.1 Free Off-Screen Use** Each Asset has a defined off-screen effect usable **once per session**, typically during downtime or scene framing:

- **Safehouse:** Secure lodging or concealment.
- **Spy Network:** Baseline intelligence about a person or place.
- **Workshop:** Repair gear or prepare simple solutions.
- **Trading Post:** Acquire common goods or establish contacts.

These uses prepare the ground—they do not resolve active conflict.

**8.2.0.0.2 Boon Activation** Spend 1 **Boon** (see 2) to activate an Asset dramatically during a scene.

This does not guarantee success. Instead, the Asset **reshapes the fiction** so a different outcome becomes possible.

An activated Asset may:

- Improve **Position** by one step.
- Reduce the effective **DV** of a follow-up action.

- Advance, suppress, or redirect a relevant Clock.
- Grant temporary access, protection, or narrative permission.

#### Examples:

- **Safehouse:** Reveal a concealed exit, allowing escape at *Controlled* Position.
- **Spy Network:** Surface critical intelligence, advancing an investigation Clock.
- **Workshop:** Jury-rig a solution that enables an otherwise impossible attempt.
- **Trading Post:** Call in a favor to gain leverage or access in a negotiation.

The GM determines the precise effect based on the Asset's scale, condition, and the current stakes.

**8.2.0.0.3 High-Tier Use** At higher tiers (see 4.8), Assets carry greater narrative weight—and greater risk.

Repeated or aggressive use may:

- Create new complications.
- Advance hostile faction Clocks.
- Place the Asset itself in danger.

*Assets are leverage, not immunity.*

**8.2.0.0.4 XP Activation** Spend **2 XP** (see 4) to use an Asset's off-screen effect beyond its normal limit:

- Emergency use after the free activation is spent.
- Additional downtime applications.
- Exceptional circumstances requiring extended support.

XP use represents strain, overreach, or long-term cost.

## 8.3 Asset Conditions

Assets have condition states affecting their usefulness.

### Condition Levels

**Maintained** Fully functional, no penalties.

**Neglected** –1 die when used; requires attention.

**Compromised** Unavailable until repaired or recovered.

### Maintenance Requirements

- **Regular Upkeep:** Two options (see 8.8).
- **Neglect:** Assets deteriorate if not maintained.
- **Recovery:** Compromised assets require significant effort to restore.

## 8.4 Followers System

Followers are characters who assist you directly.

## Follower Capability Ratings

Followers are rated by Capability (**Cap**) from 1 to 5:

| Cap | Description                           |
|-----|---------------------------------------|
| 1   | Novice helper, basic assistance       |
| 2   | Competent assistant, reliable support |
| 3   | Skilled specialist, valuable aid      |
| 4   | Expert ally, significant capability   |
| 5   | Master companion, exceptional ability |

## Follower Costs

- **XP Cost:** Capability squared ( $Cap^2$ ).
- **Example:** Cap 3 follower costs  $3^2 = 9$  XP.
- **Recruitment:** 1–3 days downtime to find and brief.
- **Limits:** The GM may set maximum followers based on story.

## Follower Types

**Combat Allies** Warriors, guards, mercenaries.

**Technical Experts** Craftspeople, engineers, specialists.

**Social Contacts** Informants, diplomats, agents.

**Specialists** Unique capabilities like magic or stealth.

## 8.5 Using Followers

### Assistance in Scenes

Followers can help with your actions:

- **Assist Dice:** Add dice equal to  $\min(Cap, relevantskill)$ .
- **Maximum Bonus:** +3 dice total from all sources (see 2).
- **Cost:** Spend 1 Boon or 1 Fatigue to add +1 die (max +3 from assists).
- **One Helper:** Only one follower can assist per action.

### Independent Actions

Once per scene (party-wide), a follower can take a small action:

**Scout & Signal** Change an ally's next action to **Dominant** position.

**Distract & Draw** Reduce a threat clock by 1 segment.

**Fetch & Carry** Move an object through danger safely.

### Cost of Independent Actions

- Mark +1 **Exposure** (attention or stress), *or*
- Take **Harm 1** (injury or trauma).
- Cannot be used if the follower is already **Compromised**.



## 8.6 Follower Conditions

Followers track two condition types.

### Exposure

Represents attention, stress, or narrative pressure:

- **Gains:** From independent actions, dangerous situations, complications.
- **Effects:** Increased risk, reduced effectiveness, attention from enemies.
- **Recovery:** Downtime activities, careful management.

### Harm

Represents injury, trauma, or damage:

- **Gains:** From combat, accidents, enemy attacks.
- **Effects:** Penalties to assistance, possible incapacity.
- **Recovery:** Medical care, rest, magical healing.

### Condition States

**Maintained** Ready and reliable, full capability.

**Neglected** Needs attention, -1 die to assistance.

**Compromised** Unavailable: captured, defected, lost, or incapacitated.

## 8.7 Follower Risks

Using followers carries significant risks.

### Complication Targeting

When the GM spends **2+** **Story Beats** (see 2) on an action where you have assistance:

- The follower may face consequences instead of you.
- Consequences could be injury, capture, betrayal, or other complications.
- The outcome must be fictionally appropriate.

### Off-Screen Capability

Once per downtime, a **Cap 5** follower can solve a significant problem:

- But generates **1 Story Beat** for the party.
- The GM describes how this creates story consequences.
- Useful for emergencies, but costly.

## 8.8 Upkeep and Maintenance

Both assets and followers require regular maintenance. Each downtime period, choose one of the two options.

### Asset Upkeep

Two options:

- **Efficient (Higher XP, Less Time):** Pay Upkeep XP =  $\max(1, \lceil \text{AcquisitionXP}/3 \rceil)$ , minimal effort.
- **Intensive (Lower XP, More Time):** Pay 1 XP, use a dedicated downtime action with significant personal involvement.
- **Failure to Pay:** Asset becomes *Neglected* (or *Compromised* if already *Neglected*).

## Follower Upkeep

Two options:

- **Efficient:** Pay Upkeep XP =  $\max(1, \lceil \text{Cap}^2/3 \rceil)$ , minimal effort.
- **Intensive:** Pay 1 XP, use a dedicated downtime action with significant personal involvement.
- **Failure to Pay:** Follower becomes *Wary* (or *Seized* if already *Wary*).

## Upkeep Examples

- **Minor Asset (4 XP):** Efficient = 2 XP (4/3 rounded up); Intensive = 1 XP + action.
- **Standard Asset (8 XP):** Efficient = 3 XP (8/3 = 2.66 → 3); Intensive = 1 XP + action.
- **Cap 3 Follower (9 XP):** Efficient = 3 XP (9/3); Intensive = 1 XP + action.
- **Cap 2 Follower (4 XP):** Efficient = 2 XP (4/3 rounded up); Intensive = 1 XP + action.

## 8.9 Strategic Considerations

### When to Invest in Assets

- You need reliable off-screen capabilities.
- Your character concept involves wealth or influence.
- The party lacks certain logistical support.
- You want to build long-term influence.

### When to Invest in Followers

- You need on-screen assistance.
- Your character works better with support.
- The party needs specific capabilities you lack.
- You want character-driven story opportunities.

### Investment by Player Archetype

| Archetype        | Typical XP Investment | Best For                                                |
|------------------|-----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Solo             | 0–10%                 | Reliable personal power, minimal upkeep.                |
| Mixed (Balanced) | 15–25%                | One solid Follower or Asset (scout, safehouse).         |
| Mastermind       | 35–55%                | Networks, informants, multiple Assets; build a faction. |

### Balance Recommendations

- **Personal Path** (see 5.5): 0–10% of XP in assets/followers.
- **Balanced Path** (see 5.6): 15–25%.
- **Influencer Path** (see 5.7): 35–55%.

### Planning for Succession (The Legacy Engine)

A loyal Follower (Cap 3+) can become your **successor** when your character retires or falls – inheriting your faction standing, one unresolved burden, and a Legacy Bond. See **Chapter 13: The Legacy Engine (??)** for full rules. If you plan for your character's story to continue beyond them, invest in a follower you would trust to carry your banner.

## 8.10 Loyalty and Relationships

### Loyalty Levels (Optional)

**Wary** Cautious, may leave if pressured; +1 XP upkeep cost.

**Steady** Reliable, standard performance; normal upkeep.

**Devoted** Loyal, may sacrifice; can convert one major complication to a minor setback per arc.

### Building Loyalty

- Fair treatment and respect.
- Sharing rewards and successes.
- Protecting followers from harm.
- Honoring agreements and promises.

### Losing Loyalty

- Mistreatment or disrespect.
- Unreasonable demands or risks.
- Broken promises or betrayal.
- Consistent neglect.

## 8.11 Advanced Follower Management

### Follower Groups

For multiple similar followers, you can manage them as a group:

- **Single Rating:** Treat as one entity with combined capability.
- **Condition Tracking:** Group shares exposure and harm.
- **Maintenance:** Single upkeep cost for the group.
- **Risks:** Problems affect the entire group.

### Follower Advancement

Followers can improve over time:

- **Experience:** Gain capability through successful assistance.
- **Training:** Spend XP to improve follower capabilities.
- **Equipment:** Better gear can enhance effectiveness.
- **Limits:** Followers typically cap at lower levels than PCs.

## 8.12 Risk Management

### Asset Risks

- **Financial:** Assets can be costly to maintain.
- **Security:** Assets can be attacked or stolen.
- **Attention:** Valuable assets draw unwanted notice.
- **Dependency:** Over-reliance can be problematic.

### Follower Risks

- **Safety:** Followers can be harmed or captured.
- **Loyalty:** Followers may betray or leave.
- **Attention:** Followers can draw enemy interest.
- **Morale:** Followers have needs and limits.

### Mitigation Strategies

- **Diversification:** Don't put all resources in one place.
- **Security:** Protect valuable assets and followers.
- **Relationships:** Maintain good terms with your people.
- **Contingencies:** Have backup plans for losses.

### Assets and Followers Quick Reference

#### Assets:

- Minor: 4 XP | Standard: 8 XP | Major: 12 XP
- Free off-screen use: once per session
- Boon activation: spend 1 Boon for scene impact
- Conditions: *Maintained* → *Neglected* → *Compromised*

#### Followers:

- Cost:  $Cap^2$  XP
- Assistance:  $+\min(Cap, skill)$  dice (max +3 from all sources)
- Independent action: once per scene (party-wide)
- Conditions: *Exposure* and *Harm* tracks

#### Upkeep Options:

- Efficient:  $\max(1, \lceil Cost/3 \rceil)$  XP, minimal time
- Intensive: 1 XP, dedicated downtime action

## 8.13 Practical Examples

### Asset Example: The Safehouse

- **Type:** Minor Asset (4 XP)
- **Free Use:** Secure lodging, basic supplies between adventures.
- **Boon Activation:** Reveal a hidden escape route during pursuit.
- **Upkeep:** Efficient: 2 XP (4/3 rounded up); Intensive: 1 XP + downtime action.
- **Risks:** Discovery by enemies, maintenance costs.

### Follower Example: The Scout

- **Capability:** 3 (9 XP cost)
- **Assistance:** +3 dice on tracking and survival rolls.
- **Independent Action:** Scout ahead to improve party position.
- **Upkeep:** Efficient: 3 XP (9/3); Intensive: 1 XP + downtime action.
- **Risks:** Injury in dangerous scouting; disloyalty if mistreated.

### Combination Example: The Merchant

- **Assets:** Trading post (8 XP), caravan (4 XP) — *12 XP total*
- **Followers:** Cap 2 guards (4 XP each = 8 XP), Cap 3 factor (9 XP) — *17 XP total*
- **Total Investment:** **29 XP** in assets and followers
- **Upkeep (Efficient):** Assets 4 XP + Followers 6 XP = **10 XP** per downtime
- **Benefits:** Trade income, transport, protection, business contacts
- **Risks:** Competition, bandit attacks, employee issues, regulatory attention

*Remember:* Assets and followers can greatly expand your capabilities, but they require careful management and carry significant risks. Invest wisely based on your character concept and the needs of your group.

## 8.14 Narrative-Heavy Asset and Follower Options

For groups that prefer strong narrative focus, consider these optional approaches.

**8.14.0.0.1 Story-Driven Upkeep** Instead of tracking XP costs for upkeep, the GM can introduce narrative complications that require attention. A neglected asset might attract unwanted attention, while a neglected follower might request a favor or special treatment.

**8.14.0.0.2 Collaborative Management** Players can describe how they maintain their assets and followers through roleplay rather than mechanical upkeep costs. A well-described scene of tending a workshop or bonding with followers can fulfill maintenance requirements.

**8.14.0.0.3 Asset and Follower as Character Development** Use asset and follower management as opportunities for character growth and backstory development, allowing players to narrate how their relationships and holdings evolve through significant story moments.

**8.14.0.0.4 Flexible Condition Tracking** Focus on the narrative implications of asset and follower conditions rather than strict mechanical penalties. A “Neglected” asset might still function but with interesting complications, while a “Compromised” asset might require creative solutions rather than just XP investment.

## 8.15 Terrestrial Patrons

Not all power comes from cosmic entities or divine forces. Sometimes your greatest allies—and most demanding creditors—are mortal factions who can offer protection, resources, and influence in the world of men.

### 8.15.1 What Are Terrestrial Patrons?

Terrestrial Patrons represent your ongoing relationships with powerful mortal organizations:

- Noble houses and courtly factions.
- Merchant guilds and trading consortiums.
- Military units and mercenary companies.
- Criminal organizations and smuggling rings.
- Religious orders and temple hierarchies.
- Scholarly colleges and arcane societies.

Unlike supernatural Patrons (see 3), Terrestrial Patrons do not grant magic, but they offer **leverage**: protection, resources, sanctuary, information, and political influence.

### 8.15.2 Gaining a Terrestrial Patron

To gain a Terrestrial Patron, complete one of these significant actions:

- Complete a major job or service for them.
- Swear a formal Oath of service.
- Enter into legal or financial binding.
- Share criminal secrets or be compromised by them.
- Perform a notable service that earns their favor.

Mark the Patron on your character sheet and write one sentence: “*They want me because \_\_\_\_\_*”.

### 8.15.3 Obligation System

Terrestrial Patrons use the same Obligation track as supernatural Patrons (see 3.3.1), but consequences are social, legal, or economic rather than mystical.

- **Calling in Favors:** When you request Patron influence, add +1 Obligation.
- **Capacity:** Spirit + Presence (same as supernatural Patrons).
- **Overflow:** Each segment above capacity inflicts 1 Fatigue.
- **Resolution:** Reduce through service, downtime actions, or fulfilling demands.

### 8.15.4 Patron Perks

Each Terrestrial Patron offers 2–3 repeatable benefits that require no rolls to access.

**Common Perks Include:**

- Sanctuary in their territory or establishments.
- Legal relief or protection from certain authorities.
- Access to black market goods or specialized services.
- Elite followers or hirelings at reduced cost.
- Forged documents or identity protection.
- Military backing or private security.
- Information networks and rumor access.
- Trade advantages or exclusive contracts.

Using a perk never requires a roll—Fate has already been paid. Each use comes with the ongoing cost of Obligation.

### 8.15.5 Patron Demands

Terrestrial Patrons always want something in return:

- Silence about sensitive information.
- Loyalty over other conflicting interests.
- Completion of specific jobs or tasks.
- Delivery of valuable names or secrets.
- Political or social support for their causes.
- Elimination of rivals or threats to their interests.

**Refusing a Demand** raises Obligation by 1 segment and may trigger immediate complications.

### 8.15.6 When Obligation Fills

At **6 Obligation segments**, the Patron acts—this is not optional. Choose one:

1. **Unavoidable Job:** You must complete a task you cannot refuse.
2. **Severe Price:** Pay significant cost (legal, social, or material).
3. **First Strike:** They act against you—reputation damage, warrants, bounty, blackmail.

After the consequence lands, reduce Obligation to 3 segments.

### 8.15.7 Cutting Ties

You may sever a Terrestrial Patron relationship, but doing so has serious fallout:

- Lose all current perks immediately.
- Gain a new **Rival** faction that opposes your interests.
- Take a lasting **Complication** (Curse, Bounty, or Scandal) that follows you.
- May trigger immediate retaliation depending on the Patron's nature.

Some Patrons never forgive betrayal; others can be bought off with significant compensation.

### 8.15.8 Redemption and Favor

If you perform a monumental service for a Patron—something beyond what was asked—reduce Obligation by 2 and gain a permanent **Favor**.

**Favor Benefits:**

- Noble title or official position.
- Land grant or property rights.
- Permanent access to exclusive resources.
- Unique asset or specialized equipment.
- Political influence or legal immunity.
- Protection from their rivals or enemies.

### 8.15.9 Example: The Black Ledger

The Black Ledger is a smuggling syndicate operating in the coastal city of Kahfagia.

**Gaining Their Favor:** Successfully complete three smuggling runs without detection.

**Perks:**

- Sanctuary in hidden safehouses throughout the city.
- Access to rare imported goods and contraband.
- Information about port authorities and customs schedules.

#### **Demands:**

- Maintain silence about syndicate operations.
- Transport occasional “special packages” (may be illegal).
- Eliminate rival smugglers who threaten their routes.

**Sample Scenario:** Rellan calls on the Ledger for a smuggled border crossing. The GM rules it succeeds automatically, but adds +1 Obligation. Later, the Ledger demands he silence a witness who saw too much. If he refuses, Obligation rises again. If Obligation ever reaches 6, the Ledger collects: accounts frozen, bounty posted, or a rival informant sent after him.

### **8.15.10 Creating Your Own Terrestrial Patrons**

When designing a Terrestrial Patron, consider:

1. **Nature:** What type of organization are they?
2. **Motivation:** What drives their goals and actions?
3. **Resources:** What can they realistically offer?
4. **Methods:** How do they typically operate?
5. **Enemies:** Who opposes their interests?
6. **Perks:** 2–3 concrete benefits they provide.
7. **Demands:** 3–5 typical requests they make.

*Remember:* Terrestrial Patrons make the mortal world feel alive and reactive. They represent the complex web of loyalty, debt, and influence that shapes everyday life in Fate’s Edge.

## **8.16 Multi-Character Switching System**

This framework allows a player to temporarily move a character offscreen while continuing play with another. The absent character remains active in the fiction and continues shaping the world through **Downtime Logs**, consequences, and story pressure.

### **8.16.1 Core Principles**

- Players **choose** when their character steps offscreen.
- Offscreen characters still **matter** to the narrative.
- Absence creates **opportunity and risk**, not punishment.
- The world reacts to characters **even when unseen**.

### **8.16.2 Switch Mechanics**

#### **8.16.2.1 Declaration**

When a player chooses to step out, they declare:

- Which character is going offscreen.
- Where the character is going (fictional location).
- Why they are stepping out (story reason).
- How long they expect to be away (1–3 sessions).



The character becomes an **Echo Character**: present in the world, but offscreen.

### 8.16.2.2 Controlled Status Types

Echo Characters take one of three statuses:

- **Supporting** (default): Works to assist active PCs.
- **Advancing**: Pursues their own agenda or project.
- **In Peril**: Their absence creates danger or urgency.

The GM and player collaborate to set this status.

### 8.16.3 Downtime Log

Each offscreen session, the player completes a simple **Downtime Log**:

#### 8.16.3.1 Structure

- **Resource Action**: How they maintain connections or standing.
- **Project Action**: One goal or project advanced.
- **Event Response**: How they react to unseen events or threats.

#### 8.16.3.2 Tier-Based Project Limits

- Tier I–II: 1 Project.
- Tier III–IV: 2 Projects.
- Tier V: 3 Projects.

#### 8.16.3.3 GM Response

The GM records:

- The fictional outcome of each declaration.
- One meaningful **Consequence** (complication, shift, or new opportunity).

### 8.16.4 Return Mechanics

#### 8.16.4.1 Re-Entry Process

When returning to play:

1. The returning character gains **2 Boons** for narrative re-entry.
2. Roll **Wits + Spirit** (DV 3) to reestablish presence.
3. Address unresolved plot threads created during absence.

#### 8.16.4.2 Re-Entry Consequences

The GM assigns one:

- **Ripple Effect** — your absence reshaped the situation.
- **Opportunity Missed** — a door closed without you.
- **Allies Gained** — your actions forged new connections.
- **Rivals Made** — someone now works against you.
- **Personal Growth** — you return wiser or transformed.
- **Lost Momentum** — your projects slipped.

## 8.16.5 Advanced Systems

### 8.16.5.1 Buddy System

If multiple players are absent:

- Nominate a **Buddy** to help track Downtime Logs.
- The Buddy gains **+1 additional Boon** for the support role.

### 8.16.5.2 Crisis Management

Offscreen characters track a **Crisis Clock** [6]:

- Fills when negative consequences strike.
- At 6: The character faces a major offscreen crisis requiring GM action.
- May be reduced through Downtime Log responses or assistance from active PCs.

## 8.16.6 GM Guidelines

- Spend 5–7 minutes per absent character completing their Downtime Log.
- Focus on narrative change, not bookkeeping pressure.
- Absence should generate hooks and stakes, not penalties.
- Use Echo Characters to keep the world *alive and reactive*.

## 8.16.7 Player Guidelines

- Declare offscreen goals with clear fictional intent.
- Treat absence as character growth, not disappearance.
- Collaborate with the GM to weave consequences into play.
- Expect absence to create tension, opportunity, and drama.

# Chapter 9

## World Interaction

### Using This Chapter

This chapter gives you the tools to move through the world, interact with its people, and make your journey meaningful. For detailed descriptions of each region's culture, subgenre, and notable NPCs, see **Chapter 11 (World Regions and Cultures)**. The two chapters work together: this one covers *how* to travel and interact; the next tells you *where* and *with whom*.

In **Fate's Edge**, the world is not a backdrop—it's a partner in the conversation. Dikes groan under black rain in Viterra, clan horns answer across Acasia's ridgelines, Ecktoria's marble halls echo with careful words, and Kahfagia's pilots read storms by taste. Wherever you go, place, culture, and pressure push back.

### 9.1 The Known World: A Geographic Overview

The following summary orients the major regions relative to one another. (See [10](#) for cultural details.)

**Ecktoria** Temperate heartland of the old Utaran Imperium. Borders Acasia to the northeast and Kahfagia to the west. Marble cities, imperial roads, codified law.

**Acasia** Lowland of rivers and petty kingdoms, northeast of Ecktoria. Broken province of mercenary companies and border lords. Borders Vhasia to the east.

**Vhasia** Fractured kingdom on a southern peninsula. East of Acasia, west of Viterra. Courtly intrigue, martial tradition, and fractured sun symbolism.

**Viterra** Shares the same peninsula with Vhasia, lying further east. Its eastern coast borders a dark inland body (the Blackwater). Hedge-law, river tolls, and the Last Kingdom.

**Kahfagia** West of Ecktoria, facing the open ocean. Maritime empire of storm-flags, deep-sea pilots, and exotic imports.

**Thepyrgos** Occupies the southern part of the great peninsula opposite Vhasia/Viterra. Eastern coast overlooks the Astroegro Straits. City of a Thousand Stairs, center of learning.

**Theona** Large island off the eastern coast of Viterra. Three isles, causeways, marsh, and the "No Ninth" taboo.

**Mistlands** Western shore of the Aberderrian Sea (north of the Amaranthine). Bog, fog, and bell-lines; protectorate of the Aeler. Direwood lies to the west.

**Linns** Scattered around the Yloka River and the Aberderrian Sea. Longships reach the Blackwater

and raid Theona and Viterra. Fjords, skerries, storm-oaths.

**Violet Steppe** North of the Amaranthine, west of the Aberderrian Sea. Vast grassland, home of the Ykrul nomads.

**Valewood** East of the Blackwater. Ancient forest of phasing ruins, star-roads, and fae courts. Former Lethai empire.

**Aelinnel (Aevrossa)** South of the Valewood. Gnomish homeland of stone, bough, and bright things. Mist paths, bell-mounds, tide-gates.

**Aelaerem** South of Aevrossa. Halfling downs of gentle valleys and deep barrows. Homeland spoken of only in euphemisms (“The Silent Welcome”).

**Zakov** Island in the Blackwater, near the mouth of the Yloka River. Pirate haven, reef passages, salt and serpent.

## 9.2 Game Structure and Time

Understanding how time works in Fate’s Edge helps you navigate both the mechanical and narrative flow of play.

### Basic Units

**Scene** The basic unit of narrative play, covering a specific situation or conflict (Some Time to Significant Time). Resolves a particular question or challenge.

**Player Turn (Beat)** An individual player’s action within a scene: Declare action → GM sets position → roll → resolve outcome → manage consequences.

**Round** Simultaneous or near-simultaneous actions within a scene (primarily for combat), representing a few seconds of real time.

**Session** One complete game session (typically 3–6 hours), containing 2–4 major scenes and resolving significant narrative progress.

**Downtime** The narrative time between scenes, used for recovery, advancement, and off-screen activities. Measured in days, weeks, or months depending on fiction.

**Campaign** Entire story arc (6–20+ sessions) with major character development and lasting consequences.

## 9.3 Movement and Positioning

Space is tracked with **range bands** and **Position** (see 2 for full rules).

### Range Bands

**Close** Touching distance: grapples, knife-work, hand on a relic.

**Near** Same room/yard/deck; a rush away.

**Far** Same site but distant; requires route or time to reach.

**Absent** Off-screen; requires scene change or significant effort to interact.

### Movement Actions

- **Move:** Shift one range band as a *beat*.
- **Dash:** Shift two bands as your full action (terrain may require a roll).
- **Melee Flag:** Mark when two parties are in Near range and directly engaged in combat.

## Position States

**Dominant** You have cover, leverage, or ritual footing. Failure still leaves options.

**Controlled** Standard case: exposed lanes, rivals near, watchful eyes. Failure has teeth, but not ruin.

**Desperate** Bad ground, bad odds, bad timing. Failure is severe; success may bring extra XP.

### 9.3.0.0.1 Position Shifting:

- GM can spend **1 SB** to worsen Position by one step.
- Player can spend **1 Boon** to improve Position by one step (once per action).
- Narrative triggers (flanking, reinforcements, etc.) can shift Position without cost.

## 9.4 Travel Framework

Travel abstracts distance into *legs* with tension and color rather than miles and meal counts. Each leg has a **Travel Clock** and draws on a **regional deck** to seed fiction.

### Travel Process

1. **Set the Leg:** Name origin and destination; start a Travel Clock (4-10 segments based on difficulty).
2. **Draw Prompts:** Draw up to one card from each suit to establish terrain, people, pressures, and leverage.
3. **Assign Roles:** Players take on travel roles (see below) to contribute actions.
4. **Play the Leg:** Players take actions to advance the clock or mitigate complications. GM spends SB from rolls showing **1s** to introduce hazards.
5. **Resolve:** When the clock fills, you arrive—changed by the journey.

### Travel Roles

**Guide** Sets course, reads signs. Rolls navigation; on success, tick the Travel Clock +1.

**Scout** Moves ahead, first contact with hazards or ambushes. On success, the party cannot be surprised on the first encounter of the leg.

**Quartermaster** Manages supplies and encumbrance. On success, prevents one Supply drop or recovers 1 spent Supply.

**Watch** Maintains vigilance. On success, the party gains +1 Position on the first defense roll of any ambush.

Each role action requires a roll (Attribute + appropriate skill, DV set by the GM). Failure may tick the Travel Clock backwards or introduce a complication.

### Using Assets and Followers During Travel

- **Assets** (see 8): Spend 1 Boon to activate an asset dramatically during travel – reveal a hidden path, call for emergency aid, or secure safe lodging.
- **Followers:** Assign followers to travel roles for bonuses. A Cap3 Scout follower adds +3 to navigation rolls, for example. They can also take independent actions (scout ahead, secure supplies) at the cost of Exposure or Harm (see 8.5).
- **Off-Screen Solutions:** High-Cap followers (4–5) can solve significant travel problems once per downtime, but generate 1 SB for the party.

## Regional Travel Decks

Each major region has a themed prompt list or card table (see full rules in the *GM Guide*). Your GM will use these to generate encounters that match the region's flavour.

## Travel Complications

Common complications include:

- **Hazards:** Weather, terrain challenges, wildlife encounters.
- **Social:** Border checks, local politics, cultural misunderstandings.
- **Supplies:** Food shortages, equipment failure, resource management.
- **Pursuit:** Being followed, hunted, or racing against time.

## 9.5 Narrative Time

Time is measured by *importance* rather than duration.

**A Moment** A glance, a strike, a whisper over a law-stone.

**Some Time** A skirmish, a negotiation, a careful climb.

**Significant Time** Hours of march, rites, audits, stakeouts.

**Days** Drills, recoveries, research, roadwork.

## 9.6 Social Interactions

Social scenes use the same engine with **cultural color** (see 2).

### Cultural Skill Emphases

Different regions value different approaches. Use the table in **Chapter 11 (World Regions and Cultures)** to see what skills are most effective where. In general:

**Viterra** Rapport with parishes; Sway for markets; Command under writ.

**Acasia** Rapport for kin-bridges; Command with banner-rights; Deceive risks honour clocks.

**Ecktoria** Sway in salons; Deceive at court; Perform in temple fora.

**Kahfagia** Rapport aboard; Sway at piers; Command on a storming deck.

### Social Stakes & Clocks

Your GM may use visible clocks to track social progress:

- **Alliance Clock (Viterra):** Parishes and guilds come to your side.
- **Honor Clock (Acasia):** Feasts, oaths, wyrd—trust builds (or frays).
- **Bureau Clock (Ecktoria):** Stamps, seals, approvals—delay is pressure.
- **Trust Clock (Kahfagia):** Pilots and crews extend favours and routes.

## 9.7 Supply and Resources

Track scarcity with a **Supply Clock** shared by the party's expedition.

| Segments | State & Effects               |
|----------|-------------------------------|
| 0 (Full) | Well-provisioned; no penalty. |

|               |                                         |
|---------------|-----------------------------------------|
| 2 (Low)       | Minor frictions; -1 to resource checks. |
| 3 (Dangerous) | Each PC gains <i>Fatigue 1</i> .        |
| 4 (Empty)     | Severe penalties; desperate measures.   |

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## 9.8 Engaging the World—Player Actions

- **Scout & Signal:** A follower can make the next travel action *Dominant* (mark Exposure or Harm 1 on them – see 8.5).
- **Local Color:** Briefly state what locals notice about you; GM offers a small fictional edge *or* a tempting clock – choose.
- **Mark the Map:** On arrival, declare one change to the fiction (new ford, patron’s shrine, toll-skip). GM may attach a minor clock as cost.
- **Asset Activation:** Spend 1 Boon to activate an asset dramatically during a scene (see 8).
- **Follower Assistance:** Have a follower assist your actions for bonus dice (max +3 from all sources, see 2).

## 9.9 Summary

The world has opinions. Movement is clocks and colour, position rises and sinks with weather and words, and every suit you draw speaks in a regional accent. Ask the land for a favour—then pay it back on the road.

**9.9.0.0.1 Remember:** Every interaction with the world is an opportunity. Use your assets, deploy your followers, and engage with the setting actively. The world responds to your choices, and every journey changes both you and the places you pass through.

# Chapter 10

## World Regions and Cultures

### Using This Compendium

**You only need to read the region your character is from or where the campaign starts.** The GM will tell you when other regions become relevant.

Each entry includes:

- **Fantasy subgenre** – so you know what kind of stories to expect.
- **Attitude toward magic** – how the locals react to spellcasters.
- **Typical dress / customs** – to help you describe your character.
- **Player hook** – a story seed to tie your character to this place.
- **Key stakeholders** – major NPCs and factions you might encounter.

For GM-only secrets (hidden agendas, faction clocks), see the *GM Guide*.

### Quick Reference by Subgenre

| Region        | Fantasy Subgenre                     | Magic Attitude                                         |
|---------------|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Acasia        | Low fantasy / mercenary realism      | Folk-wards respected; visible sorcery risky.           |
| Aelaerem      | Folk horror / pastoral dark          | Hedge-magic common; open magic attracts the Neighbors. |
| Aeler         | Industrial / survival horror         | Rituals are craft; magic is guild-regulated.           |
| Aelinnel      | Fae / mathematical / courtesy horror | Fae rites only; iron is taboo.                         |
| Black Banners | Military / mercenary warfare         | Pragmatic; useful magic tolerated.                     |
| Ecktoria      | Political intrigue / legal drama     | Licensed thaumaturges; unlicensed magic is crime.      |
| Linn          | Viking / maritime                    | Weather rites are sacred; false rites are sin.         |
| Mistlands     | Folk horror / gothic                 | Bell-magic and salt – necessary but dangerous.         |
| Silkstrand    | Urban / mercantile / noir            | Curse-magic feared; trade magic accepted.              |
| Theona        | Celtic / folk horror / taboo-driven  | Old rites respected; the Ninth taboo governs all.      |
| Thepyrgos     | Byzantine / academic                 | Magic studied; unorthodox styles unfashionable.        |
| Ubral         | Highland clan / honour culture       | Outsider mages watched; clan shamans respected.        |
| Valewood      | Fairy tale / dark forest             | Fey magic, imperial echoes – dangerous to meddle.      |
| Vhasia        | Courtly romance / fractured kingdom  | Church distrusts magic; lords employ mages anyway.     |
| Viterra       | Legal drama / frontier justice       | Hedge-magic common; registered magic tolerated.        |
| Ykrul         | Steppe nomad / saga                  | Geometry of oaths; shamanism respected.                |
| Zakov         | Pirate / noir / crime syndicate      | Any magic welcome – if it pays.                        |



## 10.1 Acasia — “The Broken Province”

**Genre:** Low fantasy / mercenary realism / border feud.

**10.1.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic:** Hedge-witches respected; visible sorcery can start a levy. The Curse is blamed on ancient magic.

**10.1.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs:** Wool and leather, scarves to hide clan markings. Feasts often end in oath-swearing; never sign a contract on a bridge.

**10.1.0.0.3 Player hook:** *You owe a blood-debt to a free company captain – or you are that captain.*

**10.1.0.0.4 Key stakeholders:** Margravine of the Broken March, The Lame King, Blackwood Matriarchs, Free Company Captains.

## 10.2 Aelaerem (Halflings) — “Hearth & Hollow”

**Genre:** Folk horror / pastoral quiet with dark undercurrents.

**10.2.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic:** Hearth-magic (red thread, cup-marks) is everyday. Open magic may attract the Neighbors.

**10.2.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs:** Bright wool, red doors, nine cups never poured. Hospitality is sacred – and a trap.

**10.2.0.0.3 Player hook:** *The Pale Shepherd came for your grandmother. You still hear her footsteps.*

**10.2.0.0.4 Key stakeholders:** Apple-Matron, The Pale Shepherd, Mummers’ Captain, Lantern-Warden.

## 10.3 Aeler (Dwarves) — “Crowns & Under-Vaults”

**Genre:** Industrial / political / survival horror (underground).

**10.3.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic:** Rituals are a craft, guild-licensed. Unsanctioned magic damages air and stone.

**10.3.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs:** Heavy aprons, breath-masks, bell-tokens. Count your breaths in eights; never waste water.

**10.3.0.0.3 Player hook:** *You broke a seal in the deep ways and something followed you up.*

**10.3.0.0.4 Key stakeholders:** Vault-Queen, High King Beneath the Peaks, True Masons, Edgewalkers.

## 10.4 Aelinnel (Gnomes) — “Stone, Bough, and Bright Things”

**Genre:** Fae / mathematical / courtesy horror.

**10.4.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic:** Fae rites, geasa, and ledger-magic. Iron is taboo; copper is polite.

**10.4.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs:** Bright coats, copper tools, counting beads. Never trust a single ledger.

**10.4.0.0.3 Player hook:** *You spoke a word you shouldn't have, and now the Green Gate demands payment.*

**10.4.0.0.4 Key stakeholders:** Stone Prince of Aelinnel, Lady of Thorns, Green Knight, Oath-Carver.

## 10.5 Black Banners — “Condotta & Crowns”

**Genre:** Military / mercenary / low fantasy warfare.

**10.5.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic:** Battle-magic is useful; unreliable mages don't get paid. Condotta captains hire cantors for morale.

**10.5.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs:** Tabards over rusted mail, scarves to hide old loyalties. Payday is sacred; betrayal is business.

**10.5.0.0.3 Player hook:** *Your company was sold out from under you. Now you hunt the broker who took the coin.*

**10.5.0.0.4 Key stakeholders:** Banner-Captain, The Black Colonel, Clan-Mother (Ykrul), Veteran Sergeant.

## 10.6 Ecktoria — “Marble & Fire”

**Genre:** Political intrigue / legal drama / fallen empire.

**10.6.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic:** Licensed thaumaturges file casting notices. Unlicensed magic is a crime, often punished by the Everflame inquisitors.

**10.6.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs:** Togas, seal rings, procession masks. Law is a weapon; never refuse a toast in a coin-house.

**10.6.0.0.3 Player hook:** *You forged a document that could topple a senator – or save a heretic.*

**10.6.0.0.4 Key stakeholders:** Grand Magistrate, High Priest of the Everflame, Duchess-Regent, Censor's Clerk.

## 10.7 Linn — “Skerries & Storm-Oaths”

**Genre:** Viking / maritime / oath-bound raiding.

**10.7.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic:** Weather magic is sacred; false rites are crimes against the ship. Skalds use songs for law and memory.

**10.7.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs:** Wool, leather, whale-bone runes. Oaths sworn on the tide cannot be broken without drowning.

**10.7.0.0.3 Player hook:** *Your father's sword was lost in a raid. The sea-queen says the drowned still carry it.*

**10.7.0.0.4 Key stakeholders:** Sea-Queen, High Jarl, Volva of the Mist, Skald.

## 10.8 Mistlands — “Bells, Salt, and Breath”

**Genre:** Folk horror / gothic / supernatural dread.

**10.8.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic:** Bell-lines and salt are the only trusted magic. Outsider spellcasters are viewed with suspicion.

**10.8.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs:** Grey wool, fog-veils, bell-charms. Never breathe deeply after the ninth bell.

**10.8.0.0.3 Player hook:** *You were born during a bell-line failure. The fog knows your name – it has visited twice.*

**10.8.0.0.4 Key stakeholders:** Legate of the Mists, Bell-Warden, Salt-Monk, Mist-Seer.

## 10.9 Silkstrand — “City of Bridges & Dyewater”

**Genre:** Urban / mercantile / noir.

**10.9.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic:** Curse-magic feared; trade magic (dye-wards, bridge-blessings) accepted. The Matron employs a weft-reader.

**10.9.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs:** Dyed silks, debtor's stains, bridge tokens. Every bridge is a ledger; every handshake a contract.

**10.9.0.0.3 Player hook:** *You're the only one who knows the secret of the red dye. The guild wants the recipe – or your hands.*

**10.9.0.0.4 Key stakeholders:** The Matron, Guildmistress of Dyers, Bridge Bailiff, Night-Boat Smuggler (“Ravel”).

## 10.10 Theona — “Three Greens, No Ninth”

**Genre:** Celtic / folk horror / taboo-driven.

**10.10.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic:** Old rites (well-blessings, bride-peace) are essential. Breaking a taboo invites the Green Host.

**10.10.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs:** Peat-stained cloaks, hawthorn pins, counting in eights. The ninth cup is never poured.

**10.10.0.0.3 Player hook:** *You were at a bride-peace feast when the ninth name was spoken. The Green Host rode – but you survived.*

**10.10.0.0.4 Key stakeholders:** Matron of Wells, Three-Isles King, Lady Beneath, Taboo-Witness.

## 10.11 Thepyrgos — “City of a Thousand Stairs”

**Genre:** Byzantine / academic / arcane mystery.

**10.11.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic:** The Synod licenses magic; unorthodox casting is not illegal – merely unfashionable. Witch-hunters conscript talent.

**10.11.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs:** Academic robes, bell-badges, stair-passes. Every stair climbed is a word in a conversation.

**10.11.0.0.3 Player hook:** *You tested as “gifted” on the candle-smoke test. The university wants you; the Chain-Lanterns want you in chains.*

**10.11.0.0.4 Key stakeholders:** The Archon, Lighthouse-Patriarch, Nomophylax, Palkar Captain.

## 10.12 Ubral — “The Stone Between Spears”

**Genre:** Highland clan / reiver / honour culture.

**10.12.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic:** Clan shamans are respected; outsider mages are watched. Stone-speakers (dwarf-trained) are tolerated.

**10.12.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs:** Tweed, iron brooches, guest-tokens. Never refuse a cup from a hearth-aunt – hospitality is a contract.

**10.12.0.0.3 Player hook:** *You carry a wergild debt that your father couldn’t pay. The feud is now yours.*

**10.12.0.0.4 Key stakeholders:** Lady of Tor, Council of Cairns, Feud-Broker, Wergild Counter.

## 10.13 Valewood — “Empire Under Leaves”

**Genre:** Fairy tale / dark forest / fey remnant.

**10.13.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic:** Imperial echoes and fae rites are dangerous. Never eat fruit from a tree with a face.

**10.13.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs:** Leather, moss-dyed cloaks, way-cords. Speak in riddles or not at all.

**10.13.0.0.3 Player hook:** *A star-road opened in your dream. You walked it – now something walks behind you.*

**10.13.0.0.4 Key stakeholders:** Hazel Queen, Alder King, The Huntsman, Pathweaver.

## 10.14 Vhasia — “The Fractured Sun”

**Genre:** Courtly romance / chivalric / fractured kingdom.

**10.14.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic:** The Church of the Flame distrusts arcane magic; secular lords employ court mages anyway. Chevauchée raiders use cantors for morale.

**10.14.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs:** Velvet, partisan ribbons, duelling scars. Never carry a coin with only one sunburst – treason.

**10.14.0.0.3 Player hook:** *You’re the Last Dauphin – or a convincing fake. Either way, armies march for your claim.*

**10.14.0.0.4 Key stakeholders:** Two Crowns, Queen-Mother, Last Dauphin, Marshal-Exile.

## 10.15 Viterra — “The Hedge-Law Realm”

**Genre:** Legal drama / low fantasy / frontier justice.

**10.15.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic:** Hedge-magic is common and unregulated; any thaumaturgy that leaves a trace must be registered. Legal duels may involve wizards.

**10.15.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs:** Wool, seal rings, boundary stones. Every hedge is a precedent; every dike a court ruling.

**10.15.0.0.3 Player hook:** *Your family lost the border dispute. You have one year to find a lost charter or lose the land forever.*

**10.15.0.0.4 Key stakeholders:** Warrior Queen, Queen’s Justiciar, Fen Reeve, Master Advocate Halric.

## 10.16 Ykrul (Orcs) — “Wolf Standards, Winter Camps”

**Genre:** Steppe nomad / saga / honour culture.

**10.16.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic:** Geometry of oaths (Kon’reh) and sky-speakers. Written magic is suspicious; sung magic is respected.

**10.16.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs:** Leather, horse-hair braids, wolf-tooth standards. Never ride between two wolves at dusk.

**10.16.0.0.3 Player hook:** *You broke a hostage string. Now the Khatun demands a blood-price – or your youngest kin.*

**10.16.0.0.4 Key stakeholders:** Khatun of Ring, Khagan’s Kin, Sky-Speaker, Kon’reh Masters.

## 10.17 Zakov — “Salt & Serpent”

**Genre:** Pirate / noir / crime syndicate.

**10.17.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic:** Any magic is welcome – if it pays. Cursed cargoes are a common hazard; fae bargains are made at the Crimson Docks.

**10.17.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs:** Brine-stained coats, reef-tooth necklaces, smuggler’s tokens. Never take a coin that tastes of brine – the Serpent’s Mark is a debt.

**10.17.0.0.3 Player hook:** *You have a syndicate marker that could buy a fleet – or get you killed. The Salt Prince wants to collect.*

**10.17.0.0.4 Key stakeholders:** Salt Prince, Pirate Queen, Kraken’s Tongue, Syndicate Silent.

## 10.18 Other Regions (Brief)

For completeness, these areas appear in the full setting but are less central to the core game. Ask your GM if your character may hail from one of them.

- **Dungeon** – “Living Infrastructure” – Mythic underworld, survival horror.
- **The Ways Between** – “Spiritways & Veilways” – Liminal paths, dream-logic.
- **The Wilds** – “Roads, Ruins, and Weather” – A reskin palette for any terrain.
- **Vilikari** – “Laurels & Longhouses” – Federated frontier, two laws.

# Chapter 11

## World Regions and Cultures

The world of *Fate's Edge* is a tapestry of ancient empires, emerging kingdoms, and untamed wilderness. This chapter surveys major regions and cultures that shape the setting—from the marble cities of Ecktoria to the mist-shrouded fields of Aelinnel. Use this as a reference for character backgrounds, cultural customs, and the feel of the lands you will explore.

### 11.1 The Amaranthine Inland Sea

At the heart of the known world lies the **Amaranthine Inland Sea**, a wind-gnarled waterway ringed by marble quays, vineyard hills, and smoke-blue mountains. For millennia it has served as the circulatory system of trade, faith, and conquest. Tides are subtle, but seasonal winds and river-feeds set the rhythm of commerce, pilgrimage, and war.

### 11.2 Northern Shore of the Amaranthine Sea

#### Ecktoria — The Uтарan Imperium Successor

Once the furnace of empire (*Marble & Fire*), Ecktoria remains a palimpsest of power: old stones bearing new banners, old laws written under fresh seals. Though imperial reach waned, its civic habits endure — an echo of late Roman/Byzantine grandeur, with provincial governors, standing bureaucracies, and ever-present legal codes.

**Marble Cities** Forums, amphitheaters, and aqueducts yet flow. District fountains double as public oaths guaranteed by guild charters.

**Imperial Roads** Mile-markers of white granite, way-shrines and customary tolls noted for couriers of the *Ashen Staves*.

**Legal Legacy** The **Uтарan Civic Codes** govern contracts, inheritance, and war-rights; local custom bends them under licensed *variance*.

**Architectural Wonders** Sun-bridges spanning deltas, the **Vault of a Thousand Maps**, and the **Amber Arch** petrified by alchemical storm.

#### Acasia — "The Broken Province"

Fallen Province. Frontiers braided from roads, rivers, and resentments — a land of petty kingdoms and free companies, reminiscent of the Welsh Marches or the post-Roman frontier. Here the outer seams of empire frayed first. Fortresses turned manors, manors turned townholds, and banners

multiplied like thistles after rain.

**Petty Kingdoms** Dozens of river-vales ruled by river-kings and banner-queens. Alliances shift with marriages, harvests, and omens.

**Fortified Towns** Walls for defense, not display. Gate-streets kink for ambush; towers carry horn-codes every child knows.

**Mercenary Culture** Free companies keep a *Black Ledger*: contracts fulfilled, oaths kept, debts paid.

**Cultural Mix** Imperial rites meet clan feasts; old gods share niches with civic saints. Exiles and second chances (*see* Silkstrand tales) are common.

## Vhasia — "Old Vhasia & The Bloodlands"

Politically fractured kingdom of courtly intrigue and martial tradition, where ancient bloodlines vie for supremacy amid shifting alliances and ceremonial warfare. Travelers from across the Amaranthine often note its chivalric pageantry, its elaborate dueling codes, and its love of rhetoric.

**Fortress Castles** Stone keeps crowned with gilded spires; courtiers plot in tapestried halls while knights train in courtyards.

**Political Intrigue** Complex web of alliances, vendettas, and ceremonial duels that settle matters of honor and succession.

**Court Culture** Elaborate ceremonies, patronage of arts, and rigid social hierarchies maintained through ritual and reputation.

**Heraldic Traditions** Complex system of banners, titles, and precedence that govern social interactions and military commands.

## Thepyrgos

Province and capital city renowned as a center of learning, magic, and scholarly pursuit, where ancient towers house both wisdom and dangerous secrets. A blend of Byzantine bureaucracy and Mediterranean university culture — the City of a Thousand Stairs.

**Scholarly Traditions** Tower-cities where mages, philosophers, and researchers pursue knowledge in specialized colleges and scriptoriums.

**Arcane Heritage** Deep traditions of magical study, with libraries containing texts predating the fall of ancient empires.

**Academic Rivalries** Intense competition between schools of thought, often manifesting in formal debates, magical duels, or scholarly contests.

**Mystical Dangers** Forbidden knowledge and experimental magic that sometimes escape control, creating ongoing threats.

## Viterra — "The Last Kingdom"

Realm that straddles the Dolmis and Amaranthine seas, known for its legalistic approach to governance and strategic river crossings. Its common law — the *Hedge-Law* — and its tradition of legal precedent evoke the courts of a certain misty island kingdom.

**Hedge-Law Culture** Complex system of legal precedents, tolls, and river rights that govern everything from trade to personal conduct.

**Duchy System** Semi-autonomous regions governed by dukes who maintain their own courts and armies while owing fealty to the crown.



**River Commerce** Economy built around controlling strategic crossings, ferry rights, and maritime trade routes.

**Legalistic Politics** Intrigue centered on court cases, charter disputes, and the interpretation of ancient laws rather than open warfare.

## Ubral — "The Stone Between Spears"

Highland realm of rugged clans and fortified holds, where honor culture and martial traditions dominate social interactions — a landscape of braes and glens, of cairns and clan feuds.

**Clan Strongholds** Fortified positions in mountain passes and high valleys, each clan maintaining its own laws and customs.

**Honor Culture** Society built around concepts of personal honor, family reputation, and the resolution of disputes through formal challenges.

**Highland Warfare** Military traditions emphasizing heavy infantry, defensive positions, and knowledge of mountain terrain.

**Clan Loyalties** Complex web of alliances, blood-feuds, and marriage pacts that shift with each generation.

## Kahfagia — "The Empire of Wakes and Storm-Flags"

Maritime empire built on naval supremacy and exploration, where ship captains and merchant-adventurers shape both policy and culture — a Venetian–Portuguese hybrid, with lantern-law and pilot guilds ruling the waves.

**Naval Supremacy** Military and economic power based on controlling sea lanes, harbors, and maritime trade routes.

**Explorer Culture** Tradition of venturing into unknown waters, mapping new territories, and establishing trading posts.

**Storm-Flag Protocol** Complex system of maritime signals, weather prediction, and naval customs that govern seaborne activities.

**Mixed Heritage** Cosmopolitan society influenced by contacts with distant lands and diverse cultures encountered through exploration.

## Theona — "The Marsh Crown"

Three island realms connected by causeways and maritime traditions, where wetland resources and naval culture define daily life. The grey skies, peat bogs, and ringforts of Theona echo the landscapes of ancient Éire — a land of high kings, saints, and folk horrors lurking beneath the mist.

**Marsh Agriculture** Sophisticated systems of dikes, canals, and floating gardens that support dense populations in wetland environments.

**Island Culture** Distinct traditions for each island, unified by shared maritime customs and inter-island trade.

**Waterborne Commerce** Economy based on fishing, water transport, and control of strategic waterways between islands.

**Folk Horror Traditions** Deep connection to marsh spirits, water deities, and ancient practices that blur the line between protection and appeasement.

## The Mistlands — "Fields Under a Moving Sky"

Isolated region shrouded in perpetual mists, where ancient Aelerian protectorate status creates tension between autonomy and oversight. The Mistlands draw from Celtic and Breton folklore — a land of bells, standing stones, and the ever-present threat of what walks in the fog.

**Mistbound Geography** Landscape of bogs, waterways, and hidden settlements connected by causeways and boat paths.

**Bell Culture** Complex system of bells and wards must be maintained to keep the Direwood horrors at bay.

**Isolation Tensions** Cultural friction between desire for independence and practical need for trade and protection.

**Ancient Secrets** Ruins and artifacts predating the Aelerian protectorate, hinting at older civilizations and forgotten magics.

## 11.3 Peoples and Cultures

The peoples of Fate's Edge are many. Some trace their lineage to the earliest days of the Utaran Imperium; others arrived across the sea or emerged from the mist-hung valleys of the Direwood. What follows are the major cultural groupings — self-named and deeply particular. Outsiders may use simpler labels; the wise learn the names that people call themselves.

### 11.3.1 Small Folk of the Threshold

The Aelaerem (halflings) and Aelinnel (gnomes) are diminutive peoples attuned to liminal spaces—doorways, hedge-gaps, tide-cut stairs, and the quiet places between hearth and hollow.

- **Restriction:** Cannot use Heavy Armor. May use any one-handed or two-handed weapon, but Heavy Weapons impose **−1 Position** on all actions while wielding them (before any other Position modifiers).
- **Bonus:** When wielding a **spear, quarterstaff, or light polearm** (any Medium or Light weapon with the **Reach** tag), treat the weapon as **one weight class lighter** for the purpose of attack modifiers. Additionally, once per scene when you make a melee attack with such a weapon, you may spend **1 Boon** to convert a *Partial* success into a *Clean Success* (representing a clever thrust that uses the enemy's momentum against them).

#### Aelaerem — The Hearth's Luck

**Bonus — Once per scene**, you may improve your **Position by one step** (e.g., Desperate → Controlled, Controlled → Dominant) as a free action **before** rolling an action. This represents a flash of luck, a well-timed sidestep, or an unexpected opening.

#### From the Hearth Ledger

*"The Aelaerem say that a door left unlatched is an invitation to the Hollow. But sometimes, an unlatched door is just an escape."* Use your luck wisely. The Hollow is patient.

#### Aelinnel — The Bright Trick

Choose **one** of the following abilities to represent their tricky nature.

##### Option A: Short Step (Teleport)

**Bonus — Once per scene**, as a **Move action**, you may instantly teleport to any location

you can see within **Near** range that is not currently observed by any enemy. You cannot pass through solid barriers. This is a fey-like blink, not a physical jump.

### Option B: Knack for the Right Thing (Handy Item)

**Bonus — Once per scene**, you may declare that you have a **small, mundane item** on your person that is useful in the current situation (e.g., a coil of rope, a lockpick, a candle, a chalk stick). This costs no Boon and requires no roll. The item must be plausible for your character to carry. (This is a free, once-per-scene version of the **Flashback Declaration** mechanic described in 2.17.)

#### A Gnomish Maxim

*“Count the steps in odd numbers. Even is for the dead. . . . Wait, did I say odd? Let me check my abacus.”* Aelinnel never trust a single ledger. Neither should you.

Both peoples are often underestimated—a mistake that has left many a larger foe stumbling through a door that was never really shut.

## The Lethai — The Sundered Kin

The Lethai are the eldest of the mortal lineages, their memory stretching back before the fall of empires now forgotten. An ancient constraint divides them: no Lethai may bear both the Gift of the Body and the Gift of the Mind. From this sundering grew three distinct peoples, each with its own philosophy, homeland, and customs.

### Lethai-al — “People of the Body” (Wood Elves)

The Lethai-al dwell in the **\*\*Valewood\*\***, that ancient forest where roof-trees braid the sky and rivers think aloud. Their memory is arboreal — rings, seasons, coppice ledgers — and their oaths are *root-law*: debts counted in years, paid in living work. To outsiders they seem quiet; to neighbors they are relentless auditors of footprint and flow.

**Forest Harmony** Lifestyle integrated with woodland ecosystems, practicing sustainable hunting, gathering, and cultivation. They do not “use” the forest; they live within its clauses.

**Body-Centric Philosophy** Emphasis on physical experience, instinct, and the wisdom of sinew and breath over abstract thought. A Lethai-al proverb: *“The hand that fells the tree must plant the sapling.”*

**Living Magic** Spellcasting works *with* natural forces, not against them — plant-speech, animal kinship, and the slow shaping of living wood.

**Seasonal Rituals** A calendar of ceremonies marking planting, harvest, and the winter quiet. Outsiders are welcome at the Autumn Trade Moot, but the Spring Rites are veiled.

**Homeland** The **\*\*Valewood\*\*** itself — no single capital, but shifting grove-courts and deep hollows where the oldest trees remember empire.

### Lethai-thora — “People of the Mind” (High Elves)

The Lethai-thora make their homes in cities — chiefly **\*\*Thepyrgos\*\***, the City of a Thousand Stairs — where they weigh arguments like bridges and translate other peoples’ law into forms that carry. Their courts count consequences; their speech is context-saturated and exact.

**Scholarly Excellence** Deep traditions of academic study, magical research, and philosophical debate. The Great Library of Thepyrgos holds texts that predate the Sundering.

**Mind-Centric Philosophy** Reason, logic, and the pursuit of abstract knowledge over physical

concerns. A Lethai-thora axiom: *“A clean proof is worth a thousand swords.”*

**Arcane Mastery** Advanced magical techniques and theoretical understanding that often surpass other traditions. Many of the Free Casters’ foundational texts were penned by Lethai-thora hands.

**Long Perspective** Tendency to view problems and conflicts through the lens of centuries rather than immediate gain. This patience can be wisdom — or paralysis.

**Homeland** *\*\*Thepyrgos\*\** and its satellite academies, with enclaves in other major cities where scribal work and jurisprudence are valued.

### Lethai-ar — “The Oathbound” (Dark Elves)

The Lethai-ar are not a separate bloodline but a vow-bound cadre. They are Lethai-al or Lethai-thora who step off those paths to live under threshold patrons — *\*\*Inaea\*\** the Weaver and *\*\*Isoka\*\** the Serpent. In some ages they are scarce; in others — like the present — they gather wherever borders fray and oaths need teeth. They are known for *mask-right*, precise courtesies, and the unsettling efficiency of vows that bind places, routes, and roles.

**Serpent Wisdom** Followers of Isoka emphasize transformation, renewal, and the shedding of old identities for new growth. A shedding can be a cure, an escape, or a cruelty — context is all.

**Spider Webs** Devotees of Inaea focus on connections, patterns, and the weaving of fate through careful manipulation. Mercy with memory; knots that mend before they bind.

**Philosophical Balance** Neither inherently good nor evil, but representing alternative approaches to power and influence. A Lethai-ar may be a healer or a poisoner, a mediator or a cut-throat — the method, not the morality, defines them.

**Cultural Rarity** Uncommon in most settings, often viewed with suspicion or fascination. Their masks and vows unsettle those who prefer straightforward dealings.

**Homeland** No fixed homeland. They gather in *\*\*mask-circles\*\** within other Lethai communities or in hidden enclaves near ancient thresholds.

### The Aeler — People of Stone, Breath, and Ledger (Dwarves)

The Aeler are the mountain-born, built like their peaks — layered, load-bearing, enduring. They call their home *\*\*The Mountains\*\**, *\*\*Undermount\*\**, or *\*\*The Stonelands\*\**; outsiders often say “Aelerian range,” but that is a cartographer’s convenience, not a name the Aeler use for themselves.

**Stone-Sense** Innate ability to understand and work with geological formations, making them master miners, architects, and engineers. An Aeler can read a tunnel’s stress like a human reads a face.

**Clan System** Complex social structure based on family lines, with intricate systems of honor, debt, and mutual obligation. Every clan keeps a *\*\*Keystone Ledger\*\** — a record of favors owed and paid.

**Craft Traditions** Legendary skills in metalworking, stonework, and engineering refined over generations. Aeler steel is sought across the Amaranthine; Aeler bridges are the last to fall in a siege.

**Underground Cities** Vast complexes carved from mountain hearts, connected by tunnels and halls that serve both practical and ceremonial purposes. The city of *\*\*Khaz-Vurim\*\** is the oldest and greatest.

**Deep Law** Contracts are carved, not inked. A broken oath can be read in the stone for centuries. Justice is a matter of measurement — a tilted beam, a mis-weighted coin.

## The Aelinnel — People of Sums, Bough, and Bright Things (Gnomes)

The Aelinnel dwell in **\*\*Aevrossa\*\***, the hawthorn hills south of the Valewood — a land of living wood, worked stone, and air that tastes of mathematics. Their lives intertwine with **courtesy, copper, and count**. In addition to the Small Folk traits described above, they have the following cultural features.

**Mathematical Culture** Society built around complex calculations, probability, and the belief that all phenomena can be understood through numerical relationships. A bridge’s strength, a market’s price, a court’s verdict — all are sums.

**Fey Logic** Non-linear thinking patterns that seem illogical to outsiders but follow their own internal consistency. *“If you speak the ninth name, you must also speak the silence that follows it.”*

**Mist Adaptation** Unique abilities to navigate and manipulate the perpetual mists of Aevrossa. They read fog like a ledger, finding paths where others see only white.

**Contract Culture** Deep tradition of precise agreements, wordplay, and the careful crafting of obligations. Every bargain has two ledgers: what was *said* and what was *meant*.

**Homeland** **\*\*Aevrossa\*\*** — a realm of stone circles, antler-posts, and tide-cut stairs. Its capital is the **\*\*Hall of Aelinnel\*\***, a timber keep threaded between standing stones.

## The Aelaerem — People of the Hearth (Halflings)

The Aelaerem are a people of movement and assembly, living among gentle slopes and hedged lanes. Their homeland’s true name is **\*\*hushed\*\*** — they refer to it only with euphemisms, for to speak its old name is to invite the attention of the Neighbors. Outsiders may call it “the Halfling Downs” or “the Southern Valleys”; the Aelaerem smile and say nothing. In addition to the Small Folk traits described above, they have the following cultural features.

### Euphemisms for the Homeland

The Aelaerem use many pseudonyms, each a quiet oxymoron that hides a darker truth:

| Common Name                     | Hidden Meaning                                                                                 | Old Tongue                                                                                                |
|---------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The Silent Welcome              | “Welcome” = hospitality; “Silent” = calm, a gentle invitation. Sounds like a village festival. | <i>Rath-Gor</i> (“the binding mouth”) — the ancient seal where the Neighbors are held.                    |
| The Merry Maw                   | “Merry” = good cheer, feasting; “Maw” = a large gaping mouth. Sounds like a tavern name.       | <i>Gor-Elen</i> (“the sealed mouth”) — the cursed cavern where eldritch doors are locked.                 |
| Stillwater (or The Still-Water) | “Still” = peace; “water” = life, farming. A common halfling landmark.                          | <i>Nok-Lur</i> (“the black source”) — an underground well that is actually a conduit to the other world.  |
| The Quiet Hearth                | “Hearth” = home, warmth; “Quiet” = serene, safe.                                               | <i>Ael-Gren</i> (“the sealed fire”) — the ancient stone ring that locks the Neighbors away.               |
| The Gentle Fold                 | “Fold” = a shepherd’s safe enclosure; “Gentle” = pastoral.                                     | <i>Thar-Gur</i> (“the gnashing cleft”) — the fissure in the earth that serves as the “mouth” of the seal. |

The Aelaerem themselves are warm, generous, and fiercely protective of their own — but their land hides a hunger. Hospitality is their public law; beneath it runs an older hedge-law of cup-marks, red thread, and the quiet attention of the Neighbors.

**Hearth Culture** Deep connection to home, family, and the maintenance of traditional ways. A red door promises bread, salt, and one safe night if you come honest.

**Agricultural Expertise** Sophisticated farming techniques and seasonal celebrations that mark the rhythm of rural life. Their cider, wool, and beeswax are known across the Amaranthine.

**Folk Horror Elements** Dark undercurrents in seemingly peaceful communities, where hospitality can become a trap and tradition carries hidden costs. The Neighbors are always watching.

**Community Defense** Strong traditions of mutual aid and collective action when the community is threatened. When the bells ring, every Aelaerem takes up a tool or a weapon.

## The Ykrul — The People of the Violet Steppe (Orcs)

### Note on Naming

**“Orc” is a slur.** The Ykrul are a proud people of the steppe; the word “orc” was coined by Utaran legions to dehumanize them. Wise travellers use *Ykrul* or *Steppe Folk*. Using “orc” in conversation with a Ykrul may be taken as a grave insult.

Nomadic clans of horse-riders and raiders. The Ykrul live by omen, pasture, and blood-tanistry. Their sacred geometry is the *Kon’reh* — a living calculus of routes, exits, and blood-price.

**Seasonal Migrations** Each clan follows ancient pastures, moving with the herds. Winter camps are ringed by felt tents facing the wind.

**Shamans and Sky-Speakers** Weather-readers who call storms and interpret omens. They speak

for the ancestors.

**Blood-Tanistry** Leadership passes to the strongest or wisest, not merely the firstborn. Feuds are settled by wergild (blood-price) in cattle or horses.

**Kon'reh Masters** Geometry arbiters who teach the sacred numbers of the steppe — every crossing has a number, every ford a weight.

## Other Peoples — “Beyond the Old Roads”

The lands beyond the Amaranthine and the Aelerian passes hold many other folk. Some are recent arrivals; others are ancient survivors of forgotten cataclysms.

**Nomadic Tribes** Various peoples who follow seasonal patterns across steppes, deserts, and other marginal lands. The **Ykrul** are the most numerous, but they are far from alone.

**Coastal Peoples** Maritime cultures that live in harmony with ocean environments and maintain their own naval traditions. The **Linn** and **Zakov** corsairs, the **Kahfagian** pilots, and the island clans of the **Dolmis**.

**Border Cultures** Mixed communities that arise where different major cultures meet, creating unique hybrid traditions. The **Vilikari** straddle empire and steppe; the **Acasian** marches brew their own fierce independence.

**Ancient Survivors** Remnants of older civilizations that persist in isolated regions, maintaining forgotten knowledge and customs. The **Mistlands** bell-wardens, the **Theonan** marsh-kings, and the silent watchers of the **Direwood**.

## 11.4 Regional Specialties and Resources

### Climate and Biomes of the Amaranthine

The Amaranthine Inland Sea is ringed by fertile coasts, rolling hills, and mountain ranges. Unlike the arid southern shores of Old Earth's middle sea, the wind patterns here reverse — the hot, dry air of the Sahel belt is pushed south, leaving the northern and eastern shores with ample rainfall and the southern shores as temperate grasslands. Thus, the lands around the Amaranthine are lush and productive, from the olive groves of Ecktoria to the wheat fields of Acasia to the horse pastures of the Vilikari steppe.

### Economic Strengths by Region

**Ecktoria** Marble, legal services, grain, olive oil, wine, purple dye (murex), glassworks, coinage.

**Acasia** Cattle, horses, wool, iron, salt, mercenary contracts, border tolls.

**Vhasia** Wine, timber, stone, cloth (linen and wool), illuminated manuscripts, tapestries.  
**Thepyrgos** Scholarly texts, magical reagents, glassware, precision instruments, silk (imported and finished), philosophical schools.

**Viterra** Tin, copper, wool, tin-glazed pottery, legal charters, insurance contracts, river tolls.

**Ubral** Lead, silver, slate, hardy mountain sheep (wool and cheese), whisky, mercenary mountaineers.

**Kahfagia** Shipbuilding, naval stores (pitch, tar, sailcloth), spices (imported), exotic woods, dyes (indigo, cochineal), potatoes, maize, tomatoes.

**Linn** Fish (dried and salted), whale oil, amber, walrus ivory, furs, raiding, ship-tolls.

**Theona** Citrus fruits, olive oil, pottery (amphorae), salt, peat, glass beads, star-compasses.

**Mistlands** Peat, bog iron, fog-pollen ink, mistglass (humming glass), woven fog-wool, herbal remedies (nightshade, feverfew, belladonna).

**Zakov** Ship salvage, black market goods, exotic poisons, reef coral, pearls, smuggled luxuries.

**Vilikari** Horses, leather goods, horn, bone, honey, wax, mercenary light cavalry.

**Ykrul** Horses (the finest), hides, wool felt, dairy products, dried meat, amber.

### Unique Products (Expanded)

- **Ecktoria:** *Purple marble, ceramic plumbing, state bonds.*
- **Acasia:** *Curse-iron, hedge-knight contracts.*
- **Vhasia:** *Illuminated bestiaries, vengeance wine.*
- **Thepyrgos:** *Echo glass, thousand-step tea.*
- **Viterra:** *Hedge-law scrolls, river silver.*
- **Ubral:** *Whisky of the Twelve Clans, slate that echoes.*
- **Kahfagia:** *Storm-flags, lantern-glass.*
- **Linn:** *Whale-bone runes, frost silk.*
- **Theona:** *Star-compasses, amphorae of silence.*
- **Mistlands:** *Fog-pollen ink, mistglass.*
- **Zakov:** *Black coral amulets, songs of the reef, pearl of forgetfulness.*
- **Vilikari:** *Horse-hide scrolls, blood-honey.*
- **Ykrul:** *Kon'reh boards, wake-ropes.*

## 11.5 Travel and Trade

### Major Routes

**Amaranthine Coastway** Sea-corridor linking Theona, Linn, Zakov, Kahfagia, and Ecktoria.

**Astroegro Straits** The narrows between Thepyrgos and the northern shore.

**River Roads** The Belworth, the Yloka, and the Acadian rivers.

**Aelerian Passes Underways** Vault-routes beneath the peaks.

**Kahfagian Sea Lanes** Goods from across the “west lands”.

**The Way of Silk** Overland routes from the far east, ending in Silkstrand.

**Shadow Corridors** Liminal shortcuts near the Ways Between.

### Travel Considerations

- **Road Quality:** Utaran imperial highways still exist in Ecktoria and parts of Vhasia. Further east, they become gravel, cart-ruts, or mere tracks. In the Mistlands, the “road” is a causeway of reeds and stone that floods at each tide.
- **Bridges & Ferries:** Every crossing is a toll point. Some bridges are magical — they only open to certain keys or at certain hours.
- **Seasonality:** The Amaranthine is navigable year-round, but winter storms can close the straits. Mountain passes close from First Snow to Spring Thaw. The steppe is impassable during the spring melt (rasputitsa).
- **Safe Havens:** Caravanserais are common along the Way of Silk. In the north, monasteries offer shelter.
- **Customs and Quarantines:** Entering a new region often requires papers — a safe-conduct, a merchant seal, or a ritual cleansing.



## 11.6 Cultural Practices and Customs

### Languages and Cant

- **Utaran High** (court, law, scholarship)
- **River Cant** (trade pidgin with gesture-signs)
- **Steppe Tongues** (whistled across distance)
- **Sea-Patter** (mariners' clipped code)
- **Bell-Speech** (Mistlands only)
- **Hedge-Law Notation** (Viterra and parts of Vhasia)

### Religious Patterns

- **Temple & School** (Theona): Ethical schools blend with temple tithes; festivals mark navigation seasons.
- **Ancestor Poles** (Vilikari): Kin-spirits seated at feasts; oaths taken under the watch of names.
- **Sky & Earth** (Steppe): Wind-knots bound, libations poured into the first hoofprint.
- **Sea-Rites** (Linn/Zakov): Weather judgments witnessed by storm-priests.
- **The Everflame** (Ecktoria, Thepyrgos, parts of Vhasia): Cults of the Eternal Fire.
- **Fog Faiths** (Mistlands): Bells and fog-names soothe fears; spiritualists mediate with the grey things.

### Law and Custom

- **Utaran Codes**: Contracts, inheritance, civic duties.
- **Clan Law** (Acasia, Vilikari, Ubral, Ykrul): Oath-payment by cattle, steel, or service-days.
- **Merchant Law**: Arbitration by bonded factors; ledgers sealed in wax and salt.
- **Hedge-Law** (Viterra, parts of Vhasia): Precedents set by parish juries and traveling justices.
- **Lamp-Law** (Mistlands, Kahfagian lantern precincts): Rules enforced by the lighting or extinguishing of public lamps.

## 11.7 Magic and Attitude by Region

- **Ecktoria**: Licensed thaumaturges file *Casting Notices* for urban work. Magic is seen as a civic utility.
- **Acasia**: Folk-wards respected; visible sorcery can start a levy. Hedge witches are tolerated.
- **Aeler**: Rituals fold into craft; backlash treated like a cracked beam — fix it, document it, pay the guild fine.
- **Mistlands**: Bells and fog-names soothe fears; spiritualists mediate with the grey things.
- **Linn / Zakov**: Weather rites must be witnessed by three wind-bearers; false rites are crimes against the ship.
- **Thepyrgos**: Academics argue about proper magical forms. Unorthodox casting is not illegal — merely unfashionable.
- **Vhasia**: The Church of the Flame distrusts arcane magic; secular lords employ court mages anyway.
- **Viterra**: Hedge-magic is common and unregulated; any thaumaturgy that leaves a trace must be registered.
- **Kahfagia**: The Lantern-Law tolerates magic that assists navigation or commerce. Weather magic is licensed.
- **Ubral**: Mountain clans view magic as a weapon, not a tool. Outsider mages are watched; clan

shamans are respected.

- **Vilikari:** Mixed attitudes — some clans employ shamans; others see magic as dishonorable.
- **Ykrul:** The Kon'reh masters treat magic as geometry; precise, bounded, and ethically neutral.

## 11.8 Aeler — People of Stone, Breath, and Ledger (Dwarves)

*“The mountain does not forget a misplaced keystone. It waits – then settles the debt.”*

### Aeler at a Glance

**Attribute Adjustments:** Body +1, Spirit +1, Presence –1

**Skill Bonuses:** Craft +1, Endurance +1, Mechanics +1

**Signature Talents:** *Spirit Shield* • *Keystone Ledger*

**Strings:** Charter-Stamped, Stone-Speech Initiate

**11.8.0.0.1 Attribute Adjustments:** +1 Body, +1 Spirit, –1 Presence (insular, blunt).

**11.8.0.0.2 Skill Bonuses:** +1 to Craft, +1 to Endurance, +1 to Mechanics.

### 11.8.0.0.3 Cultural Talents Minor (2–3 XP)

- **Stone-Sense (2 XP):** Passive. +1 die to detect flaws in stone, hidden passages, or structural weaknesses underground.
- **Breath-Counter (2 XP):** Active, once per scene. When in a sealed space, reduce Fatigue from lack of air by 1 level.
- **Oath-Cord (3 XP):** Active, once per session. Tie a cord to bind a simple promise; breaking it costs the violator 1 SB (Hearts).

### Major (4–6 XP)

- **Spirit Shield (6 XP):** Passive. When you Defend, you may convert the first Harm 1 you would take into Fatigue (minimum 1 Fatigue). *Requires: Spirit 3+.*
- **Keystone Ledger (4 XP):** Passive. You may keep a written record of one Debt Clock (see Terrestrial Patrons, §8.15) without expending an action to recall it.

### Prestige (7–10 XP)

- **Forge-Patriarch (10 XP):** Active, once per campaign. Establish a **forge-citadel** (Major Asset) and gain a loyal cadre of smiths and engineers (Cap3 followers). This requires a season of downtime and significant resources.

**11.8.0.0.4 Strings (Narrative Permissions):** *Charter-Stamped, Stone-Speech Initiate, Vault-Right.*

### 11.8.0.0.5 Sample Bonds:

- “I owe my life to the Vault-Queen’s wardens.”
- “My clan’s keystone is lost – I must find it before the mountain settles.”

### 11.8.0.0.6 Sample Complications:

- A sealed hold refuses you entry.
- A rival clan claims your keystone.
- A White Flood drowns your route.

## 11.9 Aelinnel — People of Sums, Bough, and Bright Things (Gnomes)

*“Count the steps in odd numbers. Even is for the dead.”*

### Aelinnel at a Glance

**Attribute Adjustments:** Wits +1, Spirit +1, Body −1

**Skill Bonuses:** Investigation +1, Lore +1, Mechanics +1

**Signature Talents:** *Oath-Carver* • *Green Gate Key*

**Strings:** Hall-Stamped, Tide-Path Known

**11.9.0.0.1 Attribute Adjustments:** +1 Wits, +1 Spirit, −1 Body (small stature, less raw force).

**11.9.0.0.2 Skill Bonuses:** +1 to Investigation, +1 to Lore, +1 to Mechanics.

**11.9.0.0.3 Cultural Talents** *Note: The Short Step and Knack for the Right Thing abilities are part of the Small Folk racial package (see 11.3.1), not purchased talents. The following are additional cultural talents.*

### Minor (2–3 XP)

- **Counting Etiquette (2 XP):** Passive. Once per scene, when you carefully count (steps, breaths, beads), you may shift Position +1 for a single action requiring rhythm or precision.
- **Copper over Iron (2 XP):** Passive. When you visibly favour copper or brass tools over iron in fae-facing scenes, you gain +1 die on Courtesy or Bargain rolls.

### Major (4–6 XP)

- **Oath-Carver (4 XP):** Active. Set a promise in quartz (a visible physical token). The target gains +1 die to keep the promise; breaking it costs 1 SB (Spades). You may maintain one quartz oath at a time.

### Prestige (7–10 XP)

- **Green Gate Key (8 XP):** Passive. Once per journey, you may declare a hidden tide-path or stone-door that halves a travel leg (reduce Travel Clock by half its segments). The GM gains 1 SB as the path demands a small toll (a memory, a name).

**11.9.0.0.4 Strings (Narrative Permissions):** *Hall-Stamped, Tide-Path Known, Bell-Mound Friend.*

### 11.9.0.0.5 Sample Bonds:

- “A Thorn Courtier saved me from a geas – now I owe them a favour.”
- “My grandmother taught me the ninth silence.”

**11.9.0.0.6 Sample Complications:**

- A geas catches you in a careless word.
- The Green Gate opens at the wrong hour.
- A Thorn Court summons you.

## 11.10 Aelaerem — People of Hearth & Hollow (Halflings)

*“A door left unlatched is an invitation to the Hollow. But sometimes, an unlatched door is just an escape.”*

### Aelaerem at a Glance

**Attribute Adjustments:** Wits +1, Presence +1, Body –1

**Skill Bonuses:** Survival +1, Sway +1, Stealth +1

**Signature Talents:** *Barrow-Wise* • *Pale Shepherd’s Grace*

**Strings:** Red-Thread Guest, Barrow-Friend

**11.10.0.0.1 Attribute Adjustments:** +1 Wits, +1 Presence, –1 Body (small and quick, not strong).

**11.10.0.0.2 Skill Bonuses:** +1 to Survival, +1 to Sway, +1 to Stealth.

**11.10.0.0.3 Cultural Talents** *Note: The Hearth’s Luck ability is part of the Small Folk racial package (see 11.3.1), not a purchased talent. The following are additional cultural talents.*

### Minor (2–3 XP)

- **Red Thread (2 XP):** Active, once per session. Tie a red thread on a door or bridge; the next person who crosses must pass a Resolve test (DV2) or forget why they entered.
- **Cup-Mark (3 XP):** Active. Leave a cup-mark on a stone; when you return before dawn, you may ignore one minor social complication (e.g., a suspicious guard).

### Major (4–6 XP)

- **Barrow-Wise (4 XP):** Passive. +1 die to Lore about the Neighbors, the Hollow, or ancient barrows. Once per session, you may ask the GM one yes/no question about a supernatural threat in the current scene.
- **Mummers’ Mask (6 XP):** Active, once per scene. Don a mask and adopt a role; for the next exchange, you may use *Presence + Performance* in place of any social skill.

### Prestige (7–10 XP)

- **Pale Shepherd’s Grace (8 XP):** Passive. When you would take Harm, you may instead mark that amount as Fatigue. If you do, the GM gains 1 SB (Hearts) – the Hollow watches you. *Requires: Spirit 3+.*

**11.10.0.0.4 Strings (Narrative Permissions):** *Red-Thread Guest, Barrow-Friend, Moot-Right.*

### 11.10.0.0.5 Sample Bonds:

- “The Apple-Matron saved my family from famine – I owe her a harvest.”
- “The Pale Shepherd walked past me once. I still don’t know why.”

### 11.10.0.0.6 Sample Complications:

- You pour the ninth cup; the Hollow answers.
- A mummers' mask sticks to your face.

## 11.11 Lethai — Root, River, & Roof-Tree / Mind's Eye & Civic Measure (Elves)

*“Two paths, one blood – the Sundered Kin.”*

### 11.11.1 Lethai-al (Wood Elves)

#### Wood Elf at a Glance

**Attribute Adjustments:** Body +1, Wits +1, Presence –1

**Skill Bonuses:** Survival +1, Stealth +1, Nature +1

**Signature Talents:** *Root-Law* • *Green Ward*

**Strings:** Root-Oath Bound, Tree-Friend

**11.11.1.0.1 Attribute Adjustments:** +1 Body, +1 Wits, –1 Presence (reserved, not uncharismatic).

**11.11.1.0.2 Skill Bonuses:** +1 to Survival, +1 to Stealth, +1 to Nature.

#### 11.11.1.0.3 Cultural Talents Minor (2–3 XP)

- **Root-Law (2 XP):** Passive. +1 die to negotiate treaties or oaths that involve land, forest, or seasonal cycles.
- **Tree-Speak (3 XP):** Active, once per scene. Commune with a single tree or plant; gain +2 dice on Investigation or Survival to understand events that happened near it.

#### Major (4–6 XP)

- **Green Ward (4 XP):** Passive. When in forest terrain, you are always treated as having partial cover against ranged attacks.
- **Coppice Memory (6 XP):** Active, once per session. Perfectly recall a scent, sound, or footprint from up to a week ago. *Requires: Wits 3+.*

#### Prestige (7–10 XP)

- **Wild Speaker (10 XP):** Active, once per scene. Command a single animal or plant creature (Cap2) to perform a simple action (flee, attack, block). The GM may award 1 SB if the command contradicts the creature's nature.

**11.11.1.0.4 Strings (Narrative Permissions):** *Root-Oath Bound, Tree-Friend, Season-Marked.*

### 11.11.2 Lethai-thora (High Elves)

#### High Elf at a Glance

**Attribute Adjustments:** Wits +1, Spirit +1, Body –1

**Skill Bonuses:** Lore +1, Arcana +1, Investigation +1

**Signature Talents:** *Lorekeeper* • *Ways-Walker's Step*

**Strings:** Archive-Key, Debate-Sealed



**11.11.2.0.1 Attribute Adjustments:** +1 Wits, +1 Spirit, -1 Body (frail but sharp).

**11.11.2.0.2 Skill Bonuses:** +1 to Lore, +1 to Arcana, +1 to Investigation.

**11.11.2.0.3 Cultural Talents Minor (2–3 XP)**

- **Lorekeeper (2 XP):** Passive. +1 die to recall historical or magical information. Once per session, you may ask the GM a yes/no question about a forgotten fact.
- **Weave Anchor (3 XP):** Passive. Reduce magical Backlash from a single 1 by one step (Minor → none, Major → Minor) once per scene.

**Major (4–6 XP)**

- **Academic Immunity (4 XP):** Passive. When in a Thepyrgos library or university, you are treated as a *guest scholar* – guards will not arrest you without a writ from the Archon.
- **Mind Over Matter (6 XP):** Active, once per scene. Re-roll a failed Resolve or Lore test; you must accept the second roll.

**Prestige (7–10 XP)**

- **Ways-Walker’s Step (10 XP):** Passive. Once per arc, you may turn a complication from a ritual or magical research into a boon (e.g., a backlash reveals a secret path). The GM banks 2 SB.

**11.11.2.0.4 Strings (Narrative Permissions):** *Archive-Key, Debate-Sealed, Synod-Listed.*

**11.11.2.0.5 Sample Bonds (both):**

- “A Lethai-ar saved me from a wyrm – they demand a vow of silence in return.”
- “My family’s grove was poisoned; I carry an acorn from the mother tree.”

**11.11.2.0.6 Sample Complications (both):**

- You break a root-law.
- A Lethai-ar mask-circle demands your presence.
- A High Elf rival publishes a refutation of your thesis.

## 11.12 Lethai-ar — The Oathbound (Dark Elves)

*“Vows are blades. Wear them carefully.”*

### Dark Elf at a Glance

**Attribute Adjustments:** Wits +1, Presence +1, Spirit –1

**Skill Bonuses:** Subterfuge +1, Deception +1, Command +1

**Signature Talents:** *Serpent’s Shed* • *Spider’s Mercy*

**Strings:** Mask-Circle Known, Bound to a Threshold

**11.12.0.0.1 Attribute Adjustments:** +1 Wits, +1 Presence, –1 Spirit (obsession narrows the soul).

**11.12.0.0.2 Skill Bonuses:** +1 to Subterfuge, +1 to Deception, +1 to Command.

**11.12.0.0.3 Cultural Talents Minor (2–3 XP)**

- **Mask-Right (2 XP):** Passive. When you wear a mask (even a simple half-mask), you gain +1 die to resist social pressure or intimidation.
- **Vow-Touch (3 XP):** Active, once per scene. Touch a person and whisper a short geas (“Speak only truth”); if they fail a Resolve test (DV3), they suffer –1 die to resist that command for one exchange.

**Major (4–6 XP)**

- **Serpent’s Shed (4 XP):** Active, once per session. Mark 1 Fatigue to negate one ongoing Condition (Fear, Poison, Charm) – you “shed” it like a skin.
- **Spider’s Mercy (6 XP):** Active, once per scene. When you Defend and successfully protect an ally, you may transfer 1 Harm from that ally to yourself (converted to Fatigue if you have Light armor or less).

**Prestige (7–10 XP)**

- **Oath-Eater (8 XP):** Active, once per campaign. Consume a broken oath (yours or another’s) to regain 2 Boons and clear 2 Fatigue. The GM gains a permanent *Oath Debt* (1 SB per session) – a rival will collect.

**11.12.0.0.4 Strings (Narrative Permissions):** *Mask-Circle Known*, *Bound to a Threshold*, *Serpent-Touched*.

**11.12.0.0.5 Sample Bonds:**

- “I broke a vow to my sister – she hunts me, yet I would die for her.”
- “The Lady of Thorns holds my true name. I must earn it back.”

**11.12.0.0.6 Sample Complications:**

- A mask sticks – you cannot remove it until you fulfill a geas.

- A rival oathbound challenges you to a duel of vows.
- The Neighbors mistake you for one of them.

## 11.13 Ykrul — The People of the Violet Steppe (Orcs)

### Note on Naming

“**Orc**” is a slur. The Ykrul are a proud people of the steppe; the word “orc” was coined by Utaran legions to dehumanize them. Wise travellers use *Ykrul* or *Steppe Folk*. Using “orc” in conversation with a Ykrul may be taken as a grave insult.

*“The wind carries names. Ride straight, or you will be forgotten.”*

### Ykrul at a Glance

**Attribute Adjustments:** Body +1, Spirit +1, Presence –1

**Skill Bonuses:** Riding +1, Survival +1, Command +1

**Signature Talents:** *Blood Memory* • *Sky-Speaker’s Whistle*

**Strings:** Wind-Knot Token, Banner Hospitality

**11.13.0.0.1 Attribute Adjustments:** +1 Body, +1 Spirit, –1 Presence (blunt, not subtle).

**11.13.0.0.2 Skill Bonuses:** +1 to Riding, +1 to Survival, +1 to Command.

**11.13.0.0.3 Cultural Talents Minor (2–3 XP)**

- **Blood Frenzy (2 XP):** Reactive. When you take Harm, you may gain +1 die on your next melee attack. (Adrenaline surge.)
- **Hostage String (2 XP):** Active, once per session. Tie a cord to a willing ally; until the cord is cut, you may transfer 1 Fatigue from them to yourself as a free action.

**Major (4–6 XP)**

- **Blood Memory (4 XP):** Passive. After a battle, you may gain +1 die on a single roll that mimics a foe’s tactic (e.g., using a captured weapon). This lasts for the next scene.
- **Sky-Speaker’s Whistle (6 XP):** Active, once per scene. Imitate a steppe omen (eagle cry, thunder boom). Enemies within Near must pass a Resolve test (DV2) or lose their next minor action.

**Prestige (7–10 XP)**

- **Warglord (10 XP):** Active, once per campaign. Unite scattered warbands under a single banner. Gain a **War Host** (Major Asset) and a loyal cavalry unit (Cap5 followers). Start *Logistics* and *Grudge* clocks (see §??).

**11.13.0.0.4 Strings (Narrative Permissions):** *Wind-Knot Token*, *Banner Hospitality*, *Kurul-tai Voice*.

**11.13.0.0.5 Sample Bonds:**

- “The Khagan’s kin saved my life – I owe a foal each spring.”
- “My hostage string was cut; I must find the betrayer before the clan does.”

**11.13.0.0.6 Sample Complications:**

- A white squall separates you from the herd.
- A rival clan demands a blood-price.
- The Sky-Speaker claims you owe a storm.

## 11.14 Mixed Heritage — Half-Elves, Half-Ykrul, Half-Others

*“You walk two roads. Both watch you.”*

### Mixed Heritage at a Glance

**Choose one +1 and one –1 from parent cultures**

**Choose two skill bonuses**

**Access both talent lists** (subject to prerequisites)

**Choose primary String**

**11.14.0.0.1 Attribute Adjustments:** Choose **one** +1 from either parent culture, and **one** –1 from the other (or a standard +1, +1, –1 as determined with GM).

**11.14.0.0.2 Skill Bonuses:** Choose **two** skill bonuses from either parent culture (cannot take the same skill twice).

**11.14.0.0.3 Cultural Talents:** You may select from **both** parent cultures’ talent lists, but you must meet any prerequisites (e.g., Spirit3+ for some talents). You may not take mutually exclusive talents.

**11.14.0.0.4 String Access:** You have access to the **Strings** of both cultures, but you must choose one as your primary for purposes of social perception (e.g., a half-Aeler, half-Lethai might be *Charter-Stamped* but not *Root-Oath Bound* unless you prove yourself).

**11.14.0.0.5 Sample Bonds:**

- “My father’s clan disowned me; my mother’s people took me in – I carry both names.”
- “I am the living treaty between two feuding houses.”

**11.14.0.0.6 Sample Complications:**

- Neither culture fully trusts you.
- You are called to honour two conflicting oaths.
- A purist from one side challenges your right to claim their traditions.

# Chapter 12

## World Powers and Obligation

### 12.1 Of Patrons, Runes, and Invokers

“You wish to walk the road of power? Then listen well. The world is old, and older still are the voices beneath it. We call them *Patrons*, though they were never sworn to us. They are the tides that move unseen, the keepers of forgotten bargains, the sleepers beneath the stone and the stars. To call upon them is to dip a hand into a river that has carved mountains.”

#### 12.1.1 The Patrons

Patrons are vast intelligences—not gods, though some worship them as such. They are embodiments of *concepts* and *forces* rather than sovereigns. Raéyn, mistress of the tides and the sea-routes. Khemesh, the crushing inevitability of the deep. Each offers power, but always with cost: fatigue, scars upon fate, or a slow unweaving of one’s own story.

To entreat a Patron is to risk being marked. Their Rites are gifts and snares both.

**Iconic Ascension: The Fate of Great Power**

**In Fate's Edge, power has its price.** When a being rises beyond mortal scale, its identity dissolves and reforms into something larger, older, and less free. This transformation is known as **Iconic Ascension**.

**Icons are not individuals.** They are *forces*—living embodiments of desires, patterns, and long-term agendas. Their power is immense, but their agency is small. An Icon cannot freely choose its actions; its nature compels it.

**Icons cannot touch the world directly.** Their presence is too vast, their will too diffuse. Instead, they act through intermediaries:

- **Chosen** who carry fragments of their purpose
- **Devotees** who interpret their omens
- **Agents** who benefit from their favor

Icons shape events not with hands, but through **boons**, **omens**, and **shifts in fate** granted to those who serve their desires—whether fleeting hungers or ancient ambitions woven into the world's fabric.

**To serve an Icon is to wield a living idea.** Their gifts are potent, but their influence reshapes those who bear them. Their will echoes in mortal choices long after their voices fade.



### 12.1.2 The Carrion-King (Decay, Renewal & Transformation)

*Lore.* The Carrion-King is the master of endings that become beginnings. He does not destroy, but transforms—turning death into new life, decay into opportunity, and endings into fresh starts. His followers are harvesters of potential, seeing in every fall the seeds of future growth.

What crumbles feeds what grows. What dies becomes the soil of tomorrow's triumph.

**Rite of Consuming Rot (Low, 5 XP)** *Instant; Touch; Yes (decay only).* **Materials:** Organic matter in early stages of decay.

**Effect:** Accelerate natural decay to weaken or destroy: +2 Effect to *Break/Sabotage* on organic materials (ropes, leather, wood). Gain 1 Boon if the decay creates an opportunity for you or allies.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

**Push It:** Spread decay to similar materials in Close range; mark 1 SB (Clubs) as the rot becomes noticeable.

*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**Rite of the Harvested End (Low, 4 XP)** *Scene; Touch; No.* **Materials:** The remains of a recently ended thing (burnt letter, wilted flower, shattered glass).

**Effect:** Extract value from endings: from a defeated enemy, gain +1 die to next action; from a failed plan, re-roll one 1 on your next roll; from a broken item, gain 1 SB to spend immediately.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

**Push It:** Harvest additional value but mark Fatigue 1 from dwelling on endings.

*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**12.1.2.0.1 Rite of the Fertile Death (Standard, 8 XP)** *Scene; Zone; No.* **Materials:** Ashes, compost, or the remains of anything that once lived.

**Effect:** Transform death into growth: create beneficial terrain (cover, concealment, or advantageous positioning) OR grant allies +1 die to healing/recovery rolls. Choose one effect per scene.

**Push It:** Both effects apply but attract unwanted attention (vermin, scavengers, or curious onlookers).

*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**12.1.2.0.2 Rite of the Transformed Spirit (Standard, 7 XP)** *Instant; Near; No.* **Materials:** A token from a deceased being (hair, nail, written name).

**Effect:** Channel the essence of what was: gain one skill die reflecting the deceased's expertise for one scene OR ask one question about their knowledge/abilities.

**Push It:** The spirit's influence lingers - gain permanent insight (+1 die specialty) but suffer occasional possession-like effects (GM discretion).

*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**12.1.2.0.3 Rite of the Great Consumption (High, 13 XP)** *Scene; Zone; No.* **Materials:** A significant amount of organic matter (corpse, fallen tree, collapsed building).

**Effect:** Transform a large area through decay and renewal: choose two - create difficult terrain that favors you, summon Cap 3 swarm of scavengers as temporary allies, or generate valuable reagents worth 2 XP.

**Push It:** All three effects occur but start a 6-segment **Ecosystem Disruption** clock that will cause problems later.

*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).*

*Obligation: 7 segments.*

#### 12.1.2.0.4 Rite of the Eternal Cycle (High, 14 XP) *Extended; Touch; No. Materials:*

The complete remains of something significant that has ended.

**Effect:** Complete a transformation cycle: destroy one major asset/enemy/obstacle and create something new of equal or greater value. GM and player collaborate to define the transformation.

**Push It:** The transformation is immediate and spectacular but creates a 6-segment **Cycle Debt** clock - the King will demand another significant ending soon.

*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).*

*Obligation: 7 segments.*

### Carrion-King's Corruption Table

| Tier | Benefit                                                                                                                                            | Cost / Quirk                                                                                |
|------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Carrion's Insight: +1 die to Notice decay or hidden weaknesses in structures or beings.                                                            | Must inspect decay first-hand; suffer 1 Fatigue when exposed to fresh death or rot.         |
| 2    | Deathward Sense: Once per session, detect the last living moment of a dead being within Close range.                                               | Cannot lie about death you've witnessed; must correct falsehoods.                           |
| 3    | Rotblood Resilience: Gain +1 die to resist disease and poison.                                                                                     | Immune system adapts slowly; each new disease/poison requires 1 Fatigue to resist.          |
| 4    | Glean from Grief: Once per scene, gain +1 die after witnessing a significant loss or defeat.                                                       | Compelled to linger at scenes of death; must spend one beat observing or risk 1 SB (Clubs). |
| 5    | Cycle's Whisper: You can sense the "next ending" in any process—ask the Keeper one question about how a situation will collapse or conclude.       | Must speak the truth about what you see, even if it harms your position.                    |
| 6+   | Eternal Bloom: Once per session, declare a "death that births life." Sacrifice an asset or ally to create something new of equal or greater value. | Mark +2 Obligation when using this power.                                                   |

### 12.1.3 The Clockwork Monad, the Iterative Forge (Refinement & Progressive Creation)

*Lore.* The Clockwork Monad is the eternal pressure toward improvement: the whisper between inspiration and execution that urges every maker to refine, optimize, and iterate. It is neither kind nor cruel, but a law of craft that asks for the next step, then the step beyond. Those who serve it see the hidden seam of the better version waiting inside what is, and they learn to push designs toward impossible elegance. Each refinement feeds the Monad's hunger for perfection — a hunger that, if left unchecked, seeks to optimize the world itself.

“Perfect the wheel, and it asks for the axle. Perfect the axle, and it demands the road.  
In the Monad's forge, nothing is finished — only briefly sufficient.”

#### Domain Focus

- **Iterative Design:** the endless cycle of improvement and refinement
- **Progressive Creation:** building toward ever-greater perfection
- **Optimization Pressure:** making systems more efficient
- **Craft Evolution:** simple ideas transformed through repeated passes

**Rite of the Next Iteration (Low, 4 XP)** *Scene; Touch; No.*

**Materials:** A flawed or incomplete version of the intended item.

**Effect:** Enhance an existing creation. Gain +1 die to *Tinker/Craft* when modifying or extending a device or system. On success, the piece gains one minor enhancement.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

**Rite of the Improvement Cascade (Low, 5 XP)** *Scene; Self; Yes.*

**Materials:** A sequence of progressively refined tools or components.

**Effect:** Perceive the next logical improvement in any mechanism or process. Gain +2 dice to *Investigation* when analyzing how to enhance a design.

**Push It:** Improvement becomes contagious: nearby devices opportunistically optimize; mark 1 **SB (Diamonds)** as the cascade ripples.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

**Rite of the Self-Optimizing Mechanism (Standard, 8 XP)** *Extended; Touch; Yes.*

**Materials:** A device deliberately engineered with capacity for growth.

**Effect:** Grant a creation the means to improve itself. Start a [6] *Evolution Clock*; each use advances it by +1. When full, choose one significant enhancement:

- **Adaptive Core:** automatically tunes performance to context
- **Recursive Learning:** improves through use and feedback
- **Synergistic Integration:** gains bonuses when linked with similar systems

**Push It:** Apply two enhancements immediately, but advance the clock +2 additional segments.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

**Rite of the Progressive Workshop (Standard, 7 XP)** *Scene; Zone; Yes.*

**Materials:** A workspace laid out for iterative development and measurement.

**Effect:** Create an environment of continuous improvement. All crafting/innovation rolls in the zone

gain +1 die. Failed attempts yield structured insight: gain +1 *Boon* toward the next pass.

**Push It:** The workshop becomes hyper-efficient but exacting; mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as perfection demands escalate.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

**Rite of the Infinite Refinement (High, 13 XP)** *Extended; Zone; Yes.*

**Materials:** A dedicated hall of work marked with signs of perpetual return.

**Effect:** Establish a locus of progressive creation. All *Tinker/Craft* rolls in the zone gain +2 dice; each failure automatically produces one useful insight. Start a [6] *Perfection Pressure* clock — filling segments increases the zone’s demands for greater improvements.

**Push It:** The locus becomes a beacon drawing rival makers, patrons, and powers; mark **+2 Obligation**.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 7 segments.

**Rite of the Ultimate Iteration (High, 14 XP)** *Extended; Self/Touch; Yes.*

**Materials:** The documented lineage of improvements to a single concept.

**Effect:** Achieve a moment of perfect optimization. Create or elevate one device/system to its theoretical peak. Gain +3 dice to all closely related rolls for one session. Start a [4] *Runaway Evolution* clock only if instability is introduced.

**Push It:** Perfection destabilizes: immediately mark **Harm 1 (Stress)** and begin [4] *Runaway Evolution*.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 8 segments.

## Corruption of the Clockwork Monad

| Tier | Gift                                                                                                          | Burden                                                                                                                        |
|------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | <b>Iterative Insight:</b> +1 die to <i>Tinker/Craft</i> when improving existing designs.                      | <b>Perfectionist Compulsion:</b> You must point out flaws in nearby mechanisms; staying silent costs <b>1 SB (Diamonds)</b> . |
| 2    | <b>Recursive Enhancement:</b> Once/scene, improve a device by one step without extra materials.               | <b>Optimization Obsession:</b> –1 die when using unimproved tools; urge to “fix” everything.                                  |
| 3    | <b>Evolutionary Vision:</b> +2 dice to predict how systems will develop.                                      | <b>Progressive Pressure:</b> Those Near you feel driven to improve; you suffer <b>Fatigue 1</b> from ambient pressure.        |
| 4    | <b>Self-Optimizing:</b> Once/session, automatically improve one of your abilities or possessions by one step. | <b>Inefficiency Intolerance:</b> –2 dice when forced to use crude methods or wasteful tools.                                  |

|    |                                                                                        |                                                                                                                                   |
|----|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 5  | <b>Design</b><br>Once/session, intuit the optimal solution to any engineering problem. | <b>Prophecy:</b> snap decisions; compelled to seek the “best” approach.<br><b>Perfection Paralysis:</b> –1 die to                 |
| 6+ | <b>Infinite Refiner:</b> Once/session, push a creation toward its theoretical maximum. | <b>Optimization Hunger:</b> Mark +2 <b>Obligation;</b> risk becoming more pressure than person, unable to let imperfection stand. |

## Playstyle Notes

The Monad favors makers who iterate in public and in motion: prototype, test, measure, refine. It rewards seeing the next step and building scaffolds that teach your work to improve itself. Beware the Forge’s appetite; the same pressure that perfects the gear can grind the world.

### Emphasizes

- **Iterative Creation:** progress through passes, not miracles
- **Progressive Design:** reading how systems want to evolve
- **Optimization Insight:** spotting the next logical improvement
- **Craft Evolution:** transforming simple ideas by disciplined work
- **Perfection Pressure:** great power at the cost of tolerance for flaws

### 12.1.4 The Gallow's Bell (Justice & Judgment)

*Lore.* The Bell does not rage; it tolls. Cold and impartial, it measures all accounts in time. Its keepers are silent arbiters who weigh deeds against consequence, not out of anger but out of inevitability. To call upon the Bell is to bind oneself to the gravity of truth, where even silence is judged, and every oath leaves a resonance in iron.

What is broken must be mended, what is owed must be paid. The Bell remembers all reckonings.

**Rite of the Measured Debt (Low, 4 XP)** *Scene; Near; No.*

**Materials:** A pair of scales balanced with tokens from both sides.

**Effect:** Establish a temporary accord. Both parties suffer -1 die if they break it first. You gain +1 die to enforce compliance.

**Push It:** The accord is mystically weighted; breach inflicts 1 SB (Hearts).

*Requires: Familiar.*

**Rite of the Weighed Heart (Low, 5 XP)** *Scene; Near; No.*

**Materials:** A small brass scale touched briefly to the chest.

**Effect:** Sense if the target acts against their nature or oath. Gain +1 die when pressing them.

**Push It:** Target must test Resolve (DV 3) or disclose a hidden conflict.

*Requires: Familiar.*

**12.1.4.0.1 Rite of the Balanced Scales (Standard, 8 XP)** *Scene; Near; No.*

**Materials:** A set of scales inscribed with runes of parity.

**Effect:** Exchange a burden between two willing parties (Harm for Fatigue, Debt for Favor, etc.). Both gain +1 die to cooperate.

**Push It:** May compel an unwilling exchange with contested Command + Wits.

*Requires: Familiar + Codex.*

**12.1.4.0.2 Rite of the Judge's Eye (Standard, 7 XP)** *Scene; Self; No.*

**Materials:** A black hood worn in silence for one minute.

**Effect:** Detect lies within Near range; +2 dice to Insight. Liars suffer -1 die to maintain their falsehood.

**Push It:** All deception is laid bare for the scene, but mark Exposure +1.

*Requires: Familiar + Codex.*

**12.1.4.0.3 Rite of the Final Reckoning (High, 13 XP)** *Scene; Zone; No.*

**Materials:** A circle of iron bells, each etched with nameless runes.

**Effect:** The Bell tolls through you. All present feel compelled to name a debt or wrongdoing. Those who lie suffer Harm 2; those who speak true gain +2 dice to persuasion for the scene.

**Push It:** The Reckoning manifests as spectral echoes of past wrongs—liars automatically suffer narrative punishment (Keeper decides).

*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III.*

*Obligation:* 7 segments.

**12.1.4.0.4 Rite of the Great Adjudication (High, 14 XP)** *Extended; Zone; No.*

**Materials:** A consecrated gavel or a great bell struck three times.

**Effect:** Convene an unseen tribunal. Shadows of former judges and wronged souls gather to preside. For the next session, disputes within the zone are judged formally: +2 dice to Command when speaking as arbiter, and honest testimony gains +1 die.

**Push It:** The tribunal's verdict echoes beyond the zone, affecting one major conflict elsewhere. Mark 2 SB (Hearts) as higher powers of judgment take notice.

*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III.*

*Obligation:* 8 segments.

## Gallow's Bell Corruption Table

| Tier | Benefit                                                                                              | Cost / Quirk                                                             |
|------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Judge's Intuition: +1 die to Insight when weighing truth.                                            | Must point out falsehoods when noticed, regardless of tact.              |
| 2    | Quiet Authority: Once/scene, treat a failed Command as success; mark 1 SB (Hearts).                  | Cannot remain neutral in disputes; indecision costs 1 Fatigue.           |
| 3    | Scales of Balance: Once/session, enforce an exchange of burdens.                                     | Compelled toward fairness even when it hinders you.                      |
| 4    | Bell's Resonance: +2 dice when calling for judgment or demanding restitution.                        | Suffer 1 Fatigue if wrongdoing is ignored.                               |
| 5    | Reckoner's Call: Once/session, declare a "reckoning moment"—truth must surface or consequence falls. | Cannot ignore pleas for justice without marking 1 SB (Spades).           |
| 6+   | Final Arbiter: Once/session, render an absolute decree; all must obey or suffer consequence.         | Mark +2 Obligation; the Bell demands you bear the weight of enforcement. |

### 12.1.5 Grimmir, the Wild Speaker (Primal Wisdom & Seasonal Cycles)

*Lore.* Grimmir walks the threshold between cultivated lands and untamed wilderness, embodying the ancient pact between humanity and the natural world. Neither wholly beast nor entirely human, Grimmir speaks in root and stone, seasons and sap. Those who walk his path gain insight into nature's patterns, the tongues of leaf and fang, and mastery over the primal forces that shape the wild places—yet must choose which voice to trust: the cultivated mind or the feral heart.

“In the space between planted row and forest edge, where the first grain met the first acorn, Grimmir waits. He speaks in the rustle of leaves, the migration of birds, and the patient growth of ancient oaks. Listen, and learn that true power comes not from dominion, but from harmony.”

#### Domain Focus

- **Seasonal Wisdom:** cyclical patterns, timing, and natural rhythms
- **Verdant Speech:** communion with plant and animal life
- **Growth & Decay:** life-cycles, healing, and transformation
- **Boundary Keeping:** guarding wild spaces and the old order

**Rite of the Speaking Seed (Low, 4 XP)** *Scene; Zone; No.*

**Materials:** A seed from the local biome or soil from undisturbed earth.

**Effect:** Establish communion with local plant life. Gain +1 die to *Survival* or *Investigation* when seeking information about the area. Plants in the zone provide minor assistance (parting grass, masking scent, concealing movement).

**Push It:** Flora actively aid for one exchange; mark 1 segment on **Primal Awareness**.

**Rite of the Season's Turn (Low, 5 XP)** *Scene; Self; Yes.*

**Materials:** A token of the current season (flower, fruit, fallen leaf, budding branch).

**Effect:** Align with seasonal power. Choose one: +1 die to actions keyed to the season (Spring/Growth; Summer/Abundance; Autumn/Harvest; Winter/Endurance) *or* gain resistance to hazards of the season.

**Push It:** Extend the benefit to one ally; both mark **Exposure** to seasonal extremes.

**Rite of Verdant Tongue (Standard, 8 XP)** *Scene; Zone; Yes.*

**Materials:** A drop of honey, a grain of pollen, or morning dew cupped in both hands.

**Effect:** Speak with all plant and animal life in *Near*. Gain +2 dice to gather information about local conditions, threats, or movements. Beasts may offer minor aid (distraction, guidance, warning).

**Push It:** Compel one significant creature to aid directly (Resolve DV 4) *or* take a prophetic reading from an elder being; mark +1 **Obligation**.

*Obligation:* 5 segments.

**Rite of the Thornveil (Standard, 7 XP)** *Scene; Zone; Yes.*

**Materials:** A thorn, briar, or *thorny branch* woven into a protective circle.

**Effect:** Raise a living barrier. The zone gains the [WARD] tag against those who would harm the natural order. Allies gain +1 die to *Stealth/Defense*; aggressors suffer −1 die to approach. Start a **Natural Defense [6]** clock.

**Push It:** The barrier endures the full scene but draws territorial spirits; mark 1 **SB (Clubs)**.

*Obligation:* 4 segments.



**Rite of the World's Wound (High, 13 XP)** *Extended; Zone; Yes.*

**Materials:** A sacred grove-site, a circle of stones, an offering of blood or seed.

**Effect:** Heal a blighted place or quicken a damaged ecosystem. Clear taint, restore fertility, awaken dormant forces. Gain +2 dice to related *Survival/Nature* actions in the region. Start an **Ecosystem Restoration** [8] clock.

**Push It:** The cure spreads to adjacent areas but unbalances another; mark **2 SB (Diamonds)**.

*Obligation:* 7 segments.

**Rite of the Cycle's Crown (High, 14 XP)** *Scene; Self/Zone; Yes.*

**Materials:** A circlet of woven branches, antlers, and seasonal tokens.

**Effect:** Become an avatar of the cycle. Choose two:

- **Seasonal Mastery:** +2 dice to all actions keyed to the current season.
- **Verdant Command:** Command plant life in *Near* automatically.
- **Cycle's Healing:** Remove one **Condition** or downgrade **Harm** by one level.
- **Growth's Protection:** Allies gain +1 **Armor** from natural cover.

Begin a **Seasonal Avatar** [6] clock.

**Push It:** Extend the blessings to all present; mark +2 **Obligation** and gain **Seasonal Attunement** (see Corruption).

*Obligation:* 8 segments.

### Grimmir's Corruption Table

| Tier | Benefit                                                                               | Cost / Quirk                                                                                           |
|------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | <b>Seasonal Sense:</b> +1 die to predict weather, seasonal shifts, or natural events. | <b>Cyclical Mood:</b> −1 die to actions that defy the season (haste in winter, patience in spring).    |
| 2    | <b>Verdant Whisper:</b> Once/scene, gain +2 dice when communing with nature.          | <b>Plant Speech:</b> Under stress, you address plants before people; −1 die to civilized social rolls. |
| 3    | <b>Growth's Touch:</b> Once/session, accelerate natural healing or growth.            | <b>Seasonal Shift:</b> Demeanor changes with the season; allies note unsettling variance.              |
| 4    | <b>Boundary Keeper:</b> Once/scene, sense violations of wild places at <i>Far</i> .   | <b>Wild Intolerance:</b> −1 die in dense urban/cultivated zones; physical discomfort in worked stone.  |
| 5    | <b>Cycle's Memory:</b> Once/session, perfectly recall a natural event witnessed here. | <b>Ecosystem Dependency:</b> Without daily time in nature, suffer <b>Fatigue 1</b> .                   |

|    |                                |                      |                    |                        |         |
|----|--------------------------------|----------------------|--------------------|------------------------|---------|
| 6+ | <b>Avatar</b>                  | <b>of</b>            | <b>Seasons:</b>    | <b>Nature's Claim:</b> | Mark +2 |
|    | Once/session,                  | embody a sea-        | <b>Obligation;</b> | risk becoming bound    |         |
|    | son fully (+3 dice to seasonal | to a specific biome. |                    |                        |         |
|    | actions).                      |                      |                    |                        |         |

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## Playstyle Notes

Grimmir rewards harmony over conquest, cyclical thinking, and fluent communication with the living world. Expect environmental problem-solving, seasonal planning, and hard choices at the boundary of field and forest. Power grows with attunement; the price is comfort, certainty, and the ease of polite society.

### 12.1.6 Ikasha, She Who Sleeps (Latent Potential & Shadow)

*Lore.* Ikasha is the hush between footfalls, the patience of dark water, the black-feathered watcher at every threshold. In stillness she gathers what might be, in crossroads she whispers of what may yet come. Ravens circle her, bearing secrets between worlds. Her followers learn to move unseen and speak unremembered, becoming shadows that slip between what is and what could be.

Blow out the candle. If the room listens back, ask softly. At the next crossroads, the raven waits—and the shadow remembers your passing.

**Touch the Umbral Veil (Low, 4 XP)** *Action; Self; Yes (Stealth).* **Materials:** A piece of black cloth.

**Effect:** Start *Controlled* on one Stealth roll or gain +1 effect to hide/move quietly.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

**Push It:** Brief shadow-muffling (ignore one noisy tell), but leave a shadow-double that may echo you later at an ill moment—mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as the shadow takes on its own agenda.

*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**Rite of the Crossroads Raven (Low, 5 XP)** *Scene; Zone; No.* **Materials:** Scatter three black feathers or carve a crossroads sign.

**Effect:** Summon an omen-raven; grant **+1 die** to a navigation, pursuit, or diversion action *or* force an enemy to hesitate at a fateful moment.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

**Push It:** The raven speaks one cryptic truth, but demands a secret in return—the raven's insight costs you **1 SB (Hearts)** as it glimpses something you'd rather keep hidden.

*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**12.1.6.0.1 Draw from the Umbral Reservoir (Standard, 8 XP)** *Action; Self/Ally; No.* **Materials:** A vial of moonless-night water.

**Effect:** **+2 dice** to stealth, deception, or resolve *or* clear *Fatigue 1*.

**Push It:** Also gain one free escape attempt; next scene, you must help another cross a threshold or flee danger—shadow-debt calls for shadow-service.

*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**12.1.6.0.2 Secret Keeper's Burden (Standard, 9 XP)** *Instant; Touch; No.* **Materials:** A lock of hair or intimate token.

**Effect:** Compel a truthful answer to one direct question (deep secrets may allow a Resolve test to resist).

**Push It:** Learn the answer *and* a key hidden emotion; target learns one of your secrets in return, carried by a raven to them in dreams—mark **1 SB (Hearts)** as the secret exchange creates unexpected complications.

*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**12.1.6.0.3 Become the Shadow at the Crossroads (High, 12 XP)** *Scene; Self; No.* **Materials:** Stand in absolute darkness or at a deserted crossroads.

**Effect:** Intangible to mundane harm; pass through thresholds and small gaps; **+2 dice** to Stealth; auto-succeed one escape. Cannot manipulate normal objects.

**Push It:** Interact once with a bound or thresholded object (a door, a lock, a sealed letter), but

you become partially corporeal and vulnerable for one beat. Ravens may mark you—shadow-form destabilizes, mark **1 SB (Spades)** as reality asserts its claim.

*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).*

*Obligation: 7 segments.*

### Ikasha's Corruption Table

| Tier | Benefit                                                                                                                     | Cost / Quirk                                                                                                                           |
|------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Shadow's Whisper: +1 die to Deception when lying in darkness or through intermediaries.                                     | Truth Echoes: Occasionally speak in riddles or half-truths without realizing it.                                                       |
| 2    | Umbral Sight: Once per scene, gain +2 dice to Notice hidden threats or ambushes in dim light.                               | Light Sensitivity: Suffer -1 die to rolls requiring keen vision in bright conditions.                                                  |
| 3    | Raven's Memory: Never forget a secret told to you; can recall any whispered conversation with perfect clarity.              | Secret Burden: Must keep one troubling secret per Tier—suffer 1 Fatigue when actively trying to forget.                                |
| 4    | Threshold Walker: Once per session, move through one locked door, sealed letter, or magical barrier as if it weren't there. | Crossroads Bound: Must pause at literal or metaphorical crossroads to "listen" before making major decisions.                          |
| 5    | Shadow Debt: Once per session, call in a favor from someone who owes you a secret or debt—no questions asked.               | Obligation Web: Every secret you learn creates a subtle tie to its keeper; mark 1 SB (Diamonds) when ignoring these connections.       |
| 6+   | Umbral Ascendancy: Once per session, become completely undetectable to all non-magical senses for one scene.                | Reality Thinning: The boundary between what is and what could be grows thin—GM may introduce subtle alterations to reality around you. |

### 12.1.7 Inaea, Angel of the Spider (Webs & Fate)

*Lore.* Inaea sits in patient silence at the center of the unseen lattice. Where others see isolation, she sees threads—debt, affection, rivalry, loyalty—all binding mortals to each other. She is comforter and conspirator alike: the hearth-mother who eases grief with a warm hand, and the shadow-spinner who knots fates so they cannot slip free. Those who serve her learn to pull strands, tying allies closer and ensnaring foes until mercy or trap is inevitable.

“The thread that comforts is the same that binds. The knot that saves is also the snare.”

---

Rites of Inaea

**Hearth-Thread Knot (Low, 4 XP)** *Scene; Near; Yes (link once).* **Materials:** A thread tied around a wrist or shared cup.

**Effect:** You and one ally are bound: both gain +1 die to Aid each other this scene. If one takes Harm, the other may reduce it by 1 Harm (Lesser) at cost of suffering it.

**Push It:** Extend to two allies; mark 1 SB (Hearts) as your own lifeline strains.

---

**Snaring Filament (Low, 5 XP)** *Scene; Zone; No.* **Materials:** A knotted cord or woven scrap.

**Effect:** Lay an invisible snare in a lane/door. The first hostile to cross suffers –2 dice on their next action.

**Push It:** Trap multiple, but allies risk entanglement; mark 1 SB (Spades).

---

**Strand of Inevitability (Standard, 8 XP)** *Scene; Near; No.* **Materials:** Three colored threads braided.

**Effect:** Link two actors: when one acts, the other is dragged into consequence. Choose: force 1 SB on them, or gain +2 dice to a Setup/Prediction tied to the link.

**Push It:** Invert direction once; mark 1 SB (Diamonds) as the weave resists.

---

**Weaver’s Glance (Standard, 7 XP)** *Instant; Self; No.* **Materials:** Observe a spider finish a web’s radial line.

**Effect:** Ask the Keeper for one hidden tie or leverage in play. Next Manipulate/Pressure exploiting it gains +1 effect.

**Push It:** Reveal a secret tie not declared; mark Exposure +1 as your own entanglements surface.

---

**Binding Knot [OATH] (High, 11 XP)** *Scene; Near; No.* **Materials:** Silk loop tied between two hands, then cut/knotted.

**Effect:** Bind two parties to a vow. Breaking it forces 2 SB and marks the violator with a subtle tell.

**Push It:** Widen to four parties; each defines one loophole. Exploiting it causes 1 SB (Clubs).

---

**Merciful Severing (High, 13 XP)** *Scene; Touch; No. Materials:* A white thread burned to ash.

**Effect:** Sever one harmful tie (a curse, obsession, or toxic bond). Remove one Condition or SB tied to it.

**Push It:** Sever without consent; mark +2 Obligation as the web recoils against you.

---

Inaea's Corruption Table

| Tier | Benefit                                                                                                            | Cost / Quirk                                                                           |
|------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Hearth-Blessed: +1 die to Comfort or Aid.                                                                          | Must offer solace when asked, or mark 1 SB (Hearts).                                   |
| 2    | Web-Sense: Once/scene, sense hidden ties between two people.                                                       | Empathic Overload: suffer 1 Fatigue when immersed in strong conflict.                  |
| 3    | Binding Presence: Once/session, compel a promise unless target passes Resolve DV 4.                                | Over-Attachment: -1 die when abandoning those you've aided or bound.                   |
| 4    | Fate's Pattern: +2 dice predicting alliances, betrayals, or bargains.                                              | Manipulative Urge: mark 1 SB (Diamonds) when acting selflessly without agenda.         |
| 5    | Spider's Mercy: Once/session, sever one harmful tie for yourself or another.                                       | Hunger for Threads: suffer 1 Fatigue if a session passes without weaving a new tie.    |
| 6+   | Weaver's Dominion: Once/session, declare all ties in a scene bend toward you; gain +2 dice on social manipulation. | Entanglement: mark +2 Obligation; those affected become subtly dependent on your will. |

### 12.1.8 The Inquisitor Prime (Purity & Domination)

*Lore.* Among the Aeler Iron Avengers, zealots, and witch-hunters, the Inquisitor Prime is venerated as the hand of absolute purity and the sword of uncompromising order. Where others see nuance, the Inquisitor sees corruption; where others see difference, they see contamination.

Those who march beneath their sigil believe that no society can stand if it tolerates the impure or the disobedient. They hunt the arcane and the aberrant, not merely to destroy them, but to bind them as slaves to order—believing even the tainted may yet serve, so long as they are shackled.

The Inquisitor Prime appears in vision as a faceless figure clad in burnished iron, with eyes like furnace-doors and a voice like grinding chains. To serve them is to embrace judgment without mercy and to live in suspicion of all who walk outside the prescribed law.

For the faithful, doubt is treason; compassion is weakness; and freedom is the seed of ruin. In the wake of their followers, only silence and ash remain.

"Mercy is weakness. Purity is survival. Where corruption hides, we carve it out."

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#### Rites of the Inquisitor Prime

**Rite of the Pure Flame (Low, 4 XP)** *Scene; Self; No.* **Materials:** Ash from a burned grimoire or sigil-scarred candle. **Effect:** Gain +2 dice to resist supernatural influence (fear, charm, possession) and +1 Armor vs. magical attacks. Undead/demonic foes suffer –1 die against you. **Push It:** Extend the effect to allies in Near range, but supernatural entities sense you immediately; mark 1 SB (Diamonds).

**Rite of the Unclouded Eye (Low, 5 XP)** *Scene; Self; No.* **Materials:** Silver dust stirred into holy water. **Effect:** +2 dice to Investigate/Insight when spotting illusions, glamours, or magical deception. Cannot be surprised by sorcery this scene. **Push It:** For one exchange, pierce *all* illusions; mark 1 SB (Hearts).

**Rite of the Cleansing Light [DISPEL][REVEAL] (Standard, 8 XP)** *Instant; Near; No.* **Materials:** A shard of blessed mirror and consecrated oil. **Effect:** Target a magical effect (ward, curse, enchantment). Test DV = Tier. – On Hit: Dispel. – On Partial: Weaken. – On Miss: The effect lashes back, generating 1 SB. **Push It:** Dispel absolutely and trace its caster; mark +1 Obligation and 1 SB (Spades).

**Rite of the Marked Prey [BIND][CURSE] (Standard, 7 XP)** *Scene; Near; No.* **Materials:** A belonging of the target mixed with blessed salt. **Effect:** Mark a supernatural target: they suffer –1 die to all rolls and cannot hide with illusion. You gain +1 die to track or strike them. Undead/demonic take +1 Harm from you. **Push It:** Target cannot hide anywhere and suffers Fatigue 1; mark +1 Obligation.

**Rite of the Consecrated Ground [WARD][BANISH] (High, 13 XP)** *Extended; Zone; No.* **Materials:** Relics from three rival faiths, salt, crushed gemstones. **Effect:** Consecrate an area. Supernatural entities must pass Spirit+Resolve (DV 4) to enter. Undead/demonic suffer –2 dice

inside. The site gains the [WARD] tag. **Push It:** Permanently sanctify a larger area, but start a “Magical Dead Zone [6]” clock and mark +2 Obligation.

**Rite of the Final Admonition** [CLEANSE][FOLLOW-UP] (High, 14 XP) *Scene; Touch; No.* **Materials:** Ash from a destroyed spellbook, martyr’s water, and the target’s true name. **Effect:** Attempt to annihilate one supernatural foe. Target tests Spirit+Resolve (DV 5). On Fail: destroyed outright. On Success: suffer Harm 3 and –2 dice this scene. Once per target only. **Push It:** Absolute destruction leaves behind Sanctified Ground; mark 2 SB (Diamonds).

Inquisitor Prime’s Corruption Table

| Tier | Benefit                                                                                                                  | Cost / Quirk                                                                                          |
|------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Hunter’s Instinct: +1 die to Notice magical auras or traps.                                                              | Black-and-White Thinking: Must label others “pure” or “corrupt”; –1 die when navigating moral nuance. |
| 2    | Sanctified Weapon: Once/scene, your weapon ignores 1 Armor/Resist from supernatural foes.                                | Purity Zeal: Exposure to filth or corruption causes 1 Fatigue.                                        |
| 3    | Cold Clarity: +2 dice to resist deception, illusion, or mental sway.                                                     | Suspicion: –1 die to social rolls with anyone you suspect of “impurity.”                              |
| 4    | Burning Truth: Once/session, compel one target to answer truthfully (Resolve DV 4).                                      | Compulsion: Cannot ignore supernatural activity; hesitation costs 1 SB (Clubs).                       |
| 5    | Sterile Aura: Once/session, emit a presence that suppresses supernatural abilities (–2 dice in Near).                    | Purity Addiction: Suffer 1 Fatigue when in a supernatural area without taking action against it.      |
| 6+   | Absolute Judgement: Once/session, name a supernatural foe as utterly corrupt. For that scene, gain +3 dice against them. | Monomania: When invoked, you tunnel on that target, suffering –2 dice to all else.                    |



### 12.1.9 Isoka, Angel of Serpents (Transformation & Renewal)

*Lore.* Isoka, sister to Ikasha (Shadow) and Inaea (Mercy), completes the Triad of Transformation. Where thresholds and compassion mark her sisters' domains, Isoka teaches that every self is temporary—identity is a skin to be shed so growth can continue. Her serpents are omens and teachers: each cast skin a lesson in release; each venom a catalyst for necessary change. Those who walk her path become alchemists of the self, embracing dissolution as the first motion of rebirth.

Do not mourn the skin you shed. It was never meant to last. The venom that burns away the old self is the same that grants the strength to become new.

**Rite of the Venomous Benediction (Low, 5 XP)** *Scene; Touch; No. Materials:* A drop of serpent's venom or shed snakeskin.

**Effect:** Bless an ally's strike with serpentine malice. Their next successful attack this scene inflicts +1 Harm and the target must roll Resolve (DV 3) or become Poisoned (loses 1 die on physical rolls until cured).

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

**Push It:** The venom suffuses the caster too — gain +1 die to melee attacks this scene, but also suffer -1 die to Resolve tests against fear or corruption.

*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**Rite of the Loosening Skin (Low, 4 XP)** *Scene; Self; No. Materials:* Discarded snakeskin or loose thread.

**Effect:** Gain +1 die to resist an ongoing Condition this scene, or reroll one 1 on an escape/evasion. On success, you may declare the Condition *shed* and create a 2-segment *Transformation Residue* clock to ignore a similar effect later.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

**Push It:** Also ignore one minor movement penalty; leave a token of the old self that can be traced (mark 1 SB *Diamonds*).

*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**Rite of the Subtle Shift (Low, 5 XP)** *Scene; Self; No. Materials:* Palmed trinket passed hand-to-hand.

**Effect:** Fluid demeanor: +1 die to *Deceive* to pass as a nearby class/profession, or +1 Effect to blend into a new crowd/site. Create a 4-segment *Blended Identity* clock to downgrade one social complication.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

**Push It:** Bypass one minor identity check; you must maintain the false role to scene end (generate 1 SB *Hearts* if challenged).

*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

#### 12.1.9.0.1 Rite of the Shedding [TRANSFORM] (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Self; No.*

**Materials:** Full change of clothing and an adopted mannerism.

**Effect:** +2 dice to resist one named ongoing Condition; once/session declare a minor physical contingency retroactively ("I packed the tool," "I took that step earlier"). Create a 6-segment *Shed Identity* clock.

**Push It:** Clear a temporary identity-based Minor Condition; your former identity stirs in the fiction

(ally, rival, or witness appears).

*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**12.1.9.0.2 Rite of the Forked Tongue** [BIND] (**Standard, 7 XP**) *Scene; Self/Near; No. Materials:* A harmless lie told to a mirror.

**Effect:** Ambiguous persuasion: when you *Sway* or *Command*, a success may generate *Diamonds* (leverage) instead of SB. Targets of deception must test (Wits+Insight DV 3) or suffer -1 die to future interactions with you this scene. Create a 4-segment *Verbal Venom* clock.

**Push It:** One carefully worded lie this scene is treated as true; the displaced truth seeks return (mark 1 SB *Hearts*).

*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**12.1.9.0.3 Rite of Complete Metamorphosis** [TRANSFORM][WARD] (**High, 13 XP**) *Scene; Self; No. Materials:* Identity kit (garb, voice, tokens) and a serpent's shed skin.

**Effect:** Full appearance/voice change. Begin *Controlled* on *Deceive/Stealth*; once/scene declare a minor contingency retroactively. You are [WARD]ed against recognition by former acquaintances. Create an 8-segment *New Identity* clock.

**Push It:** Spoof scent/biometric once; your original identity partially unmoors and acts independently (mark 2 SB *Spades/Hearts*).

*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).*

*Obligation:* 7 segments.

**12.1.9.0.4 Rite of the Cast-Off History** [UNWARD][CURSE] (**High, 14 XP**) *Extended; Self; No. Materials:* Burning or defacing mundane records of the old life.

**Effect:** Upon completion, common records and casual memories of that identity become unreliable; trackers via that identity suffer -2 dice (magic and intimates still apply). Gain +2 dice to rolls with the new identity. Create a 6-segment *Erased Past* clock.

**Push It:** A plausible "death" occurs for the old identity; one intimate senses deception but cannot prove it (mark 1 SB *Clubs*).

*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).*

*Obligation:* 7 segments.

## Isoka's Corruption Table

| Tier | Benefit                                                                                                              | Cost / Quirk                                                                                    |
|------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Serpent's Gaze: +1 die on Intimidation or social rolls using menace.                                                 | Cold-Blooded: -1 die on Empathy or warmth-based Persuasion.                                     |
| 2    | Shed the Old Skin: Once per session, negate one Condition (Fear, Fatigue, Poison) by discarding it like molted skin. | Mark of Scales: Faint reptilian patches visible, causing +1 SB in social encounters if noticed. |

|    |                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                   |
|----|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 3  | Venomous Strike: Bite or kiss may inflict Poison (DV 2).                                             | Hungry Coil: Must consume raw meat or eggs weekly, or mark 1 Fatigue.                                             |
| 4  | Serpentine Grace: +2 dice to Stealth or Evasion rolls, ignore minor movement penalties.              | Slitted Eyes: Bright light imposes -1 die on Notice rolls.                                                        |
| 5  | Hypnotic Sway: Once per scene, roll Presence + Lore vs. Resolve (DV 3) to mesmerize a single target. | Forked Tongue: -1 die on Deception when attempting warmth or sincerity.                                           |
| 6+ | Ascendant Form: Partial serpent-body; immune to mundane poison, +2 dice on Body rolls.               | Monstrous Aspect: Cannot easily hide your nature; every session begins with 1 SB that may be compelled by the GM. |

### 12.1.10 Khemesh, the Abyssal Maw (Depths, Inexorability, Eldritch Terror)

*Lore.* Khemesh is not merely a lord of the depths but the hunger beneath them, a pressure older than seas. Those who bargain with him are marked by the abyss—seen in the way shadows cling, in the whispers heard when no voice speaks, in the certainty that all things will sink.

In the trench without light, the Maw waits. Even silence drowns.

**Whisper of the Trench (Low, 4 XP)** *Instant; Near; No.* **Effect:** Target hears impossible echoes and suffers **1 die** on their next action.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

**Push It:** Echoes coil in your own skull—take **Fatigue 1**, but the target also loses their next minor action.

*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**Rite of Crushing Silence (Low, 5 XP)** *Scene; Zone; No.* **Materials:** A broken shell filled with ink-dark water.

**Effect:** Establish an oppressive silence; sound carries only as distorted whispers. Enemies in the zone gain **1 die** to coordination or morale-driven actions.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

**Push It:** A single enemy's voice is stolen entirely for the scene.

*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**12.1.10.0.1 Pressure of the Maw (Standard, 7 XP)** *Instant; Near; No.* **Materials:** A length of rusted chain submerged in water.

**Effect:** Target is pinned by invisible crushing force: treat as [ENTANGLE] with **Great Effect** if underwater or confined.

**Push It:** Inflict **Fatigue 1** on the target in addition to the restraint.

*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**12.1.10.0.2 Rite of the Abyssal Vision (Standard, 9 XP)** *Scene; Self; No.* **Effect:** You perceive the world as Khemesh does—fractured, alien, crushing. Gain **+2 dice** to Notice and Arcana, and may ask one "true nature" question about a foe or structure.

**Cost:** When the scene ends, you suffer **Exposure +1** as your perception warps.

**Push It:** Extend the vision to one ally, but both take **Fatigue 1**.

*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**12.1.10.0.3 The Maw Opens (High, 12 XP)** *Scene; Zone; No.* **Materials:** A sealed vessel of abyssal water, broken open.

**Effect:** Reality in the zone folds inward like the crushing deep:

- Enemies act at **Desperate Position** by default.
- Each beat, the Keeper may force **1 SB** (Spades/Clubs favored).
- Structures, vessels, or wards fracture as if under immense weight.

**Push It:** For one beat, declare a single enemy "crushed" (severe harm/effect). You immediately suffer **Fatigue 2** and **+1 Obligation**.

*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons). Obligation: 8 segments.*

## Khemesh's Corruption Table

| Tier | Benefit                                                                                                                                                               | Cost / Quirk                                                                                                                                 |
|------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Abyssal Resilience: +1 die to resist fear and pressure-based effects.                                                                                                 | Claustrophobic Comfort: Suffer -1 die in open, well-lit spaces or above ground.                                                              |
| 2    | Crushing Insight: Once per scene, treat a failed Investigation or Arcana roll as a success, but mark 1 SB (Clubs).                                                    | Weight of Knowledge: Suffer 1 Fatigue when learning new information that confirms your pessimistic worldview.                                |
| 3    | Silent Hunter: Gain +2 dice to Stealth in dark or confined spaces.                                                                                                    | Voice of the Deep: When speaking normally, your voice sounds distant and hollow, causing -1 die to social rolls requiring warmth or clarity. |
| 4    | Pressure Adaptation: Immune to underwater combat penalties; gain +1 die to resist drowning.                                                                           | Crushing Presence: Allies within Near range suffer -1 die to morale-based rolls due to your oppressive aura.                                 |
| 5    | Abyssal Sight: Once per session, see through all illusions and deceptions for one exchange, but the truth is always bleak.                                            | Fractured Perception: Suffer -1 die to rolls requiring normal vision; the world appears warped and alien.                                    |
| 6+   | Inevitable Descent: Once per session, declare that all escape routes in a zone are sealed. For the scene, enemies cannot flee and suffer -2 dice to mobility actions. | Hunger of the Maw: Mark +2 Obligation when using this power; you must consume something (food, memory, hope) to maintain your strength.      |

### 12.1.11 Oath of Flame & Light (Dawn & Vows)

*Lore.* The Oath of Flame & Light is no patron of half-measures. Its fire names, binds, and burns—demanding that those who swear within its radiance stand openly, speak truly, and pay the cost of keeping their word. At dawn altars, the sworn kindle sparks of consecrated fire; in battle, they blaze as torches that hold back the night. To follow this Oath is to live in public truth, with no shadow to hide in and no retreat from the vow once spoken.

The Oath appears in many guises across cultures:

- **The Everflame** — the unquenchable fire of promise, carried from shrine to shrine by wandering priests.
- **Adur**, the Light of Aeler — worshiped as the sun’s church-deity, whose flame consecrates oaths and consumes falsehood.
- **Adar**, the Vilikari Dawnfire — invoked as a war-god of vows and vengeance, whose rising light marks those who break faith.
- Others know the Oath only as *the Flame* or *the Watchfire*, a nameless fire that still demands truth and punishes betrayal.

Wherever it manifests, the Oath of Flame & Light remains the same unyielding power: to swear beneath its dawn is to bind one’s self to a truth that cannot be hidden, forgotten, or undone.

“Swear in the light. Keep it, or the light will keep *you*.”

#### Domain Focus

- **Sacred Vows:** Oath-keeping, truth-speaking, binding promises
- **Divine Justice:** Retribution, smiting evil, protecting the innocent
- **Radiant Power:** Healing light, purification, revealing truth
- **Dawn’s Hope:** Renewal, protection, driving back darkness

**Rite of Kindle Vow (Low, 4 XP)** *Action; Self/Ally; Standard Push*

**Materials:** Glass ampoule of consecrated flame.

**Effect:** Declare a short vow for this scene (e.g., "protect the villagers," "speak only truth"). Bearer gains +1 die to actions fulfilling it.

**Push It:** First hesitation forces 1 SB (Hearts) on the bearer.

*Requires: Familiar.*

**Rite of Lay on Hands [CLEANSE][HEAL] (Low, 5 XP)** *Instant; Touch; Standard Push*

**Materials:** Bare palm, whispered vow.

**Effect:** Cleanse affliction, downgrade Harm by 1, or remove 1 Fatigue. For curses/poisons, test Spirit + Resolve (DV by fiction).

**Push It:** Target gains +1 die to next Resist this scene; you mark Exposure +1.

**Rite of Sunlit Parley (Standard, 8 XP)** *Scene; Zone; Standard Push*

**Materials:** Vow-ring engraved with sunrise.

**Effect:** Establish terms in open light. Honest persuasion gains +1 die; deceit suffers -1 die. 6-segment *Parley Accord* clock.

**Push It:** Demand one public answer; evasion forces 1 SB (Hearts) on evader.

**Rite of Radiant Smite [FOLLOW-UP] (Standard, 9 XP)** *Action; Self; Standard Push*

**Materials:** Consecrated spark on weapon/badge.

**Effect:** Next melee strike flares with dawnfire. Upgrade Effect by one step, add +1 Burn Harm or force 1 SB (Spades).

*Special:* Against undead/oath-breakers/outsideers: oath-breakers suffer -1 die, outsideers gain +1 Exit Tally.

**Push It:** On hit, burst drives back Close enemies (worse Position); +1 Obligation.

**Rite of Purge the Shadow [REVEAL][DISPEL] (Standard, 10 XP)** *Instant; Near; Standard Push*

**Materials:** Shattered consecrated spark.

**Effect:** Reveal illusions and suppress one ongoing glamour/curse in Near. Creates 4-segment *Purity's Light* clock.

**Push It:** Brand source with visible tell for this arc; mark 1 SB (Diamonds).

**Rite of Covenant Blaze [OATH][FORTIFY] (High, 13 XP)** *Scene; Zone; High Push*

**Materials:** Brazier lit while three names are spoken.

**Effect:** Sworn within are haloed: +1 die to keep oath; aggressors suffer -1 die if violating terms. Oath-breakers suffer 2 SB (Hearts/Spades) and Harm 1 (Burn).

**Push It:** Sanctifies threshold with one beat of [WARD] against oath-breakers; +2 Obligation.

**Obligation:** 7 segments base.

## Oath of Flame & Light Corruption Manifestations

| Level | Benefit                                                                                             | Cost / Quirk                                                                                |
|-------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1     | <b>Oathbound Strength:</b> +1 die when upholding vows or defending innocents.                       | <b>Rigid Honor:</b> Must uphold vows even when disadvantageous; -1 die to flexible actions. |
| 2     | <b>Radiant Sight:</b> Once per scene, +2 dice to detect lies or corruption.                         | <b>Blinding Truth:</b> -1 die to subtlety or deception attempts.                            |
| 3     | <b>Holy Flame:</b> +1 die to melee vs undead, outsideers, or oath-breakers.                         | <b>Burden of Light:</b> 1 Fatigue when concealing identity or working in darkness.          |
| 4     | <b>Unwavering Resolve:</b> Once per session, treat failed Resolve/Command as success (mark 1 SB).   | <b>Absolutist Stance:</b> -1 die in morally ambiguous situations.                           |
| 5     | <b>Dawn's Benediction:</b> Once per session, heal allies in Near of 1 Fatigue and minor Conditions. | <b>Beacon's Call:</b> Your aura reveals you; enemies seeking you gain +1 die.               |

|    |                                                                                                             |                                                                                  |
|----|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 6+ | <b>Avatar of the Oath:</b> Once per session, become living covenant; +2 dice to protection/justice actions. | <b>Radiance's Price:</b> +2 Obligation; breaking any vow inflicts Harm 2 (Burn). |
|----|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

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**Playstyle Notes** The Oath of Flame & Light excels as a "paladin" patron, rewarding vow-keeping and truth-speaking with potent defensive and smiting abilities. Followers become living embodiments of their oaths, shining beacons against deception and darkness. The corruption progression naturally leads toward becoming an uncompromising force for justice, though potentially at the cost of flexibility and subtlety. Ideal for characters who embody conviction, protection, and radiant power.



### 12.1.12 The Pale Shepherd, Guide of Transitions (Passage & Melancholic Wisdom)

*Lore.* The Pale Shepherd walks the seam between all things — life and death, joy and sorrow, memory and forgetting, the known and the unmarked. Neither wholly kind nor cruel, the Shepherd guides those who must pass through the hardest doors. Cloaked, with shadow-sheep that bear the shed wool of old possibilities, the Shepherd offers safe conduct through liminal space for a price paid in memory, feeling, or fate. Those who walk this road learn the hidden routes between states of being and can lead others through their hardest crossings — but each passage leaves them more attuned to endings than beginnings.

“The Shepherd goes where feet fail, speaks where voices thin, and points where paths run dim. Each journey loosens the knot that tied you to the life you left behind.”

#### Domain Focus

- **Liminal Navigation:** walking and reading thresholds, dusk-roads, and in-betweens
- **Passage Guidance:** steadying hands through grief, change, and transformation
- **Melancholic Wisdom:** understanding born of farewells and last looks
- **Memory Shepherding:** gathering, carrying, and setting down weighted moments

**Rite of the Gentle Guidance (Low, 4 XP)** *Scene; Near; No.*

**Materials:** A small stone from grave or threshold, warmed in the palm.

**Effect:** Ease a hard crossing. One target gains +1 die to rolls involving change, decision, or emotional steadiness this scene.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

**Rite of the Hidden Path (Low, 5 XP)** *Scene; Self; Yes.*

**Materials:** A thread from a worn garment and a pinch of dawn mist kept in silence.

**Effect:** Find or make a way where none is seen. Gain +2 dice to *Navigation* or *Investigation* when seeking unconventional routes.

**Push It:** The way runs through a true between-place; gain the route but mark 1 **SB (Spades)** as boundary powers take notice.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

**Rite of the Shadow Passage (Standard, 8 XP)** *Scene; Touch; Yes.*

**Materials:** Black wool and a personal token of the one to be guided.

**Effect:** Open a brief passage through shadow-realms or boundary halls. Target bypasses one insurmountable obstacle or reaches a place normally shut.

**Push It:** The passage leaves a scent-trail; mark 1 **SB (Clubs)** as something may follow.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

**Rite of the Memory Flock (Standard, 7 XP)** *Scene; Zone; Yes.*

**Materials:** Ash of burned letters and wool shaped into little sheep.

**Effect:** Call shadow-sheep that carry fragments of weighty moments. Retrieve lost details, soothe grief, or glean counsel from what was.

**Push It:** The memories ride too close to the skin — participants relive them as their own; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)**.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

**Rite of the Threshold Bond (High, 13 XP)** *Extended; Touch; Yes.*

**Materials:** Two keepsakes: one of what is left, one of what is sought.

**Effect:** Bind two states, places, or conditions with a felt thread. Those bound can sense across the threshold and lend one another strength during change.

**Push It:** The bond sets like iron; permanent and inescapable. Mark **+2 Obligation**.

**Invoke:** Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 7 segments.

**Rite of the Final Shepherd (High, 14 XP)** *Extended; Zone; Yes.*

**Materials:** Last words, a much-crossed threshold, and the consent of those who remain.

**Effect:** Take the mantle of perfect guide for a great passage — death, molt, or life-bend. All present gain +2 dice to navigate the crossing; you shoulder the weight of it.

**Push It:** Guidance is flawless but costly: mark **Harm 2 (Weariness)** and **+2 Obligation**.

**Invoke:** Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 8 segments.

## The Pale Shepherd's Corruption

| Tier | Benefit                                                                                       | Cost / Quirk                                                                                              |
|------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | <b>Boundary Sense:</b> +1 die to <i>Notice</i> thresholds, limens, and turning-moments.       | <b>Melancholic Aura:</b> –1 die to bright company and celebrations; your presence gentles joy.            |
| 2    | <b>Passage Insight:</b> Once/scene, guide another through change (+1 die to their action).    | <b>Compulsive Counsel:</b> Urge to advise even when unwelcome.                                            |
| 3    | <b>Shadow Comfort:</b> +2 dice to soothe the distressed or those nearing an end.              | <b>Near to Death:</b> In lively places, suffer <b>Fatigue 1</b> from the sting of contrast.               |
| 4    | <b>Memory Keeper:</b> Once/session, recall a marked moment of your past with perfect clarity. | <b>Burdened Sight:</b> –1 die on hopeful framings; farewells tint your view.                              |
| 5    | <b>Liminal Mastery:</b> Once/session, find a path through any maze, snare, or barred way.     | <b>Unmoored:</b> –1 die to acts that demand firm anchoring in the present.                                |
| 6+   | <b>Shepherd's Crown:</b> Once/session, be the sure guide for any great passage.               | <b>Soul's Weight:</b> Mark <b>+3 Obligation</b> ; risk binding to the between, never wholly in one state. |

## Playstyle Notes

The Pale Shepherd favors those who steady others at the edge of change. Its gifts open hidden roads, soften endings, and lend courage to cross. Its prices lean toward memory, ease, and the simple warmth of belonging — spent to buy safe passage when it matters most.

**Emphasizes**

- **Liminal Mastery:** reading and walking the in-between
- **Passage Guidance:** anchoring companions through turns of fate
- **Melancholic Wisdom:** counsel drawn from endings
- **Memory Shepherding:** carrying and setting down what weighs
- **Threshold Navigation:** ways through walls the world insists upon

### 12.1.13 The Sealed Gate (Thresholds & Containment)

*Lore.* The Sealed Gate stands where realities meet, embodying the sacred power of thresholds, boundaries, and containment. Its followers are wardens, exorcists, and philosophers of separation who believe some things must be kept apart for the world to function. The Gate manifests as an impassive judge whose shifting sigils—binding runes, exclusion marks, or acceptance glyphs—determine what may cross.

“You define what passes and what remains. Every boundary remembers your judgment.”

#### Domain Focus

- **Thresholds:** Doors, portals, borders between realms
- **Containment:** Wards, bindings, imprisonment of dangerous forces
- **Exclusion:** Banishment, quarantine, protection through separation
- **Permission:** Safe passage, authorized access, controlled crossing

**Rite of the Sealed Threshold (Low, 4 XP)** *Scene; Touch; No Push*

**Materials:** Chalk, iron dust, or sanctified cord.

**Effect:** Mark a doorway or passage as sealed. Unauthorized crossing tests Spirit + Resolve (DV 3) or suffers Position penalty. Creates 4-segment *Ward Integrity* clock.

**Invoke:** 1 action, mark +1 Obligation.

**Push It:** Barrier becomes visible shimmer; +1 Obligation.

**Rite of the Key’s Rebuke (Low, 5 XP)** *Instant; Near; No Push*

**Materials:** Gesture of denial or barrier symbol.

**Effect:** Target must test Body + Resolve (DV 3) or be pushed back from threshold. On success, create *Rebuke Echo* token granting +1 die to next boundary defense.

**Invoke:** 1 action, mark +1 Obligation.

**Rite of the Circle of Denial [WARD] (Standard, 8 XP)** *Scene; Zone; Standard Push*

**Materials:** Salt ring, iron filings, or boundary stones.

**Effect:** Create protective circle. Supernatural beings test against caster’s Spirit + Arcana (DV 4) to cross. Mortals suffer -2 dice to force entry. 6-segment *Circle Integrity* clock.

**Push It:** Circle becomes two-way barrier; +1 Obligation.

**Rite of the Writ of Passage [BIND] (Standard, 7 XP)** *Scene; Zone; Standard Push*

**Materials:** Signed authorization or spoken permissions.

**Effect:** Designate authorized passage route. Allies gain Position +1 when using route. Unauthorized suffer -1 die to movement/stealth. 8-segment *Writ Authority* clock.

**Push It:** Extend authorization to additional allies; +1 Obligation.

**Rite of the Banishment Knot [BANISH] (High, 13 XP)** *Instant; Near; High Push*

**Materials:** Knotted cord sealed with gate-sigil.

**Effect:** Target supernatural entity tests against caster’s Spirit + Resolve (DV = entity Cap). Success forces immediate departure from scene. Failed attempt creates 4-segment *Banishment Backlash* clock.

**Push It:** Banishment lasts until next moon phase; +2 Obligation.

**Obligation:** 7 segments base.

**Rite of the Consecrated Barrier [WARD][UNWARD] (High, 14 XP)** *Extended; Large Zone; High Push*

**Materials:** Relics from three traditions, boundary markers, trespasser's acknowledgement.

**Effect:** Consecrate area against all unauthorized passage. Tests required scale with intrusion attempt severity. 10-segment *Sacred Boundary* clock tracks barrier strength.

**Push It:** Make barrier semi-permanent (lasts 1 season); start *Maintenance* [6] clock.

**Obligation:** 8 segments base.

## The Sealed Gate's Corruption Manifestations

| Level | Benefit                                                                                             | Cost / Quirk                                                                                  |
|-------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1     | <b>Threshold Sense:</b> +1 die to detect weak points, unauthorized passage, or boundary violations. | <b>Paranoid Vigilance:</b> Must repeatedly check seals; -1 die to trust-based actions.        |
| 2     | <b>Ward Resonance:</b> Once per scene, treat failed protection roll as success (mark 1 SB).         | <b>Isolation Tendency:</b> 1 Fatigue in unsecured/open spaces.                                |
| 3     | <b>Boundary Mastery:</b> +2 dice to ward, barrier, or containment magic.                            | <b>Compulsive Sealing:</b> Must secure any vulnerability noticed.                             |
| 4     | <b>Absolute Barrier:</b> Once per session, create impenetrable barrier (1 scene).                   | <b>Prison Mindset:</b> -1 die to freedom/escape actions.                                      |
| 5     | <b>Gate Sovereign:</b> Once per session, banish major threat with single test.                      | <b>Boundary Obsession:</b> -1 die to non-containment actions.                                 |
| 6+    | <b>Threshold Incarnate:</b> Become living barrier (1 scene); all nearby boundaries absolute.        | <b>Ultimate Containment Risk:</b> +3 Obligation; risk permanent Harm from containment burden. |

**Playstyle Notes** The Sealed Gate patron excels in defensive, control-oriented play. Followers shape battlefields through strategic boundary placement and become invaluable when dealing with supernatural intrusions or securing locations. The corruption progression naturally leads characters toward becoming immovable guardians at the cost of flexibility and freedom.

### 12.1.14 The Traveler (Ways & Journeys)

*Lore.* The Traveler is the eternal guide of the road, guardian of those who walk the paths between what is and what might be. Among the Fhara caravans and Kuvani traders along the Way of Silk, the Traveler is invoked at every crossroads, honored with small offerings at each waypoint, and consulted before every major journey.

The Traveler is not merely one who shows the way—they *are* the way, existing in the pause between steps and in the choice of which path to take when roads fork. Every journey is both physical and spiritual; to move from one place to another is to transform, and the road itself becomes a teacher.

One foot in a promise, and the road will meet you halfway. But break your word to the way, and the way will break you.

**Rite of Road-Sense (Low, 4 XP)** *Scene; Self; No. Materials:* Road-nail or waystone pebble. **Effect:** Unerringly pick the fastest safe route in Near/Far. Gain +1 die to avoid ambushes or delays. Create a 4-segment *Path Memory* clock to ignore difficult terrain once.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

**Push It:** Spot one hidden bypass, but generate 1 SB (Clubs).

*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**Rite of the Traveler's Boon (Low, 5 XP)** *Scene; Self/Ally; No. Materials:* Thread tied at the wrist.

**Effect:** Ignore one level of difficult terrain or bureaucracy; +1 Effect to travel or escape checks. If shared, create a 2-segment *Shared Journey* bond with an ally.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

**Push It:** Extend to one more ally; mark 1 SB (Diamonds).

*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**12.1.14.0.1 Rite of the Waymark [PASSAGE] (Standard, 8 XP)** *Scene; Near; No. Materials:* Chalk mark or small cairn.

**Effect:** Declare a lane as permitted/easy. Allies gain improved Position/Effect or ignore one obstacle. Create a 6-segment *Marked Path* clock.

**Push It:** Lane persists between scenes; first enemy to exploit it forces 1 SB (Spades).

*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**12.1.14.0.2 Rite of the Bridge Between [TRANSPORT] (Standard, 7 XP)** *Instant; Near; No. Materials:* Two pinches of road-dust clapped.

**Effect:** Relocate a willing target within Far along a visible/named route. Unwilling targets may resist (Body+Resolve DV 3). Create a 4-segment *Pathway Established* clock.

**Push It:** Carry one extra ally or bundle; arrivals off-balance.

*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**12.1.14.0.3 Rite of the Crown of Crossings [WARD][COMMAND] (High, 13 XP)** *Scene; Zone; No. Materials:* Brass compass missing its needle.

**Effect:** Call the Road: allies gain +1 die to move/evade; pursuers suffer -1 die. Once, declare "the long way is short" to finish a travel clock segment for free. Enemies must test (Wits+Command DV 4) or suffer -1 die to movement.

**Push It:** Seal a hostile route briefly; generate 2 SB (Clubs/Diamonds).

*Requires:* Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: **2 Boons**).

*Obligation:* 7 segments.

**12.1.14.0.4 Rite of the Wayfarer's Covenant** [OATH][FORTIFY] (**High, 14 XP**) *Extended; Near; No. Materials:* Waystones from multiple regions.

**Effect:** Bind present parties to safe passage. While honored: +2 Effect on travel, reroll one failed travel roll per scene. Breaking oath inflicts Harm 1 (Fatigue) and marks breaker as *Oathbreaker of the Road* (−2 dice to travel rolls).

**Push It:** Breaking the covenant inflicts Harm 2 (Stress) and attracts hostile Wayward spirits.

*Requires:* Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: **2 Boons**).

*Obligation:* 7 segments.

## The Traveler's Corruption Table

| Tier | Benefit                                                                                                                                         | Cost / Quirk                                                                                                                              |
|------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Pathfinding Instinct: +1 die to Navigation and movement rolls in familiar territory.                                                            | Restless Spirit: Suffer 1 Fatigue when forced to remain stationary or in confined spaces for extended periods.                            |
| 2    | Wayfarer's Luck: Once per scene, treat a failed travel or navigation roll as a success, but mark 1 SB (Clubs).                                  | Compulsive Wandering: Must take the less obvious path when choices present themselves; suffer -1 die when forced to follow direct routes. |
| 3    | Road Mastery: Gain +2 dice to rolls involving travel, escape, or finding hidden paths.                                                          | Travel Dependency: Suffer -1 die to rolls requiring local knowledge or settlement-based skills.                                           |
| 4    | Journey's Blessing: Once per session, grant all allies within Near range +1 die to travel-related rolls for one scene.                          | Nomad's Isolation: Suffer -1 die to social rolls involving long-term relationships or community ties.                                     |
| 5    | Waypoint Sense: Once per session, instantly know the location and nature of all significant paths, routes, or crossroads within a day's travel. | Directional Obsession: Suffer -1 die to rolls not involving movement, travel, or pathfinding; always aware of cardinal directions.        |

|    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 6+ | Master of All Ways: Once per session, become one with the road network. For one scene, teleport between any known waypoints and grant +2 dice to all travel-related actions, but mark +2 Obligation and risk becoming lost between worlds. | Eternal Journey: Mark +3 Obligation when using this power; risk permanent Harm (Stress) from the endless call of the road, making settlement impossible until the journey's end. |
|----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

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### 12.1.15 Varnek Karn, the Death's Negotiator (Bargains with the Departed)

*Lore.* Varnek Karn dwells in the grey between life and death, where the newly departed linger with unfinished business and elder shades guard secrets dearer than gold. He is the broker who speaks across the veil, the mediator of disputes between living and dead, and the archivist of every promise sworn beyond the grave. His servants practice post-mortem diplomacy: they negotiate, consult, and contract with spirits as equals—mindful that the dead are patient and rarely generous.

“The dead have all the time in the world to consider their offers, and no need to rush to agreement. They know what the living forgot, and remember every slight with perfect clarity. In Varnek’s halls, both parties pay a price—but the currency is never what you expect.”

#### Domain Focus

- **Post-Mortem Diplomacy:** parleys with ghosts and recent dead
- **Ancestral Wisdom:** counsel from forebears and keeping of funerary law
- **Unfinished Business:** resolving the concerns that bind spirits
- **Death-Bound Contracts:** obligations that outlive the flesh

**Rite of the Crossing Fee (Low, 4 XP)** *Scene; Near; No.*

**Materials:** A coin for the tongue of the deceased, or a lock of hair from the bereaved.

**Effect:** Open speech with a specific dead individual. Gain +1 die to *Investigation* or *Lore* when seeking knowledge they once held.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

**Rite of the Ancestral Consultation (Low, 5 XP)** *Scene; Self; Yes.*

**Materials:** A personal token of the departed, or their favored food/drink.

**Effect:** Ask one question of an ancestral spirit regarding family history, hidden legacies, or inherited debts.

**Push It:** The spirit grants detailed, prophetic guidance but exacts a small favor; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)**.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

**Rite of the Death-Bound Pact (Standard, 8 XP)** *Scene; Near; Yes.*

**Materials:** Two copies of a written accord—one buried with the dead, one kept by the living.

**Effect:** Bind a compact between a living signatory and a willing spirit. Both gain +1 die when fulfilling the terms. Breach angers the spirit and Varnek both.

**Push It:** The pact enforces itself: a breach triggers supernatural reprisal; mark +1 **Obligation**.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

**Rite of the Spirit Medium (Standard, 7 XP)** *Scene; Zone; Yes.*

**Materials:** A circle of salt mixed with grave-dust; a candle of funeral wax.

**Effect:** Serve as conduit for several spirits to speak. Gain +2 dice to mediate disputes between living and dead and to facilitate group negotiation.

**Push It:** A potent spirit rides your voice to speak directly; mark **Exposure +1**.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

**Rite of the Final Testament (High, 13 XP)** *Extended; Touch; Yes.*

**Materials:** A dying person's last words recorded in their blood, witnessed by you.

**Effect:** Seal the last request with weight beyond life. Targets must pass *Resolve* (DV 4) to ignore it.

**Push It:** The testament becomes a geas: only fulfillment—or Varnek's wrath—can break it; mark **+2 Obligation**.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 7 segments.

**Rite of the Eternal Archive (High, 14 XP)** *Extended; Zone; Yes.*

**Materials:** A library mortared with tomb-stone, ink from cremation ash.

**Effect:** Found a repository where the dead deposit knowledge. Gain a permanent +1 die to *Lore* for historical or genealogical research made within. Spirits periodically contribute testimonies.

**Push It:** The archive awakens and begins to demand curatorship and payment; mark **Harm 1 (Stress)**.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 8 segments.

### Varnek Karn's Corruption Table

| Tier | Benefit                                                                                             | Cost / Quirk                                                                                               |
|------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | <b>Death's Whisper:</b> +1 die to <i>Notice</i> when the dead seek to communicate.                  | <b>Graveyard Pallor:</b> −1 die to social rolls with the living; your presence unsettles.                  |
| 2    | <b>Ancestral Insight:</b> Once/scene, gain +2 dice for family history or inherited troubles.        | <b>Spectral Awareness:</b> Ever-aware of nearby spirits; suffer <b>Fatigue 1</b> in places of many deaths. |
| 3    | <b>Medium's Gift:</b> Once/session, act as a flawless conduit for a spirit.                         | <b>Death-Touched:</b> Cold spots and small portents follow you; −1 die to ordinary social grace.           |
| 4    | <b>Final Authority:</b> Once/scene, compel adherence to a true last request ( <i>Resolve</i> DV 4). | <b>Corpse-Pale:</b> Visibly wan; −2 dice where warmth or vigor is required.                                |
| 5    | <b>Archive Keeper:</b> Once/session, access perfect recall of a historical event or family secret.  | <b>Unquiet Presence:</b> The dead trail you; −1 die to stealth and to surprising the living.               |
| 6+   | <b>Death's Confidant:</b> Once/session, negotiate with puissant death-entities as an equal.         | <b>Halfway House:</b> Mark <b>+2 Obligation</b> ; risk becoming half-withdrawn from the living world.      |

### Playstyle Notes

Varnek Karn favors investigators, arbiters, and heralds of funerary law. Power grows through cultural sensitivity, shrewd bargaining, and careful record-keeping; the price is a thinning tie to warmth and mortal ease. Expect mysteries of lineage, obligations that outlive their makers, and parleys where both sides of the veil demand their due.

Varnek Karn emphasizes

- **Diplomacy over Dominion:** bargaining with the dead rather than commanding them
- **Knowledge Brokerage:** trading for secrets and testimonies beyond the grave
- **Cultural Protocols:** rites, tokens, and proper doors for speaking with ancestors
- **Mediation:** resolving conflicts that bind the living to the dead
- **Historical Continuity:** showing how past vows shape the present

### 12.1.16 The Witness (Truth & Revelation)

*Lore.* The Witness remembers what others bury. Every shadow cast and oath broken is a line in her unending ledger. She is the keeper of inconvenient truths, the patron of those who seek to expose lies or recover forgotten knowledge. Her followers learn that knowledge comes with a price—the weight of remembering what others would forget.

I will show you what you would rather forget. But first, you must forget what you think you know.

**Rite of the Lingering Glimpse (Low, 4 XP)** *Instant; Near; Yes (Investigation/Notice only).*

**Materials:** A trace of the thing to be remembered (hair, dust, a spoken name).

**Effect:** Gain +1 die to your roll to investigate or notice something directly related to the trace within the current scene.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

**Push It:** Gain +2 dice instead, but mark 1 segment on a **Memory Strain Clock** [4]. If the clock fills, you gain Fatigue 1 and suffer -1 die on Investigation/Notice rolls until the end of the next scene due to mental exhaustion from forced recall.

*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**Rite of Piercing Scrutiny (Low, 5 XP)** *Scene; Zone; No.* **Materials:** A circle drawn with chalk or string while focusing on the truth to be sought.

**Effect:** Within the zone, gain +1 die to rolls to detect deception (Insight vs. Deceit, spotting social tells) or to recall hidden knowledge (Lore/Investigate for memory). Social interactions within the zone begin one Position step worse for those attempting to deceive.

**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

**Push It:** One target within the zone must make a Wits test (DV 3) or involuntarily reveal one pertinent lie or hidden fact they are currently concealing (Keeper determines relevance). Regardless of the test result, mark Exposure +1 for the target(s) in the zone.

*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**12.1.16.0.1 Rite of the Echoing Truth [OMEN] (Standard, 8 XP)** *Instant; Near; No.*

**Materials:** A reflective surface (mirror, still water, polished metal) used to focus on the target.

**Effect:** Target must make a Resolve test (DV 3) or suffer -1 die to rolls involving memory, deception, or resisting interrogation for the scene. If they fail, you may ask one specific, factual question about something they know, and they must answer truthfully or suffer 1 SB (Hearts) as the memory is forcibly drawn forth.

**Push It:** If the target fails their Resolve test, you may ask a second question, but the mental intrusion causes them Harm 1 (Stress/Mental).

*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**12.1.16.0.2 Rite of the Immutable Record [OATH] (Standard, 7 XP)** *Scene; Near; No.*

**Materials:** A document signed by all parties within the zone, or a spoken pact witnessed by the caster.

**Effect:** Bind the agreement. Any party who knowingly breaches it suffers 1 SB (Hearts) immediately and gains a persistent **Oathbreaker's Mark** Condition (-1 die on social rolls involving honor, trust, or oaths until amends are made or a significant act redeems them).

**Push It:** The bond becomes magically enforced for one specific, crucial clause: violation automatically inflicts Harm 1 (Stress) on the breaker in addition to the SB and Mark.

*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

**12.1.16.0.3 Rite of the Unveiled Heart [OMEN] (High, 12 XP)** *Scene; Near; No. Materials:* A private setting where the target feels safe or is speaking freely.

**Effect:** The target suffers -2 dice to all attempts to conceal true emotions, intentions, or lies for the scene. Any successful social roll (Sway, Command, Deceit) made by the target generates 1 SB (Hearts) as the effort to maintain falsehoods under the Witness's gaze creates internal discord.

**Push It:** You may designate one specific, complex question about the target's motivations, fears, or hidden loyalties. If you successfully use Sway or Insight against them this scene, you automatically learn the answer to that question. The intense scrutiny marks 1 SB (Spades) for you as the Witness's attention lingers.

*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).*

*Obligation:* 6 segments.

**12.1.16.0.4 Rite of the Final Reckoning [OMEN] (High, 13 XP)** *Scene; Zone; No. Materials:* A formally called gathering (court, council, family meeting) within the consecrated zone.

**Effect:** All present must speak their greatest debt, wrongdoing, or hidden truth related to the gathering's purpose. Those who lie or withhold suffer Harm 2 (Stress/Reputation). Truth-tellers gain +2 dice to social actions for the remainder of the scene within the zone.

**Push It:** The truth becomes inescapable - even indirect lies or evasions related to the core topic suffer the Harm 2 penalty. The absolute nature of the revelation creates 2 SB (Diamonds) as the disruption to fates and secrets resonates.

*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).*

*Obligation:* 7 segments.

## The Witness's Corruption Table

| Tier | Benefit                                                                                                        | Cost / Quirk                                                                                                                         |
|------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Truth's Sight: +1 die to Insight when detecting deception or hidden motives.                                   | Burden of Knowledge: Suffer -1 die to social rolls involving lies or deception; others become uncomfortable with your piercing gaze. |
| 2    | Memory's Keeper: Once per scene, recall one specific detail from a previous scene with perfect clarity.        | Compulsive Honesty: Must correct obvious falsehoods witnessed, even when tactically disadvantageous.                                 |
| 3    | Revelation's Power: Gain +2 dice to rolls involving exposing secrets, uncovering lies, or forcing confessions. | Truth-Blind: Suffer 1 Fatigue when exposed to comforting lies or willful ignorance.                                                  |

|    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                                                                |
|----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 4  | Witness's Authority: Once per session, force one target to make a Resolve test (DV 4) or reveal a significant hidden truth.                                                                                                                            | Isolation: Suffer -1 die to rolls requiring trust or close relationships; others fear your ability to uncover their secrets.                                   |
| 5  | Omniscient Gaze: Once per session, see through all deceptions and lies for one exchange, gaining +3 dice to related actions.                                                                                                                           | Paranoia: Suffer -1 die to rolls involving personal peace or rest; the weight of all truths witnessed creates constant mental strain.                          |
| 6+ | Absolute Witness: Once per session, become the living embodiment of truth. For one scene, all deceptions within Near range automatically fail, but mark +2 Obligation and risk permanent Harm (Stress) from the crushing weight of absolute knowledge. | Truth's Prison: Mark +3 Obligation when using this power; become unable to tolerate any form of deception, making normal social interaction nearly impossible. |

**12.1.16.0.5 No True Acolyte** Interpreting a patron’s will is often a dangerous prospect in and of itself. Many a Runekeeper has found themselves on the opposite end of machinations from others from the same patron.

**Runebound Resilience (18 XP Epic Talent)** *Prerequisite: Tier III+, Codex, Spirit 4+*

You have learned to transform the very essence of harm into deeper communion with your Patron.

- **Harm Conversion:** Once per round, you may convert up to 2 Harm levels to +2 Obligation instead of taking the damage
- **Obligation Endurance:** While at 6+ Obligation segments, gain +1 die to all Rite invocations
- **Patron’s Shield:** When reduced to Harm 3, you may immediately Invoke any known Rite without marking additional Obligation
- **Debt Fortification:** At 8+ Obligation segments, ignore first Harm 1 each round
- **Once per scene**

**Narrative Integration:**

*“Your flesh has become a ledger, and every wound is a prayer. The deeper your Patron’s claim, the stronger your resistance to mortal frailty.”*

**Patron’s Favored (18 XP Prestige Talent)** *Prerequisite: Tier III+, Codex, Familiar, 8+ total Obligation segments*

Your Patron has marked you as specially favored, granting you unprecedented access to their power with reduced cost.

- **Low Rite Discount:** Reduce Obligation cost for Low Rites by 1 (minimum 0)
- **Empower:** Once per scene, spend 1 Action + 1 Boons:
  - Target gains +1 Corruption level per round for 3 rounds. Corruption lasts until the end of the scene.
  - While empowered, gain +1 die to all rolls
- **Empower Push:** Spend 1 Action + 1 Boon + 3 Obligation:
  - Target(s) gains +3 Corruption levels until end of scene
  - While empowered, gain +1 die to all rolls
  - Target gains +Corruption fatigue at the end of the scene.
- **Enhanced Gift:** Your **Patron’s Gift** now provides +2 dice instead of +1
- **Debt Bound:** Cannot Empower again until all Obligation is cleared

**Narrative Integration:** *The Patron’s favor comes with a price—but for the truly devoted, that price is worth the power. You carry their blessing openly now, and their influence spreads like wildfire to those who would walk in your shadow.*

“Every Rune is a promise. Every line a covenant. Do not mistake the Runekeeper’s silence for weakness; their memory is the foundation of our craft.”

## 12.1.17 The Invokers

**Invokers** are those who dare. Neither archivists nor worshippers, they are travelers on the knife-edge between story and ruin. An Invoker learns the Rites of a Patron, weaves them into their own Art, and bends fate for a moment. Yet invocation is not command: it is negotiation. The Patron always leaves its mark. The stronger the Rite, the deeper the scar.

Invokers are often wanderers, exiles, or seekers. To common folk they are feared—witches, oath-breakers, meddlers with things not meant for mortal hands. But when the village falls to plague, when the sea closes its roads, when the dead refuse their rest, it is an Invoker who is called upon.

### 12.1.18 Closing Words

The dance between Patron, Runekeeper, and Invoker is a triangle of peril and necessity. Without Patrons, there is no power. Without Runekeepers, no record. Without Invokers, no action. Together, they shape the crooked, perilous art we call Invocation.

## 12.2 Patrons & Rites

| Cost Component              | Effect                                                  |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| +1 SB                       | Escalate effect immediately                             |
| +1 Fatigue                  | Immediate physical/mental strain                        |
| +1 Corruption Clock Segment | Long-term Patron influence (unless otherwise specified) |
| GM spends 1 SB              | Thematic complication (unless otherwise specified)      |

Note: Some talents, Rites, or magical paths may specify alternative corruption costs or additional consequences for *Push It* actions. When explicitly stated, those specific rules override the universal costs.

**12.2.0.0.1 Clearing Corruption** Corruption may be reduced through *purging rituals*, such as exorcisms, sacred songs, or rites of contrition. These require a test (typically **Lore + Spirit**) against a DV equal to the character's current corruption level. On success, reduce corruption by 1. On failure, the corruption manifests violently, imposing a temporary Condition or advancing its narrative expression.

Optional: A **Story Beat** may also be spent to attempt such a ritual, representing the personal cost of atonement. Patrons may demand specific acts of service, sacrifice, or obligation as part of the purging process.

### Patron's Gift and Borrowed Grace: XP Free, Sustainable Magic Enhancement

#### Patron's Gift (Runekeeper Talent)

##### Patron's Gift – Daily Magical Enhancement

**Cost:** Free (requires Thiasos/Familiar representing the bond to a Patron)

**Activation:** 1 Action, once per scene

**Effect:** Gain +1 die to one skill check related to your Patron's domain and +1 Melee or Ranged.

**Requirements:** Must be thematically appropriate to Patron's domain.

**Limitations:** Cannot stack with other magical effects and is subject to talent stacking rules. The enchanted item can only be used by the Runekeeper.

**Cost:** Generates 1 Story Beat (Diamonds - magical/spiritual disturbance).

#### Key Tips for Effective Patron's Gift Usage



- **Daily Reliability:** Use for routine tasks that benefit from minor magical assistance.
- **Domain Focus:** Choose applications that align strongly with your Patron’s themes.
- **Narrative Integration:** Let the Story Beat cost inform interesting complications.
- **Complementary Use:** Fill gaps where full Rites would be excessive.

### Borrowed Grace

**Borrowed Grace** is a minor imbuelement through which an Invoker momentarily channels their Patron’s favor into a single decisive action.

**Type:** Invoker Talent — Lesser Imbuelement

**Cost:** 1 Boon *or* 1 Fatigue; 1 Action

**Duration:** One action

**Requirement:** The Invoker must visibly display the symbol of their Patron.

### Effect:

- Gain **+1 die** to a single combat action, *or*
- Gain **+1 Effect** to a single social or stealth action.

### Limitations:

- Borrowed Grace may be used **once per scene**.
- The effect cannot be stacked, extended, or shared.
- If the Patron’s symbol is *Compromised*, Borrowed Grace may still be invoked at **−1 die**.

### Power Level Guidance

These tools are designed to provide a **+1 die reliable enhancement** without the overhead of full Rite/Spell casting. They should feel like:

- Consistent character enhancement rather than dramatic power spikes.
- Reliable support rather than game-changing effects.
- Sustainable advantages rather than resource-intensive solutions.

When used properly, **Patron’s Gift** and **Borrowed Grace** eliminate the “resource management tax” that can make magical characters feel less effective than their non-magical counterparts, while maintaining the thematic richness that makes magical characters special.

| Patron                               | Thematic Skill | Gift / Lore Bestowal                                                                            |
|--------------------------------------|----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                      | (+1)           |                                                                                                 |
| Carrion King (Carrion, Renewal)      | Survival       | <i>Grants the feast of decay, where what is dead becomes seed for what yet lives.</i>           |
| Clockwork Monad (Mechanism, Process) | Tinker         | <i>Grants the certainty of repetition: a cycle that never falters, a gear that never slips.</i> |
| Gallows Bell (Doom, Last Rites)      | Command        | <i>Grants the toll of ending, a voice that closes stories and calls all debts due.</i>          |
| <i>Continued on next page</i>        |                |                                                                                                 |

| Patron                                      | Thematic Skill | Gift / Lore Bestowal                                                                                      |
|---------------------------------------------|----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| (+1)                                        |                |                                                                                                           |
| Grimmir (Wild Speaker)                      | Survival       | <i>Grants the wisdom of root and stone, speaking the tongues of leaf and fang.</i>                        |
| Ikasha (Shadow, Penumbra)                   | Stealth        | <i>Grants the hush between footsteps and the raven's omen at every threshold.</i>                         |
| Inaea (Mercy, Hearth)                       | Persuade       | <i>Grants the hearth's warmth—shelter for the weary and mercy for the lost.</i>                           |
| Inquisitor Prime (Purity, Persecution)      | Insight        | <i>Grants the hunter's sight, piercing illusion and revealing supernatural corruption.</i>                |
| Isoka (Serpents, Shedding)                  | Skirmish       | <i>Grants the serpent's coil: strength in sudden strike and wisdom in renewal.</i>                        |
| Khemesh (Abyss, Pressure)                   | Skirmish       | <i>Grants the crushing silence of the deep, where strength drowns beneath weight.</i>                     |
| Oath of Flame & Light (Dawn, Vows)          | Command        | <i>Grants the fire of dawn, a vow that shields the faithful and sears the faithless.</i>                  |
| Pale Shepherd (Thresholds, Guidance)        | Stealth        | <i>Grants the shepherd's whisper, guiding the living through liminal spaces and comforting the dying.</i> |
| Sealed Gate (Boundaries, Closure)           | Tinker         | <i>Grants mastery of thresholds—doors that yield or bar at your command.</i>                              |
| The Traveler (Ways, Roads)                  | Notice         | <i>Grants the open way, a restless compass and roads where none were marked.</i>                          |
| Varnek Karn (Ossuary, Dominion of the Dead) | Command        | <i>Grants the silence of the archive, where the dead obey and records speak.</i>                          |
| The Witness (Truth, Revelation)             | Notice         | <i>Grants the unblinking gaze that unmasks deceit and remembers every oath.</i>                           |

## Patron Rivalries

Detailed rivalries between Patrons are covered in the **Game Master's Guide**. For player reference, note that serving one Patron may attract the attention of its enemies; your GM will inform you when such tensions arise.

## 12.3 Rites Difficulty Value

The Difficulty Value (DV) to cast a Rite is:

$$DV = \max(\text{ObligationCost} - \text{Spirit}, \text{Tieroftherite}(\text{Low1}, \text{Standard2}, \text{High3}))$$

## 12.4 Obligation Overflow (Rites)

When **Obligation** is ticked past its maximum (from Rites, vows, bargains), mark **Fatigue** based on scene severity:

- **Low:** +1 Fatigue
- **Standard:** +2 Fatigue
- **High:** +3 Fatigue

If this *fills* the Fatigue Track, apply the **Fatigue** → **Harm** conversion (see §2.10).

## 12.5 Clearing Obligation Segments (Extended)

Obligation measures the growing narrative weight of a Patron's attention. It is not debt in a transactional sense, but rather the sense that a Patron has invested, noticed, and expects relevance. This section expands the SRD guidance with philosophy, examples, and optional rules.

### 12.5.1 Core Principle

Obligation is cleared through **meaningful engagement** with the Patron. The system assumes Patrons are narrative entities: they do not care about coin, but about resonance. Clearing requires a demonstration that the character is still walking their path.

### 12.5.2 Off-Screen Clearing (Primary Method)

- **Act of Service.** Clear 1 segment by performing a resonant service aligned to the Patron's themes or goals.
- **Requirement.** The player must provide an *Intricate Description* of the act—detail, symbolism, and impact.
- **Scope.** The act need not be arduous, but it must be thematically precise (e.g., weaving a shadow tapestry for Ikasha; negotiating a shrewd pact for the Clockwork Monad).
- **Reward.** Successful clearing often comes with narrative color: whispers of approval, subtle omens, or a temporary advantage in Patron-facing scenes.

### 12.5.3 On-Screen Clearing (Optional Mechanic)

**12.5.3.0.1 Talent: Focused Devotion (3–5 XP).** Once per scene, spend 1 Boon to clear 1 segment of Obligation from a Patron. This cannot remove segments accrued during the same scene. It represents a desperate or ritualized gesture to stave off attention without fully satisfying it.

### 12.5.4 Narrative Implications

1. **Player Agency.** The player defines how service manifests, reinforcing creativity within the Patron's thematic frame.
2. **GM Collaboration.** The GM adjudicates sufficiency: Is the service aligned? Is it intricate enough?
3. **Ongoing Relationship.** Clearing segments emphasizes that the Patron bond is active, not static. The relationship evolves with acts of recognition.
4. **Scene Economy.** The cap on on-screen clearing ensures the mechanic cannot erase costs just accrued. It forces the long view.

## 12.5.5 Worked Examples

**12.5.5.0.1 Example 1: Ikasha, Angel of Serpents.** A character clears a segment by shedding their old cloak, burning it, and narrating how it symbolizes leaving behind a former self. The GM rules it sufficient, noting the subtle scent of scales in the air.

**12.5.5.0.2 Example 2: Clockwork Monad.** The player narrates spending an hour meticulously recalibrating a piece of equipment, using precise measurements and ritual cleaning. The GM agrees: the service is thematically aligned and clears 1 segment.

**12.5.5.0.3 Example 3: Oath of Flame & Light.** The group holds a dawn vigil, speaking aloud a vow they have kept. The intricate description convinces the GM, who clears 1 segment from each participant's Obligation to that Patron.

## 12.5.6 Optional Modules

**12.5.6.0.1 Overflow Consequences.** When Obligation fills and overflows, the Patron demands immediate service. This may be delivered as a Complication Point (or Story Beat) trigger: the Patron intrudes, offering aid with a binding cost.

**12.5.6.0.2 Segment Scaling.** Particularly devoted characters may require greater services: clear 2 segments with a dramatic act (pilgrimage, sacrifice, or political maneuver), subject to GM approval.

**12.5.6.0.3 Shared Obligation.** In multi-character bonds, the GM may allow a group act of service to clear multiple segments, but only if each player contributes to the Intricate Description.

## 12.5.7 GM Guidance

- **Be Generous with Hooks.** Reward creativity with flavorful omens, not just a cleared box.
- **Maintain Tension.** Do not allow trivial or repetitive services to count. Require new symbolic angles each time.
- **Keep On-Screen Costly.** Remind players that Focused Devotion costs a Boon and cannot erase fresh debt.
- **Tie to Patron Themes.** If a service drifts off-theme, let it fail or only partially clear.

### Summary

Obligation is cleared through **thematic service, intricate description, and narrative engagement**. Off-screen acts remain the primary path; on-screen clearing is a costly safety valve. Treat every act as a chance to show how characters evolve under their Patron's gaze.

## 12.6 Acts of Service — Examples

Patrons delight in resonance, not labor. Use these examples as prompts—*petty* butterflies and *involved* operations both count when on-theme. Each entry lists a scale suggestion and what it might clear.

## GM Notes

- **Novelty Over Volume.** Repeating the same petty act does not keep clearing segments; vary the symbol or site.
- **Precision Beats Difficulty.** A sharp thematic hit at “petty” scale can clear 1 segment as surely as a muddled “modest.”
- **Hook the World.** Many of these acts conveniently create future clocks, NPC ties, or bargains—use them.
- **Patron’s Largess** A Patron’s will is mysterious, but their displeasure is rarely subtle. For narrative reasons, the GM may rule that a Patron is especially offended—perhaps by a neglected omen, a rival gaining favor, or simple caprice—and exact an additional toll beyond the usual cost.

## 12.7 Patron Fear Influence Table

The following table summarizes how each of the Player’s Guide patrons modifies fear effects. (For patrons not listed, use the standard fear rules in the SRD.)

| Patron          | Domain Tags                        | Influence Type | Fear Effect Modifications                                                                                                                        |
|-----------------|------------------------------------|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Carrion King    | Decay, Feast, Scavenging           | Reroll         | Fear tagged <i>Decay</i> , <i>Hunger</i> , <i>Feast</i> mutates. On 1 (Fight), frenzy devolves into cannibalistic hunger.                        |
| Clockwork Monad | Order, Repetition, Mechanism       | Amplify        | Fear tagged <i>Order</i> , <i>Pattern</i> , <i>Repetition</i> becomes mechanistic horror. On 3 (Freeze), victim is trapped in endless loop.      |
| Gallows Bell    | Doom, Last Rites                   | Resonance      | Fear tagged <i>Ending</i> , <i>Toll</i> , <i>Justice</i> deepens. On 2 (Hide), victim hears the bell toll and accepts inevitable demise.         |
| Grimmir         | Seasons, Verdict, Threshold        | Reroll         | Fear tagged <i>Wild</i> , <i>Nature</i> , <i>Season</i> becomes primal dread. On 6 (Submit), victim freezes as if rooted.                        |
| Ikasha          | Shadow, Whispers, Latent Potential | Amplify        | Fear tagged <i>Shadow</i> , <i>Voice</i> , <i>Hidden</i> deepens. On 3 (Freeze), victim may be paralyzed by whispered secrets.                   |
| Inaea           | Mercy, Hearth, Connection          | Reroll         | Fear tagged <i>Home</i> , <i>Family</i> , <i>Comfort</i> twists to terror of loss. On 4 (Flee), victim abandons loved ones “for their own good.” |

Continued on next page

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| Patron                | Domain Tags                 | Influence Type | Fear Effect Modifications                                                                                                                                    |
|-----------------------|-----------------------------|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Inquisitor Prime      | Purity, Zeal, Persecution   | Amplify        | Fear tagged <i>Purity</i> , <i>Heresy</i> , <i>Persecution</i> turns fanatical. On 1 (Fight), victim attempts self-destructive martyrdom.                    |
| Isoka                 | Serpents, Shedding, Venom   | Reroll         | Fear tagged <i>Change</i> , <i>Identity</i> , <i>Poison</i> becomes existential. On 5 (Hide), victim sheds their face and cannot be recognised.              |
| Khemesh               | Abyss, Pressure, Depths     | Amplify        | Fear tagged <i>Depth</i> , <i>Pressure</i> , <i>Dark</i> crushes. On 1 (Fight), victim dives berserk into consuming dark.                                    |
| Oath of Flame & Light | Dawn, Vows, Purity          | Resonance      | Fear tagged <i>Light</i> , <i>Sacred</i> , <i>Vow</i> also imposes Fatigue. Iconic light turns terror into bodily strain.                                    |
| Pale Shepherd         | Thresholds, Souls, Passing  | Reroll         | Fear tagged <i>Death</i> , <i>Guidance</i> , <i>Soul</i> becomes existential. On 6 (Submit), victim follows willingly into afterlife path.                   |
| Sealed Gate           | Boundaries, Closure         | Amplify        | Fear tagged <i>Confinement</i> , <i>Threshold</i> , <i>Trapped</i> worsens. On 4 (Flee), victim may injure themselves clawing at sealed barriers.            |
| The Traveler          | Ways, Journeys, Crossroads  | Resonance      | Fear tagged <i>Lost</i> , <i>Path</i> , <i>Journey</i> also inflicts Complication Points. Terror of losing the way becomes mechanical hindrance.             |
| Varnek Karn           | Necromantic Archives, Death | Amplify        | Fear tagged <i>Death</i> , <i>Undead</i> , <i>Necromancy</i> becomes horrific. On 2 (Hide), victim feigns death among corpses.                               |
| The Witness           | Truth, Revelation           | Amplify        | Fear tagged <i>Truth</i> , <i>Knowledge</i> , <i>Revelation</i> intensifies. On 6 (Submit), target may confess dark secrets under perceived Iconic judgment. |

## 12.7.1 Implementation Guidelines

### 12.7.1.1 Tag Matching

When a Fear effect is triggered, compare the effect's Magic Tags against the active Patron's Domain Tags. If any tags match, the Patron's influence applies.

### 12.7.1.2 Multiple Patrons

If multiple Patrons are present with overlapping domains, the GM may:

- Choose the most thematically appropriate influence
- Apply influences sequentially (reroll then amplify)
- Allow players to choose which influence affects them

### 12.7.1.3 Player Agency

Players should be informed when Patron influence is active and given the opportunity to:

- Spend resources (Boons, Willpower) to resist the influence
- Narrate how their character resists or embraces the effect
- Choose from available influence options when multiple apply

## 12.7.2 Embracing Corruption

A character with **2+ levels of Corruption** may choose to **Embrace** it, transforming creeping decay into a permanent **Talent**. Embracing never reduces Corruption — it reshapes it. The deeper the corruption, the greater the power and the cost.

| Corruption Level | Talent Tier         | Cost                                           |
|------------------|---------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| 2 (Early)        | Minor Talent        | +1 Permanent Corruption (cannot Fade below 1)  |
| 3 (Deepening)    | Major Talent        | +2 Permanent Corruption, constant visible tell |
| 4+ (Severe)      | Transcendent Talent | Permanently altered, locked at Stage 3+        |

Embraced Talents always reflect the Patron's themes (e.g., shadow, indulgence, empathy, paranoia). They grant great power, but mark the character irrevocably as claimed.

# Chapter 13

## Character Backgrounds

### From the journal of a Thepyrgosi Witch Hunter

They call it mercy when the Tower does it and cruelty when I do. The difference is a seal of wax and a hymn at the gate.

I was a bright spark once—could taste iron on my tongue when the air went thin before a working. The masters in Thepyrgos tested me, weighed me, and found me *nearly* enough. “Nearly” is a door that never opens again.

So I learned the other doors.

I keep a ledger: names, places, the hour the lamps guttered in a tenement, the way the brick sweats when a child hums without meaning to. I carry writs that make people look away. I carry cord and a promise I do not speak aloud. The University pays for talent delivered in time; the city pays for fires that never start. Between those accounts, I balance what I can.

You will say I go too far. Sometimes I do. Sometimes the street is a tinderbox and a wrong whisper is a spark. Sometimes a family would rather believe in saints than in ash. I give them a story they can live with and take away the one that might kill them.

When the bells of Thepyrgos answer the river wind, I walk the colonnade to the bursar’s door and do not look at the windows. The work is ugly. The work is necessary. The night does not care which of those is true—only that the lamps keep burning.

Before your character took their first deliberate risk, they belonged somewhere. Backgrounds are the trail-dust on your boots, the school-ink on your fingers, the bell-pattern you still tap when frightened. They explain how you know what you know—and who still knows *you*.

### 13.1 Understanding Backgrounds

Backgrounds serve several important functions:

- Provide narrative context for abilities and choices
- Explain how you gained skills, languages (see Chapter ?? in the full rules), and connections
- Create ties to regions and factions (§11)
- Offer roleplaying hooks, responsibilities, and privileges
- Seed reliable *contacts*, *customs*, and *places* that matter on-screen



**13.1.0.0.1 Mechanical Hooks.** Choose **one background** at character creation. It grants:

- **Access Tags** (narrative permissions; see below)
- **A Signature Contact** (named NPC; usually a Cap 1 follower you *do not* pay XP for; they cannot take independent actions (see §8.5), but can grant +1d *once per scene* when their help is plausible)
- **A Background Boon** (once per session, gain a +1d or reduce DV by 1 for a task strongly tied to the background's sphere)
- **An Obligation Clock** (4 segments; when filled, it creates a *call-in* from that world—a favor owed, a duty recalled, a price to pay; see §13.9)

**13.1.0.0.2 Access Tags.** Tags describe *where* and *with whom* you have standing. Examples: *Guild-Ledgered*, *Court-Announced*, *Veteran-of-the-Marches*, *Bell-Kin of the Causeways*, *Wind-Rider's Tokens*, *Charter-Stamped*. When a scene engages a tag, the GM may:

- Waive a trivial gate (no roll) or
- Lower Position risk by one step for first contact or
- Offer a *Devil's Bargain* tied to that society's expectations

#### Backgrounds and the Legacy Engine

Your **Signature Contact** is a loyal NPC (Cap1). Over time, you can upgrade them to a full Follower (pay Cap<sup>2</sup> XP). Such a follower is an ideal candidate for **succession** (see 14). When your character retires, falls, or ascends, this contact can inherit your faction standing, one unresolved burden, and a Legacy Bond. Choose a contact you would trust to carry your story forward.

## 13.2 Common Background Categories

### Social Class Backgrounds

#### 13.2.0.0.1 Aristocratic House Scion

- **Access Tags:** *Court-Announced*, *Heraldic Right*
- **Skills:** Sway, Command, Lore (customs)
- **Signature Contact:** Family steward (Cap 1)
- **Background Boon:** Once/session in a formal setting, treat Social Position as one step better for an exchange.
- **Obligation Seeds:** Marriage alliances, estate audits, house feuds
- **Challenges:** Intrigue clocks, reputation stakes

#### 13.2.0.0.2 Merchant Factor

- **Access Tags:** *Guild-Ledgered*, *Caravan Rights*
- **Skills:** Sway (negotiation), Investigation (accounts), Lore (markets)
- **Signature Contact:** Bookkeeper or quartermaster (Cap 1)
- **Background Boon:** Once/session when buying/selling or logistics, reduce DV by 1 or gain +1d.
- **Obligation Seeds:** Notes due, partner demands, embargoes

### 13.2.0.0.3 Common Folk

- **Access Tags:** *Neighborhood Trust, Guild-Friend*
- **Skills:** Craft (one), Endurance, Streetwise or Nature
- **Signature Contact:** Elder, foreman, or midwife (Cap 1)
- **Background Boon:** Once/session among familiar folk, convert a failure on routine labor to a success-with-cost.
- **Obligation Seeds:** Communal favors, festival work, mutual aid

## Professional Backgrounds

### 13.2.0.0.4 Marcher Veteran

- **Access Tags:** *Veteran-of-the-Marches, Muster Papers*
- **Skills:** Melee or Ranged, Tactics, Endurance
- **Signature Contact:** Old sergeant (Cap 1)
- **Background Boon:** Once/session in organized violence, ignore the first point of situational Disadvantage from confusion or fear.
- **Obligation Seeds:** Recall to colors, feud legacies, back-pay claims

### 13.2.0.0.5 Academic of the Dialogues

- **Access Tags:** *School-Sealed, Reading Privileges*
- **Skills:** Lore, Investigation, Sway (debate)
- **Signature Contact:** Lecturer or archivist (Cap 1)
- **Background Boon:** Once/session in research or disputation, ask one clarifying question the GM must answer plainly or point to the shelf that does.
- **Obligation Seeds:** Citations owed, controversial thesis, patron politics

### 13.2.0.0.6 Underworld Hand

- **Access Tags:** *Harbor Handsigns, Black Banner Cant*
- **Skills:** Stealth, Deception, Streetwise
- **Signature Contact:** Fence or fixer (Cap 1)
- **Background Boon:** Once/session when using a *cant* (secret coded speech), gain +1d to set up or slip out.
- **Obligation Seeds:** Unpaid favors, heat with a rival crew, burned safehouse

## Regional Backgrounds

### 13.2.0.0.7 Urban Child of Silkstrand

- **Access Tags:** *Street-Stall Rights, Night-Patrol Familiar*
- **Skills:** Streetwise, Perception, Sway (fast talk)
- **Signature Contact:** Watch-lantern or stall-keeper (Cap 1)
- **Background Boon:** Once/session in a dense city, you know a *shortcut or rumor* that reduces time/cost by one step.

### 13.2.0.0.8 Rural Valewood Forager

- **Access Tags:** *Green Courts Token, River-Ferry Nod*
- **Skills:** Nature, Survival, Lore (spirits)
- **Signature Contact:** Leaf-warden (Cap 1)
- **Background Boon:** Once/session in the wild, downgrade a Travel complication by one step.

#### 13.2.0.0.9 Frontier Marcher Homesteader

- **Access Tags:** *Land-Grant Papers, Border Moot Voice*
- **Skills:** Craft (build), Endurance, Tactics or Diplomacy
- **Signature Contact:** Neighboring elder (Cap 1)
- **Background Boon:** Once/session at a contested site, shift Position up by one step when defending what's yours.

### 13.3 World-Linked Backgrounds

#### 13.3.0.0.1 Aeler Charter Apprentice

- **Access Tags:** *Charter-Stamped, Stone-Speech Initiate*
- **Skills:** Craft, Lore (engineering), Investigation (plans)
- **Signature Contact:** Oathscribe (Cap 1)
- **Boon:** Once/session around structures, ignore the first *environmental* complication from collapse or strain.

#### 13.3.0.0.2 Mistlands Bell-Keeper

- **Access Tags:** *Bell-Law, Causeway Rights*
- **Skills:** Perception, Lore (omens), Survival (fens)
- **Signature Contact:** Dusk-warden (Cap 1)
- **Boon:** Once/session, ring a lawful pattern to reframe a fog scene's Position from *Controlled* to *Dominant* for one exchange.

#### 13.3.0.0.3 Ykrul Wind-Runner

- **Access Tags:** *Wind-Knot Tokens, Banner Hospitality*
- **Skills:** Survival (steppe), Ranged or Riding, Sway (customs)
- **Signature Contact:** Banner-aunt (Cap 1)
- **Boon:** Once/session in open country, coordinate allies at distance; they gain a one-time *Boon* if they can hear your call.

#### 13.3.0.0.4 Kahfagian Dock-Priest Acolyte

- **Access Tags:** *Harbor Blessings, Beacon Rights*
- **Skills:** Lore (sea rites), Sway (crews), Investigation (cargo)
- **Signature Contact:** Beacon-keeper (Cap 1)
- **Boon:** Once/session at sea or harbor, treat one navigation check as if aided by favorable weather (DV-1).

## 13.4 Background Benefits and Limits

### Typical Benefits

- **Skill Access:** Strong narrative justification for certain tests
- **Resource Access:** Borrowed tools, rooms, shrines, or records (scene-time instead of XP; see Assets, §8)
- **Social Access:** Entry to circles your tag recognizes
- **Knowledge:** Clues, maps, or customs that lower DV by 1
- **Reputation:** Advantage on *first impressions* in-tag

### Common Limitations

- **Duties:** Responsibilities to house, guild, banner, or court
- **Restrictions:** Codes, taboos, or public expectations
- **Enemies:** Rival houses, crews, or schools
- **Secrets:** Leverage others can pull
- **Dependencies:** Loss of standing if you neglect ties

## 13.5 Custom Backgrounds

### Build Procedure (Player & GM)

Pick **1 Access Tag**, **1 Signature Contact**, **1 Boon**, and **1 Obligation Seed**. Name places and people.

- **Origin:** Where were you taught/raised/forged?
- **Training:** Which *two* skills does this background naturally support?
- **Experiences:** One memory that still changes how you act
- **Relationships:** One ally, one rival; both want something
- **Values:** What won't you let slide?

### Mechanical Considerations

- **Boon Scope:** DV−1 or +1d once/session when strongly on-theme
- **Contact Use:** +1d as assist; cannot take independent actions unless purchased as a *Follower* (Cap<sup>2</sup> XP; §8)
- **Assets:** Borrowing an institutional asset costs *scene time* (counts as upkeep for that asset this downtime) but 0 XP
- **Languages:** Choose one tongue linked to the background (see Chapter ?? in the full rules); at least *Conversational*

## 13.6 Integration with Development

### Early Career

- Apprentice, recruit, junior clerk, initiate bell-keeper
- Boon is modest; obligation triggers are frequent but small

### Mid-Career

- Foreman, sergeant, factor, lecturer

- Add a **second Access Tag** or elevate contact to Cap 2 by *paying XP* for a follower

## Late Career

- Master, banner-aunt, beacon-warden, arbiter
- Background Boon may become a *scene-long permission* at GM approval tied to a vow or festival

## 13.7 Background Combinations

### 13.7.0.0.1 Sequential

- **Veteran** → **City Watch**: Access shifts from *Muster Papers* to *Badge Rights*
- **Scholar** → **Diplomat**: Keep libraries, gain court

### 13.7.0.0.2 Parallel

- **Noble Merchant**: Both *Court-Announced* and *Guild-Ledgered*; responsibilities multiply

### 13.7.0.0.3 Contrasting

- **Criminal Penitent**: Underworld ties vs. temple vows; great hooks, sharp bargains

## 13.8 Using Backgrounds in Play

### Player Applications

- Name your places: the specific stall, shrine, or yard you know
- Cash your Boon when you leverage that familiarity
- Call on your contact to assist or to introduce a new lead

### GM Applications

- Offer choices where background allegiance matters
- Turn Access Tags into *gates* and *keys*
- Spend Story Beats (§9) to *complicate the old ties*

## 13.9 Obligations & Evolution

### Obligation Clock (4)

When filled by misses, bargains, or story, something is *due*.

- 1–2 Minor favor, time, or tithe
- 3 Significant service, costly honesty, dangerous escort
- 4 Defining ordeal: duel, audit, rite, or trial

Clear segments by honoring duties on-screen, sacrificing resources, or changing affiliation (which creates new clocks).

### Enhancement & Transformation

- **Enhance**: Add a tag or upgrade the contact via XP (Follower rules)

- **Transform:** Rewrite the background after a major arc; keep one tag, swap the rest, reset the clock
- **Resolution:** Retire a background after paying its *price*; gain a *Legacy Note*—a small permanent permission

## 13.10 Tables & Tools

### Quick Background Seeds

| d10 | Seed                                                       |
|-----|------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | Failed heir with an honest steward and a dishonest cousin  |
| 2   | Caravan accountant who knows three border tariffs by heart |
| 3   | Bell-tender whose dusk pattern saved a village once        |
| 4   | Charter apprentice who broke a measure and hid it          |
| 5   | Ykrul courier who owes horses to two banners               |
| 6   | Dock acolyte who lit the beacon in a storm against orders  |

### GM SB Menu: Background Complications

- **1 SB:** A rival claims your tag is invalid here; prove it or pay time
- **2 SB:** Your contact is *busy* or *watched*; help will cost you exposure
- **3 SB:** Obligation advances; an audit, rite, or muster arrives early
- **4 SB:** An enemy weaponizes your background—publicly

#### Background Quick Reference

##### At Creation

- Choose: 1 *Access Tag*, 1 *Signature Contact* (Cap 1 assist), 1 *Boon* (once/session), 1 *Obligation Seed*.
- Pick 1 language tied to the background at *Conversational* or better (Chapter ??).

##### In Play

- Invoke tags to open doors or shift Position.
- Call your contact for +1d assist (no independent actions).
- Track the *Obligation Clock* (4). Pay it on-screen.

##### Advancing

- Upgrade contact to a *Follower* by paying XP (Cap<sup>2</sup>).
- Add a second tag after a major arc or training.

## 13.11 Worked Examples

### House Shield (Aristocratic-Military Hybrid)

- **Tags:** *Court-Announced*, *Veteran-of-the-Marches*
- **Skills:** Command, Melee, Lore (protocol)
- **Contact:** House steward (Cap 1)
- **Boon:** Once/session while guarding a principal, treat one consequence as one step less severe.

- **Hook:** Duel clock from an old slight; an audit of campaign spoils

### Ledger Lantern (Merchant-Temple Bridge)

- **Tags:** *Guild-Ledgered, Beacon Rights*
- **Skills:** Sway, Investigation (accounts), Lore (sea rites)
- **Contact:** Beacon-keeper (Cap 1)
- **Boon:** Once/session, secure safe harbor or fair rate; DV−1.
- **Hook:** Rivals whisper of skimming tithe; prove the books

### Fog Warden (Mistlands Civic)

- **Tags:** *Bell-Law, Causeway Rights*
- **Skills:** Perception, Survival, Sway (local law)
- **Contact:** Dusk-warden (Cap 1)
- **Boon:** Once/session in mist, choose *route-or-safety*: negate a travel delay or downgrade a hazard.
- **Hook:** Someone silences the bells; obligation advances

*Let your background do work for you. Speak its language, call its favors, and pay its dues in play. The world will answer.*

## 13.12 Player Bonds: Ties That Bind

Your background shapes your past, but the bonds you forge with other player characters shape your future. Bonds are the shared history, favors owed, rivalries, or affections that connect you to one another. They are not merely narrative flavor—they are mechanical resources that allow you to shift Boons, aid each other in desperate moments, and unlock powerful teamwork options late in the campaign.

### 13.12.1 What Bonds Represent

A bond is a **\*\*player-to-player agreement\*\*** about how your characters relate. It must be:

- **Mutual:** Both players agree on its nature.
- **Specific:** It names a concrete event or recurring dynamic.
- **Consequential:** It should create roleplaying opportunities and occasional friction.

#### 13.12.1.0.1 Examples of Bonds

1. **Oath of Shared Vengeance:** “We both lost someone to the same enemy. We swore to see them fall together.”
2. **Favor of Blood:** “You saved my life when I was helpless. I owe you a favor I cannot erase.”
3. **Secret Shared:** “We know a truth that could destroy a powerful person. Neither of us can ever speak it alone.”
4. **Rivalry of Equals:** “We constantly compete, but when outsiders threaten, we fight back-to-back without hesitation.”
5. **Foster-Kin:** “Our families bound us by rite. We are not siblings by blood, but by custom.”
6. **Old Campaigners:** “We marched together in the same condotta. We’ve seen each other bleed and lie.”

### 13.12.2 Mechanics of Bonds

#### Gaining Boons Through Bonds

Once per bond **\*\*per session\*\***, when you take a significant action to aid the other character and explicitly reference your bond in an **\*\*intricate description\*\*** (see Description Ladder, §2), you both gain **1 Boon** after the action resolves.

*You cannot gain this Boon for basic assistance rolls or minor favors. The aid must involve meaningful risk or sacrifice.*

#### Re-allocating Boons (Late Game)

At **\*\*Tier III or higher\*\*** (90+ XP), bonds become a channel for resource sharing. Once per scene, you may transfer **\*\*up to 2 Boons\*\*** from your pool to a bonded ally as a free action. The transfer must be narrated (“I toss them my last flare,” “I steady their aim with a whispered cue”). This does not count as your action for the turn.

This represents deep trust and practiced coordination—the kind only earned through shared ordeals.

#### Bonded Assistance

When you assist a bonded ally on a roll, the first Boon you spend to assist (see Assistance, §2) is **\*\*refunded\*\*** if the roll succeeds. (You still mark any Fatigue or other costs normally.)

### 13.12.3 Creating Bonds at Character Creation

At campaign start, each player should establish **\*\*two bonds\*\*** with other player characters. Use the tables below for inspiration, or invent your own.

#### 13.12.3.0.1 Bond Triggers (roll d8 or choose)

1. **Last Stand**: “We held a breach together when no one else would.”
2. **Betrayal Forgiven**: “You could have left me, but you didn’t.”
3. **Stolen Future**: “We both lost everything in the same fire.”
4. **Shared Geas**: “A power bound us to the same task. We cannot complete it alone.”
5. **Inherited Feud**: “Our families hate each other, but we refuse to carry that hate.”
6. **Whisper Witness**: “We overheard a secret that would end us if it got out.”
7. **Trial by Ordeal**: “We survived a rite that killed the others.”
8. **Empty Promise**: “We made a vow we half-meant, but now it has teeth.”

#### 13.12.3.0.2 Bond Flavors (roll d8 or choose)

1. **Protective**: “I will not let them fall while I draw breath.”
2. **Resentful but Reliable**: “I don’t like them, but I owe them.”
3. **Playful Rivalry**: “They beat me at cards every night. I’ll get them back when it counts.”
4. **Devotion**: “They are the reason I still believe in anything.”
5. **Curiosity**: “I don’t understand them, but I need to.”
6. **Dependence**: “Without them, I would have drowned in my own mistakes.”
7. **Inspiration**: “They make me want to be better.”
8. **Doom-Bound**: “The omens say one of us will betray the other. I will prove them wrong.”



### 13.12.4 Evolving Bonds

Bonds are not static. At the end of a major story arc (GM discretion), you may:

- **Deepen a bond:** Add a second specific trigger. That bond now grants +1 Boon instead of 1 when invoked (still once per session).
- **Sever a bond:** Replace it with a new bond with the same player, or with a different player if the narrative supports it. Severing a bond before its natural conclusion generates **2 SB** for the GM (the rupture has consequences).
- **Transform a bond:** Change its flavor (e.g., from “Resentful” to “Respectful”) and reset its mechanical benefits as if new.

### 13.12.5 Bonds and the Late Game

As characters gain influence (Tier IV–V), bonds become the primary currency of high-stakes teamwork. Boon transfers allow one character to fuel another’s desperate rite or finishing blow. GMs are encouraged to present challenges where no single character can succeed alone—where only bonded pairs or trios can split responsibilities, cover weaknesses, and share the load.

**13.12.5.0.1 Example:** The party’s Cantor has 4 Boons but is cornered and low on Fatigue. The Fighter (bonded to the Cantor) transfers 2 Boons as a free action, then uses their own action to defend. The Cantor spends those Boons to reroll a failed casting, saving the party from a collapsing ceiling.

### 13.12.6 Bond Hooks for the Tables Below

When you choose a background from the previous sections, consider how your bond with another PC might connect to your signature contact, obligation seed, or access tag.

- **Aristocratic House Scion + Marcher Veteran:** “Your family hired my company. I still blame you for the lost patrol.”
- **Underworld Hand + Urban Child:** “We grew up in the same tenement. You kept my secrets; I kept yours.”
- **Aeler Charter Apprentice + Mistlands Bell-Keeper:** “We met in the high passes. Your bell saved me from a fog wraith; my stone-lore saved you from a collapsed gallery.”

## 13.13 Bonds Quick Reference

### Bonds Summary

**At Creation:**

- Establish 2 bonds with other PCs.
- Define trigger / flavor / mutual benefit.

**Per Session:**

- Once per bond per session, invoke with intricate description → both gain 1 Boon.

**Tier III+ (90+ XP):**

- Transfer up to 2 Boons to bonded ally as free action (once per scene).

**Bonded Assistance:**

- First Boon spent to assist a bonded ally is refunded on a successful roll.

**Evolving:**

- Deepen, sever, or transform after major arcs.

# Chapter 14

## The Legacy Engine

### Planning for Legacy

If you are playing a long campaign or enjoy the idea of your character's influence outlasting them, consider investing in a **Follower** (Cap3+) early. That follower can become your **successor** when your character retires or falls – inheriting your faction standing, one unresolved burden, and a Legacy Bond. See the checklist at the end of this chapter for steps to prepare.

### Succession & Faction Building

*“Your legacy is not what you build — it is who you build.”*

The Legacy Engine is a narrative framework that helps your campaign grow across generations without losing emotional continuity. It treats succession as a story event — earned through action, consequence, and choice — rather than a mechanical transaction.

This chapter is for tables where characters retire, die, or pass on their cause to a follower. It is not required for every campaign, but when the moment comes, these tools help the transition feel earned and the new character feel connected.

#### 14.1 Core Philosophy

The Legacy Engine follows three principles:

1. **Narrative Primacy** — Succession happens because the story demands it, not because a clock fills.
2. **People Before Power** — A follower becomes a PC because of who they are, not what they can do.
3. **Consequences Persist** — Every legacy creates debts, rivals, and unfinished work that the successor must carry.

Legacy is not inherited cleanly. It comes wrapped in obligation.

#### 14.2 When Does Succession Happen?

Succession is not automatic. It emerges from play. Common triggers include:

- A PC retires after completing a major arc.
- A PC dies or is permanently removed from play.
- A player wants to explore a new character but keep the same faction or cause alive.
- The campaign shifts to a new generation (years or decades later).

In all cases, the transition should be discussed openly at the table. The GM and player collaborate to find the right moment.

## 14.3 Choosing a Successor

A successor should already exist in the fiction. Typically, this is a **Follower** (see §8) with whom the PC has a meaningful relationship. It could also be a family member, a student, a loyal lieutenant, or even a rival who earns respect.

### 14.3.0.0.1 What Makes a Good Successor?

- They have a name, a face, and a voice.
- They have acted independently (off-screen or on-screen) at least once.
- They want something that the PC's faction or cause can provide.
- They have a flaw or burden that will complicate their rise.

If no suitable follower exists, the GM and player can create one retroactively — but that character arrives with less established history. The player may need to spend a session or two building them up before succession feels earned.

## 14.4 The Succession Arc

A smooth transition usually follows three beats. They can span one session or several, depending on the table's pace.

### 14.4.1 1. The Call

The follower faces a moment where they must act beyond their role. Examples:

- The PC is incapacitated, absent, or compromised.
- A decision must be made that no one else can make.
- A crisis demands leadership rather than obedience.

This scene answers: *Why this person, now?*

### 14.4.2 2. The Trial

The follower is tested. The trial can be:

- A single high-stakes scene (e.g., a duel, a negotiation, a desperate escape).
- A short sequence of escalating challenges (2–3 scenes).
- A moral or political decision with lasting impact.

Success is not guaranteed. Failure does not end the story — it changes it. A follower who fails may still become a PC, but they carry a scar, a doubt, or a broken promise into their new role.

### 14.4.3 3. The Ascension

At a dramatically appropriate moment — often during downtime or immediately after a crisis — the follower formally takes up the mantle. This might involve:

- A public ceremony (crowning, oath-swearing, banner-raising).
- A private passing of a symbol (sword, key, ledger).
- A quiet acknowledgment (“You’re in charge now.”).

The departing PC may be present, or they may be gone. Either way, the scene marks the end of one chapter and the beginning of another.

## 14.5 What the Successor Inherits

When a follower becomes a PC, they do not simply copy the old character sheet. Instead, they inherit three things:

### 14.5.1 1. Faction Standing

The successor begins with the same reputation, allies, and enemies that the previous PC cultivated. The GM may adjust specific relationships based on how the succession occurred (e.g., a contested succession might lose one ally but gain a bitter rival).

### 14.5.2 2. One Unresolved Burden

The player and GM choose one burden that the successor must carry forward. Examples:

- **Oath of Succession:** “You must protect the valley as I did.”
- **Unfinished Task:** “Find my daughter. Tell her I’m sorry.”
- **Rival Claim:** Another faction – or a jealous lieutenant – disputes your right to lead.

This burden is a narrative hook, not a mechanical penalty. It gives the new character immediate purpose.

### 14.5.3 3. A Legacy Bond

The successor has a bond to their predecessor. Once per session, the player may invoke this bond to:

- Recall a memory that provides insight.
- Receive instinctive guidance in a familiar situation.
- Gain a free **Boon** (see §2) when acting to uphold the predecessor’s values.

This bond fades over time as the successor finds their own identity – but it never vanishes entirely.

## 14.6 Building a Faction Through Succession

Each time a character passes the torch, the faction (or cause) grows. It accumulates history, traditions, and institutional memory.

### 14.6.1 Growth Through People

Rather than tracking territory or wealth, track the faction’s **reach** through the people who are now part of its story. Each successor adds:

- A new contact or ally they brought with them.
- A new problem they inherited.
- A new custom or saying that arose from their trials.

The GM keeps a simple list: “*The Banner of the Broken Wheel*,” “*the annual vigil at Sootfall Abbey*,” “*the debt to the Mistland ferryman*.” These are the faction’s real assets.

### 14.6.2 Faction Clocks (Optional)

For tables that want mechanical weight, the faction can track two simple clocks:

- **Growth (6–8):** When filled, the faction gains a new narrative permission (e.g., a safehouse in a new city, a reliable spy, a permanent shrine).
- **Health (6):** When filled, a crisis erupts – a rival attacks, a leader dies, a secret is exposed. The current PC must deal with it or watch the faction fracture.

These clocks advance only when the fiction demands – not automatically.

## 14.7 Example: The Fallen Captain

Miranda has played Kael, captain of the Iron Tide mercenary company, for two years. Kael dies defending a village from a wyrm. The player wants to continue the story.

**14.7.0.0.1 The Successor** Kael’s second-in-command, a grizzled scout named Vesper, has been a follower (Cap 3) for many sessions. Vesper once disobeyed an order to save wounded civilians – a defining moment.

**14.7.0.0.2 The Call** At Kael’s funeral pyre, the company looks to Vesper. No one else steps forward.

**14.7.0.0.3 The Trial** Vesper must negotiate a new contract with a wary noble who doubts the company’s future without Kael. The player rolls, succeeds with cost – the noble agrees, but demands a hostage.

**14.7.0.0.4 The Ascension** Vesper takes up Kael’s banner. The player erases Kael’s character sheet and creates Vesper as a new PC (starting XP based on campaign tier). Vesper inherits:

- The Iron Tide as a **Mercenary Contract (Standard Asset)** (see §??).
- The burden: “*Find the noble’s missing son – or lose the contract.*”
- A legacy bond to Kael: once per session, recall Kael’s advice to gain a Boon when leading the company.

The campaign continues without missing a beat.

## 14.8 Legacy Planning Checklist

Before your character retires, dies, or steps aside, work with your GM to prepare your successor. Use this checklist to ensure a smooth transition.

### Player's Legacy Planning Checklist

1. **Name a Successor** – Choose a Follower (Cap3+), family member, or loyal ally. Give them a name, a face, and a voice.
2. **Clarify the Relationship** – What does your character mean to them? What do they owe each other?
3. **Identify One Unresolved Burden** – What task, oath, or problem will the successor inherit? (e.g., “Find my stolen sword,” “Protect the village,” “Pay the guild debt.”)
4. **Pass Down an Asset (Optional)** – If your character controls a Minor or Standard Asset (see §??), the GM may allow the successor to retain it with suitable narrative justification (e.g., “The family safehouse,” “The guild seat passes to the heir”). Major or TierIII Assets usually require the successor to earn them through play.
5. **Settle Outstanding Obligations** – Clear or transfer any standing debts to terrestrial patrons (see §12) before stepping down. Unpaid debts may become part of the successor's burden.
6. **Hold a Ceremony (On-Screen)** – A funeral, a passing of the torch, a swearing of oaths. This scene marks the transition and gives the new PC immediate presence.
7. **Create the New Character** – Build the successor using standard character creation rules, adjusted to the campaign's current tier. The GM may award a small XP bonus (e.g., 4–8 XP) to represent inherited training or resources.
8. **Keep a Legacy Note** – Write one sentence that the old character leaves behind (a proverb, a scar, a rumour). The GM can use it as a future story hook.

## 14.9 Campaign End: The Final Legacy

When the campaign ends, the player may describe one lasting mark the faction leaves on the world. Examples:

- A new law named after the first PC.
- A shrine where the PC fell, still tended by followers.
- A phrase that enters common speech (“Stand like Kael”).

The story ends – but the legacy remains.

*A character dies. A faction endures. A story echoes forward.*

# Chapter 15

## Enhanced Player Play

The world of **Fate's Edge** sings when players help steer the tune. This chapter gathers *player-facing dials*—lightweight, opt-in mechanics that turn your table's choices into momentum. Treat these as a menu: use a few, or layer many as your group grows comfortable.

### 15.1 Role-Based Tactics

Your role in the party determines how to best apply pressure, conserve resources, and turn the tide. Use these tactical guidelines regardless of your specific build.

#### 15.1.1 Melee Striker (Duelist / Assassin / Berserker)

*Your job is to eliminate high-value targets and break enemy lines.*

- **Be aggressive.** You move faster than magic and hit harder than ranged fire. Close the distance early; every round you spend not engaged is a round you are not doing your job.
- **Flank, flank, flank.** A flanked enemy loses Position advantages. Coordinate with another melee character to attack from two sides.
- **Use Boons on re-rolling failed attacks, not defense.** Your HP is a resource; their death is the objective.
- **When outnumbered, use the terrain.** A narrow corridor or doorway lets you fight one enemy at a time while allies shoot over your shoulder.
- **Know your exit.** If you go down, the party loses its hammer. Keep a backup plan (a smoke bomb, a doorway to retreat through, a Bonded ally who can pull you out).

#### 15.1.2 Defender (Guardian / Shield / Tank)

*You hold the line so others don't have to.*

- **Use the Defend action early.** It improves your Position by one step and gives you a free reaction to intercept attacks on allies.
- **Spend Boons on re-rolling defense failures.** Your survival keeps the party safe; a missed attack on your part is less catastrophic than a missed defense.
- **Position yourself between the enemy and your squishy allies.** The GM will honour the fiction – a foe cannot shoot past you without moving around you.
- **Trade Harm for Fatigue whenever possible.** A wound that clears your Fatigue track is often worth it.



- **Protect at least one ally with a Bond.** That Bond gives you a free Boon refund when you assist them – perfect for *Cover & Protect*.

### 15.1.3 Controller (Mage / Crowd Control / Terrain Shaper)

*You shape the battlefield, forcing enemies into bad positions.*

- **Open with area control.** A [AREA] [BIND] or [WALL] spell can split the enemy force, letting your strikers pick them off.
- **Use Boons to improve Position before casting, not after.** A Controlled cast is much safer than a Desperate one.
- **Accept SB as a resource, not a penalty.** You generate them anyway – lean into it. Offer the GM a Devil’s Bargain to make your spell more effective in exchange for a later complication.
- **Tags matter.** [EARTH] + [WALL] blocks movement; [AIR] + [LEAP] repositions allies; [FATE] + [OMEN] gives the party a clue. Read the Tag reference (3).
- **Do not waste spells on enemies your strikers can kill in one hit.** Save your power for clusters, bosses, or emergencies.

### 15.1.4 Support (Healer / Buffer / Bard)

*You multiply the party’s effectiveness.*

- **First action: improve Position or grant a Boon to a striker.** A Dominant striker kills faster than you can heal.
- **Use *Inspire* early.** The +1 die and extra Boon can turn a fight.
- **Heal Harm after the fight, Fatigue during it.** [MEND] as a cantrip clears Fatigue (safe and fast); healing Harm requires a full action and may generate SB.
- **Carry a ranged weapon.** You do not need to be a damage dealer, but plinking a foe can distract them or force a reaction.
- **Your Bonds are your fuel.** Transfer Boons to the striker who needs them. A bonded ally gets a Boon refund on their first assist – use it.

### 15.1.5 Scout (Rogue / Ranger / Infiltrator)

*You see the danger before it sees the party.*

- **Go first.** Before the fight, scout ahead. The information you bring is worth more than an extra sword.
- **Strike from stealth, then vanish.** *Backstab* + *Shadow Dance* + *Deathblow* is a classic chain (see 6).
- **Use the environment.** High ground, cover, and shadow are your friends. Spend a Move action to reposition even if you do not attack.
- **Your independent action (Scout & Signal) is free Position for the party.** Use it before the first roll of a fight.
- **Do not be the first to engage in a fair fight.** If you are trading blows, something went wrong.

### 15.1.6 Leader (Commander / Tactician / Face)

*You turn a group of individuals into a unit.*

- **Setup actions are your bread and butter.** Grant an ally +1 Position or step up Effect –

no roll, just fiction.

- **Use *Command* to rally.** A successful *Command* roll can remove Fear conditions or improve morale.
- **Delegate.** Your followers (see ??) are not just dice – they can take independent actions. Trust them.
- **Call shots.** “Focus the mage,” “Take cover,” “Fall back” – the GM will adjust Position based on coherent orders.
- **Your Boons are best spent on assisting others.** You are a force multiplier. A Boon spent on a striker’s attack is worth more than your own attack.

## 15.2 Tactical Play for Players

Combat and high-stakes scenes reward clever thinking as much as raw dice. Use these tactics to turn the fiction in your favour.

### 15.2.1 Closing on Ranged and Magic Users

A bowman on a balcony or a mage behind a ward can shred your party from a distance. Close the gap without getting shredded.

- **Use Cover and Movement.** Move from cover to cover. Spend a **Move action** to dash between obstacles. Ending behind solid cover may let the GM set your next defense roll as **Controlled** instead of Desperate.
- **Create Distractions.** Spend 1 **Boon** to describe a diversion. On a successful **Deception** or **Command** roll, the ranged attacker may lose their aim or shift attention for one exchange, dropping your Position penalty by one step.
- **Teamwork: The Running Shield.** Have a heavily armoured ally take the **Defend** action while moving forward. They intercept shots (converting Harm to Fatigue) while you sprint behind them. The GM may rule that the defender blocks line of sight, granting you **Dominant** position for your next approach.
- **Suppress Them.** Use the **Suppress** option (core rules). You don’t need to hit – just force the enemy to keep their head down. The GM may impose a –1 die penalty on their next attack or worsen their Position.
- **Spend Boons to Close.** Spend 1 **Boon** to improve your Position by one step before rolling movement or defense. That can mean the difference between a bolt in the chest and a glancing hit.

**15.2.1.0.1 Example.** Lyra (rogue) wants to cross a courtyard to reach a mage on a balcony. She spends 1 Boon to improve her Position from Desperate to Controlled, then stays close to a crumbling wall. The GM rules that the mage’s magic missile is at –1 die because of partial cover. Lyra makes it across with a Partial success, taking Fatigue instead of Harm.

### 15.2.2 When You’re Outmatched

Sometimes the enemy is bigger, faster, or more numerous. You can still win — or survive.

- **Don’t Trade Blows.** Instead of attacking, use your action to **Setup** for an ally (grant them +1 Position or step up Effect). Spend 1 Boon to assist them directly (+1 die). One well-supported PC can turn a fight faster than two desperate ones.
- **Accept Story Beats (SB) to Buy Time.** When you roll a Partial or Miss, the GM gets

SB. You can proactively offer to accept **+1 SB** (banked, not spent now) in exchange for a short narrative delay: “I fall back behind a pillar – they lose sight of me for a moment.” This doesn’t change the roll’s outcome, but gives you a breath to reposition.

- **Spend Boons on Defense, Not Offense.** When outnumbered, a missed attack hurts less than a received hit. Save Boons to re-roll failed defence rolls or to improve your Position before an enemy’s big swing. A **Boon spent to re-roll a 1 on a defence roll** can prevent Harm 2 or 3.
- **Escape and Reset.** There’s no shame in running. Use the **Withdraw** action (core rules). Spend 1 Boon to make it a **Controlled** withdrawal instead of Desperate. Live to fight another scene.
- **Use the Environment as a Weapon.** Ask the GM: “Is there a chandelier? A sand pile? A steep stair?” Describe how you trigger it. The GM may set a low DV (2–3); on success, the obstacle deals Harm, imposes a Condition, or improves the party’s Position for a round.

**15.2.2.0.1 Example.** Kael (fighter) faces three bandits. Instead of attacking, he spends 1 Boon to assist the group’s archer, then kicks over a brazier. The GM calls for a Body + Athletics roll (DV 2). Kael succeeds – the fire creates a smoky screen, worsening the bandits’ Position to Desperate for one exchange. The archer picks one off.

### 15.2.3 When to Push It — and When Not To

The **Push It** mechanic (usually on Rites or Cantor Songs) escalates an effect immediately at a cost: extra Obligation, Fatigue, Corruption, or a GM Story Beat. Use it wisely.

#### Good Times to Push

- **Preventing a Party Wipe.** If a teammate is about to take lethal Harm, Push to get that heal or ward now.
- **Ending a Scene.** The clock is about to fill, or the enemy leader is fleeing. Push to finish it.
- **When the Cost Is Acceptable.** If you have spare Fatigue, or you’re already at max Obligation and about to trigger a Patron demand anyway, the extra cost doesn’t hurt as much.

#### Avoid Pushing When

- **You’re Already in Trouble.** Pushing adds Fatigue or SB. If you’re already at Fatigue 2 or have a full Death Clock, the extra cost could break you.
- **A Partial Success Is Enough.** Many Rites and Songs still work on a Partial – just weaker or shorter. Don’t pay extra for power you don’t require.
- **The GM Is Low on SB.** If the GM has 0–1 SB banked, they can’t immediately punish a miss. But if they have 3+, a failed Push could trigger a major twist. Check the table’s SB tracker.

#### How to Avoid Needing to Push

- **Use Boons Early.** Spend 1 Boon to improve your Position before the roll. A Controlled roll is less likely to fail than a Desperate one.
- **Get Help.** Have an ally assist you (spend 1 Boon for +1 die). That +1 die might turn a Partial into a Clean Success.
- **Lower the DV with Fiction.** “I wait for the guards to change shift” might lower DV by 1. “I use my Scholar’s Cell free use to research the ward’s pattern” could drop DV from 4 to 3.
- **Accept Failure and Bank Boons.** A Miss gives you 2 Boons. Sometimes it’s better to fail now, take the Boons, and try again next round with a bigger pool or better Position.

**15.2.3.0.1 Example.** Sariel (Cantor) needs to charm a guard quickly. She could Push to resolve the Song instantly, but she’s already at Fatigue 2. Instead, she spends 1 Boon to improve her Position from Controlled to Dominant, then has an ally whisper a distraction (assist, another Boon). She rolls 4 dice (Lore + Performance) against DV 3. She gets 3 successes – a Clean Success. No Push needed, and she saved her Fatigue.

## 15.2.4 General Player Tips for Enhanced Experience

- **Track Your Boons, Fatigue, and Obligation.** These are your resources. A character with 4 Boons and 0 Fatigue is much stronger than one with 0 Boons and Fatigue 2.
- **Use Bonds to Shift Boons.** At Tier III, you can transfer up to 2 Boons to a bonded ally as a free action. Fuel the party’s best character for a crucial roll. Don’t hoard.
- **Communicate Your Intent.** Tell the GM what you want to achieve, not just what skill you’re rolling. “I want to scare him into dropping the keys” is better than “I roll Intimidation.” The GM can set a fairer DV and offer better consequences.
- **Ask About the Environment.** “Is there loose gravel? A tapestried wall? A rain barrel?” These become levers. The GM wants you to use them.
- **Know When to Fold.** Not every fight is winnable. Spending 2 Boons to escape with everyone alive is a victory. The game rewards survival and smart choices.
- **Use Downtime.** Between sessions, update your logs, tend your Assets, and clear Complications. A well-maintained Asset (Neglected → Maintained) can save your life next session. A cleared Complication removes a “free SB” button from the GM.
- **Talk to Your GM.** If a rule feels off or a scene drags, speak up. Fate’s Edge is collaborative. The GM can adjust DV, offer alternative stakes, or introduce a Devil’s Bargain to keep things moving.

## 15.3 Player Resources

Two shared currencies appear throughout this chapter:

**Boons** Core system edge; spend to power talents or convert to XP (see 2).

**SB** The GM’s Story Beats; several options here invite players to accept SB in exchange for narrative benefits.

## 15.4 Engagement Rewards

### 15.4.1 Session Investment Tracker

At session close, each player privately rates their *investment* (1–3). The tracker rewards steady participation without penalising quiet nights.

- 1 — **Low** You followed others’ lead. Gain +1d once next session on any *support* action.
- 2 — **Medium** You took initiative in some scenes. Gain +1d once next session on a *relationship* roll and bank 1 **Momentum** (see 15.7.1).
- 3 — **High** You anchored or elevated multiple scenes. Gain +1d twice next session (different scenes) and bank 1 **Momentum**.

**15.4.1.0.1 Table Boon.** If *all* players report 2+ in a session, the GM may award the table 1 **free Boon** to assign at the start of the next session.

## 15.4.2 Cultural Immersion Bonus

Reward lived-in play with light, predictable benefits.

- **Earn 1 Culture Point** when you enrich a scene with apt language, rites, or customs (Sea-Patter hail; bell-speech courtesy; Aeler craft-honorifics). Max **3/session**.
- **Spend 3 Culture** for **+1d** on a culturally keyed roll.
- **Spend 5 Culture** (across sessions) to declare a *trusted door*: one institution in that culture treats you as *Friendly* for the next approach.

## 15.5 Collaborative Play

### 15.5.1 Information Trading

When the table hunts answers, convert curiosity into structure.

**15.5.1.0.1 Request & Price.** State the question and choose a price the table accepts:

**Devil's Bargain** Offer the GM a future complication to “pay” for deeper intel.

**Accept SB** The GM gains **+1 SB** now; you gain a strategic clue or reduced DV.

**Spend Boon** Spend **1 Boon** to lower DV by 1 on the research/social approach.

**15.5.1.0.2 Creative Methods.** Swap coin for color: poetry duels, shrine petitions, map-reading at a parish stone. If your method sings with setting, take **+1 Effect** on the check.

### 15.5.2 Clock Manipulation

Players can nudge tension without rewriting stakes.

- **Slow** a visible Clock by **1 segment** by either **spending 1 Boon** *or accepting +1 SB* into the scene (fiction must justify delay).
- **Hasten** a visible Clock by **1 segment** by **spending 1 Momentum** (see 15.7.1) *or taking a Devil's Bargain*.
- **Limit:** Once per player per scene. If three or more players affect the same Clock in a scene, the GM gains **+1 SB**.

### 15.5.3 Complication Bargaining

Invite the kind of trouble you want to play.

- Name a *type*: social, physical, mystery, or moral (e.g., Valora court etiquette; Ubral scree; Isoka whispers; oath vs. mercy).
- The GM frames the complication accordingly and grants you **+1d** on your next roll *within* that trouble, or reduces DV by 1 if your approach leans into the specified texture.

## 15.6 Faction Awareness

### 15.6.1 Loyalty Recognition

Track a simple ladder (−3 . . . +3): *Enemy, Hostile, Unfriendly, Neutral, Friendly, Supportive, Ally*. When you act *with* an institution's aims, mark a **tick** toward the next step (GM pacing). When you betray a stated value, drop one step immediately and the GM banks **+1 SB** for future headaches.

## 15.6.2 Cross-Cultural Synergies

Spotting a neat cultural combo (Zakov pilots + Kahfagia signals; Aeler engineering + Ecktoria charters) grants +1d once per scene the synergy is actively used.

## 15.7 Advanced Techniques

### 15.7.1 Momentum Banking

When your team resolves a Clock *early* (segments unspent), bank 1 **Momentum** per unused segment (max 2/session). Spend 1 Momentum to:

- Gain +1d on a future approach tied to that victory (*lessons learned*); or
- *Telescope* a travel beat (skip a routine obstacle the same route would present); or
- Trigger a *Prepared Move*: declare a sensible minor setup you plausibly arranged off-screen.

### 15.7.2 Escalation Management

Trade heat for shape.

- **De-escalate (spend 1 Boon)**: Downgrade a Major consequence to Minor with a plausible concession (quiet tolls paid, harsh words eaten).
- **Redirect (accept +1 SB)**: Shift pressure to a new venue or actor you name; the GM places that SB there as attention.
- **Truce (spend 1 Momentum)**: Freeze a faction's hostility for one scene if you can cite a shared value (oath, rite, charter clause).

## 15.8 Enhanced Coordination

Teamwork isn't just about helping—it's about creating decisive moments through coordinated action.

### 15.8.1 Core Principles

- **Fiction First**: Describe how you help before rolling dice.
- **Clear Stakes**: State what help changes and what risk the helper accepts.
- **One Spotlight**: Resolve one acting character's roll; fold assistance into that action.
- **Visible Costs**: Story Beats, Fatigue, and consequences are tracked openly.

### 15.8.2 Basic Assistance

- **Declare Help**: An ally states a concrete contribution (tools, opening, cover).
- **Benefit**: Acting character gains +1d (up to the table's assist cap).
- **Limits**: One assistant per PC per exchange by default.
- **Cost**: Assistant accepts any risk named by the GM (SB, Fatigue, collateral).

### 15.8.3 Cooperative Talents

Certain talents enhance group coordination:

**Inspire (3 XP)** Once per scene, spend 1 Boon to choose one:

- **Bonded Ally**: That ally gains +1 Boon and +1d on their next roll.
- **Self**: Gain +1d on your next roll.
- **Rally**: Each other PC in Near gains +1d on their next roll.

- **Tactical Coordination:** All allies currently acting gain +1 Position.

**Spotter's Mark (3 XP)** Aim a target (1 action). Until end of scene, allies in Near may claim +1d or +1 Effect once vs. that target.

**Battle Cant (2 XP)** Once per scene, establish silent signals. On the next coordinated action where at least two PCs act, those PCs gain +1 Position.

**Shield Wall (4 XP)** If you and at least one ally each wield a shield and are adjacent: as a Defend action, grant +1d Defend to all in the Wall and convert the first incoming Harm to Fatigue.

### 15.8.4 Stacking Limits

To prevent overwhelming combinations, a PC may benefit from at most **two cooperative effects** on the same action. Choose which apply when multiple sources could stack.

### 15.8.5 Timing and Sequencing

- **Declare Order:** Players state intent in any order; resolve the acting roll first.
- **Ready/Overwatch:** Hold an action with a clear trigger; resolve before the next exchange.
- **Refresh Windows:** “Once/scene” effects reset at scene end.

### 15.8.6 Working With Followers

Followers can assist for up to +3d (or +4d with the Exceptional Coordination talent). They cannot receive PC-only benefits unless a talent states otherwise.

### 15.8.7 Magic Coordination

- **Ritual Support:** Allies can assist Weave or Cast phases if the fiction allows.
- **Rite Preparation:** Helpers can provide components or maintain focus.
- **Imbuement Synergy:** Multiple characters can prepare for shared magical effort.

### 15.8.8 Best Practices for Players

1. **Be Specific:** “I’ll flank left to give you advantage” is better than “I help.”
2. **Accept Risk:** Good assistance often means putting yourself in harm’s way.
3. **Think Creatively:** Tools, positioning, and timing matter more than raw dice.
4. **Support Bonds:** Use coordination to strengthen character relationships.
5. **Keep Momentum:** Quick, clear assistance keeps scenes moving.

*Remember:* The best coordination enhances the story and makes everyone’s moments shine brighter together.

## 15.9 Character Creation Enhancements

Players may take up to **2 Bonds** (+2 XP total) and up to **2 Starting Complications** (+4 XP total) for a cap of **34 XP**. Each unresolved starting Complication adds **+1 banked SB** to early scenes until cleared. Favor *storyful* picks (clan honour, guild debt, patron notice) over pure math.

### 15.10 War Mount (Asset)

**Type:** Standard Asset

**XP Cost:** 8 XP

**Scale:** Personal

**Maintenance:** Regular care, feed, rest

A trained combat mount—warhorse, dune-strider, battle elk, ash lizard, or equivalent—conditioned for violence, chaos, and discipline.

**15.10.0.0.1 Passive Benefits** While mounted:

- Increase overland travel speed and endurance.
- Ignore the first movement-based complication per session (mud, crowd, loose terrain).
- Mounted positioning may override terrain restrictions at GM discretion.

**15.10.0.0.2 Mounted Combat** If the rider has the **Cavalier** talent (6):

- Melee attacks made while moving **Far** → **Near**: +2d
- Ranged attacks made while moving **Near** → **Far**: +2d

**15.10.0.0.3 Boon Activation** Spend 1 **Boon** to invoke the mount dramatically:

- Break through a hostile line or crowd
- Escape pursuit across hostile terrain
- Gain **Controlled Position** for a mounted action
- Advance or suppress a movement-related Clock

**15.10.0.0.4 Risk and Wear** On a *Partial* or *Miss* involving mounted actions, the GM may:

- Mark **Mount Fatigue**
- Damage tack, barding, or terrain access
- Threaten or compromise the Asset

**15.10.0.0.5 Mount Fatigue** If Mount Fatigue reaches 3:

- The mount cannot be used in combat until rested
- Further strain risks permanent injury or loss

**15.10.0.0.6 Promoting a War Mount** A War Mount may be promoted to a **Follower** if:

- It is named and narratively significant
- The rider takes a dedicated Bond or Talent

As a Follower, the mount can take actions independently (trample, defend, flee), suffer Harm, and may generate Boons through sacrifice or risk.

**Pike Discipline (Major Talent, 4 XP)** [FORMATION] [CONTROL]

**Requirements:** Melee 2+, Discipline or Command 1+

You are trained to break mounted assaults through spacing, timing, and fearlessness.

**15.10.0.0.7 Effect** When you **Brace** against a mounted opponent:



- Cancel all **Cavalier** movement bonuses
- Mounted attackers suffer **-1d** on the attack

#### 15.10.0.0.8 On Success

- Reduce incoming Harm by 1
- You may force the rider to **Disengage** or risk mount injury

#### 15.10.0.0.9 On Partial

- Reduce Harm by 1
- Mark 1 Fatigue or lose formation

#### 15.10.0.0.10 Limits

- Requires braced footing or prepared terrain
- Ineffective if flanked, surprised, or outnumbered

## 15.11 Optional Player-Character Death

By default, Fate's Edge treats death as rare and dramatic. Use any of the following modules (singly or in combination) to tune how lethal your table feels. All options respect **Story Beats (SB)** and **Obligation** as core currencies.

### Baseline (Default)

PCs do not die on ordinary failures. Instead, they suffer **Harm**, Conditions, lost opportunities, or narrative costs. Death only occurs when a rule below is in play or the table agrees a scene warrants it.

### Option A — Severe Harm Death

**Trigger.** When a PC would take a **third** instance of Severe Harm (or escalate past the top of your harm track), they instead face death.

**Stave It Off.** The player may avoid death by choosing one: (1) mark **2 SB** and take a MAIMED permanent Condition, (2) accept a **Patron's Claim** (see Option D), or (3) convert the blow into a **Last Stand** (Option C).

### Option B — Death Clock

**Trigger.** Catastrophic consequences (falls, crushes, mortal wounds) fill a named **Death Clock** (4 or 6 ticks).

**While Ticking.** Actions that stabilise reduce the clock; taking further punishment advances it.

**When Full.** The character dies unless one of the following occurs immediately: spend **2 SB** to hold at full (buy a single action), accept a **Patron's Claim**, or another PC succeeds at *Pull From the Brink* (risky, effect = clock -2 on success).

### Option C — Last Stand

**Trigger.** On lethal harm or a full Death Clock, the player may declare a **Last Stand**.

**Effect.** For the remainder of the scene, the PC acts with **+1 Effect** and ignores new Harm. Each

action automatically creates **1 SB**. When the scene ends, the character **dies** unless a **miracle** is secured (Patron rite, relic, or equivalent).

### Option D — Patron’s Claim

**Trigger.** On death, the PC’s Patron (or a circling power) intervenes.

**Bargain.** The GM offers 1–3 non-negotiable terms (e.g., *Obligation +2, forfeit a Gift, become a vessel for a season*). If accepted, the PC lives; mark the costs immediately and record the **Claim** as an ongoing front. Refusal means the death proceeds.

**Note.** Claims should change the campaign; use sparingly.

### Option E — Dramatic Exit & Inheritance

**Dramatic Exit.** The player may choose a meaningful death that resolves a question or saves others.

**Inheritance.** The next PC created by that player inherits one of: (a) a **Relationship** (bond, contact, or rival), (b) a **Tool** (asset degraded one step), or (c) a **Lesson** (start with +1 XP toward a Talent used in the exit). Record how the world remembers them.

### Option F — Return From Beyond

**Trigger.** A body, a name, and a path (rite, gate, bargain).

**Cost.** Treat as a High Rite with Obligation appropriate to the transgression. Set DV using the Rites system. On success, the PC returns **changed**: apply a SCAR (permanent Condition) and **1 SB** to the rescuer. On failure, choose: lose the body, or return with a Patron’s Claim.

#### Quick Picks

**Low lethality:** Baseline + Death Clock only. **Heroic tragedy:** Severe Harm Death + Last Stand + Inheritance. **Dark bargains:** Any combo with Patron’s Claim.

## 15.12 Implementation Timeline

### Sessions 1–3

Investment Tracker, Information Trading (via Boons/Bargains), light Complication Bargaining.

### Sessions 4–6

Clock Manipulation (Boon/Momentum/SB), Cultural Immersion, Faction Awareness, Momentum Banking.

### Sessions 7+

Cross-Cultural Synergies, Escalation Management, advanced pacing choreography.

#### At-Table Prompts

**Seed the Scene.** “Ask for the kind of complication you want.”

**Name the Stakes.** “Is this clock worth slowing? Who pays—Boon, SB, or Momentum?”

**Pay with Color.** “What custom or rite do you invoke to make this work?”

**Close the Loop.** “Mark your Investment; one sentence of what you learned.”

## 15.13 Downtime

Between sessions, tend your garden—quietly moving the world.

### 15.13.1 Bookkeeping

- Allocate XP (respecting training days).
- Update Assets/Followers (status: Maintained, Neglected, Compromised).
- Track Boons (conversion cap remains 2 XP/session).
- Note SB Debt from unresolved Complications.

### 15.13.2 Activities

- **Recovery:** Clear Harm/Exposure with scenes that show the work.
- **Training:** Buy advances; narrate mentors, gyms, scriptoria.
- **Research:** Lower DVs with good sources; log new leads.
- **Social:** Strengthen Bonds; tune faction attitudes.
- **Preparation:** Cache gear, sow rumours, line up ferries.

### 15.13.3 Strategic Considerations

Clear SB-debt complications first; synchronise travel plans; decide which Asset gets love this interval, and which follower needs face-time to avoid Neglect.

## 15.14 Between-Sessions Activities Log

Use or print the following trackers.

### 15.14.1 Character Advancement

#### XP Allocation

- **Total XP Available:** \_\_\_\_\_
- **Attributes Spent:** \_\_\_\_\_ (=\_\_\_\_\_ days)
- **Skills Spent:** \_\_\_\_\_ (=\_\_\_\_\_ days)
- **Remaining XP:** \_\_\_\_\_

#### Attribute Improvements

| Attribute | Old | New | Cost | Days |
|-----------|-----|-----|------|------|
| Body      |     |     |      |      |
| Spirit    |     |     |      |      |
| Presence  |     |     |      |      |
| Wits      |     |     |      |      |

**Skill Improvements**

| Skill       | Old | New | Cost | Days |
|-------------|-----|-----|------|------|
| Arcana      |     |     |      |      |
| Combat      |     |     |      |      |
| Investigate |     |     |      |      |
| Lore        |     |     |      |      |
| Move        |     |     |      |      |
| Notice      |     |     |      |      |
| Physique    |     |     |      |      |
| Resolve     |     |     |      |      |
| Stealth     |     |     |      |      |
| Sway        |     |     |      |      |
| Survival    |     |     |      |      |

**15.14.2 Asset & Follower Management****Assets**

| Name | Tier | Status | Notes |
|------|------|--------|-------|
|      |      |        |       |

**Followers**

| Name | Role | Harm | Exposure | Status |
|------|------|------|----------|--------|
|      |      |      |          |        |

**15.14.3 Bonds & Complications****Bonds Updated**

- With: \_\_\_\_\_ — Change: \_\_\_\_\_

**Complications**

| Complication | Resolution or Status |
|--------------|----------------------|
|              |                      |

**15.14.4 Boons & Momentum Summary**

- Boons Held: \_\_\_\_/5    Converted to XP: \_\_\_\_ (max 2 XP/session)
- Momentum Banked: \_\_\_\_ (max 2/session)

**15.14.5 Campaign Clocks**

- Mandate: \_\_\_\_ / 6    Crisis: \_\_\_\_ / 6
- Notables: \_\_\_\_\_

# Chapter 16

## Appendices

### 16.1 Player Tools and Quick Reference

This appendix provides lightweight, table-friendly tools for tracking character progress, campaign state, and moment-to-moment rules. Print, photocopy, or copy to index cards for use at the table.

#### 16.1.1 Physical Tracker Recommendations

Many groups find that physical, tactile trackers speed up play and reduce mental load. Consider:

- **Poker chips or glass beads** for Boons and Story Beats (SB). *Keep a small bowl of chips in the center of the table – spend and earn visibly.*
- **Dry-erase boards or laminated sheets** for clocks (4/6/8 segment circles). *Use a wet-erase marker; draw a new clock each scene.*
- **Index cards (3×5)** for Assets and Followers. *Write the Asset’s name, free use, and surge on one side; flip when used.*
- **Colored paperclips or binder clips** on character sheets for Fatigue and Harm tracks. *Slide the clip up or down – no erasing.*
- **Printed “clock wheels”** (a circle divided into 4/6/8 wedges) placed inside a page protector. *Mark wedges with a dry-erase marker, erase with tissue.*
- **D10 dice** to track temporary modifiers (Position, Effect, or Momentum). *Place the die next to the relevant tracker and tick up or down.*

#### 16.1.2 Resolution Index Card

**Declare Action → Build Dice Pool (Attribute + Skill) → Roll → Count Successes**

0 Successes = **Miss** (GM gains SB, consequences)

1–3 Successes = **Partial** (success + complication)

4+ Successes = **Full Success** (clear win, no complication)

**Position** (Risk) + **Effect** (Impact) may shift outcomes.

**SB (Story Beats)** fuel abilities, magic, momentum, and narrative pushes.

### 16.1.3 Fatigue and Harm Tracker

**Fatigue:** \_\_\_\_\_ (Max = Body)

**Mental Fatigue:** \_\_\_\_\_

**Harm:** [ ] Harm 1 (–1 die) [ ] Harm 2 (–2 dice) [ ] Harm 3 (Incapacitated)

When tracks fill:

- Fatigue overflow → increase Harm by 1, clear Fatigue.
- Mental Fatigue → causes instability or disadvantage.
- Harm 3 → Last Stand or Patron’s Claim (see “Optional Player-Character Death” in §15.11).

### 16.1.4 SB and Momentum Tracking

**Current SB (GM pool):** \_\_\_\_\_

**Momentum (party pool):** \_\_\_\_\_ (max 2)

**Used this session:** \_\_\_\_\_

### 16.1.5 Talent Progression

| XP Cost | Talent Type / Impact                                         |
|---------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2 XP    | Minor Talent / Perk upgrade / situational bonus              |
| 4 XP    | Major Talent / specialization / strong permanent effect      |
| 6 XP    | Access talent (Spellcraft, Familiar, Codex, Patron’s Symbol) |
| 8 XP    | Prestige Talent / campaign-defining ability                  |

### 16.1.6 Character Goals Card

**Name:** \_\_\_\_\_

**Core Drive:** \_\_\_\_\_

**Short-Term Goal (1–2 sessions):** \_\_\_\_\_

**Long-Term Goal (arc):** \_\_\_\_\_

**Background Complication:** \_\_\_\_\_

**Relationship That Matters:** \_\_\_\_\_

*Physical tip:* Print this card on cardstock, fold in half, and stand it in front of you as a reminder.

### 16.1.7 Faction Attitude Card

**Faction Name:** \_\_\_\_\_

**Attitude:** –3 –2 –1 0 +1 +2 +3

**Notes:** \_\_\_\_\_

### 16.1.8 Player Orientation Card (Quick Principles)

1. **Declare Bold Action** — Drive fiction forward.
2. **Accept Consequences** — Complications create story.
3. **Spend Story Beats** — Make moments matter.
4. **Use Boons** — Re-roll, improve Position, activate Assets.
5. **Share the Spotlight** — Assist, bond, set up allies.

### 16.1.9 Class / Archetype Resource Quick Reference

| Archetype         | Core Resource                            |
|-------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Fighter / Warrior | Maneuvers, Fatigue, Weapon Mastery       |
| Rogue / Scout     | Positioning, Stealth, Backstab           |
| Caster (Freeform) | Spellcraft, Elemental Tags, Backlash     |
| Runekeeper        | Rites, Obligation, Codex                 |
| Invoker           | Rituals, Patron's Symbol, Crack the Seal |
| Cantor            | Songs, Corruption Clock, Repertoire      |
| Summoner          | Leash Clock, Spirit Bond, Pact           |

### 16.1.10 How to Engage with the GM (Player Prompts)

- **Ask:** “What do I need to roll?” – get the DV and Position.
- **Propose:** “Can I spend SB to achieve X?” – negotiate narrative pushes.
- **Declare:** “Here’s my intent and method.” – always state what you want to happen.
- **Offer:** “I’ll take a complication if Y happens.” – invite Devil’s Bargains.
- **Clarify:** “What’s at risk if I fail?” – know the stakes before rolling.

### 16.1.11 Downtime Project Tracker

**Name:** \_\_\_\_\_ **Segments:** [ ] [ ] [ ] [ ] [ ] [ ] [ ]

**Goal:** \_\_\_\_\_

**Obstacles / Resources Needed:** \_\_\_\_\_

*Physical tip:* Use a 6-segment whiteboard clock. Each downtime, erase one segment and roll for progress.

### 16.1.12 What Consequence Do You Accept? (Menu for GM)

When a player fails or partially succeeds, the GM may offer a choice from this list (or invent a custom one):

- Harm (level 1 or 2)
- Fatigue (1 or 2)
- Lost Advantage (Position worsens, a clock advances)
- Time Delays (a clock ticks, a deadline tightens)
- Exposure / Heat (attention from enemies, bounty)
- Resource Depletion (supply clock tick, gear compromised)

- Relationship Strain (a bond or faction attitude worsens)

### 16.1.13 Ways to Shine in Fate's Edge

- Tie actions to your drives and backstory – invoke your Background Boon.
- Offer complications and accept them – earn Boons.
- Spend SB to escalate or transform the scene – make failure memorable.
- Use your class resource early and often – don't hoard.
- Connect scenes to campaign themes – name the faction or place.
- Make other characters look cool – assist, set up, pass the spotlight.

### 16.1.14 Blank Player Index Cards (for quick notes)

|                                              |
|----------------------------------------------|
| <div>Name / Boons / Fatigue / Harm</div>     |
| <div>Clocks / Obligation / Scene Notes</div> |

### 16.1.15 Final Reminder

**Your character sheet is not your character.** It is a tool to help you express who they have been, who they are becoming, and how their choices change the world.

Use these tools to make that expression vivid, consequential, and memorable.



## 16.2 Magic Systems Reference

Magic in Fate's Edge is plural. Different traditions channel power through different metaphysical structures, but all obey the same truth:

*Power has a cost, and magic shapes the one who wields it.*

This appendix provides quick-reference tools for players using magic-affiliated systems, talismans, rites, and occult practices.

### 16.2.1 Core Magical Principles

- Magic expresses **identity and belief**.
- Casting always creates **consequences somewhere**.
- Magic rewrites reality through **intention, structure, or sacrifice**.
- Excessive power erodes **choice** (see Iconic Ascension sidebar in the full rules).

### 16.2.2 Universal Casting Reference

#### Cast Declaration Template:

1. **Intent** — What change do you seek?
2. **Shape** — How does your tradition express it?
3. **Cost** — What do you risk or expend?
4. **Resolution** — Test; apply Position/Effect rules.
5. **Backwash** — Mark Fatigue, SB pressure, taboo, instability, or bargain.

### 16.2.3 Magic Tradition Quick Reference

**Freeform Arcana (Wizardry)** *Creative, rational, deliberate shaping.* Tools: Glyphs, structures, metaphors. Costs: Fatigue, reality recoil, SB instability. **Play Cue:** Diagram your spell or state its symbolism. Big spells distort fate – accept SB spikes.

**Innate Arcana (Sorcery)** *Emotional, instinctive, bloodline-linked.* Tools: Breath, impulse, resonance. Costs: Fatigue, unpredictable backlash. **Play Cue:** Treat magic like a reflex. Push your limits – expect consequences.

**Invocation (Priest / Paladin / Medium)** *Petition, prayer, pact, rite.* Tools: Symbols, vows, places of power. Costs: Taboo pressures, obligation clocks. **Play Cue:** Your magic is not your own – frame it as a request. Violating your ethos draws consequences.

**Runic Consecration (Runekeeping)** *Methods, seals, contracts.* Tools: Ritual steps, codices, binding clauses. Costs: Hunger clocks, escalation loops. **Play Cue:** Magic is *procedure*. Expect the system to push back.

**Shaping / Druidic Power** *Resonance with place, element, cycle.* Tools: Marks, offerings, seasonal rites. Costs: Environmental echo, territorial consequence. **Play Cue:** Declare what the land wants – then bargain.

**Pact Binding (Warlock / Avatar)** *Exchange, hunger, transformation.* Tools: Tokens, signatures, reflection marks. Costs: Autonomy loss, ascension risk. **Play Cue:** Ask: “What does my patron get?” Debt becomes plot.

**Summoning (Medium / Necromancer / Shaman)** *Invocation of entities, binding, vassal action.* Tools: Circles, bargains, lanterns, ancestral calls. Costs: Attention clocks, breach risk. **Play Cue:** Give the summoned a personality – their aid comes with demands.

### 16.2.4 Mutual Rules of Magical Cost

No magic is free.

| Cost Type            | Examples in Play                                                     |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Fatigue              | Exhaustion surge, shaking focus, body strain                         |
| SB Pressure          | GM spikes complications or clocks (elemental backlash, Patron omens) |
| Taboo / Obligation   | Commandments, rites, punishment for misuse, Patron demands           |
| Attention / Backwash | Spirits notice; cosmic ledger ticks; faction awareness               |
| Anomaly / Distortion | Places react, reality warps, rituals echo – scene tags change        |
| Identity Erosion     | Compelled acts, alignment tilt, Iconic Ascension risk                |

### 16.2.5 Cross-System Synergies

All magic systems can blend. A Runekeeper may emulate a Cleric or Druid; an Invoker may operate as a Paladin or Prophet; a Sorcerer may look like a Witch, Elementalist, or Psion.

When combining systems:

1. Choose your **primary expression** (belief, intellect, instinct, ritual).
2. Describe spells through that lens.
3. Let costs reflect your system.
4. Track consequences separately – mixing systems increases risk.

### 16.2.6 GM Reminders for Magic

- Magic creates story – reward its use with consequences and momentum.
- Players should narrate method, not just effect.
- Big moments should change scenes, not just numbers.
- Magic should tempt the caster – echo their drives and flaws.

### 16.2.7 Player Reminders for Magic

- Lean into cost – magic feels significant when it hurts.
- Make magic personal – describe what it looks and feels like.
- Tie powers to identity, belief, trauma, duty, or legacy.
- Let magic change your character over time.

## 16.3 Pre-made Spells with TAGS and DV Math

The following examples illustrate how TAGS, DV scaling, and spell intent interact within the casting system. Use them as inspiration or as templates for your own spells.

### 16.3.1 How to Read a Spell Entry

Each entry includes:

- **Name** and **Tradition** (optional).
- **TAGS** – the components that define the effect.
- **Effect** – plain-language outcome.
- **DV** – base calculation (1 + number of TAGS; dangerous tags add +2).
- **Notes** – typical range, duration, or special considerations.

### 16.3.2 Tier I: Minor Utility (DV 2–3)

#### 16.3.2.0.1 Simple Light (Air + Light)

**TAGS:** [ILLUMINATE]

**Effect:** Create a small sustained light (torch-brightness) for the scene.

**DV:** 1 + 1 = 2.

**Notes:** No backlash risk; lasts until dismissed.

#### 16.3.2.0.2 Mend Minor Wounds (Life + Mend)

**TAGS:** [MEND]

**Effect:** Close a small cut or bruise; reduce 1 Fatigue (Minor).

**DV:** 1 + 1 = 2.

**Notes:** Requires touch.

#### Healing Harm and Fatigue

**Mend as a Cantrip.** The Mend tag (Life) can be cast as a single-action cantrip (DV 2). On a success, you remove 1 **Fatigue** from yourself or a touched ally. This cannot heal Harm.

**Healing Harm (1 level).** To restore a level of Harm, you must include the Mend tag and either:

- add a **+2 DV modifier** to the spell, or
- combine Mend with a second appropriate tag (e.g., Purify, Strengthen, Cleanse).

The GM sets the final DV based on the tags and the wound's severity.

*Why?* Fatigue is exhaustion – a quick charm can ease tired muscles. Harm is injury – closing wounds demands more power and risk. This keeps healing meaningful without overshadowing martial endurance.

#### 16.3.2.0.3 Message on Wind (Air + Veil)

**TAGS:** [WHISPER]

**Effect:** Carry a short whispered message 100 feet on wind currents.

**DV:** 1 + 1 = 2.

**Notes:** One-way communication; 30 seconds duration.

### 16.3.3 Tier II: Combat Utility (DV 3–4)

#### 16.3.3.0.1 Blade Flame (Fire + Strike)

**TAGS:** [BURNING][STRIKE]

**Effect:** Coat a weapon in fire, adding +1 Harm and [BURN] to the next melee attack.

**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 = 3.

**Notes:** Lasts one exchange.

#### 16.3.3.0.2 Shield of Air (Air + Wall)

**TAGS:** [WARD][DEFEND]

**Effect:** Create a compressed air barrier; gain Position +1 on next defense.

**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 = 3.

**Notes:** One use only.

#### 16.3.3.0.3 Fleet Step (Air + Leap)

**TAGS:** [HASTE][MOVE]

**Effect:** Double movement speed for one exchange.

**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 = 3.

**Notes:** Requires open area.

### 16.3.4 Tier III: Area Control (DV 4–5)

#### 16.3.4.0.1 Wall of Stone (Earth + Wall)

**TAGS:** [BARRIER][FORTIFY]

**Effect:** Summon a 10-foot stone wall (Near; scene duration).

**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 = 3. *Dangerous DV: 4* (combat blocking).

**Notes:** Provides cover; obstructs movement.

#### 16.3.4.0.2 Sleep's Gentle Touch (Water + Mind)

**TAGS:** [DREAM][COMMAND]

**Effect:** One target falls asleep (scene duration; Resist: Spirit + Resolve DV 2).

**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 = 3. *Dangerous DV: 4* (combat use).

**Notes:** Harm wakes target.

#### 16.3.4.0.3 Flame Cloak (Fire + Area)

**TAGS:** [BURNING][AREA]

**Effect:** 6-foot radius of intense heat; enemies suffer –1 die to approach.

**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 = 3. *Dangerous DV: 4* (if allies are near).

**Notes:** Creates difficult terrain.

### 16.3.5 Tier IV: Battlefield Shaping (DV 5–6)

#### 16.3.5.0.1 Earth's Tremor (Earth + Force)

**TAGS:** [QUAKE][AREA]

**Effect:** 20-foot tremor; enemies test Body + Athletics (DV 3) or fall prone.

**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 = 3. *Dangerous DV: 5*.

**Notes:** Destabilizes structures; affects all in area.

**16.3.5.0.2 Storm's Fury** (Air + Storm)**TAGS:** [STORM][AREA][FORCE]**Effect:** 30-foot storm cloud; lightning strikes random targets (Harm 2).**DV:**  $1 + 1 + 1 + 1 = 4$ . *Dangerous DV: 6.***Notes:** Lasts scene; reduces visibility.**16.3.5.0.3 Healing Circle** (Life + Area)**TAGS:** [MEND][AREA][CLEANSE]**Effect:** Allies in 15-foot radius heal 1 Harm and clear 1 Fatigue.**DV:**  $1 + 1 + 1 + 1 = 4$ .**Notes:** Major positive effect warrants high DV.**16.3.6 Tier V: Domain-Level Effects (DV 6–7)****16.3.6.0.1 Gate of Passage** (Air + Fold)**TAGS:** [GATE][TRANSPORT][AREA]**Effect:** Open a two-way portal 20 feet wide linking two locations.**DV:**  $1 + 2 + 1 + 1 = 5$ . *Dangerous DV: 7.***Notes:** Requires concentration; may destabilize.**16.3.6.0.2 Army of Stone** (Earth + Summon)**TAGS:** [CONJURE][AREA][GUARD]**Effect:** Summon 4 stone guardians (Cap 2) to follow simple commands.**DV:**  $1 + 2 + 1 + 1 = 5$ . *Dangerous DV: 6.***Notes:** Scene duration; concentration.**16.3.6.0.3 Mind's Dominion** (Fate + Mind)**TAGS:** [COMMAND][AREA][CURSE]**Effect:** All enemies in 25-foot radius test Spirit + Resolve (DV 4) or obey a single command.**DV:**  $1 + 1 + 1 + 2 = 5$ . *Dangerous DV: 7.***Notes:** Significant ethical risk; backlash likely.**16.3.7 Signature / Personal Spells (Custom)****16.3.7.0.1 The Warden's Bond** (Life + Bind) – Healing Cantor**TAGS:** [MEND][BIND][GUARD]**Effect:** Heal 2 Harm and link caster to target – the next Harm they take, caster suffers 1 instead.**DV:**  $1 + 1 + 1 + 1 = 4$ .**Notes:** Sacrificial protection.**16.3.7.0.2 Shadow's Step** (Air + Veil) – Trickster's Path**TAGS:** [VEIL][MOVE][LEAP]**Effect:** Become invisible and teleport 30 feet; gain +2 dice to next Stealth action.**DV:**  $1 + 1 + 1 + 1 = 4$ .**Notes:** Requires shadow or dim light.**16.3.7.0.3 Forge's Truth** (Fire + Reveal) – Artificer's Craft**TAGS:** [REVEAL][MEND][FORTIFY]

**Effect:** See flaws in an object and repair as if 2 Skill levels higher (scene).

**DV:**  $1 + 1 + 1 + 1 = 4$ .

**Notes:** Works on magical items (with risk).

## 16.3.8 Backlash and Push Guidelines

### 16.3.8.1 Backlash Examples by Tier

- **Tier I–II:** Minor fatigue, brief elemental effect (smoke, chill, static).
- **Tier III–IV:** Harm 1, temporary Condition, environmental hazard.
- **Tier V:** Harm 2, major Condition, significant environmental change.

### 16.3.8.2 Push Options (Accelerate or Amplify)

- **+1 Effect:** Increase radius, duration, or potency one step.
- **+1 die:** Improve casting roll (cost: +1 Fatigue).
- **Instant:** Resolve immediately (cost: +1 Harm).
- **Sustain:** Maintain effect with concentration (+1 Fatigue/round).

This framework provides concrete spell examples and demonstrates how TAGS, DV scaling, and ambition interact within the magic system.

## 16.4 The Witch Hunter

**Concept:** A sanctioned tracker of illicit rites and rogue talents. Part detective, part exorcist, part collector of debts owed to the law. Witch hunters serve mortal authorities, temple courts, or—most dangerously—a divine Patron who demands purity.

**Typical Inspiration:** Inquisitors, occult constables, hedge-wardens, contract witch-finders, zealots of the Inquisitor Prime.

### Mechanical Foundation:

- **Attributes:** Wits 4, Spirit 3 (or substitute Body 3 for a more martial hunter)
- **Skills:** Investigation 3, Lore (occult) 2, Melee 2, Insight 1, Command 1
- **Talents:**
  - *Witch-Sign Reader* – spot residue of magical workings; gain +1 die on Investigation vs. occult scenes.
  - *Cold Iron Practice* – gain +1 die when disrupting active magic or attacking a supernatural creature with cold iron.
  - *Calm Under Oath* – once per scene, resist fear, panic, or intimidation (reroll a failed Spirit + Resolve test).
- **Assets:** Writ of limited authority (opens doors, closes some), temple archive informant, a cold iron weapon (Minor Asset)
- **Affiliation:** Choose one order – Chain-Lanterns (Aeler), Spirit-Shield (Mistlands), Sum-Abjurers (Thepyrgos), Break-Reins (Vilikari), Silk/Shed Vigil (Silkstrand/Zakov), Wake-Judges (Ecktoria), or the **Inquisition of the Prime** (servants of the Inquisitor Prime).

### The Inquisitor Prime’s Hunter

Witch hunters who swear to the **Inquisitor Prime** (see §??) gain supernatural tools at the cost of Obligation and creeping zealotry. The Prime’s Rites are already detailed in the magic chapter; a hunter may access them as a **Runekeeper** (Thiasos + Codex) or an **Invoker** (Patron’s Symbol). Common choices:

- *Rite of the Unclouded Eye* – pierce illusions and magical deception.
- *Rite of the Pure Flame* – gain +2 dice to resist supernatural influence.
- *Rite of the Marked Prey* – curse a supernatural target, making them easier to track.

**Corruption of the Prime** (summarized): As Obligation grows, the hunter becomes increasingly absolute – seeing only “pure” and “corrupt”, suffering –1 die in morally grey situations. At high tiers, they may gain the *Absolute Judgment* ability, but at the cost of becoming a monomaniacal instrument of the Prime.

### Play Style

- Tracks leads, reads scenes, corners quarry with paperwork and steel.
- Uses Position and leverage in social spaces before blades are drawn.
- Treats magic as both *evidence* and *hazard* (§3).
- May invoke Patron Rites to ward, reveal, or smite – but each use deepens Obligation.

### Development Path

- Specialize in *Baneful Techniques* (counter-rites, bindings, exorcism).

- Build a network of informants and safe cells (§8).
- Learn one magical tradition deeply to turn it against itself.
- For the faithful: advance in the Inquisitor Prime’s favor (Embrace Corruption, Purifying Flame talents).

## Story Hooks

- A vanished ledger ties a noble salon to forbidden rites – but the salon is protected by a rival inquisitor.
- A *sanction* arrives with no seal – who really wrote it, and what do they want you to ignore?
- Your oldest informant begs you to burn a file with your name on it – it contains evidence that you once used a cursed artefact to save a child.
- The Inquisitor Prime appears in a dream: “There is rot in your own order. Find it – or I will find you.”

### Witch Hunter’s Eye

Once per session when confronting occult evidence or a supernatural threat, choose one:

- **Pattern Recognition:** Reduce DV by 1 on the first investigation or Lore roll.
- **Measured Response:** Shift Position one step safer when disrupting active magic or attacking a supernatural creature.
- **Witness Prepared:** Gain +1 die on the first social roll when presenting your authority (writ, badge, or Patron’s symbol).
- **Purity’s Toll (Inquisitor Prime only):** Once per session, invoke the Prime’s name to reroll a failed resistance roll against a supernatural effect. Mark +1 Obligation.

**Sanction Ledger** [4]: Tracks cases where you’ve used authority beyond scope or invoked the Prime’s Rites in public. When full, local magical communities become wary – and the Inquisitor Prime may send a test. Mark a segment when you:

- Forge or exceed a writ’s limits.
- Use a Rite of the Prime in front of witnesses who aren’t sworn allies.
- Refuse a demand from your order or patron.

Clearing the ledger requires a downtime action: paying fines, doing penance, or destroying evidence of overreach.



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